

this can't be the place

alternative theories of the internet

INC Reader #18

this can't be the place: alternative theories of the internet

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The logo for the Institute of Network Cultures features the text "Institute of network cultures" in a lowercase, sans-serif font. The word "Institute" is on the top line, "of" is in the middle, and "network cultures" is on the bottom line. Behind the text is a complex, abstract network diagram with numerous nodes and connecting lines, creating a web-like structure.



**Amsterdam University
of Applied Sciences**

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edited by
Ruben Stoffelen
and **August Kaasa Sundgaard**

INC READER #18

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INTRODUCTION: IS THIS THE PLACE?

RUBEN STOFFELEN AND AUGUST KAASA SUNDGAARD

How do you feel when you refresh your timeline for the tenth time? How does it feel to only move in a single direction, an endless scroll? Did you ever imagine the internet to turn out this way? Do you *imagine* the internet at all? What happened to networks and communities? Is it normal to feel so alone? *Is this the place?*

While editing this reader we repeatedly found ourselves asking the question: what defines this era of the internet? A sense of doom, maybe – technofascism and brutality, a loss of control, an inability to grasp what we're entangled in. And yet, we attempt to make sense of our precarious positions, to wrap our heads around the place we've ended up in. It feels like discourse is always attempting to catch up. There's an acute desire to untangle the complexities of the contemporary internet, but the deeper you go, the more lost you seem to get. Nothing seems to accelerate more rapidly than the internet, and to write about something that is in constant flux feels contradictory – is writing not an act of crystallization, after all?

This book is a collection of texts that want to see the unseeable and uproot our assumptions about theory and the essay form. At the time of publishing, we find ourselves at a particularly critical moment; where the acknowledgement of the power held by those who govern the mainstream internet has entered popular discourse. Alongside this realisation, we're finally ready to acknowledge that our ways of being are also entangled with the internet and those who own it. But at the same time, we're not ready to fully fall into the trap of techno-nihilism; the internet continues to engender moments of hope and community, of glitch and resistance, and it is these moments that we seek to dwell on.

As the conditions for *being* have developed in tandem with the internet, so has publishing. *To exist online is already to publish*. It was perhaps inevitable, then, that a research institute dedicated to understanding the internet would come to treat publishing not as a means to an end but as a method in itself. This book is a testament to that belief and to the community it has gathered.

This Can't Be the Place: Alternative Theories of the Internet gathers a sample of longform articles, previously published digitally for the Institute of Network Cultures between the years of 2020-2025. It brings together people from wildly different disciplines united by a shared restlessness about what the internet is doing to us, and what we might still do with it. They reflect the diverse, international, and stubborn community that has gathered around the INC over the past years: misfits and outliers who never quite fit inside the institutions they came from, and who found here something rare for a research center – a safe haven for the burned out and disillusioned.

The format that holds them together has its own important history. The INC Longform series began as a collaboration with the Domain for Art Criticism and a constellation of cultural publications in the Netherlands and Flanders. What brought them together was a shared diagnosis: that existing writing and research practices were failing to keep pace with the shift from print to screen reading, and that the forms inherited from the magazine and the academic journal were poorly suited to the ways in which people actually encountered text in a digital environment. To find a better fit, the collaborators experimented widely: podcasts, photo-essays, dialogic critique, collaborative writing. And then the longform.

The longform online article was not an obvious bet. The received wisdom of the time held that online readers wouldn't read anything longer than a few paragraphs; that the screen demanded brevity, that depth was a print-era luxury. The INC's contention was that this was a failure of imagination. The question was never whether people wanted to read online, but whether writing and publishing were willing to reform themselves to deserve being read there. The dreary bullet-point article needed to be left in the past, to make room for something the term "longform" was, at the time, just beginning to articulate.

At its core, the longform was a reclamation of the essay. We achieved this by welcoming the personal voice alongside theory and collaborative writing, without letting academic convention smother what makes the essay form so alive. At INC we have always believed that making critical writing accessible is not a matter of dumbing it down, but of trusting the reader enough to bring them fully in. The essay, at its best, is world-opening and too often it's flattened that into something airless and closed. The longform was a way of refusing that closure – of keeping theory-driven critical writing in genuine contact with the wider public. By embracing a multimodal approach and encouraging writers to enrich their articles with images, videos, and an abundance of links, we also wanted the longform to connect readers outward to the wider ecosystem of resources that the internet still makes possible, against all odds.

The longform was also created to address another tenet of INC's publishing philosophy: urgency. Where academic publishing moves sluggishly, with papers sitting in review for months, the longform was designed to respond to the here and now. Urgent publishing is messy and dynamic, and so are longforms, but therein lies their charm. To defy the fixity expected of "serious" texts, and instead embrace nonlinearity and fluidity, is exactly their point. We believe that anyone can write theory; that theory can and should be uncoupled from the strict frameworks that so-often pin it down.

This reflection on the history of the INC Longform is indebted to Miriam Rasch, who edited the first longform reader, *Let's get physical* (2020). Since then, the torch has been passed to new team members: Chloë Arkenbout, Tommaso Campagna, and Sepp Eckenhaussen, who have carried the project forward while continuing to develop INC's publishing practice. During this period, INC expanded into the audiovisual realm with *The Void (T.V.)*, a research project on tactical video and an audiovisual publishing venue for practice-based research. In parallel, two other research projects pushed at the boundaries of what publishing can be. *Going Hybrid*

investigated how experiments in hybrid cultural programming could develop into durable, participatory practices. *.expub* explored how publishing infrastructures might become free from platform monopolies and the tired binary of print versus digital.

The Longform itself has also developed. Formally, we see a growing use of images and videos within articles, alongside more adventurous editorial strategies, including embedded code-based graphics, visual effects applied to text and images, and non-linear storytelling through hyperlinks. Thematically, too, there has been a shift. Tactical media, platform critique, and questions of labor and infrastructure remain central, but they are now joined by a growing focus on internet aesthetics, identity, and online subcultures. This feels less like a change of direction than a change of terrain: as the boundaries between obscure internet culture and the mainstream have become increasingly porous, so has the writing that tries to make sense of it. The articles gathered in this reader are a representative sample of that evolution. They are formally adventurous, theoretically rigorous, and collectively tracing the shape of an internet that has changed almost beyond recognition in five years.

Given this history – given that the longform was born as a digital form, designed for the screen, structured around the affordances of the web – the question naturally arises: why publish it as a physical reader? The answer, perhaps, is the same one the longform itself has always given. The internet is not the opposite of the physical; it never was. To hold these essays in your hands is not to rescue them from the web but to give them a different kind of persistence.

Amsterdam, April 2026.

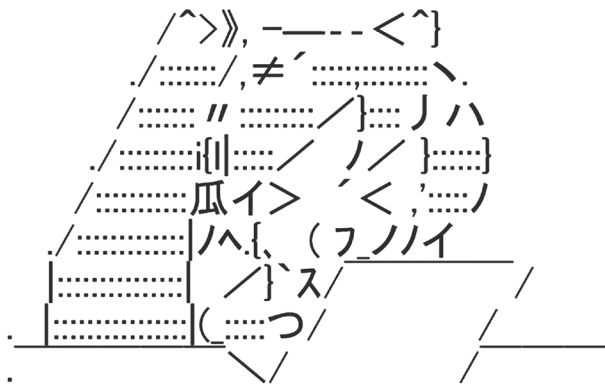
INC gf



theorizes simple pleasures
rhizomatic in thought, practice, and desire
loves a sweet treat
doomscrolls as research
open source
online affect as the last remaining
form of symbolic exchange
spirals into political despair at 2 a.m.
tactical illusions
treats networks as living organisms
emotionally saturated,
politically sharp
“there’s no ethical consumption
under late capitalism”
“i don’t read theory”
you love the idea of loving her,
and that’s close enough

needs fewer rules and more becomings
symbolic rebellion
follows intensities, not plans
“bla bla bla”
believes in alternative futures
thinks “authenticity”
is the kink of the naïve
decentralized networks
but loves instagram
semiotic sabotage
symbolic exchange >>> content creation
her first kiss feels like a minor deterritorialization
LOVES instagram
collective action is the closest thing
to magic still available
will absolutely derail a simple
question into ontology
thinks you’re cute
and structurally alienated

I'M OVERWHELMED
BY IMAGES



NO SHOT LIKE SCREENSHOT: BANAL, SUBLIME AND DANGEROUS

DUNJA NEŠOVIĆ

Originally published January 19th, 2022

Screenshot

From Wikipedia, the free encyclopedia

A **screenshot**, also known as **screen capture** or **screen grab**, is a digital image that shows the contents of a computer display. A screenshot is created by the operating system or software running on the device powering the display.

screenshot is something else entirely; several things in fact: the screenshot is a kind of document, a remediated photograph, and a mode of witnessing and poetic world disclosure.

the screenshot is the selfie of the device.

contain no characteristics of a central perspective. They are images of stratifications of windows (applications)³⁰ — of the realities of the computer — but they also enable insights into the intimate, private life of the users. They present an image of the

an archive constantly in motion.

Ironically what screenshots captured here was not **stillness** but interaction,

screenshots were framed as *haunting*.

a ‘technological uncanny’,

a death mask.

, they play with expected boundaries of digital time and space.

show the rare, the obvious, and the unbelievable.

restoring the significance of the human gaze

for rethinking perception as unfixed, nonlinear, embodied, and mobile.

Through screenshotting, computational devices such as computers and smartphones give us an easy way of preserving the contents of their screens for a myriad of purposes. Whether screenshotting serves a creative, documentary or even a surveilling purpose, it represents in Jacob Gaboury's words, "one of the many vernacular computational practices, in that there is a great deal of variance in how they are used, modified, and disseminated."¹ The desire to capture screen imagery tells us a lot about our relationship to the intricate worlds we experience through a flat and mildly penetrable surface.

The screenshot represents *the digital networked image*, given that screenshot's ontology is connected to its inherent embeddedness in its originating context of digital, screened technologies, cultures and modes of being, as it is materially and operationally always delimited and defined by them. Theoretically approaching the screenshot to support this account means examining its aesthetic, functional, and mediating characteristics that are specific to the networked, screened environment of its origin.

First theoretical conceptualizations of the screenshot have approached it by comparing it and contextualizing it within the medium of photography. A significant portion of (a handful of) papers written on the screenshot discuss it in the context of in-game photography often for the purpose of legitimizing the screenshot medium within the art field. The screenshot is in those instances also named a photograph, which might additionally be due to the aesthetic of these 'photographs' that capture the video-game imagery marked by the simulation of the three-dimensional 'real world'. Whether it concerns in-game photography or images of other screenscapes, screenshot's link to photography becomes prevalent in its academic theorization.

In many ways, the screenshot remediates, or integrates, the characteristics of photography in itself. Notably, it is a capture of light in an image, it encompasses simulated camera shutter sounds that follow the act of screenshotting, it creates stillness from an otherwise dynamic and moving environment and bears a strong indexical trace of as well as iconic resemblance to it, it represents a document and presumes active witnessing and world-making through perception and capture. But does this correlation to photography limit our understanding of this relatively new and underexplored medium? Jan Švelch reflects on the possibility that looking beyond photography when thinking about screenshots might help us gain a deeper comprehension of its properties and capacities:

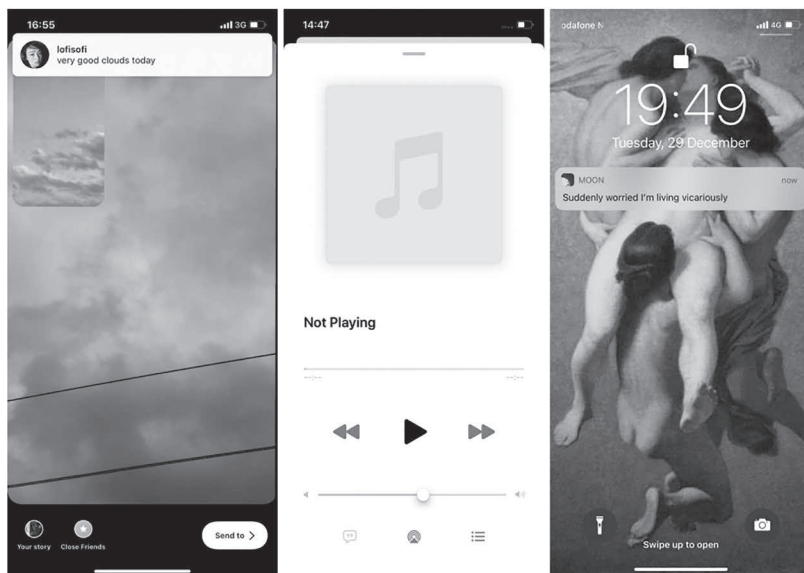
By searching for similarities between screenshots and photography, the perspective of remediation downplays the technological differences between the various images that are commonly understood and labelled as screenshots.²

1 <https://www.fotomuseum.ch/de/2019/07/05/screen-selfies-and-high-scores/>

2 Jan Švelch, 'Redefining screenshots: Toward critical literacy of screen capture practices', *Convergence: The International Journal of Research into New Media Technologies* 27.2 (2020): 554-569.

While Švelch's thesis accounts for a certain taxonomy of screen-capturing imagery, I am interested in downplaying screenshot's connection to photography to examine the specificity of vernacular practices of screenshotting. Susan Sontag notices in her essay 'The Image-World' that "when the notion of reality changes, so does that of the image, and vice versa."³ Bearing that in mind, studying the screenshot might reveal the nuances of our changed, ubiquitously screened (sense of) reality and how this peculiar image and image-making practice inserts itself into it or is otherwise producing it.

The peculiarity of screenshots might become obvious if we consider that other screens such as old television⁴ and cinema screens have only served as an output of media content, framed as a window into a different kind of reality which, similar to non-mediatized reality, provides no option to the viewer of capturing and preserving the 'raw' image it presents to us. Of course, in the cases of screened reality as well as our material environment, the images of both could be captured with the aid of a camera that physically and aesthetically inserts itself between the subject and the object of the image. Screenshots, on the other hand, are created with minimal or no mediation that influences the final form of the image. In that sense, they ontologically and aesthetically more resemble the futuristic fantasies of capturing the images directly with our eyes.



3 Susan Sontag, *On Photography*, New York: Farrar, Straus and Giroux, 1977.

4 John Smith, "How to Take Screenshots on Your Smart TV Screen," *Medium*, October 22, 2019, <https://medium.com/@johnkpdsmith/how-to-take-screenshots-on-your-smart-tv-screen-6596a2899e0d>.

Transparent Mediation, Networked Authorship

Vernacular screenshots depict the flat, two-dimensional screen surface that perceptively replicate the exact contents of the screen. In that sense, the screen imagery is transparently mediated, as there is no in-between device and operation that leaves the signs of its mediation in this image-making (such as it is in the case of camera or brush and canvas). In his work on the screenshot, Paul Frosh points out that we almost exclusively ‘look through’ screenshots, rather than looking at them, given that “the reflexive indicators of self-mediation are absent – signs which draw attention to the screenshot itself as a media object.”⁵

On the other hand, given that “computer graphics, unlike film and television, do not begin as images”, screenshot represents a ‘secondary mediation’ in Gaboury’s terms, in the sense that the computer-generated images of the screen, are already a mediation of mathematical computation and visual representation of digital information.⁶ Gaboury notes that screenshots are a significant medium insofar as they allow us to examine how humans have been visualizing computation both by investigating the technical processes of photographing screens, as well as the visual documentation of cultures that are being mediated through those screens.

Transparently mediating through screen capture, as well as representing a still copy of computational mediation, screenshots are located in the ambiguous territory of contemporary image-making that complicates the questions of mediation and authorship.

Screenshot can be classified as a technical image, which is a concept by Vilém Flusser that groups together the images created with technical devices.⁷ In his account, technical images inherently lack dimension since they are assembled from particles that are only registrable and produced through the aid of apparatuses. He identifies the keys as the most important tools for creating these types of images. Flusser notes on photography:

Then he [the photographer] takes an apparatus in hand to “grasp” (with concepts such as “perspective” or “shutter speed”) what he has visualized. The apparatus calculates these concepts automatically, and the photographer presses a button to release the machine to carry out these calculations, making the vision of the house into an image.

In that sense, the human maker of technical images is, according to him, also a visualizer – they need to visualize the finished image and also visualize how to control the apparatus

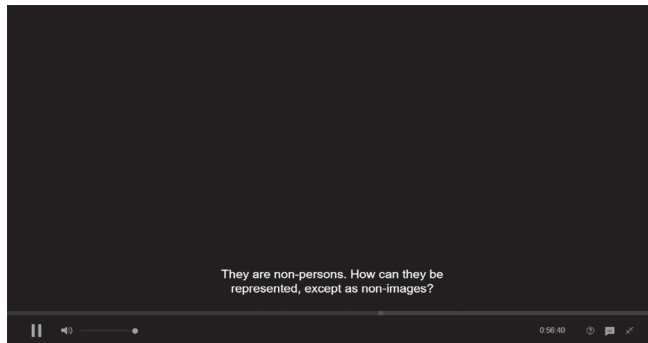
5 Paul Frosh, *The Poetics of Digital Media*, Cambridge (MA): MIT Press, 2018.

6 Jacob Gaboury, “Screen Selfies and High Scores,” *Still Searching...* blog, Fotomuseum Winterthur, July 5, 2019, <https://www.fotomuseum.ch/en/2019/07/05/screen-selfies-and-high-scores/>

7 Vilém Flusser, *Into the Universe of Technical Images*, Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 2011.

in the right way to achieve the desired result. Human technicality is of big importance in this process since it works together with the technology of the apparatus to produce an image. Screen imagery is already a finished technical image, programmed, designed and executed (or constantly in execution) usually by someone other than the one who is capturing a screenshot. The screenshot-taker (or screenshotter) presses the buttons on the apparatus (which are often not primarily designed to fit only this function), but they are at that moment not visualizing anything – they are merely recognizing and selecting. The screenshotter first recognizes the significant imagery from the screen and then selects the particular function of the keys and their combinations to instruct the technical device to take an exact image of the screen at that moment. The interventional input of the screenshotter, as well as the medium of screenshot, in terms of the characteristics it instills in the final image, is very small, almost non-existent.⁸

Švelch notes that one of the most important characteristics of the screenshot as documentation is the irrelevance of authorship: “due to an arguably mechanical act of their creation, photographic screen capture and screenshot trivialize the creative input of their authors”.⁹ This irrelevance points to the diminished role of the user in creating a screenshot and the image’s higher level of ‘machinic objectivity’.



non-screenshot of Sans Soleil (Chris Marker, 1983), MUBI

In technical terms, screenshots are authored in the intersection of humans and machines, in which the machine (or the human that programmed the machine) determines what is visible, and what is possible to be captured, distributed and seen again. For example,

-
- 8 In a vain attempt to simulate the photographic intervention of brightness of the screenshot, I tried to re-adjust the brightness of the screen and take a screenshot only to see that the done image is always the same brightness - namely my device is programmed to capture the image as having the highest brightness as default.
 - 9 Jan Svelch, 'Redefining screenshots: Toward critical literacy of screen capture practices', *Convergence: The International Journal of Research into New Media Technologies* 27.2 (2020): 554-569.

streaming platforms such as Netflix and Mubi don't allow screenshotting of their content, as the moving images they distribute across private screens are copy-righted and screenshotting them counts as infringement. The user is in those instances not permitted to take a screenshot, and their image-making practices of the screen are subjected to what they don't see being programmed.

Without any speculation on how the screenshot might develop in terms of its expansion of affordances that allow for the greater agency of the user (both in technical and normative terms) and in turn greater similarity to the photographic medium, at this moment the technique concerning the screenshot is over-determined by the device that is merely allowing them to preserve what they are seeing being shown to them. As if our smartphones and computers are talking back to us through their option for screenshotting and saying "take a picture, it'll last longer" thus affirming the relevance and impact of the imagery constantly presented to us. Frosh goes so far as to say that screenshot represents a selfie of the device:

The screenshot is an image of the state of the device as it presents itself for viewing and interaction with a user, as subject to human intentionality and temporality. It preserves an instant of what we could call the 'screenscape': the dynamic, contingent, humanly oriented 'face' of the device as it appears on the screen. To stretch an analogy somewhat, the screenshot is the selfie of the device.¹⁰

Selfie, as a digital image form, presupposes mechanical image-making in which the subject and the object of the photo are one and the same. In that sense, naming the screenshot the selfie of the device again locates the 'authorship' of the screenshot mainly in the machine. Historically, the subject of the image is always subjugated to the maker of the image, as not only beauty but also power, lies in the eye of the beholder. This dynamic is somewhat complicated by the screenshot, as the distinction between the image-taker and the object of the image is not as straightforward as it is in photography, painting and cinema.

As the screen in this instance represents an output for images, as well as the potential input for the screenshot, it fuses the boundaries of human and machinic vision and image-making.

Zylinska, in her book *Non-human Photography* notes how non-human vision allows us to form a critical distance from the concept of perception as a given and embrace its creative characteristics:

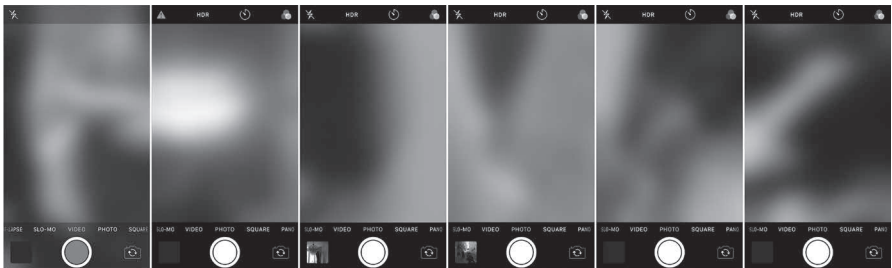
We could therefore go so far as to suggest that our visual apparatus introduces edges and cuts into the imagistic flow: it cuts up the environment so that we can

10 Paul Frosh, *The Poetics of Digital Media*, Cambridge (MA): MIT Press, 2018.

see it, and then helps us stitch it back together again. With this idea, we arrive at the concept of perception as active, or even world-making, rather than just secondary and responsive.¹¹

In this sense, perception, as materialized through the screenshot, is world-making inasmuch as it is allowed to exist by the programmed interface. In the cases in which the screenshot is disallowed, it limits the user's perception to be validated and creative, leaving all the power to the machine (and the other human who programmed the machine) to decide how a user can appropriate and visually work with their digital environment.

The question of authorship and creative input of the screenshotter is mainly based on what Nicholas Bourriaud named the aesthetic of post-production, that is, in the use and remix of already available data.¹² With postproduction, artists make use of already existing objects, cultural forms and the world itself. It is emblematic of the appearance of the web (although there are artists that engaged in Postproduction before its genesis – such as New Realists and Pop Artists for example), since “the activities of DJs, Web surfers, and postproduction artists imply a similar configuration of knowledge, which is characterized by the invention of paths through culture.” He also notes that in that sense “the artwork functions as the temporary terminal of a network of interconnected elements, like a narrative that extends and reinterprets preceding narratives.” Whereas the screenshot doesn't necessarily have to be an artwork, its creative and aesthetic parameters are based on the selection and appropriation of what is already there, and in such a way that presumes an instant transformation of the 'raw' visual material into a barely mediated image.



And So the New Aestheticist Screenshots..

If, as Frosh notes, the screenshot “preserves an instant of the screenscape,” it also validates the digital environment as equally ‘real’ as the physical one through our ability to observe, document and preserve.¹³ He continues, “like physical space, we cannot

11 Joanna Zylinska, *Non-Human Photography*, Cambridge (MA): MIT Press, 2017.

12 Nicholas Bourriaud, *Postproduction*, New York: Lukas & Sternberg, 2007.

13 Paul Frosh, *The Poetics of Digital Media*, Cambridge (MA): MIT Press, 2018.

occupy the same points of that [digital] space at the same time". Screenshots confirm the fact that our digital environments are deeply personal, even though we, as smartphone and computer users, might still have the same (or quite similar depending on the OS we use) interface designs, affordances and technical devices we use to browse them. Even though the classical notion of a point of view doesn't apply in screenshotting as it does in photography, it emphasizes more the changing of the digital environment from person to person rather than the ability of a body to take up different points in the same physical space. With the development of highly algorithmically curated digital environments, the originality of the screenshot and its subsequent point of view, again, unlike the photograph that demonstrates the skill of the camera operator to capture a lived moment in a technically virtuous and original way, stems from the uniqueness of the digital environment of the user (and of course their ability to recognize it).

Screenshot as a creative and communicational practice belongs to post-digital or new aesthetics, which are defined by the intertwinement of humans and machines in realms of perception, image-making and visual languages. As David Berry and Michael Dieter observe in their definition of post-digital aesthetics, the role of the practitioner in the networked, platformized digital environment, which is "marked by the shift from exceptional to ordinary perceptions of digital creativity", is also imagined in terms of techniques of recognizing patterns, cataloguing, curating, interpreting and transcribing), and then actualizing these engagements as artifacts for potential contemplation."¹⁴ Additionally, Vito Campanelli identifies that the "most authentic nature of the New Aesthetic is precisely that of the archive, [...] an archive constantly in motion".¹⁵ Campanelli continues:

The New Aestheticist is a new figure in between those of artist and curator, characterized by the capacity to aggregate aesthetic materials. In other words, the function of the New Aestheticist is to derive value from an image produced by machinic entities and to 'ascribe' an aesthetic to it.

Screenshot's artistic and aesthetic potential is exactly located in this notion of finding the strange in the trivialized and commercialized digital environment and it is probably one of the most emblematic image forms that reflect the current configurations of what we call (digital) reality. Whether the screenshot serves an aesthetic, communicative or archival purpose, they generate in-between the humans and (their) machines, being computed and visually preserved at once. The 'in-betweenness' of screenshots corresponds to

14 David M. Berry and Michael Dieter, 'Thinking Postdigital Aesthetics: Art, Computation and Design', in David Berry and Michael Dieter (eds) *Postdigital Aesthetics Art, Computation and Design*, London: Palgrave Macmillan, 2019, pp. 1-11.

15 Vito Campanelli, 'New Aesthetic in the Perspective on Social Photography', David M. Berry and Michael Dieter (eds) *Postdigital Aesthetics Art, Computation and Design*, London: Palgrave Macmillan, 2019, pp. 259-270.

“the sublimity of the images produced by the innovative forms of collaboration between humans and machines enabled by digital media” which are representative of the New Aesthetic.¹⁶

The online project “Screenshots of Despair, conceived as a Tumblr blog that relies on the screenshot submissions of everyday users, identifies itself as New Aesthetic poetry. It features mainly the incidental machinic imagery of the screen that uncannily anthropomorphizes the interface and its visual communicative practices. The imagery is sublime and uncanny, as it contains the traces of both human and non-human, producing the estranged familiar that might both be banal and fascinating.

Campanelli quotes Don DeLillo noting that in the images of the New Aesthetic we recognize ourselves ‘but also something other than ourselves; or rather, still ourselves – but ourselves complicated, enmeshed, othered’.¹⁷ The imagery on the screens we use is always ‘for us’ either because we sought them out, or were humanly or non-humanly (algorithmically) delivered to us and the archive we continue to build from them corresponds to the collection of traces of visual gifts we receive on a daily basis that we continue to use for different purposes.

Apart from selecting single instances from our environments for screenshotting, screenshots also have the potential to faithfully represent the fragmented, windowed environment of our computer screens. Artist Toru Izumida created a series of collages named simply ‘Screen Shots’ in which he “use[d] selections of online media to create unexpected combinations that are finalized into a single screenshot.¹⁸”



16 Ibid.

17 Ibid.

18 Beckett Mufson, “An Artist’s Screenshot Collages Capture Computerized Creativity,” *VICE*, September 10, 2014, <https://www.vice.com/en/article/qkwbxx/an-artists-screenshot-collages-capture-computerized-creativity>

Uncannily Intactile

The uncanniness of screenshots comes not only from their visual content but also from their lack of operativity. The screenshot deadens the interface, fossilizes it and disables any further exchange on the part of the user. The dynamic digital environment becomes its “shadow” through the screenshot, as Winfried Gerling would put it, given that the computer-generated images of the screen that usually have a utilitarian function, come to a ‘full stop’ through being screenshotted:

If the screen is filled with the screenshot of the previous status of the screen, the difference only becomes apparent when attempting to operate within the screenshot. The screenshot is taken as reality—that has been—on the computer screen (and pixel-precise). It is a strange confusion with reality that could never occur in photographs. The latter were only confused with nature early on; otherwise the photograph has always been understood as a representation.¹⁹

By becoming visually the same as the interface, and yet completely inoperational, the screenshot invokes uncanniness that might correspond to its meaning as psychoanalytically defined through human relationship to death, as Laura Mulvey writes in her account on film stills:

For human and all organic life, time marks the movement along a path to death, that is, to the stillness that represents the transformation of the animate into the inanimate. In cinema, the blending of movement and stillness touches on this point of uncertainty so that, buried in the cinema’s materiality, lies a reminder of the difficulty of understanding passing time and, ultimately, of understanding death.²⁰

More often, the uncanniness of screenshots will elicit the feelings of frustration and anxiety we encounter when our computers freeze and become inoperable, shining the light on the amount of dependency and powerlessness we experience in those moments.

The other names for screenshot, including screengrab, according to Frosh, point to screenshot’s tactility through its becoming an object to be manipulated as a file and an image.²¹ Correspondingly, Martine Beugnet notes that the images in the era of the interface are marked not only by sight, but also by touch:

Our experience as viewers increasingly become that of “users”: we touch the screen to activate a menu and select a resolution, to choose and enlarge an image,

19 Winfried Gerling, ‘Photography in the Digital’, *Photographies* 11.2-3 (2018): 149-167.

20 Laura Mulvey, *Death 24x a Second: Stillness and the Moving Image*, Chicago: Reaktion Books, 2006.

21 Paul Frosh, *The Poetics of Digital Media*, Cambridge (MA): MIT Press, 2018.

zoom into it or reduce its size, to start or pause a video, to scroll through or superimpose images, to slow down or speed up their course, to make them disappear.²²

As screenshots can be manipulated by touch as any other digital image, they disable touch of what they represent, namely the interface. Lack of tactility is very much present in the screenshot, especially when encountered on touch screens, given that the touch becomes insignificant as it has no interfacial function it usually has when operating a computer or a smartphone through the screen. Their exactness in representation evokes uncomfortable feelings of the impossibility of interaction, a technological uncanny that won't subdue no matter how many times we tap the flat surface.

On the other side, the uncanniness and even computational deceptiveness of screenshots come into play when the other ways of interfacial relations become present. A recent problem regarding screenshots concerns the screenshots of the CoronaPass QR code.²³ As QR codes provide interaction through the scanning of visual data, the difference between the authentic QR code emanating from the app and a screenshot of it becomes invisible with a successful reading of the code by the scanner. Screenshot in that sense can facilitate, not the lack of interaction, but the unwanted, forbidden, or illegal interaction, through their mimicking of 'screen authenticity'.

Authenticity and Data Extractivism

The authenticity of screenshots is, in general, hard to pinpoint, given that the metadata they provide more or less only concerns the date, time, and device of taking the image, and contains no information on the operative contents of the screen²⁴. In that sense, they can easily be falsely fabricated²⁵ and there are only a few ways to forensically determine if they are 'real' or not. Moreover, another layer of the authenticity of digital images arises in the context of the screenshot. The recent debate on screenshotting minted digital artworks²⁶ invokes the Benjaminian discussion on the aura of digital artworks. The NFT as a digital certificate of ownership, devalues the imagistic properties of the digital artworks that can be easily replicated with the help of a few keys on your device. It displaces the 'authenticity' of the work on the place on the blockchain, rather than trying to preserve its possessional exclusivity like the streaming platforms, by disabling the image to be screen-replicated through the code. Moreover, this authenticity is also located in the proof of monetary value

22 Martine Beugnet, 'Touch and See? Regarding Images in the Era of the Interface', *InMedia* [Online] 8.1 (2020).

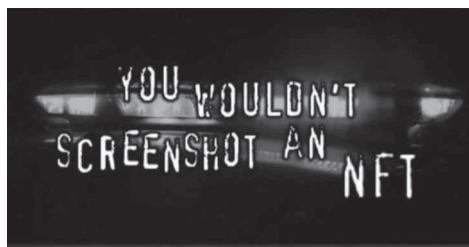
23 <https://www.security.nl/posting/715107/Aanpassing+CoronaCheck-app+moet+misbruik+shot+qr-codes+tegenaan>

24 <https://superuser.com/questions/1010186/how-to-prove-the-authenticity-of-a-screenshot/1010249>

25 <https://technastic.com/make-a-fake-create-fake-screenshots-for-almost-everything/>

26 <https://medium.datadriveninvestor.com/why-nfts-dont-have-a-screenshot-problem-4e8b284051b9>

and ownership, rather than in the material and aesthetic properties of the image. As the function of the screenshot allows for immense reproduction and appropriation, the purpose of the NFT also might be read as a response to it, seeking to preserve the intended (market) value of the artwork.



The screenshot was already connected to Hito Steyerl's concept of 'poor image'²⁷ by Švelch that generates in digital environments and is marked by its low resolution, lack of focus, easy reproducibility and shareability. Steyerl writes:

The poor image is a copy in motion. Its quality is bad, its resolution substandard. As it accelerates, it deteriorates. It is a ghost of an image, a preview, a thumbnail, an errant idea, an itinerant image distributed for free, squeezed through slow digital connections, compressed, reproduced, ripped, remixed, as well as copied and pasted into other channels of distribution.

Not only is the screenshot a poor image, but it is also a free image, especially when conceived in the context of NFTs and digital artworks. Steyerl notes that the poor image lacks focus, due to its usually low resolution, which she also connects to the visual and narrative purpose of focus – to denote power – “focus is identified as a class position, a position of ease and privilege while being out of focus lowers one’s value as an image.” Taking another step in this direction, NFTs direct focus from the visual and material properties of an image to the digital certificate of ownership in order to position the artwork’s value. Given that a digital artwork can be screenshotted, and NFT (as an operational piece of code) cannot, the digital information of the screenshot as an image is stripped from the information of the original image.

Kelly Pendergrast writes²⁸ on her screenshotting practices as a type of imagistic resistance to the corporate platform culture that extracts data and metadata from the endless flow of images it receives from the users:

27 Hito Steyerl, “In Defense of the Poor Image,” *e-flux Journal* no. 10 (November 2009), <https://www.e-flux.com/journal/10/61362/in-defense-of-the-poor-image/>

28 Kelly Pendergrast, “Screen Memories,” *Real Life Mag*, January 14, 2021, <https://reallifemag.com/screen-memories/>

The act of screenshotting an image (rather than downloading it) strips out the metadata from the original photograph, and I don't necessarily attribute the artist if I share. [...] The screenshot is a gesture that lays claim to the act of seeing, and turns the framing and capturing of an image that often contains a mixture of windows and picture fields (a web page, a Microsoft Word window, all of it) into an act of creating anew. The old metadata: Gone! In its place, my image, with fresh data and the pleasingly prosaic file name "Screen Shot 2020-12-01 at 9.54.48 PM."

By disrupting the circulation of data by creating a new piece of visual and digital information, the screenshot taker actively disrupts the traceability and computability of the image which could be used for surveillance and governance on the side proprietary digital platforms. The lack of original metadata in screenshots, whether they represent minted artworks or any other digital image, means shifting the focus and agency from the coded to the visual, as that is also the only realm accessible to most computer and smartphone users.

In her account of poor images, Steyerl notes that they create 'visual bonds', which is a term by Russian avant-garde filmmaker Dziga Vertov:

This "visual bond" was, according to Vertov, supposed to link the workers of the world with each other. He imagined a sort of communist, visual, Adamic language that could not only inform or entertain, but also organize its viewers.

By being devoid of monetary value, as well as useful metadata, screenshots are digital images with primarily visual quality, providing the users to establish visual bonds to other users and their respective digital environments, through their aesthetic, affective and informational purposes.

Data Gathering, Image Surveillance

Apart from its aesthetic possibilities, one of the screenshot's functions lies in its documentary nature. Frosh explains the documentary aspect of the screenshot as an archival and epistemic practice, which, when coupled with the heightened iconicity and indexicality of screenshot, points to the intensified visual aspect of the screenshot as a digital document – "documenting is an epistemic practice: the kind of knowing that is all wrapped up with showing, and showing wrapped with knowing."²⁹

29 Paul Frosh, *The Poetics of Digital Media*, Cambridge (MA): MIT Press, 2018.

Frances Corry presented a study on the potential harm of screenshot's documentarity.³⁰ She chose to focus on two events, one that pertained to the use of screenshots to expose a sexual predator, and the other one to the misfortunate event of teenage suicide caused by exposing the private content of her videos via screenshotting and distributing the images. In her analysis, Corry offers a perspective on screenshots as images that

move digital information between the walls of seemingly private (e.g., one-to-one communication) or privatized realms (e.g., proprietary platforms) and public display, just as they threaten to save and circulate media that was assumed to be ephemeral. In each, they play with the expected boundaries of digital time and space.

She notes that screenshots in that sense make manifest Wendy Chun's and Sarah Friedland's concept of leakiness in the digital realm that presupposes the "simultaneously breaching and sustaining assumed boundaries between public and private." In both analyzed cases, the screenshotting practice manifests the power of the digital observer to preserve the instant of the fluid digital environment (that is also composed of other people and not only machines) and leverage or abuse that evidence to their liking.



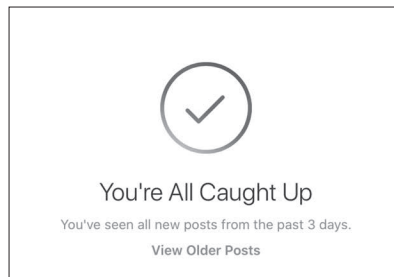
Though the power of screenshots can be present and very significant as a catalyst of such extreme cases, it is also a fundamental part of much more mundane situations. Snapchat famously lets users know when their messages and sent photos are being screenshotted, in order to preserve the sense of transparency and security of its users that might deal with sensitive content while communicating with their peers. Kaitlyn Tiffany, in her account on screenshots, notes that the screenshot facilitates "the idea that anything and everything you do online could be—and let's face it, probably is—captured by someone, somewhere, and then stored for future use, has imbued our lives online with

30 Frances Corry, "Screenshot, Save, Share, Shame: Making Sense of New Media Through Screenshots and Public Shame," *First Monday* 26, no. 4: <https://firstmonday.org/ojs/index.php/fm/article/view/11649/10107>

a latent sense of paranoia.³¹ Screenshots, in their everyday use, are used as an instrument of surveillance — peer-to-peer or lateral surveillance, as Mark Andrejevic names this type of surveillance produced by the pervasiveness of watching practices instituted by social media.³²

No Shot Like the Screenshot

As a very rudimentary medium, that more or less only allows its users to freeze and save the instant of their digital environment in the same way it is shown to them, screenshot tells a lot about the dynamics of the relationship of humans with their indispensable screens and different types of functions and values of the image in this screen-mediated environment. Screenshot continues to be framed and determined by the visible and invisible possibilities of the screen of its origin, as well as the eager and curious user who aims to establish a connection with it through the act of screenshotting. Similar to what we think we know about technical image-making, but simultaneously exceeding it and being embedded within the ephemeral images of computer and smartphone screens, the screenshot exists as a covert and simplified symptom of the complex web of relations users are subjected to in their everyday 'time-wasting'



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31 Kaitlyn Tiffany, "Screenshots Are the Gremlins of the Internet," *The Atlantic*, June 1, 2021, <https://www.theatlantic.com/technology/archive/2021/06/screenshots-gremlins-internet/619062/>

32 Mark Andrejevic, 'The work of watching one another: Lateral surveillance, risk, and governance', *Surveillance & Society* 2.4 (2005): 479-497.

ENTROPYPOSTING OR THE ART OF SABOTAGING YOUR ONLINE SELF

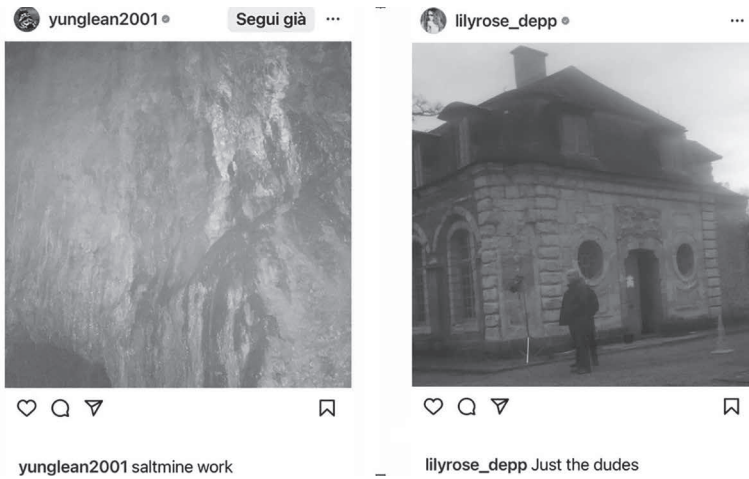
ARIANNA CASERTA

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In an ocean of perfectly constructed auto narrations, users draft an ode to the "non-readable" in search of the only method to reappropriate the entropic and spectral side of the Internet.

I remember scrolling through Yung Lean's Instagram profile meant trying to decode the rules of a universe nobody knew anything about. Pages full of distorted shapes, ultra-bright objects, mysterious textures and blurry surfaces of dubious origin that create confusion in the comments section. In a virtual ocean of packaged and well-structured Instagram feeds, Lily-Rose Depp - nepo baby on the rise - was posting blurry pictures of herself and her friends. Ugly, unpolished photos, depicting actions far more ordinary than was expected of someone her status. Her profile repelled—and at the same time fed—the frenzied appetite for gossip. Translated into a spasmodic hunt for clues that would reveal her luxurious lifestyle, fans were digging into the folds of her personal online narrative. Why were these people using Instagram in the exact opposite way it was meant to? Why were they, on purpose, offering their audience something so ambiguous and unreadable?

Today's users have more than absorbed the aesthetics of the undecipherable, causing its rules to be able to spill over into every field of the visual landscape: design, fashion, beauty, performative and figurative art. But the intense adoration for entropyposting—the impulse of sharing non-decodable and unreadable information online—goes far beyond the luminescent hyperpop-esque imagery cleverly manufactured by Drain Gang. And far deeper than any product that lo-fi aesthetics has ever spawned. As much as I recollect its form, entropyposting doesn't even resemble the primitive act of "Instagram dumping", sometimes affiliated with Shitposting. The latter is about an effortless, unbothered, post-ironic narration: it is about merging into the chasm of images online. Entropyposting is exactly the opposite. It is cryptical, mysterious, sorcerous, and complex: it forces you to stop and take a pause from the chasm, trying to decrypt something. It is - if anything - closer to a method of pushing technology to its limits, generating useless content and making social interactions less clear and progressively more complicated.



Screenshots from Yung Lean's and Lily-Rose Depp's Instagram

There is something about the anti-glamorous attitude of these celebrities sharing unappealing, blurry, badly cropped, crooked, or extremely pixelated images that are reminiscent of the uncommitted and often boring way of dressing that some super-rich people like to be seen in public.¹ As Caroline Busta writes in "The internet didn't kill counterculture-you just won't find it on Instagram":²

"Away from the parades, palaces, and disproportionate girths of modern-day strongmen like Viktor Orbán, Kim Jong Un and Donald Trump, the most iconic features you'll find among the big tech set are more likely to be a black turtleneck, a Patagonia fleece jacket, and the absence of handbags."

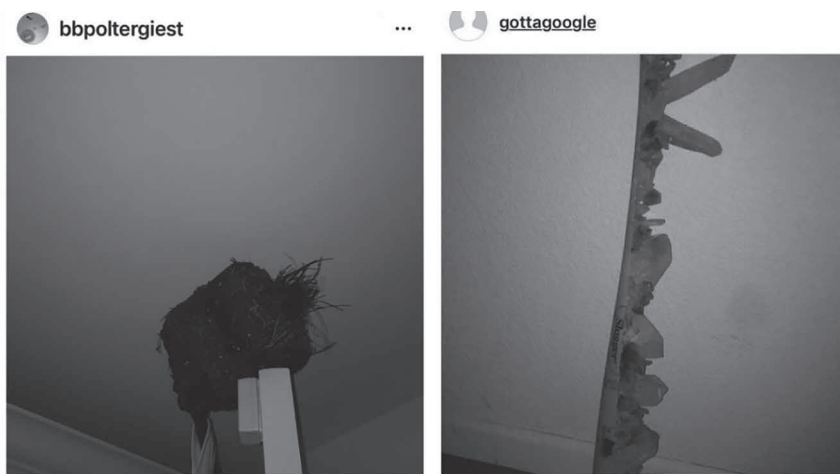
Busta suggests that "real power keeps a low profile because it doesn't need a social media presence: it owns it." This is one hypothesis: celebrities do not need to try. Their game has already been played, and their engagement stays unchanged. They do not follow the algorithm: they shape it.

The truth is that one cannot think of entropyposting (as we know it today) only as a way to betray the platform. Like every other Internet trend, entropyposting is far from being a rebellion against technological hegemony: rather, it is once again a disposable way of representing oneself online; a *modus operandi* ready to catch up with users all over the world until it disappears to make way for the next trend.

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- 1 Simon Usborne. "Mark Zuckerberg and the Art of Being Smart Casual." *The Independent*, November 10, 2014.
 - 2 Caroline Busta. "The internet didn't kill counterculture — you just won't find it on Instagram." *Document Journal*, January 14, 2021.

However, there is no limit when unreadability becomes the *Zeitgeist*: if it's true celebrities narrate themselves in lowkey terms to betray their audience's craving for information, the final stage of entropyposting resembles anything but a way to go unnoticed. The denial of gossip, glitz, and information pornography to the voyeuristic user has shown the latter something unfamiliar: if the 'degree of disorder' rises, it increases its non-readability and unpredictability. A rise in disorder corresponds to an increase in entropy, and entropy—understood as the measure of the complexity in a message—creates information. Clear information gives less information than a glossy non-entropic narrative would. Instead, a complex narrative generates curiosity, answers unasked questions, doesn't stop at the surface, and triggers the creation of infinite possible worlds.

The key, then, is to find something that forces a break in the flow, that demands more attention. And in a world of perfectly structured Instagram reels, TikTok formats and trends, pre-packaged branded posts with their appropriate #adv hashtag, and social media management courses that teach step-by-step how to beat the algorithm, content slips by our attention as if it never laid on it before. The only way to resist? Increase the degree of disorder. Force the user to pause for more than the 2.5 seconds of maximum attention span calculated by social media analytics. Add entropifying to one's own online narrative.



Screenshots from Death Grips' Instagram posts

But the music industry is the cradle of more than just one aesthetic shift: the creepy Instagram profile of Sacramento trio Death Grips lends itself to entropyposting theories to such an extent that it may provide a visual essay for it. With music videos and album covers designed to trigger the madness and curiosity of Reddit users worldwide, the trio pioneered the art of entropyposting by paving the way for the *L'Âge d'Or* it is undergoing today (yes, all your friends have shared a still from the *Guillotine* video at least once, no matter the context). These are semantic stimuli that are impossible to categorize, and complex to

approach except with a cynical, sneering, post-ironic attitude: authorless remnants on the fringes of that glossy Internet that you believe you rule at the click of a button, with its reassuring windows, annoying pop-ups and well-distributed hierarchies; interfaces whose every secret we are certain to know.

The idea of the 'digital wreckage' has been pondered most of all by English experimental musician and visual artist Dean Blunt. It is shocking to trace his influence in so many musical scenes that have arisen in the very last few years in Europe: godfather of a certain sub-genre of avant-garde pop and, since 2012, founder of the music label World Music, Blunt is considered one of the most prolific figures in Internet music, famous for always imagining his production in a contradictory, ubiquitous, multifaceted aesthetic flow, where different stimuli overlap, refusing the dynamics of a market that conceives a musical product as a well-packaged object dictated by the reins of majors.

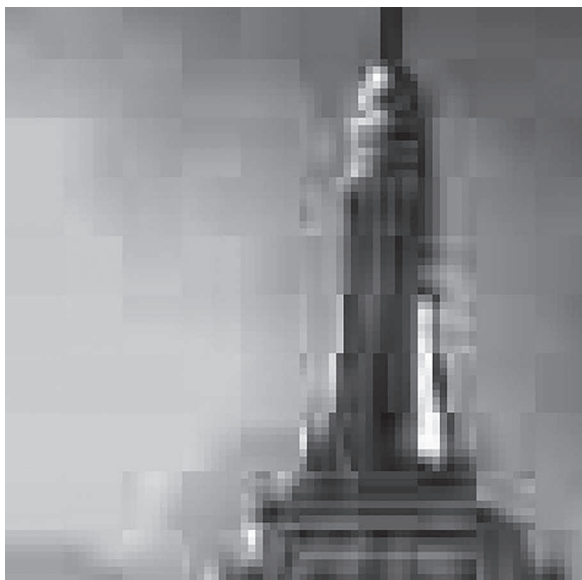
Starting in the 2010s, the Insta account World Music released covers of hundreds of singles and mixtapes drawing on unprecedented art direction: pixelated screenshots from Facebook homes, photos downloaded from Google Images in the worst possible quality, underwhelming graphics created in Paint, triumphs of Comic Sans, stretched emojiis, and stock images. With those projects with such ambiguous visual identities released on Bandcamp, World Music declared itself against a hierarchy of images, - and music - poking fun at the somewhat clumsy care with which artists curated their projects, underestimating the fact that they would be dispersed across the web along with all the other nomadic images and sounds that take part in the stream. Dean Blunt and World Music caused a *détournement*: instead of trying to emerge, they were preoccupied with blending perfectly into the cacophonous landscape of information of all types and forms, to navigate the Web aimlessly, authorless, recipientless. That is, until the abstraction of the *Black Metal* album (apologies to Kanye West and his Donda, which came much later).

Direct descendants of Dean Blunt's heritage, the Spanish visual artist duo Fomotrauma, associated with the Spanish label Rusia IDK, is the best example of the impact of world music operations on digital natives: a new school of artists that take their cue from the exauthoring of newly created images, ready instead to give context back to the precious digital junk that is destined to be lost and rediscovered in an endless cycle of downloads and screenshots.

In the paranoid loop of content suggested to users according to their darkest inclinations, new generations of users are interested in bringing backscattered images, giving entropy to the interface to try and break free from a constrained system, and bringing uncertainty back into preconfigured patterns. The Internet has always been spoken of as something extremely close to magic, a black box of spectres that has more in common with ghosts than with codes. But how much abstraction is allowed in a system made of interfaces?

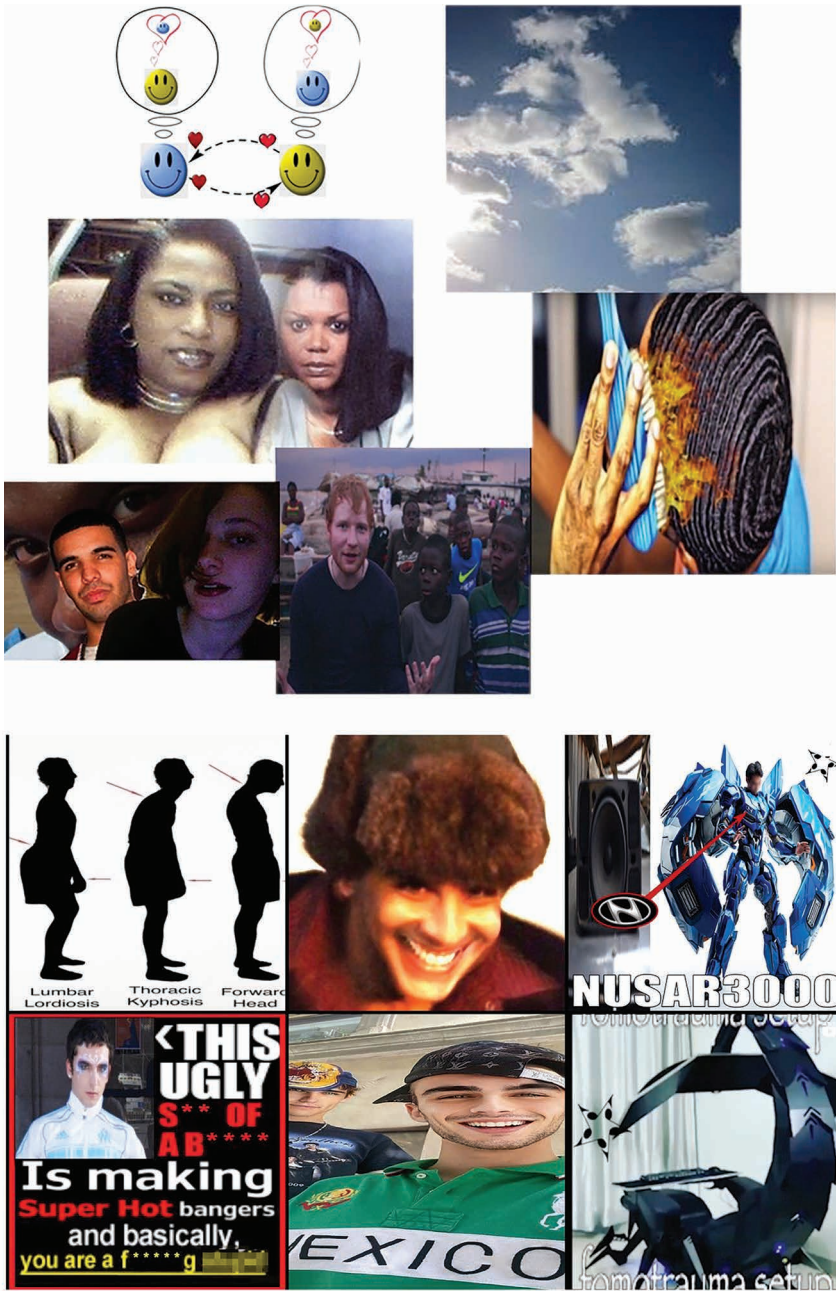
Entropyposting is a practice of compressions, reiterations, confused processes, of fascination with all visual impulses that are difficult to place, with no point of departure and therefore no point of arrival. Something that resembles the immateriality of a GAN-generated image or a portrait by Gerhard Richter, who worked on that inaccessibility that only mass-media reproduction can give to an image. Or even as in the case of American photographer Thomas Ruff's JPEGs series, - composed of images downloaded from the Internet and resized to worsen their quality to the maximum - or the spray paintings by Turin-based artist WOC, which crudely reproduces iconic pop culture images by worsening something we'd be able to enjoy in 4K.

The world of art microcelebrities has more than absorbed the spirit of the times of which entropyposting is the child: the highly followed profiles of art director Ben Ditto (or as Interview Mag recently called him, "The Renaissance Man of the Internet Age"³) seem like dark portals to gore, horror, and ironic images, all fused together in an exquisitely pop way. The founder and editor-in-chief of Coeval Magazine, Donald Gjoka, holds the same power: his Internet activity enraptures and confuses, portraying an online dimension where AI-created images, post-ironic memes, and childish drawings coexist on the same surface.



JPEG, Thomas Ruff

3 Interview. "Meet Ben Ditto, The Guy Meme-ing His Way Through War." *Interview Magazine*, March 14, 2022. <https://www.interviewmagazine.com/culture/search-history-meet-ben-ditto-the-guy-meme-ing-his-way-through-war>

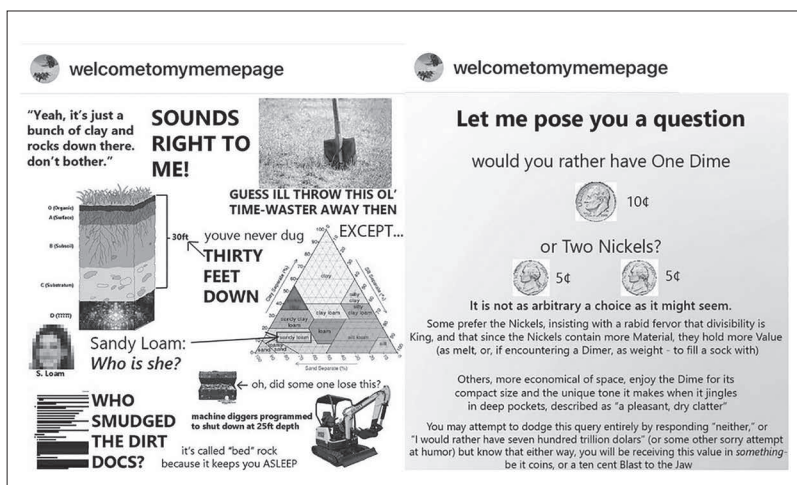


A selection of album covers from World Music projects (Dean Blunt, Bar Italia, Inga Copeland, Hype Williams), 2009–2023 and posts from Fomotrauma's Instagram profile

Debunking the idea that every trend is destined to disappear over time, the aesthetic trend that has most powerfully devirtualized the practice of Entropyposting is definitely permanent: tattoos. The aesthetic has translated its hallmarks into messy, twisted, web-like designs that resemble time-worn manuscripts or the glitchy interface of a poorly designed website. In the world of moving images, director Ryan Trecartin embodies the beating heart of entropyposting practices by presenting himself as a leader of chaotic imaginaries and a narrator of worlds of absolute digital schizophrenia, where every scene seems to come straight from a home video shot by teenagers caught in collective hysteria, or from the darkest corners of the deep web.⁴

For the same reasons, meme culture has begun to revolve around cryptic infographics and all-text images. As Biz Sherbert explains in the essay "Intimacy and the Machine: Godposting – or: New Internet Esotericism", today's kabbalistic graphics macerate and reject hyper-readability by swallowing perfectly curated, user-friendly blocks of text and turning them into something deliberately hard to read, something viscous enough to tickle the brain's grooves before thought slips over them and is already clicking on the next story.⁵ In Talk Magazine, writer Alexi Alario, adds, "that's why the unnecessary complexity and baroque-ness of these charts are so appealing: because they force us to spend time decoding something."

Sans Serif? Out. Deep-fried fonts and overlapping elements? In. And no, sorry, you will not be able to consume this meme in 0.3 seconds. You'll have to wait and read the whole thing before (maybe) you can be rewarded with a dopamine rush.



4 Ryan Trecartin. I-Be Area. 2007. Digital color video with sound, 128 min. Solomon R. Guggenheim Museum, New York, <https://www.guggenheim.org/artwork/22506>.

5 Biz Sherbert. "Intimacy and the Machine: Godposting – or: New Internet Esotericism." Various Artists. September 15, 2021, <https://various-artists.com/godposting/>.

The visual landscape has completely changed. Tired of the vulgar, didactical, and all-too-obvious content that TikTok stars keep shoving down our throats, we now know that we have to aim for closure, restlessness, mystery, for silence. We want to decode, not be decoded.

In the essay "In Defense of the Poor Image", published in November 2009 for Issue #10 of e-flux, artist Hito Steyerl defined the implications of sharpness in establishing class privilege, where the "poor" image, "a rag or a rip, an AVI or a JPEG, a file whose name is deliberately misspelled" is opposed to the privileged position of high resolution, ("Focus is identified as a class position"), legitimizing itself in opposition with the violent dislocation and circulation of audio-visual debris without credibility. It is Hito Steyerl herself who points to an essential change, a major semiotic shift where the phenomenon of poor images fits perfectly:

"On the one hand, [the poor image] works against the fetish value of high resolution. On the other hand, this is precisely why it ends up fitting perfectly into an information capitalism that thrives on compressed attention spans, on impression rather than immersion, on intensity rather than contemplation, on previews rather than visions."

Born in response to the privatization of online narratives - where every post is commodified and serves to give a very specific piece of information - entropyposting is not structured to signify, but to counter-signify. Seeking to diverge, however, the territory of poor imagery lends itself to the more distinctive dynamics of capitalism: narratives lose matter and gain speed, and their inability to focus makes room for submissiveness.

Restoring importance to the magma of pixels by making fun of those same images and the way they spread so quickly is a way of feeling like the Web Makers of one's own destiny, of restoring the Internet to something fickle, imperfect, failing, and non-corporate. If the promise of Web 3.0 is a user-centred Internet, the natural motion is to break up the interface or to go against it to the point of interference. But if the interface adapts, it grows new limbs, like a multifaceted self-regenerating monster.

Please, beware of your entropyposter friends who suddenly delete all the photos from their social media accounts, change their user name to an endless code of letters and numbers and suddenly share a blurry screenshot of a video game interface or the overexposed photo of a garbage dumpster seen on a back road to their parents' house.

On the Internet, nothing is truly spontaneous or dictated by instinct. Our profiles are no different from the walls of an art gallery or museum: everything posted is a symbol of something that can be deciphered and understood in its context. Just like a ready-made that acquires new meaning when displayed in a fancy gallery, each of our enigmatic contents hides a secret message. We're aiming to be obscure, to convince ourselves that we have finally come to understand something that no one else can ever come close to

grasp. We have had enough of internet microtrends, the endless little niches that suddenly turn mainstream. We are tired of coming face to face with the fact that we are all, hopelessly, inevitably, the same. We long for individuality, not globalization. And the saddest thing? Instagram is far from saving us. Because nothing, absolutely nothing is too complex for users. And if entropy is the Zeitgeist, there is no secret anymore: we've discovered it already.

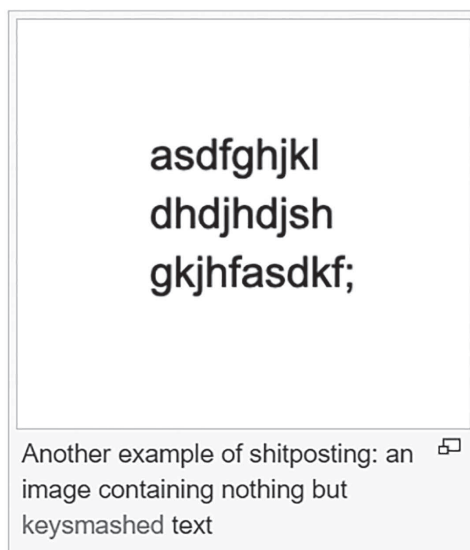
Arianna Caserta (Rome, 2001) is a writer and researcher focusing on online identities, post-internet art, and the intersections between film and internet culture. Her work has appeared in online magazines including *Dazed*, *i-D*, *032c* and *Nero Editions*. She holds a BA in Film and Photography, where she wrote her thesis about teen nihilism in cinema, and she's currently a MA student in Film Theory, where she investigates the links between cinema and digital culture.

FROM SHITPOSTING TO SHITPUBLISHING

EZEQUIEL SORIANO

Originally published on February 10th, 2025

These last years I have been spending my time publishing nonsensical books¹ of illegible, plagiarized, stunning, low-quality, sublime, and uncanny content. I was developing a weird publishing project that aimed to grasp the *extremely online* poetics, displacing shitty content from forums, wikis, and digital platforms into books. Practicing *trollish literature*. These books display cursed memes, poorly translated novels, *keysmashed* text, random images, *lorem ipsums*, YouTube comments, Wikipedia graffiti, niche forum discussions, motivational quotes, spam, ai-generated blog entries, pixelated and saturated photos, boring amateur poems, and automatic video transcriptions. In this article, I describe these publishing experiments as attempts to go from shitposting to shitpublishing.



Screenshot of Shitposting article in Wikipedia <https://en.wikipedia.org/w/index.php?title=Shitposting&oldid=1189859960> (or a keysmashed haiku)

1 <https://www.artefactosnativos.com/>

Definitions

Wikipedia describes *shitposting* as “the act of using an online forum or social media page to post content that is satirical and of ‘aggressively, ironically, and trollishly poor quality’”. The most liked definition of *shitposting* in the Urban Dictionary says:



Screenshot of urban dictionary definition of 'Shitposting' by thesinner6666

However, the most flavored shitpublishing definitions linger in the shadows of these web pages. One of the last definitions on Urban Dictionary is:



In the Shitposting Wikipedia article, on the 10th of November 2017, someone with the IP 204.109.101.63, erased the description of *shitpost* to copy-paste the entire script of Christopher Nolan's *The Dark Knight Rises*. In these shitposting gestures, we can identify the core idea of *shitpublishing*. Shitpublishing is shitposting in *literary* contexts, such as books, an encyclopedia, academic journal, or journalist articles.



A screenshot of the first talk entry of Wikiedia's *Shitposting* article.

Spamming Books

Shitposting is about spamming, about flooding online communication with nonsensical rubbish. It is similar to the gesture of shouting in a public debate or pasting stickers on informative posters in the street. *Shitpublishing* is about categorizing these acts as done work, translating these oral gestures into literary or written 'knowledge'. It turns *trash-talking* into *trash-writing*.

From a literary perspective, shitposting engages with text in its material dimension. It takes into account the materiality of language. As Goldsmith wrote about Mallarme's poetry: "words are no longer primarily transparent content carriers; now their material quality must be considered as well"². *Keysmashing* gives letters the same materiality that many modernist poets were experimenting with. It creates pieces of internet vernacular literature that are not meant to be read but to be weighed.



Amazon Screenshot of the books *ASDFGH* by Asdfgh

Shitpublishing approaches book-making in the same materialist way. Amazon hosts several books of this *keys mashed* shitpublishing 'microgenre'. Books like *Asdfgh* by Asdf Asdfg and ASD dfg, *asdfgh* (Japanese Edition), *(Transparency) US - Cover creator or PDF Upload without checking checkbox* by asdfgh, *Marja: abhi marja* by asdfg asdf, or *safg* by asdf.

2 Kenneth Goldsmith, *Uncreative Writing*, Columbia University Press, 2011.

These *keysmashed* books embody the fast, lazy, and materialist approach of shitposting. Shitpublishing focuses on the formal qualities of the books rather than their communicative qualities. eBooks are seen as digital artifacts that can be thrown, spammed, flood a platform, or be used as a trollish authority referenced in an online discussion.

With their project *Kindle'voke Ghost Writers* (2012), the Austrian artistic and publishing collective *Traumawien* flooded Amazon's self-publishing platform with thousands of eBooks, exploiting a vulnerability in the upload system. The covers of these books imitate the iconic Willy Fleckhaus design of *Suhrkamp Verlag* editions, but under this reliable design, they hide textual rubbish. The content, typeset as canonical dramas, was entirely composed of comments scraped from YouTube. The act of spamming the Amazon marketplace with interventionist, interface-specific literature,³ was a shitpublishing gesture which used digital publications as projectile weapons.

The *Kindle'voke Ghost Writers* books function solely as data. As a cover; a product for Amazon to catalog and manage, and as a document that *occupies* space on the platform's servers. As conceptual writing works, these books are calling for a "thinkership" rather than a "readership"⁴. But beyond this artistic framing, in the context of Amazon's workers, these books are not calling for a "readership", nor a "thinkership", but a "managership": meaning that someone has to organize this data to prevent obfuscation of the platform's digital shelves.

Besides the aggressive quality of this gesture, *Kindle'voke Ghost Writers* also plays on a more symbolic dimension of shitpublishing. It turns YouTube comments into literature. This conceptual publishing project is a shitpost play that challenges the notions of what is deemed worthy of being published in a book. It muddles the distinctions between literature and content, users and authors, posting and publishing. Like Angela Genusa's *Spam Bibliography*, a book that presents all emails received in her spam folder between September 2012 and March 2013, formatted as a bibliography and sorted alphabetically. This work is described in the Library of Artistic Print on Demand (apod.li) as a "unique representation [which] makes spam messages appear as objects worth documenting and investigating".

3 Karl Wolfgang Flender, "Literary Forkbombs: Interventionist Conceptual Writing in the Age of Amazon", *Hyperrhiz*, no. 20, (2019), doi:10.20415/hyp/020.net01.

4 Vanessa Place & Robert Fitterman, *Notes on Conceptualisms*, Ugly Duckling Presse, 2009.



The Uncanny Book Valley 1: POD

Shitpublishing defines the uncanny book valley. These *things* are made to look like books, but if you approach them as a “readership” you will have an *unheimlich* experience. These oddly familiar publications inhabit the margins of what is publishable. They are positioned somewhere between real books that sound fake and fake books that could be real. To *experience* this, we only need to have a look at Tim Holman's collection Always Judge a Book by its Cover, a list of strange books he found on Amazon with titles like:

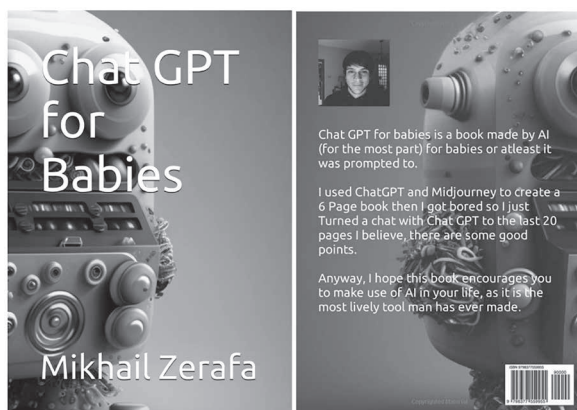
How to Talk to Your Cat About Gun Safety

I Don't Care if My Best Friend's Mom is a Sasquatch, She's Hot and I'm Taking a Shower With Her

How to Raise Your I.Q. by Eating Gifted Children

Sun-Beams May Be Extracted from Cucumbers, But the Process Is Tedious. an Oration, Pronounced on the Fourth of July, 1799. at the Request of the Citizens of New-Haven. by David Daggett

But nowadays, due to the popularization of generative AI tools, these kinds of lists will contain much weirder books. Look no further than books authored by chatGPT on Amazon. There are fascinating uncanny titles like *The AI Cookbook V: "Mindful Munchies: AI Wellness"* by George R. Martin III, *The Ai-Eye of Argon: Or, I Wrote a Novel with A.I. Assistance, But You Probably Should Not* by Martin Berman-Gorvine or *Chat GPT for Babies* by MR Mikhail Zerafa.



But let's take it one step at a time. There are two milestones in the development of shit-publishing: Print on Demand (POD) platforms and ChatGPT. Desktop publishing on POD platforms, like lulu or Amazon, expanded the limits of publishing, thereby approaching the uncanny book valley. The automation and the speediness of the publishing process on these platforms is closing the gap between posting and publishing. Publishing something on lulu only takes 15 minutes longer than posting something on a blog. And even though for a lot of internet goblins, 15 minutes is an eternity, for others, those minutes are well spent turning internet rubbish into something greater.

This was the case for many of the authors published on Troll Thread. The cover of Chris Sylvester's *STILL LIFE WITH THE POKÉMON YELLOW VERSION TEXT DUMP IN 30 PT. MONACO FONT JUSTIFIED TO MARGIN DISTRIBUTED AS A PDF OR A BOOK CONVERTED FROM A MICROSOFT WORD DOCUMENT BY CHRIS SYLVESTER 2012/2013* depicts a mail from Ashugi Kamaguchi that exemplifies the relevance of trolling in shitpublishing. Trolling about authorship, originality, authenticity, urgency, value, and hard work:

Shitpublishing is a performance that implies the gesture of publishing. We should not interpret these creative acts by actually reading the books, but through considering the act of publishing. However, publishing creates *things* that remain. Shitpublishing gestures produce ambivalent books that live on despite their ephemeral nature, generating new temporalities. This is where the uncanny character lies. These books are glitches in literary technology, mirroring the implicit decontextualization of the very act of writing and publishing.

Similar to many performers, shitpublishers engaged in this materialistic, appropriationist, and fast approach, challenge cultural valorization. They produce artifacts that question the notion of the book as an instrument of knowledge. This is the case for Holaquehase's book *Art Garfunkel ha leído más libros que tú* [Art Garfunkel has read more books than you have], which compiled all the books read by the singer since 1960, posted by him on his website. Also, Gregor Weichbrodt published a brilliant comment on hard work and artistic valorization

in his *Dictionary of Non-notable Artists*. After his Wikipedia page was nominated for deletion from the German Wikipedia, Gregor wrote a Python script to download the contents of every "article for deletion"-page from the past ten years and filtered the results by artistic occupation, subsequently publishing a dictionary dedicated to these artists.



Kelly Karivalis <kkariva1@ccp.edu>

Jan 31 (4 days ago)

to me

let's be real here. this is specifically directed to the "poet" who believes that she is writing "poetry" by copying the narration of Pokemon Yellow onto a Microsoft Word document readily available for download. i am the original writer of that text; i am the person who translated the text into english from japanse for the 1999 release of the GameBOy Color game Pokemon Yellow. I do not appreciate your associated "poet" copying my work word-for-word and passing it off as her own poetry in a different format. firstly, the original format of the script is better than a Microsoft Word version. secondly, i worked for five years writing the words that your "poet" is passing as her own. thirdly, nobody reads your "poetry" anyway. firstly, it takes to long to read. secondly, i get about five pages in and get so bored i stop reading. thirdly, all of your poetry is copied from other people. you may think that you are taking "non-poetic" work and making it poetic by taking it out of context. however, you have no respect for the original writer and their idea and their intended context for the words. i wrote Pokemon Yellow with full intention that it would be presented solely in the Gameboy Color format. it does not resonate in the Microsoft Word format. finally, from what i can gather through internet research, you and the majority of yoru associated poets are students at the university of penn. i ask you this: if you are willing to pay countless dollars for your meaningless edducation are you will ing to pay countless dollars to pay me my due respects as an author? i don't think so, so stop claiming other people's work as your own. the world doesn't need a living literary version of duchamp anyway this world is full of enough bullshitters thank you and GOOD BYE!!

~~~~~Ashugi Kamaguchi~~~~~

Cover of *STILL LIFE WITH THE POKÉMON YELLOW VERSION TEXT DUMP IN 30 PT. MONACO FONT JUSTIFIED TO MARGIN DISTRIBUTED AS A PDF OR A BOOK CONVERTED FROM A MICROSOFT WORD DOCUMENT BY CHRIS SYLVESTER 2012/2013*, by Chris Sylvester

Among many shitpublishers, the performative trolling character of the books is related to *hacking*. Sometimes, *Poetry* or *Art* functions as a hack to publicize things while avoiding legal issues. *Money by Maker*, for example, is a book consisting of 740 pages of scanned hundred dollar bills. When printed by someone, the publisher, TROLL THREAD PRESS, cannot be

held legally responsible for potential misuse, even though they don't discourage it either. But besides the daring imagination of printing money, in 2018, Paul Soulellis published *Steve, Harvey and Matt (2018)*, another 734 page artist book used to publicize sensitive political material. Soulellis describes the book on his github as follows:

This project [...] restores access to 1,964 climate change-related URLs that were removed from [www.EPA.gov](http://www.EPA.gov) on April 28, 2017. The URLs point to web pages, documents, presentations, publications, and other files that were purged by the U.S. Environmental Protection Agency under the direction of EPA Administrator Scott Pruitt and the Trump administration. Some of the assets had been accessible on the web since 1997. [...] The 734-page printed book contains EPA emails and spreadsheets that detail the purge, obtained by Freedom of Information Act requests

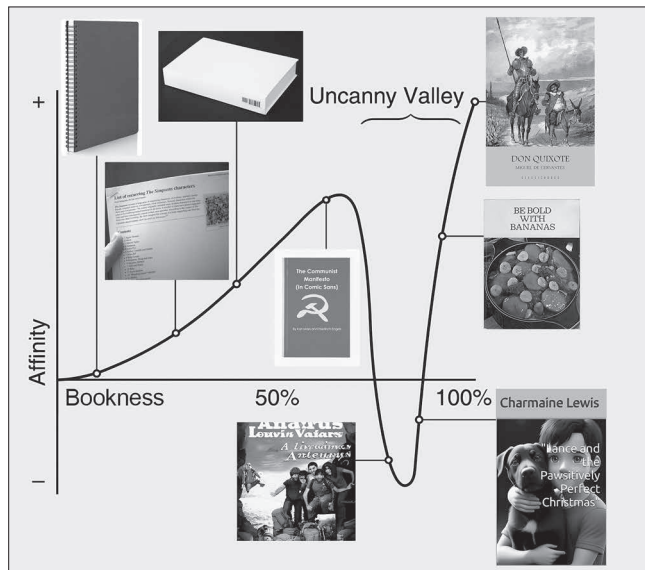
Soulellis' gesture of publicizing emails through the medium of a book or installation is also reflected by Kenneth Goldsmith's book *HILLARY: The Hillary Clinton Emails*, which compiled all emails sent from the [clintonemail.com](mailto:clintonemail.com) domain between 2009 and 2013 as "an anti-monument to the folly of Trump's heinous smear campaign against Clinton". Both Soulellis and Goldsmith instrumentalized the literary format to publicize relevant political information.

But for most shitpublishers, it is only about *expanded shitposting*; about spreading shit in different formats, embracing the mutability and the hybridness of the digital world. Like *Primera antología poética Los subtítulos de las batallas de gallos [First poetry anthology The subtitles of the rap battles]*, a book made up of YouTube automated subtitles of rap battles. This book begins with the paradigmatic sentence: "to all those fans of rap battles, if you truly like it, you like it anyway". Or *Cedeira Miope [Shortsighted Cedeira]* a book of low-definition 144p images of a Galician town. Or *Soccer Smoker*, a zine composed exclusively of b/n photographs of soccer players smoking. Or *Tutorial de Paella Clásica*, a printed powerpoint presentation created by the author's father about how to cook a Paella.

## The Uncanny Book Valley 2. The Advent of chatGPT

With the advent of ChatGPT, StableDiffusion, and other broadly used generative AI tools, shitpublishing created a deeper uncanny book valley. The power of Large Language Models (LLMs) overpassed the gesture of publishing appropriated materials from the internet, copy-pasted non-sensical rubbish, classified material, or even entire websites. LLMs can produce realistic textual *artifacts* that meet the expectations of what a book should look and feel like. ChatGPT is capable of producing originality, legibility, and common rhetorical and literary figures just as quickly as copy-pasting. Now, lazy and fast books look more like actual books and, at the same time, they have become much more unpleasant and uncanny than copy-pasted books.





*The Uncanny Book Valley.* 1) A notebook; 2) List of recurring *The Simpsons* characters (Amperamp Press, 2013); 3) *Blank On Demand* by Silvio Lorusso and Giulia Ciliberto; 4) *The Communist Manifesto (in Comic Sans)* by Friedrich Engels and Karl Marx; 5) *Los amigos de la aventura* by Dan Wislow; 6) “*Lance and the Pawsitively Perfect Christmas*” by Charmaine Lewis; 7) *Be bold with bananas* by Fruit Distributors Ltd; 8) *Don Quixote* by Miguel de Cervantes.

I have some paradigmatic examples of these AI generated shitbooks in my virtual library. I found lots of children books, like Mahlon Berv's *A Journey Through Time - The World's History For Kids*, described as “The World's History, as taught by famous personalities such as Nelson Mandela, Bruce Lee, Marie Antoinette”; or Cynthia Maitland's 3-pages book *Billy the Brave Bull Terrier: A Tale of Self-Acceptance and Kindness*. Other uncanny gems include: *Poet V: A Collection of AI-Generated Poetry About Compassion for all Beings*, *Options for the end of the world* by chatGPT: *In this book, chatGPT will consider the most popular options for the end of the world and give their prediction of probability*, *Bitcoin Fixes This* or *The Art of War Chat GPT: A.I. interpretation*. And, of course, there are the missing links between posting and publishing like Joshua Word's books *300 list of movies you can watch this Halloween: 1927 to 2024* or *40 HINDI MOVIES TO WATCH WITH FAMILY ON THIS DIWALI*. All these books, which were authored by chatGPT, inhabit the uncanny valley created by the collision of OpenAI's and Amazon Books' tectonic faults.

LLMs not only accelerate the writing and publishing process, but also the lifespan of books. The temporality of these publications is beyond fast reading or accelerated obsolescence. These books reconfigure conceptual writing and the attention economy in a wild way. They are not meant to be read but to endlessly circulate on Amazon. They are spectral images

of books. Their life span is not fast but immediate. The cover, the title, the description, and the tags are the only content that matters. The content is relegated to the metadata. This idea is brilliantly represented in Chuck Tingle's book *Pounded In The Butt By My Bizarre Assumption That Chuck Tingle Books Are Just Covers And Not Actual Books*.

There are some outstanding moves in the milieu of shitpublishing. Gestures that blur the already blurry environment of fast self-publishing. Chuck Tingle's Amazon Books production employs this accelerated and bizarre flow of shitpublishing and fast self-publishing to create a collection of surreal gay erotica. Kindle books like *Pounded In The Butt By My Handsome Sentient Library Card Who Seems Otherworldly But In Reality Is Just A Natural Part Of The Priceless Resources Our Library System Provides*, *Pounded By The Gay Unicorn Football Squad*, *Absolutely No Thoughts Of Pounding During My Fun Day With This Kind T-Rex Because I'm Aromantic And Asexual And That's A Wonderfully Valid Way Of Proving Love Is Real*, or *Pounded In The Butt By My Book "Pounded In The Butt By My Own Butt"* twist the reality of Amazon shitpublishing. Chuck Tingle creates a game of mirrors within a game of mirrors, publishing slightly real books that look like fake books and are in fact fake books whose fakeness makes them real books.

## **This Is Not the Flood We Expected (or Is It?)**

Similarly to what happened to shitposting, in recent years shitpublishing has become darker. Once upon a time, shitposting consisted of silly playful gestures by a bunch of online nerds. Nowadays, due to infamous characters like Steve Bannon, former adviser to Donald Trump, shitposting is becoming synonymous with far-right, racist, anti-feminist, and transphobic communicational strategies. Bannon's quote exemplifies this turn: "The Democrats don't matter. The real opposition is the media. And the way to deal with them is to flood the zone with shit." Many right-wing parties in the USA, Brazil, Argentina, Germany, Spain or, Netherlands (among many others) have adopted strategies linked to shitposting (from fake news to spam) to flood the zone with hate speech, fear, and anger.

Related to publishing, chatGPT has changed the rules of shitpublishing. As McLuhan (1964) said:

The 'message' of any medium or technology is the change of scale or pace or pattern that it introduces into human affairs. The railway did not introduce movement or transportation or wheel or road into human society, but it accelerated and enlarged the scale of previous human functions.<sup>5</sup>

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5 Marshall McLuhan, *Understanding Media: The Extensions of Man*, Gingko Press, 1964.

Popular LLMs have changed the shitpublishing scale. There have always been crappy children's books, ideologically problematic self-help guides or authors who make a career out of publishing garbage. However, due to chatGPT, these phenomena have grown exponentially.

A few years ago, I published two books that lowkey hacked the cultural capital of authorship: *Un libro según la UNESCO* [A Book According to UNESCO] is a book that publishes the definition of a book by the United Nations agency in 49 pages, the minimum number of pages required by UNESCO for a publication to qualify as a book. And *Una cosa hecha* [One less thing on my bucket list], a book that repeated the sentence "Plant a Tree, Have a Son, Write a Book" as many times as needed to fill 50 pages.

The goal with these books was to give them an ISBN and add them to my CV in order to increase my publications section as a PhD student. A few months later I came across this article: 'A researcher who publishes a study every two days reveals the darker side of science'. Apparently, "Thousands of scientists around the world publish at least one study every five days". It seems that my naive act of hacking the curriculum is an act that is carried out with worse intentions and better means by academics all over the world.

This scenario should lead us to ask ourselves how to deal with the new scale of "flooding the zone with shit" that LLMs facilitate. The poetic gestures of shitpublishing (from Troll Thread to Chuck Tingle) are exercises that radically mimic broader postdigital publishing dynamics. These artistic gestures emulate the general dynamics of shitpublishing, re-framing these publishing gestures to ambivalently portray the situation. The critical dimension of these literary gestures lies in the fact that they unveil shitpublishing, reframing it as critical and meticulous observation.

Likewise, the artistic exercises of shitpublishing create a necessary reflection on cultural valorization and our understanding of culture or knowledge. They expose a sort of ideological consensus about books being the *guardians of knowledge*. Instead of reproducing a Fahrenheit 451-style critical discourse on censorship, they dismantle the technology of the book as inherently emancipatory.

But these acts of radical mimesis of late-platform capitalism's accelerated dynamics simultaneously reproduce these forms while criticizing them. Shitpublishing is digital publishing accelerationism. And we know that accelerationism is fine for aesthetics but that it is not a wise political tactic. Maybe shitpublishing is as political and activist as avant-garde literature could be. In this article, I have talked about shitpublishing as closely related to hacking. But, considering it in broader political terms, what is it hacking against? Perhaps the very idea of the book, the value given to the written word, or literacy as a technology. If it is those things, then it's the same as in Pop Art, Dadaism or Conceptual Writing. Maybe the political potential is not in the "genre" or the "tool", but in the contexts you flood with shit.

Shitpublishing, of course, pertains to speed and irrelevancy. It is fast publishing but, of course, it is not urgent publishing. *In Here and now? Explorations in Urgent Publishing*, the INC reflects on the fact that 'Despite the promises of the desktop publishing revolution and the immediacy of publishing on the web, acceleration and optimization did not speed up the publishing process as much as hoped for'. Well, maybe it did speed up the publishing process towards weird places that are still unexplored. Towards practices and ways that we must try to understand in order to deal with the undetermined consequences they may bring. Maybe it will cause the fall (or bigger success) of platforms like Amazon Books, or it will challenge the classist approaches to books as cultural goods, and therefore, books will no longer be seen as something inherently positive. Perhaps reading will no longer be synonymous with critical thinking, and that's something I still don't know how to take.

*Special thanks to Diego Asterio for her sharp comments on this text.*

**Ezequiel Soriano** is an anthropologist and artist interested in digital orality, plagiarism, and machine creativity. Through textual experimentation and ethnographic research, he explores everyday practices that play with disciplinary mechanisms in order to disrupt them. His artwork engages with an ordinary, scattered, and tactical creativity that participates in a post-digital medieval carnival. He manages the publishing lab *Artefactos Nativos* and has collaborated with Santa Mònica Arts Centre, Medialab Matadero, La Escocesa, Hangar, CCCB, Xcol, UOC, USC, and the Institute of Network Cultures.



# THEORY OF THE STRETCHED IMAGE

AUGUST KAASA SUNDGAARD

Originally published November 7th, 2025

One day, while doomscrolling *Reels*, I came across a clip from *Family Guy*. It was a scene I remembered from when I was a young teenager: Peter Griffin sitting on a couch prank-calling a refrigerator. Back then, I watched *Family Guy* on my parents' TV. Now I was encountering the same scene on my phone — only this time the originally horizontal video had been stretched so violently to fill Instagram's vertical frame that Peter Griffin, a character known for being visibly overweight, suddenly looked slim.

The stretched (moving) image has proliferated far beyond this reel and has become a staple of Gen Z internet aesthetics. Its exaggerated distortions appear silly and accidental, but its conditions of possibility are anything but.

## #Stretched to fit

Beneath the surface, the stretch image is a networked image, hyperspecific to contemporary platform life. Similar to the poor image<sup>1</sup>, or the deep fried meme<sup>2</sup>, it is both a result of and stained by the infrastructures that circulate it. More specifically, it is birthed by the devices we take photos *with* as well as the limitations imposed by the platforms we post *on*. An iPhone 12, for instance, records in a 4:3 aspect ratio. Yet the platforms demand otherwise: Instagram Stories are locked into 9:16 vertical, posts range between 1.91:1 and 3:4, YouTube defaults to 16:9 horizontal, and so on. As images and videos of different sizes move through these shifting aspect ratio regimes, stretching becomes an effective and "lazy" strategy to adapt content to new platformed contexts. The stretched image is therefore less a stable picture than a contingent cooperation between software, hardware, platforms, and users. In it, we see the tension between *human vision*, which seeks coherence and proportion, and *machinic vision*, which molds images to optimize for circulation, engagement, and profit.

The stretched image is fast and cost-effective, but this efficiency comes at the expense of "quality". The stretched image is also lazy, ugly, and disproportionate. It distorts bodies, objects, and by virtue of this, "the real." Unsurprisingly, it thrives in spaces where this same

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- 1 Hito Steyerl. "In Defense of the Poor Image." e-flux Journal, no. 10 (November 2009). <https://www.e-flux.com/journal/10/61362/in-defense-of-the-poor-image/>
  - 2 Günseli Yalcinkaya. "Deep-Fried Memes: What Are They and Why Do They Matter?" Dazed Digital, November 11, 2022. <https://www.dazeddigital.com/life-culture/article/57422/1/deep-fried-memes-surveillance-capitalism-instagram-reddit-censorship/>

trade-off is valued. Most typically we find them in memes, but also, in floor-to-ceiling posters at affordable Thai massage salons (where an image simply needs to fill a wall), in internet spam (where it needs to fit a fixed ad space), and across Chinese low-cost dropshipping product ads.

Temu famously values quantity over quality, adding 10,000 new items every day. To sustain this pace, it often advertises products that don't exist yet. Some are AI-generated designs produced only after purchase (like the viral AI gorilla couch), others are template-based goods where typically pop-cultural graphics are overlaid on cheap objects in infinite combinations. In the latter case, the source images (film posters, memes, celebrity photos) carry fixed aspect ratios that rarely align with the products they're pasted onto. To solve this problem, images are "stretched to fit".

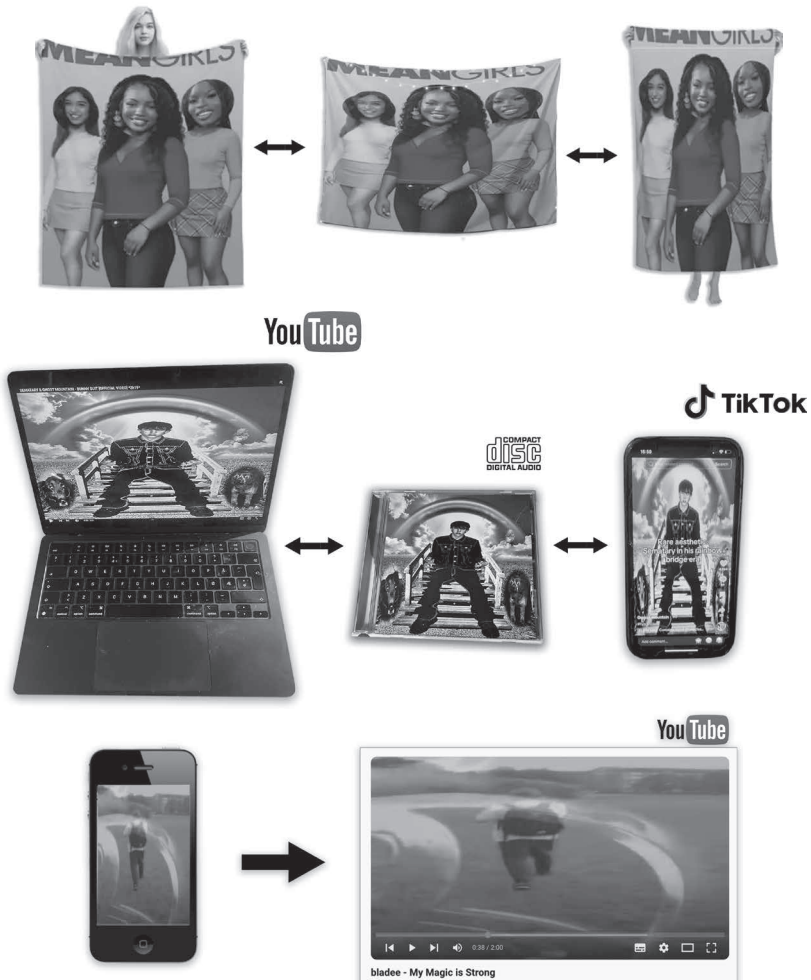
One interesting product I found was a wall tapestry of *Mean Girls*, where the protagonists' faces have been swapped with three female *Love Island* US contestants. The image has been stretched so extensively that the women appear unnaturally wide — an ironic distortion, given that *Mean Girls* was originally a satire of the "skinny, white" high-school archetype. This incoherence becomes proof of how the logic of speed and mass production overrides any human sense of logic, creating products that, as Caroline Busta wrote about Shein, are "less 'fashion' than tag clouds de-virtualized and remixed by human designers".<sup>3</sup> As the same graphic migrates from vertical towels to square pillows to horizontal tapestries, the bodies warp differently each time, producing a strange lineage of *Love Island-Mean Girls* mutants — a kind of accidental, body-inclusive product collection. Stretching images in this way allows companies like Temu to sustain an inhuman pace of production, designing products in real time as culture moves. Just in time to capitalize on short-lived memes, fleeting trends, or the temporary relevance of a reality-TV show. The stretched image, while "poor," is therefore a conduit for slop-on-demand and a token of what Daniel Feldman calls janky capitalism: a falling-apart weirdness of the world, while capital spins ever farther away from the human.

The cost-efficiency of the stretched image also helps explain why it appears so frequently in the online micro-scenes of Gen Z internet-based "underground" rappers like Nettspend, Xaviersobased, and collectives such as Shed Theory and Haunted Mound. These circles are defined by a relentless drive to release music — finished or not — and the stretched image neatly facilitates this by offering a quick, low-effort way to generate visuals. Fakemink, for example, has released nearly 100 songs on Spotify since 2023, twelve of which use stretched covers, perhaps partly, to sustain this accelerated pace of releasing. Speed, to which the stretched image responds to, is reflective of shifts in the broader music industry: Songs are increasingly shorter, sped-up versions are routinely produced for TikTok, and releases now occur on a rolling basis rather than as traditional albums cycles. These shifts are all pushed by

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3 Caroline Busta. "Hallucinating Sense in the Era of Infinity-Content: Technical Images, Film01, Angelicism, Art, Showtime, True Detective & Shein." Document Journal, May 29, 2024. <https://www.documentjournal.com/2024/05/technical-images-film01-angelicism-art-showtime-true-detective-shein/>.

culture shaped by algorithmic imperatives and shrinking attention spans, in which efficiency, speed, and continuous circulation govern both production and distribution. In ways analogous to how platformization of music accelerates sonic forms, the stretched image of, let's say Fakeminks London Saviour, functions as a visual counterpart allowing imagery to “keep up”.



Stretching an image is not the only way to adapt it to platform constraints. Cropping is probably the more common solution when faced with such a “problem”. But what makes stretching far more interesting is that, while the cropped image erases its “former limbs”, the stretched image preserves them - though in distorted form. This allows the stretched image to 1) become an aesthetic in its own right and 2) visually carry the history of its circulation. Take Bladee’s 2013 music video *My Magic is Strong*, for example: horizontally stretched footage shows Bladee frolicking on a grassy field, apparently shot vertically on a phone but stretched

to fit YouTube's horizontal frame. Or Yung Hurn's TikTok videos for *Sonne und Regen* and *100 tausend*, originally horizontally posted on Youtube, later stretched and spliced to fit TikTok's vertical frame. These stretched videos visibly trace their journey across platforms, much like poor images bear the scars of compression and digital degradation. Every stretch is a mark of repurposing, reformatting, and adaptation. In this sense, like the *poor image*, the stretched image testifies to the acceleration and circulation inherent in audiovisual capitalism.<sup>4</sup> Yet it also conveys a form of care, reflecting the attention of those who have granted it an extended life across new, platformed contexts. The stretched image thus carries a contradictory charge: both evidence of the violence that circulation enacts, and of the persistence and attention that keep it alive. Symbolically, it articulates the feeling of being pulled and pushed violently across digital platforms.

### Aesthetic Silly Boys and Goth Girls

Not all images that use this visual effect are consciously stretched to fit a given aspect ratio. This is because the stretched image has become its own aesthetic, sometimes but not always decoupled from the networked logics I just described. In the internet rap scene, à la Fakemink or Xaviersobased, for instance, the stretched image can make the rapper look wide and short, almost like Roblox characters or the reflection of a convex funhouse mirror. Stretching then becomes a tool for destabilizing rap's traditional codes, softening its more brutal edges while reinforcing a consistent aesthetic of irony, silliness and chronically online humour that defines this corner of internet hip hop. The parallel extends into the sonic landscape as well. Rap collective Haunted Mound, for instance, consistently produces dark, muddy, and heavily distorted vocals – an effect not unlike what happens when you stretch an audio track.

Aestheticized versions of the stretched image appear in selfies posted by goths online. I didn't think much of this before I visited a gothic church in Belgium and saw how the church architecture, through its elongated arches, tall spires, and towering structures, can basically be thought of as a stretched church. The emphasis on verticality in gothic architecture is to reflect an upward reach, a stretch towards god, heaven and the divine. In this context, especially due to how a lot of these goth selfies feature christian symbolism like crosses, the stretched image feels like a way for them to channel that same aspiration, translating the monumental verticality of Gothic architecture into the digital, personal scale of the selfie.

People stretch images also to signal a wide range of chronically online, alternative and niche aesthetic preferences – something you either *get* or you don't. But the point I want to make is that this aesthetic did not emerge out of nowhere. It arises from platform-imposed constraints on aspect ratio, which force images to adapt in one way or another. Without this 21st-century visual ecosystem, where images circulate across platforms and can be easily edited, there would be little reason for this aesthetic to exist at all.

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4 Hito Steyerl. "In Defense of the Poor Image." e-flux Journal, no. 10 (November 2009). <https://www.e-flux.com/journal/10/61362/in-defense-of-the-poor-image/>





## Platform Logic, and the Drive to Fill the Frame

There are two logics of social media platforms that have accelerated the tactics of stretching and solidified them into recognizable visual forms. The first logic, *memetics*, is driven by the way memes evolve through constant circulation, editing, screenshotting, and repurposing. Through these cycles of reproduction, users might stretch images to fit different aspect-ratio contexts of posting. The second logic, *cross-posting*, articulates how content creators often repurpose the same image or video across multiple platforms to maximize reach. In doing so, they are incentivized to reshape or “stretch” content to fit the aspect-ratio requirements of each platform, as “filling the screen” secures algorithmic visibility. As one of the most common pieces of advice for going viral suggests: always post in the platform’s native aspect ratio and avoid black bars at all costs.

The compulsive drive to “fill the screen” is not only enforced by platforms. It also reflects a deeper, almost biological impulse of how humans seek order and completeness - a tendency that has long been observed in art history. *Horror vacui*, Latin for “fear of empty space,” is often used to describe artworks that fill the entire surface with detail and leave as little emptiness as possible. It references Aristotle’s old and disproven idea in physics that nature abhors an empty space. The same impulse is evident in contemporary phenomena, such as viral “oddly satisfying” videos featuring objects fitting perfectly together, like BuzzFeed’s *Just 3 Minutes of Satisfying Perfect Fits*, or in rage-baiting videos where nothing “fits”.

If this horror vacui weren’t at play in posting, it would feel natural to use any aspect ratio and simply accept black “empty” bars filling the remaining space. Yet, seeing an image fill the screen, or its assigned frame, is more satisfying. The stretching of images is thus driven not only by platform incentives but also by this human desire for visual completeness. An example is Charli XCX’s now-iconic *Brat* album cover, which features a neon green background and the album title in 90% vertically stretched Arial text. The cover is notable not only because its iconic status signals that stretched aesthetics are entering the mainstream, but also because stretching elements within a fixed aspect ratio (here, the square standard of records) creates a sense of visual satisfaction. Without the stretch, the word “BRAT” would feel misplaced, leaving too much empty space above and below. It simply would not be *brat*. The neuro-technological urge to fill the screen carries an inherent paradox: An image unnaturally stretched to fit a frame feels both repellent in its weirdness, yet seductive in its ability to fill the screen.

On a side note, the stretched image is not the only contemporary visual form shaped by this desire to fill the screen. I suspect the same impulse may help explain the emergence of sludge videos. The usual analyses claim that sludge is a response to shortened attention spans and the demand for constant stimulation, but this doesn’t address why users began making these videos in the first place. Sure, experimentation likely played a role, but there is also a deeper “origin story” rooted in the fetish of filling the screen. Early sludge videos, for

instance, often combined horizontal clips from *Family Guy* with short, social-media-native vertical clips. The original *Family Guy* footage was designed for horizontal television screens, but posting it on vertical platforms like TikTok created a mismatch. Placing additional clips next to it, and thereby creating sludge, worked as a remedy to this *horror vacui* – a way to visually “complete” the frame.



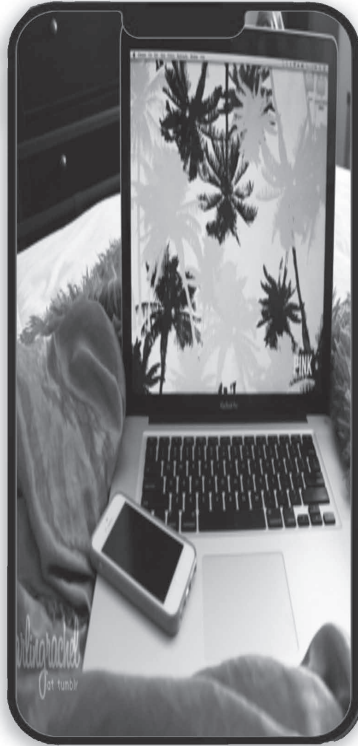
Now that a technical analysis of the stretched image is done, there are further questions to be asked: What is the stretched image stretching from and towards? What is it reaching for, with this straining, distorting movement?

## SLOUCHING TOWARDS THE VERTICAL

Aspect ratio is not just a technical term describing the relative size of images and videos. Aspect ratios carry meaning and history – and they matter, especially in a time when so much of reality is mediated through images. The square image ratio, for instance, evokes vinyl sleeves, early Instagram, and Polaroids – the image-object that originally inspired Instagram’s name. Horizontal ratios call to mind landscapes, cinema, television, YouTube, and the computer screen. And vertical ratios evoke portraits, TikTok, short-form video, and the smartphone display. These are the associations I bring with me when I encounter stretched images online.

Of particular interest here is the vertically stretched image, where a horizontal image is forced into the vertical format of a phone. This type of image is constituted by a tension between the pre-vertical ecosystem of varied aspect ratios and the contemporary dominance of vertical media. In the late 2000s and early 2010s, social media images

were far more diverse, reflecting how internet use was more evenly distributed between computers and phones. Computer-based platforms typically favored horizontal formats (e.g., YouTube), while mobile apps leaned toward vertical content (e.g., Snapchat), and platforms like Facebook, Tumblr, and Flickr were commonly used on both, creating a varied image ecosystem in terms of aspect ratio. Since then, the vertical orientation of phones has encouraged increased usage by making content consumption mobile, pushing the balance of aspect ratios strongly toward vertical formats.



The stretched vertical image operates as a site of historic tension and remediation, as seen in the instagram account of @unicornchainsaw, which posts 2010s nostalgic content under the rules of vertical authoritarianism. The account is filled with digital relics from that era, such as the 2009 Instagram interface, clips from *Skins* and *Movie Star Planet*, all stretched to fill the screen, regardless of their original aspect ratio. One reel, for example, features a slideshow of *justgirlythings* tumblr era images paired with a pitched-down version of OneRepublic's 2013 hit "Counting Stars." In the 2025 @sadbkissed version, these once-familiar hopecore horizontal images are stretched so aggressively to fit the vertical frame that the text becomes nearly unreadable.

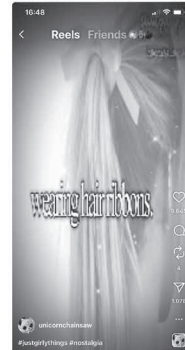
What makes this reel so striking is its temporal dissonance. I remember being a teenager when these types of sincere and hopeful images were a part of my everyday media diet. I would encounter them mostly on my family's stationary computer, on Tumblr or Facebook, and my encounter with them would be sincere. At least from what I can remember. The images evoke this feeling of a friendlier internet: a place you would visit, not a device you carried in your pocket at all times. However, the stretched editing in combination with the reel's distorted throwback music, introduces a darkness. It feels as if the images have been assaulted, forced to conform to the rigid, contemporary regime of verticality: a visual violence that mirrors the internet's shift from sincerity to a more cynical, irony-poisoned landscape.

These images now appear as reels, the default mode of image production in the 2020s, rather than standalone posts, as was the norm before 2016. No longer fixed in place, they are absorbed into the infinite, algorithmically curated, globally synchronized doomscroll. The stretched image in this context bears the mark of this short-form vertical video revolution, the 'TikTokification' of Instagram, and the flattening of social media into a stream of endless, vertical content. The stretching signifies a forced adaptation, a relic of a past internet bent and distorted to fit the logic of a new one. The images feel like fractured echoes of a lost digital era. *We cannot go back to 2010, we are stuck watching it as a reel.*

Tumblr 2014



Reels 2025



The stretched vertical image therefore articulates anxiety, friction and strain in relation to the vertical image-regime that is dictating contemporary platform life. It exemplifies how platforms “force” the production of vertical images, and that this is not necessarily a comfortable or democratic choice. In recent years, not only Instagram but also an expanded ecosystem of platforms, YouTube, LinkedIn, Pornhub and Spotify, have all shifted toward short-form vertical video. This transition is not out of user demand, but because the format produces the most addictive engagement loops, and therefore maximizes profit. Recent image history can therefore be described as a process not only of “stretching” toward the vertical, but of “stretching” for attention, for engagement, and ultimately for monetization.



If the vertical image is a visual form born from the way the vertical smartphones extend screen time and make content endlessly consumable through affording mobility, the stretched image is a counter-visual form. It allows non-vertical content, including pre-vertical internet images such as Tumblr posts and square Instagram macros, to persist under the authoritarian rule of verticality.

## Vertical Music Videos & Cross-post minimalism

The vertical stretched image is not the only visual form born out of a smartphone-mediated reconfiguration of image production. Another example is the vertical music video. Pop artists such as Ellie Goulding, Selena Gomez, Billie Eilish, Camila Cabello, Halsey, Troye Sivan, and Bebe Rexha have all either released music videos made specifically for the phone screen or re-edited existing videos to fit the vertical aspect ratio of short-form platforms. What sets vertical music videos apart is not merely their aspect ratio, but the distinct visual language that verticality seems to foster. Across these videos, a strikingly dull minimalism and extreme self-absorption dominate: little to no narrative, with the singer's body almost always filling the frame, mouthing the lyrics as if filming a TikTok. A comparison of the vertical and horizontal versions of Camila Cabello's *Havana* illustrates this difference clearly. The horizontal video is a full-scale production: a telenovela-style odyssey through the streets and everyday life of Cuba, complete with an ensemble cast, expanding the world of the song and underlining its ode to her hometown. The vertical version, by contrast, strips all that away. Frame after frame contains little more than Cabello herself, facing the camera and singing directly into the intimate space of the viewer's phone screen. Verticalization, then, tends to reduce the music video's capacity for narrative, context, and visual complexity, much like the rapid, fragmentary logic of social media content. In this context, verticalization is an active process that transforms traditionally rich media objects, like the music video, into slop. What's at stake here is the erosion of a cultural form that has, for decades, been one of popular music's most experimental and boundary-pushing media objects.

The dominance of smartphone-based media is not only producing more vertical content, as in the case of vertical music videos, but also reconfiguring horizontal content. This is evident in contemporary horizontal YouTube "slop". Think of Jubilee ("*1 Capitalist vs 20 Anti-Capitalists*"), Cut ("*The Button*"), LADbible ("*Snack Wars*"), Colors Studio, Genius ("*Verified*"), The Skin Deep, BuzzFeed, or Pop the Balloon: what unites them is an extremely minimal set, often nothing more than a greenscreen or a single-colored background. I don't interpret this shared visual language, which I call *cross-post minimalism*, as incidental; I see it as a standardized aesthetic born out of the demands of platform circulation and cross-format portability. Indeed, YouTube videos today are rarely made just for YouTube — they are designed with the expectation that they will be crossposted as short-form vertical clips on TikTok, Reels, or Shorts. By keeping the set as minimal and uncluttered as possible, the footage can be cropped and repurposed across formats with little to no friction. The result facilitates circulation but produces a flattened aesthetic: portable, depersonalized, and ultimately reflecting a capitalist logic of efficiency.



*Cross-post minimalism*

The forced regime of verticality is not only significant because of what it represents but also because of how vertical frames inherently fit a different relation of objects than let's say a horizontal frame. A horizontal frame reflects our horizontal, landscape vision, and therefore favours capturing the dialogue, the environment and the world. It reflects a mode of viewing that is outwards. A vertical frame however, does not reflect this god-given way of seeing. It is designed for the individual, the single vertical body. My previous examples of Cabellos vertical music video for Havana, as well as the *cross-post minimalism* of Youtube slop show how vertical framing centers the individual, compressing context and privileging the singular over the collective. The hegemony of the vertical image is therefore not only symbolic of the extreme individualism and narcissism that plagues contemporary society, but also an accelerator for these processes.

The social consequences of verticalization is perfectly captured in a tiktok clip of a podcast where two men are having a conversation. Instead of showing their conversation logically as a horizontal frame where their eye-sights are aligned, they made the clip into a split-screen where the clips are put on top of each other to fit the vertical demands of TikTok. You can hear that they are talking together, but visually they are talking away from each other, into nothingness. This is what verticalization does to us. It fractures dialogue, isolates bodies, and reorients communication away from shared space and toward disconnected soliloquy.

In response to this, I appreciate the trend on Instagram among cool Gen Z girls of posting horizontal photos in vertical stories. It has the feel of a quiet revolution...

## Future of the Stretched Image

So far I analyzed the stretched image as a hyperspecific artifact of the era of platform capitalism. Yet precisely because of this specificity, its future remains uncertain. The fate of the stretched image will be shaped by the constantly shifting interplay between platform-imposed conditions and the spontaneous, creative choices of users. This relationship can be productively examined through the lens of *strategies* and *tactics*, as outlined by Michel de Certeau in *The Practice of Everyday Life* (1980).<sup>5</sup> Writing about psychogeography in the context of cities, de Certeau, defined strategies as the systems imposed by institutions — such as city layouts, maps, or traffic regulations — that structure movement and define what is possible in a given city. Tactics, by contrast, are the everyday, often subversive maneuvers through which individuals navigate and bend these systems: taking shortcuts, wandering off mapped routes, or using spaces in ways not intended.

Applied to social media, platforms' rigid aspect-ratio regimes function as strategies, incentivizing certain forms of aspect ratios for posting. Stretching, by contrast, is a tactic: a user's creative, "improper" maneuver to make content fit, sidestepping the friction of reshooting or redesigning. Stretching transforms images into a form of tactical improvisation, making them "habitable" within an otherwise constraining system.

For a time, the conditions — or strategies — were constraining enough for stretched images to flourish. Yet I have observed a trend in which these conditions are narrowing. Lev Manovich's re-thinking of De Certeau for the age of user-generated content can be useful here.<sup>6</sup> According to Manovich, tactics themselves can be absorbed and elevated into strategies. What begins as bottom-up, tactical play — remix, bricolage, mashup — can become formalized into the logic of the platform itself. This is visible in the trajectory of the stretched image. As users creatively bypassed strict aspect-ratio regimes — through stretching, split-screens, "sludgification," or white-agram frames — platforms gradually adapted their policies, expanding the range of allowed aspect ratios. In 2019, for instance, Instagram introduced its "Layout" feature, allowing multiple horizontal images to be stacked within a vertical Story frame. Similarly, Instagram, once rigidly square, expanded its aspect ratio range from 1:1 to 1.91:1 landscape and 4:5 portrait, and by late 2025 even permitted ultra-wide video uploads (though not ultra-horizontal images). If these conditions continue to liberalize, the very tension that gave rise to the stretched image may disappear. We might therefore be at the end of the era of stretched images.

The increasing influence of AI on social media further complicates this picture. AI tools such as generative fill can now automatically adapt content to any aspect ratio, eliminating

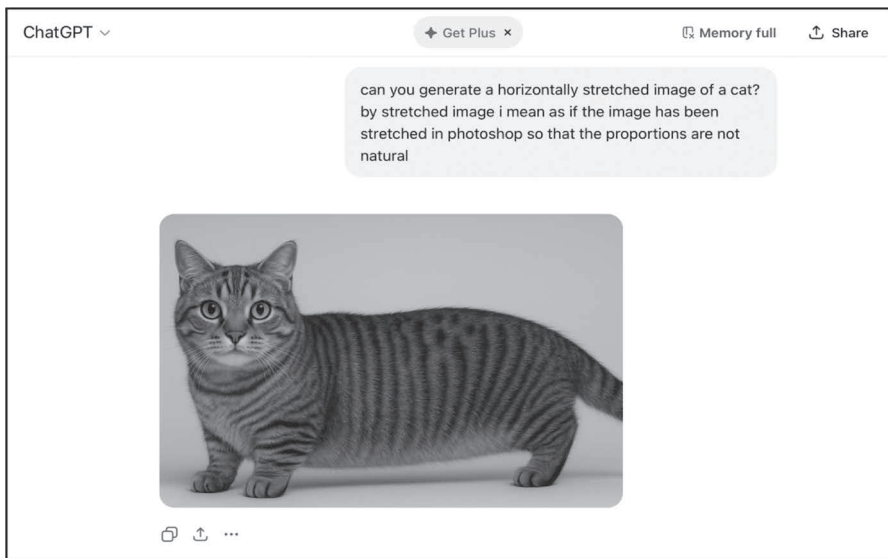
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5 Michel de Certeau. *The Practice of Everyday Life*. Translated by Steven F. Rendall. Berkeley: University of California Press, 1984.

6 Lev Manovich. "The Practice of Everyday (Media) Life: From Mass Consumption to Mass Cultural Production?" *Critical Inquiry* 35, no. 2 (Winter 2009): 319–331.



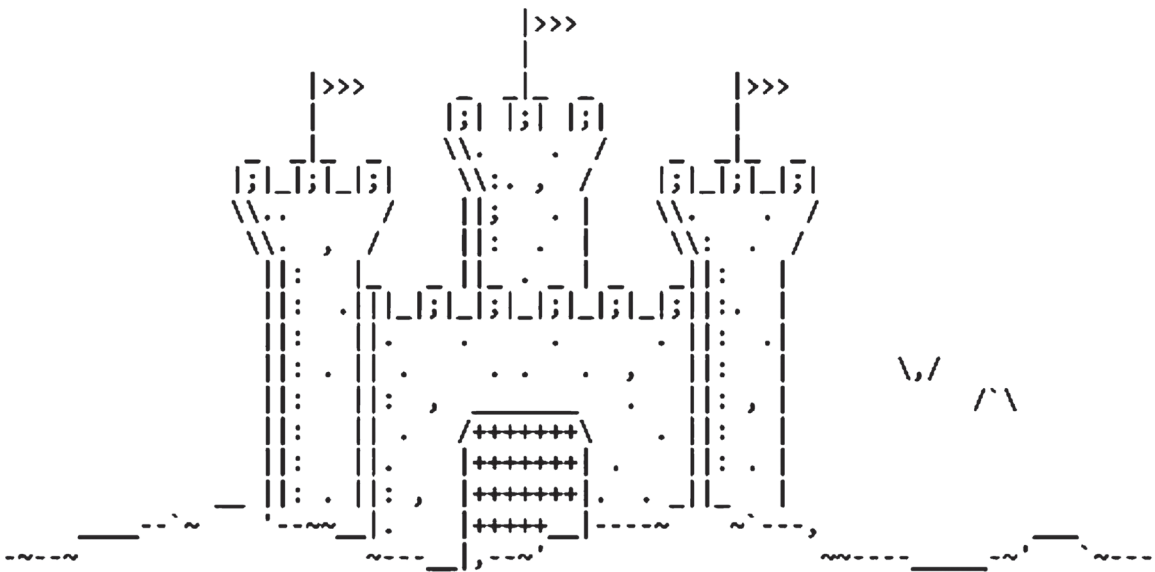
the need for creative workarounds like stretching. This is evident, for example, in the TikTok account *@filmsvertical*, where film classics such as *Goodfellas*, *Home Alone*, and *Gladiator* have been processed through generative fill to remove the black bars that horizontal content would otherwise produce on TikTok's vertical frame. Yet at the same time, there appears to be something about the logic of the stretched image that AI cannot grasp. I have repeatedly attempted to generate stretched images using AI, even specifying instructions like "pull the object in Photoshop," but the outputs tend to be naturalistic distortions — a cat with a slightly elongated back, a man with chubby cheeks — rather than the digitally stretched effect produced by a human using Photoshop. Seeing that AI cannot reproduce a stretched image, but can produce more normie social media posts like selfies, points to an interesting paradox when it comes to the stretched image: it is simultaneously inhuman — networked and technologically mediated— and irreducibly human, arising from aesthetic decisions and play that resist algorithmic reproduction. Maybe this resisting trait of the stretched image will allow it to survive, in a social media landscape increasingly contaminated by AI slop.



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# WALLED GARDENS



## NEW DEPENDENCIES

LUKAS ENGELHARDT

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*It seems that many people today experience a space problem. This applies to the physical world where living spaces in the city become less affordable by the day as wages continue to stagnate. And this is also the case for the digital spaces we inhabit, where governments and software conglomerates lock us into walled gardens and spend every single one of their considerable resources in order to sell us ads. But while spatial activism in the physical world is battle-tested and well-established, it seems that digitally we often still struggle to find useful tactics to counteract the effects of the cloud. This is an attempt to find ways in which our experience with the negotiation of physical space can help us with our digital conundrum.*



fig A.1: A Thundercloud, a mix of a cloud icon and the international squatting sign that resembles lightning strike, hanging on a small (squatted?) computer.

## Point of departure

| self hosting                                               | squatting                                                  |
|------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------|
| refusing (privacy) policies ✓                              | refusing (housing) policies ✓                              |
| hosting and serving (files) ✓                              | hosting and serving (people) ✓                             |
| programming (computers) ✓                                  | programming (events) ✓                                     |
| don't pay rent (software as service) ✓                     | don't pay rent (actual rent) ✓                             |
| community building (licenses and policies) ✓               | community building (door policies) ✓                       |
| security (encryption) ✓                                    | security (barricades) ✓                                    |
| constant maintenance ✓                                     | constant maintenance ✓                                     |
| resist cloud control ✓                                     | resist crowd control ✓                                     |
| using existing infrastructures ✓                           | using existing infrastructures ✓                           |
| recycling (old hardware) ✓                                 | recycling (building materials) ✓                           |
| open source principles ✓                                   | open source principles ✓                                   |
| following manuals and protocols ✓                          | following manuals and protocols ✓                          |
| improvised structures & unconventional design strategies ✓ | improvised structures & unconventional design strategies ✓ |
| disaster always imminent: data loss ✓                      | disaster always imminent: eviction ✓                       |
| Everything went downhill from ~2010 ✓                      | Everything went downhill from ~2010 ✓                      |
| nostalgia ✓                                                | nostalgia ✓                                                |
| nomadic in nature: changing ip addresses ✓                 | nomadic in nature: changing addresses ✓                    |
| situating yourself in a network ✓                          | situating yourself in a network ✓                          |
| de-appropriating someone else's space ✗                    | de-appropriating someone else's space ✓                    |

fig. 0.1: A lot of words in tech are referring to things in the real world.

## Cloud Gazing

On September 12, 2010, the YouTube Channel revelation13net uploaded a video titled *By Psychokinesis a Psychic turns a Cloud into a Square Cloud in Sept. 2010*. In this video, a man films the sky with a handheld camera for 2 minutes and 18 seconds. The viewer sees a single cloud on an otherwise entirely blue sky, lined by some trees on the edge of the frame. We never see the person holding the camera but can hear them speak throughout the video. They introduce themselves as T. Chase and they explain that they will attempt to change the shape of the cloud into a square through psychic powers. They keep repeating this statement like a mantra of sorts, altering and distorting their voice as the video progresses. The cloud slowly changes shape, and by the end of the video it does look more like a square than in the beginning of the video, though it's hard to say whether this might just have been the way it was always going to naturally change shape.

In September 2008, the free software advocate Richard Stallman expressed his concerns regarding cloud computing to *The Guardian*, claiming that it was stupid and just a way to lock users into proprietary ecosystems.<sup>1</sup> Stallman is a prominent advocate for privacy and the open source movement, and (among a lot of other things) the founder of the Free Software Foundation. He is well-respected in the tech community, but his statements about cloud computing received mixed responses. He was accused of populism for supposedly ignoring the lived realities of actual users who are often already trapped in their operating systems and office suites, and don't necessarily have the capacities to practice the cloud refusal he was preaching.<sup>2</sup> Others accused Stallman of simply stating the obvious. Reuven Cohan illustrated this criticism with a still from an episode of the animated TV show *The Simpsons*, which later ended up becoming something of a meme. The image shows a newspaper clipping in which Abe Simpson, the elderly father of one of the protagonists, Homer Simpson, angrily shakes his fist at the sky under the headline *Old Man Yells at Cloud*. Since my 30th birthday last year, I have sometimes thought this image is actually about me.

The Cloud is a mythical space. Its name alludes to its opaque-ness, veiling what it actually describes, which you could call network infrastructure, or maybe just someone else's computer.<sup>3</sup> Interestingly, the concept originates from exactly this position of not knowing, of occlusion. In network diagrams the cloud is traditionally used to denote parts of the network that we have no control over or have no concrete knowledge about. It's the part beyond the blinking lights of our router, it's *internet*. Its shape alludes to the uncertainty of

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1 Bobby Johnson, "Cloud computing is a trap, warns GNU founder Richard Stallman", *The Guardian*, September 29, 2008, <https://www.theguardian.com/technology/2008/sep/29/cloud.computing.richard.stallman>.

2 Mathew Ingram, "Hey hey, you you — get off of my cloud", *Mathewingram.com*, September 29, 2008, <https://web.archive.org/web/20081122005447/http://www.mathewingram.com/work/2008/09/29/hey-hey-you-you-get-off-of-my-cloud/>.

3 This sentiment also has become a meme of sorts, printed on mugs, stickers and t-shirts that you can buy all over the internet, including, not surprisingly, on Amazon.

what is out there, something elusive that constantly changes shape, is hard to grasp. The cloud is something we don't understand, by definition.

This inherent uncertainty is maybe why attempts to refuse it can often feel futile. Even defining what it is that we are refusing exactly is already a tiring exercise. As is often the case with computers, the conversation is one-sided, with us yelling at the cloud, trying to shape it, but not getting a response. Because the cloud doesn't care. Despite this perceived futility, a vague feeling of urgency remains. In 2019, web designer Becca Abbe sensed the dawn of what she called The Internet's Back-to-the-Land Movement, a new movement of users away from the cloud, in reference to the 1960s counter cultural movements away from the cities in the US.<sup>4</sup> It seems tempting to leave the celestial cloud behind, with all its fake news and inequalities, to get back down to the ground truth, so to say. But what exactly is this land we would return to, and who exactly is going there?

## Surfing the Web

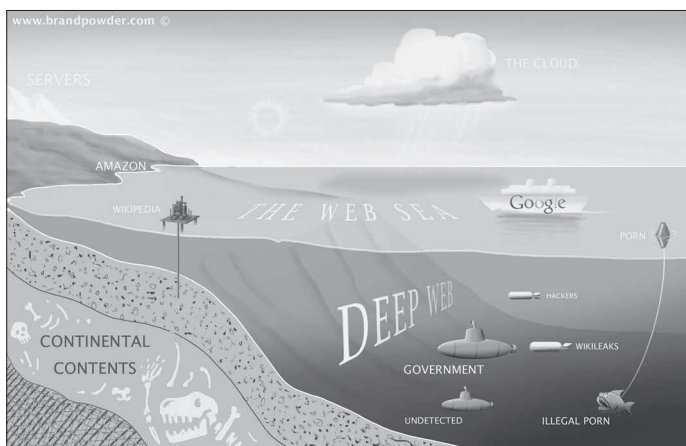


fig. 2.1: None of this makes any sense. Thank you Paul Bille for finding this image.

Before the cloud was a cloud it was an ocean. We know this, because it could be *surf*ed. In 1986, when the internet wasn't commercially available yet, it was mostly being used by scientists and governments. That year, in the Netherlands, Hans Rosenberg from Utrecht University founded the non-profit organization *SURF*,<sup>5</sup> which ran *SURFnet*, a computer network linking different academic institutions.<sup>6</sup> A few years later, in 1989, and in direct

4 Which, in turn, directly informed the early beginnings of Silicon Valley's tech world.

5 Samenwerkende Universitaire Reken Faciliteiten, *Co-operative University Computing Facilities*

6 *SURFnet* still exists today, and, among other things, founded and operates eduroam, an authentication infrastructure letting users in higher education facilities use wifi, which many readers might be familiar with.

proximity to the ocean, Susan Estrada of the San Diego Supercomputer Center founded one of the first internet service providers (ISP) in the world, and, since *SURFnet* was taken, settled on the name *CERFnet*.<sup>7</sup>

In 1991, CERFnet released a promotional comic book, *The Adventures of Captain Internet And CERF Boy*. Filled to the brim with rad crossword puzzles and bad puns, it recounts the story of Diana Domain, her surfboard-slinging alter ego Captain Internet and her side kick CERFboy, fighting against their nemesis Count Crackula. Unaware of all of this, just a year later, librarian Jean "netmom" Armour Polly published an article called *Surfing the Internet* on the University of Minnesota Wilson Library Bulletin, and shortly after that, Tom Mandel of Stanford Research Institute (SRI) wrote another one called *Surfing the Wild Internet*.

What all these examples have in common is that they evoke the fun of the web, but also the skill required to, well, surf it, as well as some sense of the fluidity, randomness, chaos, and even danger that it presented.<sup>8</sup> Using the internet was a sport, something you did for fun, and temporarily, before hanging up your wet suit and returning to real life.<sup>9</sup> Especially back then, when cities and interfaces were less smooth, people were less sad and personal computers were just beginning to become a thing, it perfectly captured this new, mysterious and seemingly bottomless place that was the internet<sup>10</sup>—other exhausted geographic metaphors include cyberspace, the electronic frontier and the information superhighway.

Today nobody surfs anymore (the ocean has evaporated into the cloud, you could say). But despite the immiscibility of water and technology, the image of the internet as a separate space free from the constraints of the *aground*, physical world, a vast ocean that just has to be navigated by a skilled steersman<sup>11</sup> with an appropriate vessel,<sup>12</sup> lingers as residue if you know where to look: in the ports and berths that we use to connect our

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7 Originally, Estrada had wanted to reference San Diego's reputation as a surfers' paradise. Her second choice, CERFnet, was an abbreviation for *California Education and Research Federation Network*, and a reference to Vint Cerf, one of the inventors of the TCP/IP protocol and so-called fathers of the internet, whose name absurdly sounds like someone with a strong German accent trying to say *wind surf*. Today, Cerf works for Google as Chief Internet Evangelist.

8 Interestingly, one of the best articles on the history of the term was published in the completely-not-tech-related surfer magazine *Surfer Today*, in which they quote Armour Polly on her intentions.

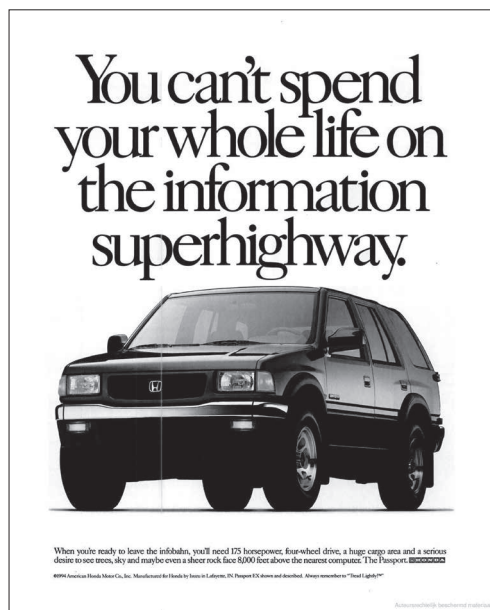
9 "The idea of cyberspace posed a line of separation between the internet and the real world. Cyberspace would be a separate universe. Created by people, enabled by technology, and occupied by information. Geopolitically, it would be like the sea once was. An unregulated and fluid space where ordinary rules need not apply." Metahaven, *Black Transparency: The Right to Know in the Age of Mass Surveillance*, Berlin: Sternberg Press, 2015, XV.

10 Arguably it helped that the term was so visual, which gave way to an endless sea of illustrations of people literally surfing on their peripherals.

11 The word cybernetics originally developed from the word steersman.

12 See: Netscape Navigator.

computers to the internet, in *anchor* links, torrent sites,<sup>13</sup> browser icons<sup>14</sup> or the names of NFT marketplaces.<sup>15</sup> The Network is eternal, and so is the ocean.



Watch me. Advertising by Honda in a 1994 outdoor magazine.

## Back to the Sea

If you want to build a ship, don't drum up people to collect wood and don't assign them tasks and work, but rather teach them to long for the endless immensity of the sea.

—Antoine de Saint-Exupéry, probably<sup>16</sup>

The appeal of the vast ocean never fully disappeared, and while some are trying their best to get back to the land, others just want to get back to the sea. Whereas *homesteading* describes self-sufficient life on land, seasteading takes this idea several steps further and out into the open sea (hypothetically, at least). Seasteading is an idea from San

13 See: Pirate Bay.

14 See: Safari.

15 See: Opensea.io.

16 De Saint-Exupéry, author of *The Little Prince*, never really said this. Instead, this quote is paraphrased from his 1948 book *Citadelle*. However, this adaptation is much more widely known, and fits the context of this chapter better than the original.



Francisco, and advocated for by the Seasteading Institute, which in turn was funded by venture capitalist and strangely obsessive *Lord of the Rings* fan Peter Thiel<sup>17</sup>, with the goal of making governments *smart*. Claiming that most of the land in the world is already taken, the seasteaders propose building floating cities in international waters, free from convention, regulation, and taxes.

Up until 2020 most attempts to make these dreams come true had been of moderate success, with crypto millionaire, anti-taxer and anti-vaxxer Chad Elwartowski coming closest when he and his girlfriend spent two months living in a small, elevated, floating platform 12 nautical miles off the coast of Thailand.<sup>18</sup> Elwartowski is one of the founders of *Ocean Builders*, a company dedicated to the promotion of seasteading, which has been developing so called *SeaPods*, floating luxury homes that look remarkably similar to Apple AirPods in renders. The platform in Thailand (which looked nothing like those renders) had been the first prototype.

But in 2020 Ocean Builders decided to give it one more try. Due to the COVID-19 pandemic, the cruise ship industry had almost gone under and they managed to buy an old, 245m cruise ship for a bit less than \$10m, around one tenth of its pre-pandemic price. They named it the MS Satoshi, after the presumed author of the original Bitcoin white paper. The plan was to lay anchor off the coast of Panama, where it would be incorporated into an artificial, floating island in the shape of the Bitcoin B. Until then they would auction off the 777 cabins to a clientele of digital nomads, startup founders and crypto enthusiasts, and finally establish the first truly free, crypto-only (and mostly male), seasteading society (or *seavilization*<sup>19</sup>).

Maybe it's stretch to claim there is a (mostly metaphorical) affinity of everything-crypto to the ocean and the freedoms it promises. But many have described the feeling of web3<sup>20</sup> to be reminiscent of the early days of the internet, among them Signal founder and former sailboat-squatter<sup>21</sup> Moxie Marlinspike.<sup>22</sup> And the image just *fits*—it speaks of a desire for the internet (the world?) to be a wide, open and adventurous place again.

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17 At the time of writing, Thiel has founded a total of six companies that are named after places and objects in J. R. R. Tolkien's *Lord of the Rings*.

18 When the Thai government discovered the existence of their seastead, Elwartowski and his girlfriend had to flee the country in fear of prosecution for violating the country's independence. Elwartowski logged the details of their dramatic escape on his vlog.

19 A term I regretfully cannot take credit for.

20 Web1: Read—Web2: Read, write—Web3: Read, write, own.

21 Marlinspike founded the Anarchist Yacht Club, which involved the squatting of derelict boats in order to fix them up and sail the world. In 2004 Marlinspike and 3 friends sailed to the Bahamas on the *Pestilance*, documenting their journey in a short film.

22 In a 2022 article, Marlinspike outlines his experience with web3. While expressing excitement from his position as a developer, he claims that web3 doesn't actually deliver on many of its promises of decentralization, a nautical example of which is the monopoly of the platform [opensea.io](https://opensea.io).

In any case, the ocean builders didn't fare well on their endeavors. Journalist Sophie Elmhirst recounts the following unfolding of unfortunate events in great schadenfreude-laden detail for *The Guardian*.<sup>23</sup> What was supposed to have become the crypto-pirate-radio station of the 21st century ended in financial disaster before the ship ever reached Panama.<sup>24</sup> According to scholar Flavia Dzodan, libertarian leaps for freedom like this fail because they don't bother to answer the question of who will do all the cleaning.<sup>25</sup> In her article, Elmhirst sums up the MS Satoshi's ultimate dilemma. "*The high seas*", she writes, "*while appearing borderless and free, are, in fact, some of the most tightly regulated places on Earth*".



fig. 3.1: *Not as endless and free as we thought. Still from the 1998 movie The Truman Show.*

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- 23 Elmhirst outlines how, the day the ocean builders officially gained ownership of the ship, its certificates of seaworthiness had expired. They had to sail it from Greece to Gibraltar to have it dry-docked and inspected, before finally starting the voyage across the Atlantic to Panama. There they had hoped to be able to de-register the ship, for it to legally become a floating residency in order to escape strict maritime law, but the government of Panama insisted that, while they were allowed to anchor, the MS Satoshi had to officially remain a ship. This led to a lot of issues regarding the disposal of waste water and especially insurance: the team was unable to find anybody that would agree to insure their stationary crypto-ship, and facing the enormous costs of running it, including having a crew on board at all times, and the fact that they were not able to sell enough cabins, they had to cancel their plans and sell the ship mid-journey.
- 24 In a resigned last blogpost, Elwartowski blamed a corona pandemic conspiracy orchestrated by global elites.
- 25 Taken from a personal conversation.

## Back to the Land

While today most people recognize that the internet is prone to tight regulation, in its beginning a lot of people thought of it borderless and free. A Declaration of the Independence of Cyberspace, which John Perry Barlow, founding member of the Electronic Frontier Foundation, published in 1996, is often used as an example of this false optimism. As their name suggests, in the 90s, the EFF perceived the internet as a new frontier, a wild and unexplored space for settlers to claim, where they could build new lives, new utopias, new modes of (smart?) governance. Barlow's text reads as a challenge to the governments of what he calls the Industrial World, or the world outside of the computers, who, according to him, had no legitimate claim to govern cyberspace.

Twenty-five years later this document has been critiqued to exhaustion. Many people have pointed out, and Barlow himself has admitted since, that this clear division between digital and physical space is not a very good model for describing the world—after all, the internet runs on real computers, which stand in real rooms that are connected to the rest of the world with real cables, all of which is powered by real electricity. The internet obviously runs on physical infrastructure, which exists in the physical world.

In his essay *Imagining the Internet: Explaining our Digital Transition*, Brewster Kahle, founder of the Internet Archive, explores the different metaphors that we have collectively used throughout the years to try and understand the internet. According to him, around 2010 the internet became more and more mobile, and more and more tied to our real identities. Around that time, cartoons depicting the internet shifted in tone: the surfers of the 90s became prisoners, bound to their oversized phones with heavy chains. As anonymity slowly disappeared, the optimism of the 90s evaporated.

Today the virtual is not separate but augmented,<sup>26</sup> which is maybe why the image of the cloud, hovering above us, overlaid like another layer in Photoshop (or Gimp), continues to stick around (that and the relentless power of marketing). As the gap between the cloud and the real world collapses, we have to think differently about the issues and inequalities inherent to both, since we can no longer treat them as independent from one another. Consequently, inequalities in the virtual (where we are limited to the possibilities the interface affords us)<sup>27</sup> cannot be solved from within it, just as code running in a sandbox cannot affect the system outside of it.

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26 The artist and design theorist Silvio Lorusso argues something similar in his text *The User Condition: Computer Agency and Behavior*, where he quotes art critic and essayist Joanne McNeil: "As smartphones blurred organizational boundaries of online and offline worlds, spatial metaphors lost favor. How could we talk about the internet as a place when we're checking it on the go, with mobile hardware offering turn-by-turn directions from a car cup holder or stuffed in a jacket pocket?"

27 We cannot, for example, just log into our social media account, and delete some of the data they have collected from us (or in many cases even delete our account)—they didn't make the buttons for that.

If Cyberspace was the indefinite space between the nodes, that magical place that existed between your computer and mine, then a digital back-to-the-land movement has to focus precisely on these nodes and their physical connections, the underlying infrastructure, which is overwhelmingly grounded, even if sometimes submerged in water. We don't need spatial metaphors, because we are dealing with real, physical space.<sup>28</sup> Luckily for us, we have much more experience in negotiating physical space than virtual space.

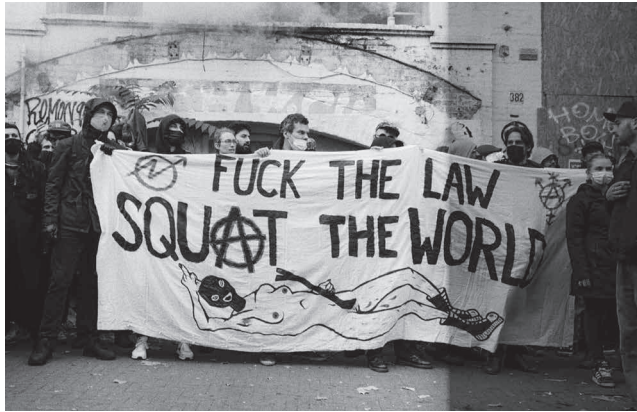


fig 4.1: A group of people negotiating physical space. The occupation of Hotel Mokum, photo by Sammy Iason, 2021.

## Occupying the Land

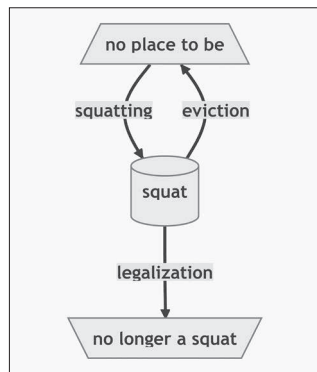


fig. 5.1 In the words of singer Nelly Furtado, *All good things come to an end. Thank you to Ada Reinthal for the initial diagram. Written in mermaid.js.*

28 To an extent, of course. The immateriality of data (not infrastructure) affords the virtual the capacity for redundancy. To use the famous piracy example, I can copy a movie and the original file remains untouched, which is, as of the time of writing, still not possible with a car.

Squatting is the act of occupying an unoccupied space without owning it or having permission to use it. It occurs around the world and is mostly connected to poverty and homelessness, where people without alternatives build settlements on unoccupied land, which over time often develop into shanty towns and slums. In 2003, the United Nations estimated that globally more than 1 billion people were living in squats and slums, projecting this number to increase up to 1.5 billion by 2020.<sup>29</sup> For most of these people, squatting is a tactic to survive.

In the Global North the term usually means something different. Here, squatting is mostly residential, meaning that it involves the occupation of vacant buildings in the city. While it's a response to the various inequalities in housing here, and as a tactic still presents the only alternative to homelessness for many (undocumented) people, it also often has an activist dimension. In their eponymous 2019 book, the collective *Architecture of Appropriation* conceptualizes squatting not only as a social movement and historical phenomenon but as a kind of *spatial activism*.<sup>30</sup>

In the Netherlands, squatting developed into a politically motivated movement after World War 2, but it wasn't until 1971 that squatters acquired legal protection,<sup>31</sup> and squatting became institutionalized. By 1980 there were weekly squatting information hours (*Kraaksprekuren*) in every Dutch city, where squatters would give free advice to whomever was interested, and the action itself was protocolized in the form of freely available manuals—interaction with the authorities and police included. In the book, *Architecture of Appropriation* suggest that since its beginnings, the squatting movement has had a decidedly *open source* character.

In 2010, around the time the internet became a cloud, squatting became a criminal offense in the Netherlands.<sup>32</sup> In the following two years more than 330 squats were evicted in Amsterdam alone. In its prime, this network of squatted places had amounted to an independent, parallel society of sorts.<sup>33</sup> This aspect of embedding yourself in a *network* is a central aspect of political squatting—the internal network of the occupants, a local

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29 United Nations, "The Challenge of Slums - Global Report on Human Settlements 2003", *UN-Habitat*, 2003.

30 René Boer, Marina Otero Verzier, Katia Truijten, *Architecture of Appropriation: On squatting as spatial practice*, Het Nieuwe Instituut, 2019.

31 That year a court ruled that if squatters could prove that they had established so-called *house peace* (*huishvrede*) they would enjoy the same legal protection in their homes as everyone else, meaning they could not just be evicted by the police without the ruling of a judge. This continues to be the legal grounds for squatting actions in the Netherlands even today.

32 Despite the raging housing crisis, which has only worsened since then. Between 2010 and 2020, the (already high) average rent price per square meter in Amsterdam increased by around 50 percent.

33 *Architecture of Appropriation* list alternative housing projects, (sub)cultural venues, food distribution centers, peoples' kitchens, legal support, media outlets and medical services as nodes in this network.

network with the neighbors, a regional network with the local scene, or an international network of political squatters around the world; they are equally important.

One way this *networked-ness* might be epitomized is in the convention of naming a newly-squatted building after the address where it is located.<sup>34</sup> By doing this, the squatters embed themselves into the broader (social) context of the city, as well as into the (local area) network of other squats there, while being simultaneously site specific and location independent. If they get evicted, the collective can squat another place next week, and the place will have a different address and a different name. Its identity will simultaneously be the same and completely different, similar to the way a computer gets assigned a new IP address in a network.

The connections between these nodes in a network are not abstract but can and have been diagrammatically mapped out, the emergency list of the former Amsterdam squat *Plantage Dok* being an example of that.<sup>35</sup> This network diagram does not include a cloud, an unknown factor beyond its control. If a cloud were to be included in this schematic, it would present *the threat* it was created to protect its members from in the first place. Instead of a network that is concerned with things like scalability, it operates on different principles. It is in its essence a network of solidarity.

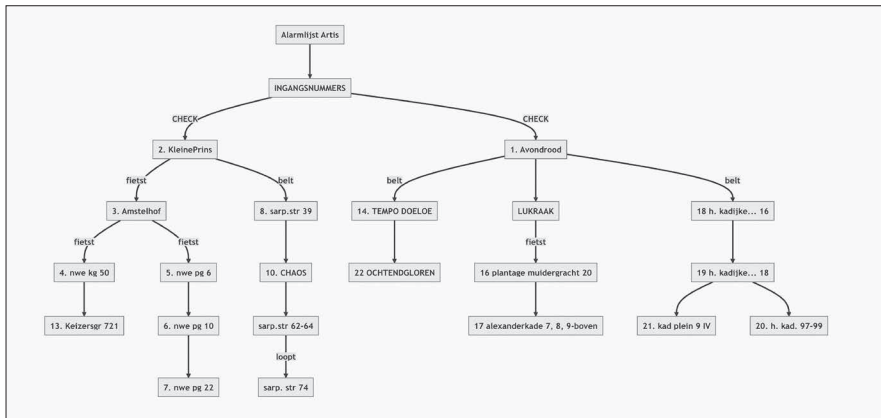


fig. 5.2 No cloud in sight on the Alarmlijst Artis (here expressed in a mermaid.js script)

34 Examples in Amsterdam include OT301 (located at Overtoom 301) and W139 (Warmoesstraat 139).

35 In a time before cell phones, this flowchart, composed on a typewriter and distributed through copying machines, mapped out how, in case of an emergency such as an attack by violent groups like the police or thugs sent by the owner, the different nodes in the immediate network should be contacted for support, in which order, by who, and by what means (by fiets, meaning by bike, or by bellen, meaning by phone). René Boer, Marina Otero Verzier, Katja Truijen, and Johannes Schwartz, *Architecture of Appropriation: On Squatting as Spatial Practice* (Rotterdam: Het Nieuwe Instituut, 2019), 55.

## Welcome to Hotel Mokum



fig 6.1: A former meme

Many of us struggled with the pressure, the excitement, the exhaustion, the uncertainty, the lack of structure, impostor syndrome. The let-down effect was real. Immediately after the action a number of people got sick. Most of us had stopped exercising, ate unhealthily, and couldn't keep up with simple household tasks. Someone said their home had started to look like a squat, while our squat had slowly started to look like a home. At the same time, most of us experienced difficulty in leaving, in going home, and felt guilty when we missed just a day or two.

We squatted Hotel Mokum on October 16, 2021. None of us had really expected to succeed. In the secretive meetings with the real squatters in which we planned the action (out of a general distrust of technology we always left our phones in another room), the best-case scenario was nothing more than a rhetorical bridge into crisis scenarios of varying gravitas that were infinitely more likely than actually succeeding: *of course, the police can just decide to leave, but more likely they will [insert various degrees of state violence here]*. But then it all turned out differently, and they did leave, and there we were, 20-odd 20-somethings and me, and all six floors of the former hotel right in the center of Amsterdam were ours, and every news outlet in town wanted to talk to us.

The day of the action we got drunk, the day after we started programming events. Our first event was a series of screenings, curated by Mateo and Jeffrey Babcock from *Jeffrey's Underground Cinema(s)*. From then on, we kept going. In the first month, we organized a neighborhood lunch, political cafes, screenings, a screen printing workshop, a chess tournament, an exhibition with more than 70 participants, a demonstration and seemingly infinite amounts of bar nights. Fueled by a mix of enthusiasm, disbelief and constant fear of eviction, we went on and on, and every time it got better and bigger, and every time it was packed.

When we didn't have a public program, we worked on the building. It had been gutted to the core and in the two years that it had been abandoned, it had decayed dramatically. After changing the locks, we cleared out the carcasses of the pigeons that had been trapped inside, cleaned the floors of their excrements, built a toilet, pumped out the water from the crawlspace beneath, built a bar, set up internet throughout the building (piggybacking on the wifi from the hotel across the street), built living rooms and bed rooms, furnished it all, and cleaned—everything, endless amounts of times. Hardly any of us had ever squatted before, let alone on this scale, and without the unconditional and selfless support and expertise from helpers, friends and members of the squatting scene, we could have never pulled any of it off.

Whatever time was left, we spent in meetings. We had to organize and decide on events, fill the sleeping schedule, plan the renovations, find legal representation, write public statements, apply for funding, talk to an endless stream of journalists, talk to the neighbors, invite activists and politicians, deny entry to other activists and politicians, form connections to other squats, talk to the owner of the building and formulate a corona policy. We organized on the fly—we set up Signal groups and a Matrix server, learned hand signs, kept times, moderated meetings, argued and solved conflicts, did check-ins and kept notes of everything. We made decisions collectively—not simply by majority, but looking for consensus even in disagreement.

Even though most of us didn't live at Hotel Mokum, we needed this place, and it needed us. We were starting to neglect the lives we had outside of it—it was consuming us. After a month, we came together in an emo meeting to discuss the emotional aspects of our involvements. It was important to create this space for us to listen to each other, let each other air grievances and send each other messages of support. Unanimously, we agreed that this month had been one of the most fulfilling months of our lives, but we had all known that before expressing it to each other. That had been the collective experience. At the emo meeting we acknowledged what happened outside of it. For a brief moment, the collective dissipated into a collection of individuals, each with their own, unique experience, with complaints, insecurities and dirty apartments.

One by one we assured each other, complimented each other on *good shares*. It was emotional and supportive. A lot of us hadn't known each other before the action, but in this moment of allowing ourselves to be vulnerable in front of each other, it felt like we had been doing this for years. We had become nodes in a (support) network, and our network, in turn, was just a node in an even larger network. As someone put it, outside the doors was now a city, not just a collection of houses. Far from autonomous, we depended on each other's solidarity; we knew that we *could* depend on each other, and that these new dependencies were voluntary.



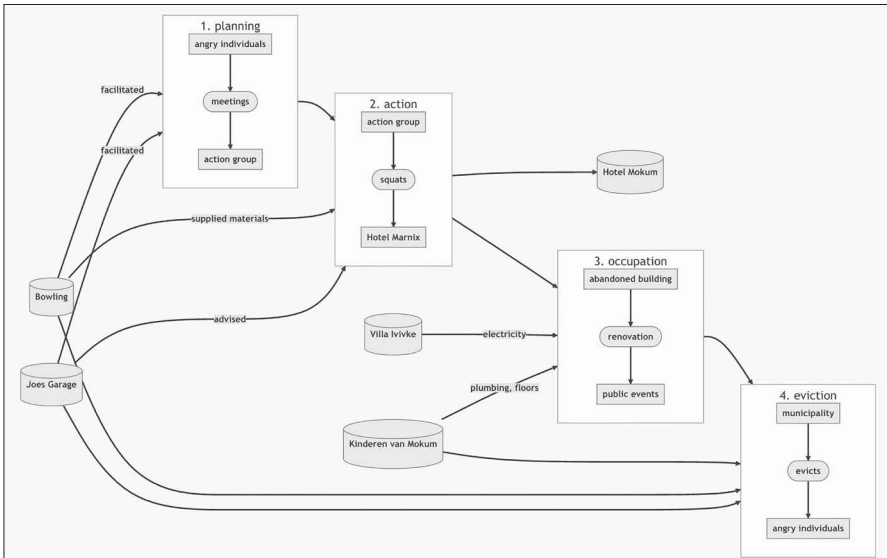


fig. 6.2: Angry individuals becoming angry individuals. The story of Hotel Mokum and some of its enablers, in mermaid.js

## Trespassing, an Afterword

There are few contact points where the augmented nature of the virtual becomes as explicit as in the (mostly cloudy) city of Amsterdam. By 1993, internet access here was still limited to a small number of households, but in 1994 Marleen Stikker, founder of the Waag Society, started the freenet<sup>36</sup> *De Digitale Stad* (*The Digital City*).<sup>37</sup> For many Amsterdammers, this was the first opportunity to access the internet. Aptly named, the *Digital City* still used the *metaphor* of the city not only in its name but also as an interface. To send emails you would have to go to the post office, for public discussions you would visit the neighborhood cafe. While text-based initially, many parts were later illustrated.

Today, in the capital of Europe's largest data center hub,<sup>38</sup> the relationship between the digital and the city (the augments and the augmented, if you will) has fundamentally shifted. Their conflation is maybe most apparent when looking at Airbnb. Arguably,

36 Freenets were proto-www networks of computers that gave users free access to information and in some cases (like with DDS) access to the internet.

37 Preceding *Geocities* by a few months, another network employing the metaphor of the city.

38 Already back in 2019, the (potentially biased) Dutch Data Center Association called the Netherlands the leader in data centers in Europe.

Amsterdam has suffered especially severely from Airbnb's business model.<sup>39</sup> In his 2016 essay *Techno-Feudalism and The Tragedy of The Commons*, William Kherbek explains this process:

1. People rent out surplus rooms and apartments on Airbnb.
2. As there is usually more money to be made on Airbnb than with traditional rental agreements, more and more living space is offered on the platform, leading to a decrease in availability of traditional housing and a consequential increase in rent prices as supply shortens.
3. The extra income from Airbnb lets the hosts keep up with rising costs of living (for example: rent) as wages continue to stagnate, which creates a dependency.
4. This leads to pressure on people to participate in the secondary housing market (Airbnb) in order to keep up and survive.

Kherbek argues that, while this process is commonly called platform capitalism, the situation is actually closer to feudalism than to capitalism (even if capitalism is the outcome). Big tech companies (*lords*) generate wealth from their users (*serfs*), exploiting their labor and data. The users find themselves in a state of inverted totalitarianism,<sup>40</sup> where the democratic structures supposed to keep things in check have been reduced to formalities. At the same time, refusal to take part in the system becomes increasingly penalized through social and financial pressure, as demonstrated in the Airbnb example. Under techno-feudalism the few own the property the many have to live on, and the data enclosed in the walled garden of the cloud is the pasture from the tragedy of the commons.<sup>41</sup>

In a similar vein, Silvio Lorusso argues that we can apply the logic of labor to the digital and that there are no class-less computers<sup>42</sup>; there are coders<sup>43</sup> and there are users<sup>44</sup> (or

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39 While this comparison is maybe hard to quantify, the grave effects of Airbnb on the local housing market are well documented.

40 Sheldon S. Wolin, *Democracy Incorporated: Managed Democracy and the Specter of Inverted Totalitarianism*, (Princeton; Oxford: Princeton University Press, 2017).

41 The Tragedy of the Commons is an economics problem conceived by economist William Forster Lloyd in 1833, in which everyone has equal access to a resource. The idea is that, if everyone were to act according to what they consider to be their immediate best interests, it would lead to over consumption, and the depletion of the resource.

42 Silvio Lorusso, "The User Condition: Computer Agency and Behavior", February 12, 2021, <https://theusercondition.computer/>.

43 The only one more powerful than the coder might be non-user, the one who doesn't use computers to begin with. Lorusso evokes the images of big-tech-CEOs that don't let their kids use social media, alluding to the privilege required for this sort of refusal, which is also expressed in Kherbek's example of Airbnb.

44 One can't help but think of the quote attributed to Edward Tufte, that the only industries that call

hackers and vectoralists in the words of McKenzie Wark).<sup>45</sup> At the core of this argument is a discussion about (computer) literacy: how much do we, as users, need to understand about the inner workings of the machines we use in order to retain capacity for action? Lorusso quotes Paul Graham, who states that in an ideal world, ordinary users shouldn't [have to] know what drivers or patches are. Similarly, in his 2018 book *The New Dark Age* the artist and writer James Bridle claims we shouldn't need to know how to code in order to use a computer, after all we don't need to understand plumbing to use the toilet.<sup>46</sup>

When we squatted Hotel Mokum, we didn't know anything<sup>47</sup> about plumbing, which was a problem because the building didn't have a toilet (or water pipes), so we needed to build one. However, a lot of the more experienced squatters, it turns out, do know about plumbing, as for them it's a source of frequently occurring issues, and within a few days they had helped us build one. While this example certainly makes a case for the benefits of knowing about plumbing (it disconnects the issue from *professionalization*, because the point here is not that squatters would be more *professional* than the rest of us), it also carries a liberating sentiment. While these practical skills might be vital for activism, they are not a requirement. In the right environments, we can pick them up along the way. The labor is liberated from class—you don't need to be a plumber to plumb.

Lorusso writes that the problem might not be illiteracy, but that instead it's about the ability to define our own behavioral patterns. Constant imposed driver and system updates often disrupt these (the toilet metaphor has really been stretched to its limits here), and as such limit our capacity for action. Not updating can be a good thing, since it lets us stick to personal and potentially un- or no longer intended ways of doing things. This ad-hoc approach to the urgencies of the situation is something central to the squatting movement. In their book, *Architecture of Appropriation* pose that unscripted and collective spatial tactics used by squatters to transform the spaces they inhabit have left behind a spatial heritage that still speaks of the desire to put the right to *live* above the right to own (private) property.<sup>48</sup>

If there is anything to learn from the world of squatting when building a digital practice, it is not about a literal translation of the concept of occupation from the physical to the virtual,<sup>49</sup> but it is about this: the capacity for action resulting from these hack-y, DIY, non-scalable and non-streamlined behavior patterns and solutions, in reusing and adapting

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their customers users are software companies and drug dealers, which is another way to think of dependencies.

45 McKenzie Wark, *A Hacker Manifesto*, Cambridge, MA; London: Harvard University Press, 2004.

46 Or, he adds, without our toilet trying to kill us. James Bridle, *New Dark Age: Technology and the End of the Future*, Verso Books, 2019.

47 shit.

48 Boer et al., *Architecture of Appropriation*, 10.

49 For example *domain squatting*, the practice of buying up domain names of companies and well known individuals before they do, mostly with the goal of selling them for a higher price afterwards

existing infrastructures and materials. These routines and tactics are a way of claiming the infamous agency over the environments we navigate, whether they be physical or digital, of breaking out of the sandbox, of refusing to take part in a game we can't win. Sticking to the metaphor of the city, these routines are the deciding factor in whether we can consider ourselves *residents* or *tourists*. In the city of the 21st century, tourists are omnipresent, to the universal dismay of the residents. In some extreme cases they might even outnumber them. While they shape their environments,<sup>50</sup> even the most curious among them ultimately don't have control over them—they are limited to the paths laid out for them by travel guides, influencers and the hotels and Airbnb's of the world. Of course, the lines are blurry here (are you a guest or a tourist when you visit friends?) and all of this is not to say that tourists have bad intentions or don't care, but by definition they lack routines and administrator rights.<sup>51</sup> Residents, however, know their environments, they shape them to their likings over long periods of time. They know and avoid the tourist traps. They have neighborhoods, and they have neighbors. Neighbors that can hopefully help them fix their toilets.

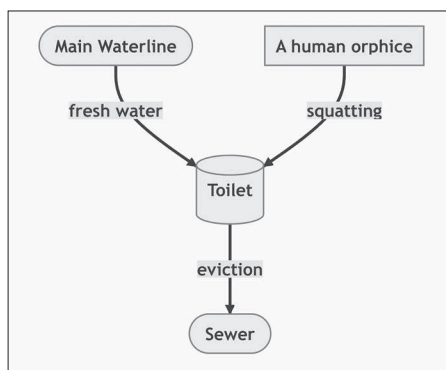


fig. 7.1: *It's not rocket science*

## Appendix: Incomplete and Unordered List of Reasons to Refuse *The Cloud*

- Workers in the Global South are being exploited and our devices are assembled by modern day slaves.
- Rare metals like cobalt, essential for lithium batteries, are extracted under horrible conditions and, among others, by children.

50 The center of Amsterdam serves as a good example here. After our inevitable eviction Hotel Mokum is, at the time of writing, being turned back into a hotel.

51 Lorusso points out that in UNIX based operating systems, users have /home folders, which is not true for iOS and Android users, rendering them homeless. Lorusso, "The User Condition".

- Other metals, like lithium, are extracted from indigenous lands without consent or regard for the environment.
- E-Waste is polluting the planet and is being dumped in landfills without regulations in the global south, poisoning both the lands and the people.
- Tech companies are constantly spying on us through our devices. The right to privacy is being eroded.<sup>52</sup>
- This information is passed on to government agencies and the surveillance state is being facilitated.
- Social media companies profit from radicalization, and a divided political landscape, fake news, disconnected filter bubbles and rabbit holes are not by-products but part of the product.
- The internet, and most devices we carry in our pockets, like smart phones, are developed from US military technology.
- Tech is a race to the brain stem. Some of the most educated people in the world put all their energy into selling us ads. Thinking we could resist the machinery is like thinking we could win against a super computer in chess.
- It's addictive on purpose. At places like the Stanford Persuasive Technology Lab people have been trained to specifically find ways of persuading users to change their behavior through digital stimuli like rewards.
- Big companies that have incomprehensible terms and conditions instead of constitutions can censor users without any form of accountability or oversight.

*fig. AP.1: The terms cloud is a bit of a stand-in for everything wrong with the internet, in this case*

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52 Douglas J. Leith, "Mobile Handset Privacy: Measuring the Data IOS and Android Send to Apple and Google," in *Security and Privacy in Communication Networks*, eds. Joaquin Garcia-Alfaro, Shujun Li, Radha Poovendran, Hervé Debar, and Moti Yung (Cham: Springer, 2021), 231–251.

# CYCLES: THE SACRED AND THE DOOMED, ON OPTIMIZATION, PMDD AND ITS METAPHORS.

MORGANE BILLUART

Originally published on December 13th, 2021



*Assemblages of screenshots from different internet resources*

We must know whether we want to change the world to experience it with the same sensorial system like the one we already possess, or whether we'd rather modify our body, the somatic filter through which it passes.

Testo Junkie, Paul Preciado<sup>1</sup>

## Day 15 - The Number One Enemy

I woke up earlier than Juli. It's day 15. The fog is slowly appearing around me. I don't see it, but I feel and hear it. It is this silent cynical voice within my head telling me that every attempt is worthless. It is the slowly escalating anxiety rushing through my veins when I start focusing on what could go wrong. The sun's rays are piercing through the mosquito net. Juli is still sleeping.

1 Paul Preciado, *Testo Junkie*, Editions Points, 2021

How do people do it? How can they do it?

The image of my parents rises in my head; the stupid idea of their monogamy and the concept of sleeping in the same bed every night. I remember thinking that doing something else would be the ultimate proof of being unloved. This thought on endless continuity and consistency feels like a weight, a terrible pressure. I sense it pouring all over me, laying in bed, covered by a light blanket and the sleeping arms of Juli. In her book *Illness as a Metaphor*, Susan Sontag investigates the cultural and aesthetic representations of disease in society. She explains how they are often displayed as images and meanings, instead of being seen as what they fundamentally are: a burden and a condition to be treated.

When I started researching Premenstrual Dysphoric Disorder, I read the list of symptoms first, to see what the condition entailed and to see how a diagnosis would be made. It was a surprise and a relief when I realized that the diagnosis was not purely a scientific one, but rather an empirical one. Still, I wondered, how does one treat a condition as a disease, when it is, in essence, seen as a fundamental component of our lives? How to approach an experience that has been understood and studied for so long as an unavoidable and fatal component of our bodies?

Before it was even categorized as a disease, PMDD existed as a metaphor. Nowadays, it is the symbol of our bodies' treatment and the prejudices around it. More than a disease, it is the result of our limited understanding of the influence of hormones on our body, psyche, and our social life. PMDD is the impact on how one's body is reflected in society. It is only once we understand the role that this metaphor plays, and how it limits the possibilities for treatment, that we can understand what is at stake behind the acknowledgment of such conditions.

Irritability, Nervousness, Lack of control, Agitation, Anger, Insomnia, Difficulty in concentrating, Depression, Severe fatigue, Anxiety, Confusion, Forgetfulness, Poor self-image, Paranoia, Emotional sensitivity, Crying spells, Moodiness, Trouble sleeping, Abdominal cramps, Bloating, Constipation, Nausea, Vomiting, Pelvic heaviness or pressure, Backache, Decreased coordination, Painful menstruation, Diminished sex drive, Appetite changes, Food cravings, Hot flashes.

One of the first questions that come to mind when reading this list is "Whose menstruating bodies do not suffer from those symptoms?". Surely, the severity of those and their frequency may vary from one individual to another. PMDD is a floating cloud that englobes an entire field of *dysfunctional* behavior and physical *incapabilities*. If you menstruate and feel terrible two weeks out of four, it's quite likely that you have this condition too. It is difficult to diagnose and treat it, specifically because the symptoms can be so diverse. As far as scientific knowledge goes, it is generally understood as a

dysfunctional reaction of the body from the changes of hormones throughout the month. These symptoms usually disappear at the beginning of each cycle, when menstruation starts.

It is complex to study PMDD as a real condition because it regroups all of the symptoms that, individually, can be dealt with, but as a whole, can make it impossible for any human being to function<sup>2</sup>. It is too complex to understand the severity of the problem in a society where menstruating bodies have been conditioned to think that pain is normal, and that menstruating is a curse that we have to learn how to deal with in silence. A body suffering from this condition can hardly express its feeling to a society that has digested that it is a normal narrative to suffer when you've been cursed and born with a uterus for centuries. The data collected demonstrated that 20% of menstruating bodies deal with PMDD; approximately 600 000 000 bodies<sup>3</sup>. PMDD is a fluctuation that, perhaps, one could deal with if we existed in a society that did not value endless efficiency or competition. If we lived in a world that did not see our uteruses as constantly available objects, if fair rates in the working environment were a thing and if generic medicine tried to look into the causes and not the symptoms. PMDD is one of the many diseases which is not understood (yet) because there's no interest, no lobby (yet). It is one more phenomenon, one demonstration that our world and systems have not been designed by other than men.

Those who suffer from this condition are moralized not only by the medical field but also by the people surrounding them. Perhaps their mental confusion is understood as hysteria, their low libido is seen as a lack of love, and their frigidity is a mystery. Perhaps their fluctuations are seen as bipolarity and their emotional unsustainability as craziness. There should be no confusion about the fact that PMDD is a condition, a disease, and a dysfunction. Like for many other diseases, its effects are highly enhanced by its unrecognition, by the absence of knowledge on the subject, and by its confrontation with society's norms. While it is still hard to know and tell where the condition comes from, what triggers, and what exacerbates it, using PMDD as a metaphoric condition enables a lens to look into the technologies of menstruating bodies and the advancements designed for them.

Over the course of the past century, enormous breakthroughs and progress have been made in the research field of menstruating bodies and female conditions. The era of the mystery of blood and burnt witches is, thankfully, long gone. Although this does not mean that the gender bias in medicine and in research has been resolved. The

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2 Kate Lucy, "PMDD is the condition that means your period can make you suicidal", *Metro*, October 5, 2019, <https://metro.co.uk/2019/10/05/pmdd-condition-means-period-can-make-suicidal-10865751/>.

3 The Recovery Village, "Premenstrual Dysphoric Disorder Statistics", ed. Megan Hull, April 19, 2021, <https://www.therecoveryvillage.com/mental-health/pmdd/pmdd-statistics/>.



majority of studies look into conditions from a male perspective and generally, women's studies remain poorly funded. Luckily, multiple books about menstruation and female reproductive organs are currently being published and the knowledge produced on these matters is ever-expanding. As we now have the chance to look into the depth of, the history of and functioning of our bodies, we are presently given the chance to better understand the mechanisms of power and oppression behind this technological progression.

## The Insufficient Technology of the Body

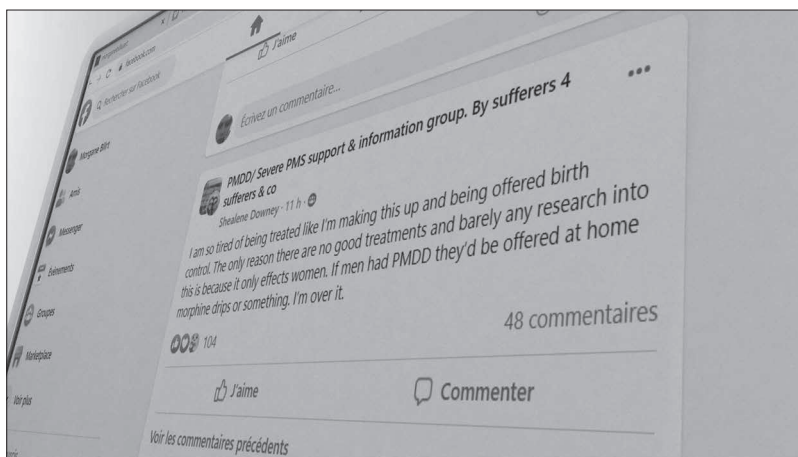
Menstruating bodies and technologies have an ambiguous relationship. Firstly, the ability to be fertile and give life remains one of the biggest possibilities of our existence. Menstruation, the absence of menstruation, as well as the many fluctuations coming throughout our cycle, are technologies that enable us to be aware of the self and of our environment. This very specific aspect of our bodies is a fundamentally political tool, and because of that exact same reason, we have been offered many assets, pills, supplements and devices, under the concept of progress, to help our bodies function better.

As a human-lived technology, the body fluctuates and sometimes does not offer the best living experiences. Not all menstruating bodies menstruate or have a regular cycle. Not all of them ovulate or can conceive. Some struggle with intense pain, some never experience pleasure. To live with your biological condition does not mean living a better life. The technology of our bodies can sometimes affect various areas of life in quite unpleasant ways. In regards to female bodies, recent progress and discoveries have offered the possibility to offer us advancements and technologies to overcome pain, obstacles, failures, and many other conditions.

For the body's Accessibility, we've been given birth control. For the body's Reproductivity, FIV. For the body's Longevity, hormones replacement. Body's Mental Instability, SSR. Body's Fluctuations, Health/Menstruating Apps... this list goes on and on.

While these technologies used to bring along a lot of enthusiasm in female and menstruating communities, perceived as tools for emancipation and freedom, they are now questioned and put in perspective with ethical, political, and ecological implications.

These rising communities, mainly perceived online, emphasize their indignations in regards to the consequences of these technologies and the remarks are generally about the lack of knowledge on the causes or implications of certain the conditions. This is particularly the case of communities of individuals suffering from Polycystic Ovarian Syndrome or Premenstrual Dysphoric Syndrome. Although these two illnesses are very much different, they both reflect a similar issue; the body suffers from its own technology, and to which the solutions provided are quite often not adequate. As a result of their feeling of being misunderstood, these communities meet and exchange their knowledge on alternative digital platforms.



Screenshot from the group PMDD/Severe PMS Support, post by Shealene Downey

Yes, science and generic medicine offered more comfort than pain in our lives. Although it would be too easy to pretend that the technological advances in the last century were only liberating and emancipating. By moving away from our biological conditionings, perhaps we were freeing the body from deterministic features and political constraints, however, the menstrual and medical revolution that we are now facing seems to demonstrate more complex dynamics. With or without the pill, with or without these conditions, our bodies are gradually realizing that the environments in which we evolve are not, by definition, designed for us. A problem that neither the pill, anti-depressants, nor this false political promise can hide anymore.

If these conditions are indeed a representation of our failed technology, recent studies which looked into the hormonal and social roots of PMS, universally known or experienced as premenstrual syndrome, demonstrated that its symptoms are highly impacted by the social environment one exists in. Researchers investigated how its effects changed depending on the social environment, demonstrating how menstruating bodies, when failing to be super-efficient and adequate, often failed into self-pathologization:

*"When women were able to be alone, they reported that their premenstrual symptoms were reduced; the 'PMS' effectively disappeared, and they felt 'better'. However, many of the women we interviewed never took time out for themselves in the whole month, and spent little time engaged in leisure activities, focusing instead on the needs of others, common to women who present with 'PMS' clinically."*<sup>4</sup>

4 Jane M. Ussher, "The ongoing silencing of women in families: an analysis and rethinking of premenstrual syndrome and therapy", *Journal of Family Therapy* vol. 24, issue 4, November 2003, 388-405, <https://doi.org/10.1111/1467-6427.00257>.

These perspectives on the subject matter invite us to wonder: what is it that makes these bodies inadequate in the first place? What is the reference we're looking into to determine how one should function? While the conditions we mentioned earlier (PCOS, PMDD, and others) are often grounded in physical and hormonal dysfunction, they seem to offer us a critical lens to look into how our technological bodies are perceived and function, what assets and advancements are being offered to us, and if these new technologies help menstruating bodies feeling better and heal within society at all.

In her thesis, *The Genesis of Premenstrual Syndrome*, Bianca Zietal reinforces the idea of PMS as a social construct by illustrating "how the concept of PMS was developed and informed by the discovery of hormones and the resulting field of endocrinology that provided a framework for conceptualizing PMS."<sup>5</sup> The researcher expands her theory and demonstrates that the metaphor of PMS illustrates its unrecognized: "This variety of uses suggests that popular culture understands PMS as something that makes for a good joke or serves to explain a negative change in a woman's behavior. However, relatively few people know that PMS has an official place as a medical diagnosis." It is specifically because we have integrated that mood swings, pain, or mental disability are a fundamental component of menstruating bodies' life so well, that, as a result, this universally known disabling phenomenon isn't still properly addressed and taken seriously. By limiting the urgency and despair in those experiences, those bodies' needs are repressed and they repress themselves in return.

Science alone won't help us. To only call out hormones and biological dysfunction for being the entire cause of our displacement would be to refuse to see how societal constructs still play a big role in this issue. Through the lens of the condition of Premenstrual Dysphoric Disorder, manifesting as an intense collection of PMS, we can ask, how this condition can help us reconfigure the technologies of our bodies and question the way that they are being taken care of in society? More than a chemical or hormonal imbalance, isn't PMDD a metaphor for our body's inadequacy? Could it also be the externalization of our incapacity to fit in the design of ideal efficiency, in the template of society at all?

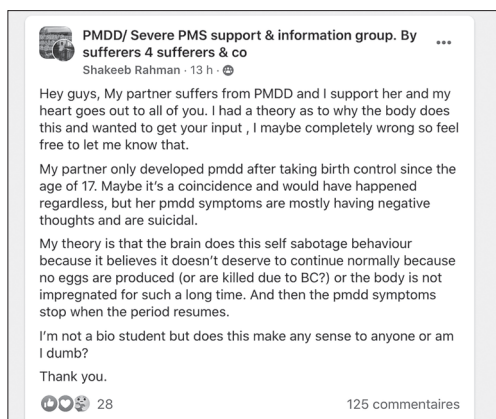
Contemporary literature addressing the topics of women and mental illnesses is scarce. It is often written by women themselves, who, based on their own understanding and experience of their bodies and minds within society, started to ask questions. In her book, *The Madness of Women: Myth and Experience*, Jane Ussher expands on how her mother's condition drove her to study psychology and investigates the dynamic of the pathologization of women's dysfunctionality. In this book, Ussher makes the following statement: "In an official announcement nearly half of all American's experience a psychiatric disorder. Does that mean no one is normal? Or do we live in such a crazy-making, sick, impersonal society that it does serious psychological damage to half of us? Should we be calling women the

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5 Bianca Zietal, "Thesis: The Genesis of Premenstrual Syndrome (PMS)". *Embryo Project Encyclopedia*, 2021. ISSN: 1940-5030 <http://embryo.asu.edu/handle/10776/13216>.

mentally ill or society's wounded?"<sup>6</sup> While this realization is a question that could be applied to a broad range of conditions and diseases, it is specifically urgent to look into how the criteria and expectations of our cultures can lead to the aggravation of those.

## Upgraded and Updated: on Hormone Replacement and Alleviation



Screenshot of the Facebook group PMDD/Severe PMS support, posted by Shakeeb Rhaman.

As previously mentioned, it is difficult and tedious to diagnose PMDD. Even though the condition seems to have been named for more than 20 years, institutes and research in its regard remain succinct. As a result, the production of knowledge and treatments are scarce and often reductive. PMDD being a disease with hormonal and psychological impacts, two fields of action are proposed. First: the pill, in order to suppress hormonal fluctuations and consequently, these impacts on the body, or second: anti-depressants, in order to alleviate the mental burden of the condition in everyday life. While these treatments might help some individuals and bodies by lessening the symptoms generated by the condition, it does not seem to change anything in regard to the urgency of the topic, as well as lack of knowledge around it. While our bodies are being offered pills and assets to cope with such conditions and what society made of them, there exists a risk of these conditions being under looked, perhaps even remaining unstudied.

In the article *Fake periods, side effects, and other things you need to know about the pill* naturopath Lara Briden explains how the number of solutions given to those bodies reflects the scope of knowledge around it. "At the moment, the pill is one of the only women's health treatments available to doctors," Briden says. "So, of course, they have no choice but to prescribe it for all manner of period problems."<sup>7</sup> It would not be the first moment

6 Jane M. Ussher, *The Madness of Women: Myth and Experience*, (Taylor & Francis, 2011).

7 Laura Briden, "Fake periods, side effects and other things you need to know about the pill", *Vogue*

in history that these bodies and the technology within are dismissed, put aside rather than questioned and supported. Therefore, it is urgent and necessary to wonder what will happen to our bodies and to these conditions if they remain hidden, unspoken. Are they veiled by the designed cure? What are the technologies proposed, and what are the implications behind these choices?

## Day 14 - Memories of Diane 35

The perfect cycle's length is 28 days. So are the number of these pills that I had to swallow. They say ovulation happens two weeks before menstruation, therefore, I should be ovulating by now. I used to feel it more intensely before. I noticed in the past how my behavior changed around that time. The texture of my discharges. The smell of my body. The look I give to men. Ovulation is, primitively, the key moment where one should conceive to have a higher chance to reproduce. My body knows that by now, but it was not always the case.

Summer 2016. I got prescribed Diane 35 to deal with skin problems and non-existent periods. I am pretty sure that my body is trying to tell me something, but I am 19 years old and I have no time to wait for my skin to be perfect and my cycle to function. These are early teens, or elderly's people problems, not mine.

I remember walking in the street of Sicily with A. He gets mad because men look at me as if I was an object. Am I not? Diane 35 cleared my skin, made my boobs grow enormous and my hair grew thicker. It's all I ever wanted, all of this potential in a small, ridiculously tiny package. I am youth and elasticity in a box. I can decide or not if I want to bleed, by the simple act of renewing my pills every month. I am ready to be used, consumed, taken, and everyone around me senses that. The utopia of my body and this relationship with A does not last very long: I soon realize that the pill cuts off my appetite, my desire, and my libido. I suddenly become this desirable object which can't be consumed.

A and I seemed to exist in perfect disharmony, a body hooked on natural testosterone, another one sedated on artificial estrogens. I hate how cliché it sounds and how grounded it feels. I now see our dysfunctionality clearer. Being on Diane35 is similar to getting a free ticket to the buffet when you just lost your taste or appetite. A luxurious hotel without a swimming pool. A reminder that it is impossible to win at everything in life.

As for many other conditions, an interesting dilemma operates between the researchers in the healthcare field and the ones who experience the condition. Is it not the perfect timing to either, create a technology that would completely free us from our biological conditioning and its complications, or on the contrary enable us to connect to the core issue and

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*Australia, August 10, 2018, <https://www.vogue.com.au/beauty/wellbeing/fake-periods-side-effects-and-other-things-you-need-to-know-about-the-pill/news-story/006e70f2afb4fd78c4616bcd1417add2>.*

fundamentals of our bodies and their functioning by rejecting technology? Although these two separate movements do have a correlated goal (to emancipate) they seem to look into two separated notions of technology. The first one belongs within, is more ancestral, holistic, and so-called “natural”, while the other one bets on technological assets and medical advancements to free us from the condition. While these two battles and research fields are worth looking into, it is necessary to emphasize a third question that needs to be examined and criticized: the effect that the environment and its design around us have on us.

In the article of the Atlantic, *Why to Menstruate If You Don't Have To?*, journalist Marion Renault illustrates the dilemma which operates in a society where many menstruating bodies would rather not experience the bleed of their biological body. While the reasons for such choices are sometimes linked to intense or unbearable pain, body dysphoria, or the lack of access to product/resources for menstruation, it is also emphasized that the underlying need and desire is to be optimal and functioning, or rather, compete better with other individuals which are not menstruating. *“I want them to be competitive against those who don't have uteruses,”* Yen said. *“Teenage years are so turbulent and horrific as is. I don't want them to suffer unnecessarily—and I can alleviate this for my child.”*<sup>8</sup> This thought exists or has probably existed in many of our minds. It is a valid and understandable idea, given the conditions in which our bodies evolve. A society where the conditions related to our reproductive systems are little or poorly studied and where paid leaves due to pain or disability are extremely rare. Not to menstruate, and therefore to not have these conditions, is the newest efficiency dream. It is an idyll because, in this space, our body would not be limited by its biological condition and is not judged for it. A world where we could be functional, optimal and where our body would not be an obstacle to our activities and ambitions. But who sold us this dream? Why should we be optimal, and for whom?

In these artificial attempts to cure and hide, nothing more is being investigated. Coming back to the testimony of Lara Briden in the article *Fake periods, side effects, and other things you need to know about the pill*, the naturopath unpacks how *“Pill bleeds are pharmaceutically induced bleeds ... to reassure you that your body is doing something natural,”* says Briden. *“Many doctors continue to prescribe birth control to ‘normalize periods’ and ‘regulate hormones’, as though the pill’s steroids are somehow equal to, or better than, your own hormones. The fact is, nothing could be further than the truth. Pill steroids are not better than your hormones. They’re not even real hormones.”*<sup>9</sup> So, is that it? Will we resolve these conditions and treatments by simply eradicating and replacing natural hormones? Is that all we know? When looking at these artificial technologies of emancipation and transformation, we observe how they simulate the real, the biological, as to convince the “naturalness” of their essence. As if our distinction with “nature” and the choices of some individuals to alter their biology wasn’t accepted yet. But it’s already there.

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8 Marion Renault, “No One Has to Get Their Period Anymore”, *The Atlantic*, July 17, 2020, <https://www.theatlantic.com/science/archive/2020/07/why-menstruate-if-you-dont-have/614350/>.

9 Briden, “Fake periods, side effects and other things you need to know about the pill”.

In regards to the second-most administered treatment offered to PMDD sufferers, SSRIs, the positive results of these medications seem to underline the psychological and mental consequences of the condition. While the body seems to correctly react to the presence of estrogen, the main hormone-induced within the first two weeks of each month, progesterone, arriving right after ovulation, seems to be the culprit of the sudden change in mood, embodiment, and perception.



*Memes posted by @pmddmemes on Instagram.*

While the studies of PMDD and its impact on mental and social life were rendered public forty years ago<sup>10</sup>, it does appear that the medical field still has not targeted the exact cause of the sensitivity of what aggravates it. As a result, to this day, SSRIs are the main and only option offered to patients and it should be emphasized that it has shown great results. Still, as for PMS, PMDD is the result of a change that operates hormonally and chemically, therefore its experience and perception are also highly emphasized by the environment in which one finds themselves. If it is indeed hard for an individual to sense their body and mind changing so drastically within such a short period of time, this experience might as well be aggravated by the social pressure which women and

10 Sex hormone-sensitive gene complex linked to premenstrual mood. (2017, January 3). National Institutes of Health (NIH). <https://www.nih.gov/news-events/news-releases/sex-hormone-sensitive-gene-complex-linked-premenstrual-mood-disorder>.

menstruating bodies have suffered from for centuries. If SSRIs can help one's mental capacities and soften their experience, it does demonstrate that the mental burden of those conditions is consequent. If those treatments can ease one's experience of their body, we should not forget to question what the changes are which need to happen within society for those bodies not to feel sick and oppressed in the first place.

In her book, *The Madness of Women: Myth and Experience*, Ussher expands her question to a broader range of conditions attributed to female and menstruating bodies: "*I thus turn my gaze onto three other manifestations of madness ascribed to significant proportions of the female population: borderline personality disorder (BPD), post-traumatic stress disorder (PTSD), and premenstrual dysphoric disorder (PMDD). While my arguments can be generalized to other 'female maladies' (such as anorexia or anxiety disorders), these three psychiatric disorders are ideal examples of the pathologization of women's reasonable response to restricted and repressive lives*"<sup>11</sup>. I insist throughout this text on the necessity to understand the social component of these issues because a greater design of technology and cures should not only hide or disguise the external reality of the patient but also aim to change and redefine the context in which one exists. Although it is also emphasized that PMDD can be inherited, studies demonstrate the correlation of discrimination, poverty, pressures to assimilate, etc with the appearance of PMDD or its aggravation<sup>12</sup>. It would be tempting, although hypocritical, not to see a direct link between these conditions and the standards of society in the era of capitalism, in between society's mechanism, patriarchy, and psychiatry. While PMS and PMDD are now universally known and understood as limiting and hurtful conditions, their existence as metaphors has not stopped existing. In their everyday life, menstruating bodies might still try their best to perform and hide their physical or psychological pain, as a way to counteract the cliché and stigmas which accompany women and anger. Those hide their day-to-day experience as a way not to be discriminated against. Not to be judged. While many fights for these conditions' visibility and the importance of its study field, it is still a vigorous battle to claim the recognition of the incapacity to perform and live optimally in society.

In 2002, almost twenty years ago, Joan C Chrisler and Paula Caplan published *The strange case of Dr. Jekyll and Ms. Hyde: How PMS became a cultural phenomenon and a psychiatric disorder*. In this paper, they both investigate how and if social context influenced PMS, and what were the solutions given to those who were highly suffering from the condition. As a result of their findings, they conclude:

"It is certainly easier to take medication to restore serenity or create emotional detachment (an often reported effect of Prozac/Sarafem) than it is to take steps to

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11 Ussher, *The Madness of Women: Myth and Experience*

12 Cory E Pliver et al., Exposure to American Culture is associated with Premenstrual Dysphoric Disorder among ethnic minority women, *Journal of affective disorders* vol. 130, (November, 2011), doi:10.1016/j.jad.2010.10.013.



make changes in one's life circumstances, and women are getting the message from advertising and other forms of media that taking medication is what they should do. And psychotherapists may find it easier to help a woman try to change herself in order to fit the feminine ideal; than to figure out how to help her resist the social and cultural pressure to be an ideal woman. Taking medication may provide apparent serenity to individual women, but it does nothing to alleviate the oppressive conditions that contributed to the stress and tension that caused them to report severe PMS. PMS is a form of social control and victim blame that masquerades as value-free."<sup>13</sup>

Still, here we are, twenty years later, and it does not seem that these considerations have shaped or changed much in the generic medical field. Thankfully, throughout the years, an army of enraged and disappointed bodies gathered to discuss and collect information and experiences which could not be found or mentioned in the earlier times.

## Femtech, in Between Holistic and Transhuman Perspectives



*A meme posted by @pmdmemes on Instagram.*

## Day 29 - Still a week to go

In moments like these, I feel the urgent need to alter my body or alter my perception. My detachment from people and from physicality has been rather intense these past days. Humans feel strange to me. I'd like to smoke a joint, although I never craved weed. I bought truffles to micro-dose but the prescribed amount isn't strong enough. I don't feel anything. When thoughts about past events and urges pop up in my mind, these tiny balls of thoughts either explode to become turmoil and

13 Joan C Chrisler and Paula Caplan, "The strange case of Dr. Jekyll and Ms. Hyde: how PMS became a cultural phenomenon and a psychiatric disorder", Annual review of sex research vol. 13, (February, 2002), <https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/12836734/>.

anxiety, or they simply disappear in the overall fog that floats in my head. I am numb.

The perspective of the relief feels quite far and aggravates its urgency. A part of me tries to see despair as fertile ground for experimentation, for change. But how dangerous is that?

It has become nearly impossible for me to write these days. Now, with more theory backed up in my brain, I can't help but always judge the social construct of these experiences. I am numb.

The feeling I initially wanted to start working with, anger, feels often too long gone. Anger is the energy of beginners, amateurs. It's the fuel of the ones who want to throw out. And I just don't know where the battlefield is anymore. Perhaps I can't write next to anger at the moment. But if not this, then what? It's too easy for me to call out on this condition and blame it for the state of my mind. It could be a thousand other things adding to my flow of hormones. It could be that normativity also includes numbness. Where's the line that one draws to call themselves sick?

Why am I not choosing to feel something? Why am I not choosing drugs? Not choosing the pill, not choosing the SRRI's? Who am I trying to be a fierce warrior for?



*Rendered image, Screenshot of the Jstor Library, Article "Is Prozac a feminist drug?"*

The isolation generated by the knowledge gaps led those who suffer from the condition to find alternative ways to connect through the internet. YouTube, Tik Tok, and Reddit became the site of experiences and testimonials that those bodies would refer to. On these platforms, one can find moving testimonies, cries for help, and success stories of patients who have found their ideal combination to alleviate their symptoms. There, different paths seem to appear, in between the ones referring to holistic fixes and natural flows, and the others, aiming for a neo-human or trans perspective of emancipation and liberation. While these ideologies share similar ideals, they seem to differ on some notions; some aspire to slow down technological

processes and their artificial changes, meanwhile, others support the futuristic ideal of biological liberation through science and medicine. Simultaneously, they both question more fundamentally the standards and designs of society that lead to these conditions and treatments. While these internet groups and communities allowed patients to collect and gather information, share their knowledge and support each other mentally, awareness and actions, something else emerged. From these online gatherings and testimonies in the age of the internet and fast-online-shipping, a new and exponential market appeared - a market much bigger than the PMDD or PCOS market alone. A market whose mission it is to change society, science, the condition of women and to vary the treatments and their accessibility: the world of FemTech.

As we started to face the sudden deterministic realization of our bodies and their conditioning, researchers and tech experts started to assemble, aiming to develop new tools and concepts which would help our bodies and their technologies in everyday life. This new industry appears to be born from a new generation of individuals, an army of strong and ambitious warriors determined to offer wellness and a sense of conformity to women and menstruating bodies. Instead of separating the two previous names ideologies - returning to nature, or emancipating from it - Femtech aspires to exist in between. It aspires to become an alliance of ancestral knowledge and forms of rituals mixed up with digital devices and high-tech tools to enhance our experience and knowledge. Femtech is a thermal ring you'll put in your vagina to track your temperature. Femtech is a menstrual app that predicts the worst moment of your cycle to make a business deal – girlboss at its finest. Femtech is a DIY kit to try out your fertility and its expiration date. Femtech is when your phone became your very personal gynecologist. Fluids are the issue, digital is the recipe. It is the world that perhaps Donna Haraway dreamt of mixed with nuances of Silicon Valley. FemTech is what technology for menstruating bodies looks like in the 21st century. Within this new ideology, more than often directed and designed by individuals who are other-than-man, it is an interesting moment to reflect on these technologies, their promises, and the obstacles one might encounter when trying to design new technology and a new philosophy for inclusion and care.



*Images extracted from the article “Femtech startups on the rise as investors scent profits in women's health”, written by Gene Marks in The Guardian.*

The Elvie pelvic floor trainer is just one of a number of products from ‘femtech’ startups which have raised almost \$50m in recent months. As mentioned earlier, we should not only focus on fixes for our bodies in society and ways to optimize pain or time, but rather think of objects and interfaces which offer care and understanding of our conditioning. The world of Femtech gives a chance for health and care to be designed and understood by a more diverse body of thinkers, designers, and engineers. It could become a revolution if we make sure it does not take the path of an optimization that takes men as the norm and gravitates towards efficiency or productivity. Even more than finding and designing cures, Femtech also has the main challenge to help our bodies fight society’s standards defined by men. This revolution holds a huge potential, one that has been banned, or hidden before: the possibility to target not only the symptoms but also the research, the gender gaps, as well as society’s standards, so far deeply imprinted in patriarchy and capitalism. Within this new field, many questions arise. What can science and technology do to our bodies? Through which aim? For who’s interest? Should we even try to understand these phenomena? Or shall we, as Preciado suggested, live in a world of “molecular excitation”?

While this research field grows and while waiting for more discoveries and fixes to appear, self-diagnosis and medication seem to be one of the ways that patients learn to deal with the condition of PMDD. At this stage, the internet sometimes feels like a safer space to talk and investigate cures. While I wait for changes to appear, and dream of a speculative database where our bodies and conditions could be studied and rendered real, our society keeps on evolving at a fast pace, designed by patriarchy with endless feelings of inadequacy as a result. This battlefield isn’t located at one spot only, it is multiple and intertwined. It is a call for care, for a change in health systems, it is a reminder to not always judge our bodily responses to the world, but also to question the world itself. On the good days, in the first two weeks, I am optimistic and fearless of the obstacles coming in the way of this revolution. On the last two, it becomes harder to stay positive, but at least anger and inadequacy drive me to write. Until the next cycle.

### **Day 3 - The Dream Girl**

Still not at my cutest because my hair is still kind of greasy from the hormones. I always love to shower around the 7th day. I am finally clean and renewed. In the evening, I grab my phone to log in to Field. I don’t know what I am looking for but I NEED attention. I have a partner and great friends but I DEMAND care. There is something in the way I carry myself and walk around the world. My stomach is now flat, my cravings are gone.

I am the dream girl. I feel hot and smart. I desire and I am desired, I stare back because I am a young flesh, young blood, and because it feels so rare, so intense to feel adequate. There is something in the smell of others, in their moves, I could suddenly hug the entire planet, perhaps even make out with it. I wish I could be that girl all of the time, could live on estrogens and serotonin, never get old and always want to fuck. Twenty-four years old, in my luteal phase: I am optimal, and it will never again get better than this. I wake up in

the morning acknowledging the time that has already passed and won't come back, I look at what I already possess. It's not much, but they all say that at least I have time, I have youth. Youth is not much when understood in the frame of fertility. I have been ovulating for over ten years already and still did not procreate. Something in my mind tells me that I have approximately ten years left. Ten years left, as they say, to find the perfect partner, to assure my back, to carefully think of and act upon, because it is youth and I because I am a woman.

The memory of the fogginess from the follicular phase is already long gone, forgotten, forgiven. I can take the world back, chase whatever I intended to do, but I have to remember: my time is limited. Soon enough, something bigger, stronger, wiser than me will limit my thinking and actions. It is because the time is so short that I choose not to think of the evil anymore. I would rather focus on what functions, look at the bleach of my hair, the hydration of my peachy skin, happily notice the lubrication of my genitals, all of this while I still can.

I have no hate, no. I feel no repression, I go out like a trophy, I am above what is dictated because I am exactly what I was intended to become. I will happily smile at strangers and perhaps fantasize for a second, patriarchy feels like a distant battle which I won because I am optimal. I could choose to love or hate, ride or die, date or break but still, time is running and I should focus on what needs to be achieved, succeed while I still can.

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# SKYLINES I'VE NEVER SEEN: NET-REAL CHINA AS HOPEIUM

ALEKSY DOMKE

Originally published on May 1st, 2025



My old roommate is crashing at my place. As a thank you, he gives me an incredibly well-designed box of Sina Ginger Candy. Sized like a cigarette box, a beautiful illustration of a ginger root [inside joke about rhizome] occupies the center, with red Chinese writing placed vertically on either side. On top, “Sina Ginger Candy” is written in an Evangelion-like, vertically stretched serif font. The rest of the label is sprinkled with various symbols and certificates like “real ginger.” I place it next to my 7-eleven Gundam, a limited edition 2005 Hello Kitty keychain and a centimeter thick plate of 5052 aluminum I brought from Asia.

We spend the next morning talking about Weibo thirst traps, Xiaohongshu shopping streams,<sup>1</sup> Chinese aunties in Balenciaga sweats and the sublime Chinese manufacturing industry. If this was 2022 we would probably be talking about some random meme or a niche Bandcamp release [we are edgy like that]. In 2025 we’re discussing the wonders of economic development in a country we’ve both never been to, but somehow share a strong connection with.

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1 Weibo and Xiaohongshu are Chinese platforms, similar to YouTube and Instagram/Pinterest.

## China's Soft Power Grind

With the release of Trump 2, the American machine of computational propaganda steps into overclock. Multipliers on the CPU — *China propaganda unit* — just got cranked up for real. Last edition's fan favorite "China Virus"<sup>2</sup> could not stand up to the new and improved AI-assisted attacks. While the U.S. is running on NVIDIA's Blackwell Architecture, it's struggling to keep in the lead against China's highly efficient, centrally-managed cores.

The New Red Scare<sup>3</sup> is America's last-ditch effort to cling onto its radiant plaque on the global scoreboard. The new admin has triggered *America's Great Crashout*, spamming its economic weapons on Canada, Mexico, EU, and most importantly — China. Since Twitter's 280-word limit proves to be limiting, U.S. officials turn to have their post-game meltdowns on [whitehouse.gov](https://www.whitehouse.gov).<sup>4</sup>

"Somehow it's a crime when Russia does it to us, but good 'information ops' when we want to discredit Beijing's Belt & Road initiatives worldwide" — Marcus Stanley in a dek for *Responsible Statecraft*.<sup>5</sup>

Just five years ago, China was predominantly seen as an Orwellian surveillance state. Fueled by headlines of Western terror bait, an image of a scary totalitarian regime was ingrained as a reflexive response. Echoing the breakneck speed of China's exponential economic development, the country's soft power climbed the ranks from an ostracized walled garden to the frontier of innovation. Driven by subsidized cultural exports and technological advancements — accelerated by the decline of American hegemony.

In 2023, influence of Mandarin-speaking digital culture rooted itself in the West as surrealist selfies, Douyin makeup and TCM, reaching even surface scrollers.<sup>6</sup> Last year, Chinese viral content has swept over Western feeds, announcing its presence with dances like Ke

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- 2 "China Virus" or "Kung Flu" are racially charged terms coined by Trump during his first presidency, referring to COVID-19. The phrases significantly contributed to Sinophobic sentiment in the West, particularly spreading through hashtags on the platform. See: Paul Cooper and Sofia Lampropoulou, "China Virus, Kung Flu, and MAGA: Countervailing and Sociological Fractionation on Twitter as Evidenced by Pro- and Anti-Trump Discourses in Relation to Covid-19," *Discourse, Context & Media* 57 (February 1, 2024): 100758–58, <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.dcm.2024.100758>.
  - 3 Ying Fu, "The Construction of China's National Image under the COVID-19 Epidemic by the American News Media," *International Journal of Education and Humanities* 15, no. 2 (July 27, 2024): 6–9, <https://doi.org/10.54097/6fgxv24>.
  - 4 The White House, "Yes, Biden Spent Millions on Transgender Animal Experiments," *The White House*, March 5, 2025, <https://www.whitehouse.gov/articles/2025/03/yes-biden-spent-millions-on-transgender-animal-experiments/>.
  - 5 William Hartung, "Can Bernie Stop Billions in New US Weapons Going to Israel?," *Responsible Statecraft*, April 2025, <https://responsiblestatecraft.org/signal-yemen/>.
  - 6 MØRNING, "China, the Internet's Favourite Trendsetter?," *Substack.com* (Burn After Reading, February 8, 2024), <https://morningfyi.substack.com/p/china-the-internets-favourite-trendsetter>.

Mu San (一笑江湖), transnational TikTok e-commerce stars like *LC Sign* or *Etong space capsule house* and Chinese-flavored brainrot. Chinese-owned games have dominated the market with titles like *Final Fantasy* or *Genshin Impact*. Snowballing off of both organic trends, and subsidized enterprise entertainment, travel influencers stormed Zhangjiajie's towering mountains, misty rice fields of Guangxi and the meandering Great Wall. Yoga girls on Instagram photoshoots in Yunnan and fratboys soyfacing in Chongqing, prompted the government to ease travel restrictions for foreign tourists. American tech nerds drool at the sight of Huawei's triple fold Mate XT smartphone and Deepseek's ChatGPT equivalent, shifting their attention away from home-grown AI Pin scams.

Increasingly hostile relations between world's competing superpowers have brought China into the media's spotlight. Although my perception might be skewed by an attentional bias, I found China's presence elevated to a familiar refrain. Whether drinking beer at a bar with people I've met at a youtuber's meetup, having Xiao Long Bao with roommates or chatting with colleagues. The American propaganda machine seems to have lost its momentum, exhausting its grip on media, allowing a shift in Western reporting and public opinion. One demographic has swallowed a disproportionate amount of China-pills — the chronically online Western youth. What happened here? And what's the role of social media and meme culture in all of this?

## Algorithmic Politics & Aesthetic Logics

The worldview-forming process for digital natives is usually based around whatever slop they get served on their algorithmic plates. The infinite canteen of Instagram's for you page seems to have introduced their brand-new Sinic menu. Today's content is often entirely removed from the 2021 wave of 'social credit score' memes. In contrast, contemporary China-posting is characterized by a surge of quasi-inspirational videos, depicting the unmatched aura of the economic giant.

In the platform-driven, algorithmic era of politics, the doomscrolling-induced paralysis draws a lot of parallels with Fisher's framework in *Capitalist Realism*,<sup>7</sup> predating current social media landscapes. Analogous to capitalism itself, algorithms are opaque, but omnipresent and unchallengeable. They structure desire, attention and worldview. The algorithm replaced ideology as the dominant structuring force of reality. The database of ideas has fallen victim to a deterministic algorithm — people don't analyze politics, they scroll into them. Knowledge collapses into aesthetics. Your carefully-researched argument and a swiss knife of references will never be content. Joe Rogan is though. [*liberal destroyed*]

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7 Mark Fisher, *Capitalist Realism: Is There No Alternative?* (Winchester: Zero Books, 2009).



The left's search for a reciprocal Joe Rogan is a Web 2.0 equivalent of Fisher's reflexive impotence. The Democrats recognize their Kamala HQ cringefest cannot compete against the Republican swarm of online grifters. Yet instead of challenging the post-truth affect regimes, they set out on a vibe-seeking venture, blindly chasing after their opponents' successes. In spectacle politics, you either win the aesthetic arms race or you get offloaded from collective memory.<sup>8</sup>



A sigma-esque montage of first-tier skylines like Shenzhen or Shanghai; high-rises glistening with hypercoordinated addressable RGB LEDs. Bullet trains and shiny pick-and-place machine timelapses interpose the aerial drone views, cut to the rhythm of SKAI's 因果 (yīn guǒ) evil jerk remix. Surfacing in countless short-form videos, aforementioned trend epitomizes a new genre of posts, reframing China as a technological power, challenging Western preconceptions.

Stylistically branching out from 'sigma male' edits, the videos share the same tone conveying <power> <dominance> <stoicism>. The choice of music and editing pace are instrumentalized in calculated ways. As a phonk subgenre, 'evil jerk' is closely associated with the manosphere, often paired with a plethora of Patrick Bateman or Jordan Peterson TikToks. TikToks, edited in an eerily similar fast-paced and beat-matched style to those celebrating China's prosperity era. The East rises not through ideology but via streamable symbolism.

Projecting this pattern forward, "mogging" a term widely used in the Andrew Tate cesspool to describe dominating another person, was applied to China's economical

8 Jodi Dean, *Democracy and Other Neoliberal Fantasies: Communicative Capitalism & Left Politics* (Durham: Duke University Press, 2009).

and technological presence on the international scene. Memes portraying the country's leader as a 'chad' have carpet bombed the algorithm in a confusing composite of alt-right aesthetic trends and anti-Western sentiment. Most recently, the image was captioned with "*Do nothing. Win.*" and spread as a response to America's failures in the economic arms race. Extrapolating this analogy further, a hustle-culture-adjacent phrase "making moves in silence" can describe China's Peaceful Development Policy — Xi is making moves in silence while Western powers implode before our very eyes.



This seduction of image, as described by Baudrillard,<sup>9</sup> instrumentalizes affective labels like <prestige> <authority> in warfare of pre-cognitive capture. All those post-internet artists who slap candles in front of a screen wrapped in lasercut cybersigilist motifs actually have a point. The algorithm is not just infrastructure, it's a semiotic spirit, seducing users into pre-coded reactions. The scroll is no longer informational but ritualistic, ceremonial. While Western tech might have you visualize Christian signifiers, they soon might be replaced with Buddhist or Taoist ones. [feel free to use this idea in your next installation for that unpaid show you have in East London.] Akin to online alt-right's tactics, the symbolic authority collapses into a circulating set of signs.

The algorithm doesn't lie, it arranges political configurations. In Pasquinelli's terms, it becomes a *real abstraction*,<sup>10</sup> embedding geopolitical narratives not through discourse, but through optimized aesthetic logics. In this way, China is not understood, but algorithmically performed, again and again, until the performance becomes perception. Connecting visual stimuli to cognitive control is not something you decide on. You scroll until it sediments into belief. Deceived by the illusion of participation, the algorithm choreographs our feelings, managing attention through symbolic saturation.

With the internet's shift from a library to a conveyor belt of content, we carelessly let the algorithm reprogram our brains when we're most vulnerable. We don't scroll to *think* about

9 Jean Baudrillard, *The Evil Demon of Images* (Sydney: Power Institute of Fine Arts, University of Sydney, 1987).

10 Matteo Pasquinelli, *The Eye of the Master: A Social History of Artificial Intelligence* (Verso Books, 2023).

what we see, it's a passive process we engage in to *avoid thinking*. This subconscious reprogramming of our brains through visual stimuli makes us prone to build emotionally-charged associations based on the way a given post is edited. Rather than persuasive, new media is habitual. Although Fox News still glazes Trump through their North-Korean-state-TV tenue, traditional propaganda is no longer as effective. This disjuncture of new media into an embodied process is excellently described by Wendy Hui Kyong Chun in *Updating to Remain the Same*.<sup>11</sup> New media doesn't simply inform, it habituates. It doesn't cultivate knowledge so much as condition a reflex: aesthetic awe as political truth, aesthetics as foreign policy. The emotional resonance happens *before* critical reflection.

After you get served thirty over-edited Peaky Blinders reels with phonk music some teen made with CapCut, the style nests itself in the depths of your brain, labeled <dominance> <power>. Next time you see a post with matching stylistic characteristics, those subliminal labels shape how you perceive its contents. Memetic templates reproduce ideology. When I first saw one of those sigma-like China edits, the wirings of my frontal lobe triggered a short circuit. The pre-programmed visual associations in my brain placed a stamp of approval on my hyperobsession. As shivers extend down my spine, I think to myself—*based*—as I proceed to put on *Ke Mu San* (hardstyle remix) on SoundCloud. I realize I no longer care about the factual, I am here for the vibe.

## IShowSpeed — Hyperrealist China & Statecraft Through Livestream

*Awaiting the mythical fall of the west, you're stuck in the limbo of enshittified remnants of European welfare-states. Your outlook for the future was ravaged by some loser who posts 150 times a day.<sup>12</sup> The hyperrealist demon of x.com has taken over. The tsunami of blue checkmarks flooded your content village and wiped out your niche twitter poetry community. Someone responded to you liking a video of a baby monkey getting mopped on the ground by an adult monkey. You open YouTube in a new tab, IShowSpeed is live right now.*

IShowSpeed, a 20 year-old American streamer has announced his Asia Tour. Asia in question: China and Mongolia. Not the Western associative reflex of Korea or Japan. China. “[IShowSpeed] embarked on a marathon livestreaming tour across China, broadcasting for six uninterrupted hours on the first day alone, he vaporized the meticulously constructed ‘China threat theory’ peddled by some in the West. His lens revealed a nation so starkly divergent from typical Western caricatures that it made many viewers confront the uncomfortable truth that their perception of China had been systematically distorted.” — *China Daily*.<sup>13</sup>

11 Wendy Hui, *Updating to Remain the Same: Habitual New Media* (Cambridge: MIT Press, 2016).

12 Elon Musk.

13 Zhang Zhouxiang, “IShowSpeed Livestreams Show World an Unfiltered China,” *Chinadaily.com.cn*, 2025, <http://www.chinadaily.com.cn/a/202503/31/WS67e9e447a3101d4e4dc2bb85.html>.

Partially engulfed in sweaty dreams by virtue of misclicking snooze two hours ago, I reach for my phone. The moment I expose my optic nerve to the environment, my finger wanders over to the Instagram icon. I get hit with the screen time limit popup courtesy of scrolling for too long after midnight. As I choose “Remind me in 15 minutes,” I am immediately greeted by Speed lip-syncing Super Idol (热爱105°C的你) with a backdrop of Chongqing’s stunning skyline. In what feels like a fever dream, Tian Yiming, the creator behind the famous song cover, enters the frame two seconds later. The epic crossover of internet celebrities from opposite sides of the globe goes viral in China and mildly confuses his Western viewers.

I get absorbed by the aftermath of clips from Speed’s stream. A never ending forest of massive, hypermodern skyscrapers, dotted with spotless architectural landmarks. Superhighways converge with elevated rail overpasses designed for an operating speed of 350 km/h. BYD’s Yangwang U9, a \$250k electric supercar packed with lavish features like individual wheel drive or a capability to perform brief vertical jumps. The night sky is broken up with DJI drones sparkling with colorful LEDs. Speed yells in excitement, “Zoom out, show the whole city! Chat, this is cyber city, this is China!” as his producers switch the stream to one of the orbiting drone cameras.

In platform-driven exquisite poverty mindset, these lavish, luxury commodities and cyberpunk aesthetics are extremely appealing to Speed’s younger audience. Resembling an open world of the popular game *Cyberpunk 2077*, Chinese cities are superlative impressions of their ‘futuristic city’ mental image. Deeply rooted within Western culture, Techno-Orientalist connotations certainly enhance this perversion.

Speed is not a propagandist, his team just purely optimizes for engagement affect and virality. A curated vibe-package of innovation and information technology through cultural iteration. How Speed presents Chinese cultures is a *simulacrum*.<sup>14</sup> How exactly is trying out a human-carrier drone in Shenzhen *Chinese culture*, or rather “*real China*”? This image of China as represented by technological fetish objects, bears questionable resemblance to culture in a typical sense — arts, social behavior or collective achievement. Speed’s itinerary mimics one of a diplomat, invited to marvel over carefully selected, cutting-edge markers of innovation. First-tier cities epitomize hypermodernity, the BYD flagship EV sportscar is a fetish object of luxury, the bullet trains are fetish objects of precision.

The hyperrealist lens of Speed’s content appeals to the viewer’s sensory system, following algorithmically-defined desires. By virtue of their affect-optimized format and the overarching backdrop of U.S. political scenery, his streams effectively arise as digital diplomacy. The format of IRL streaming captures audiences with authenticity other forms of content lack. His tour is centered around activities which align with the semiotic language of earlier discussed signifiers, shaping a sort of semiocapitalist foreign policy.<sup>15</sup> The Chinese

14 Jean Baudrillard, *Simulacra and Simulation* (Ann Arbor: The University of Michigan Press, 1994).

15 Franco “Bifo” Berardi, *Precarious Rhapsody: Semiocapitalism and the Pathologies of Post-Alpha*

century is a century of semiocapitalism, the country's image is being commodified in real time. China's network image reduces "5000 years of culture" into a set of over-iterated representations. China is LED skyscrapers, China is fast electric cars and human-sized drones, China is dancing robots. Where did the real China go? These semiotic labels distill the most recent and engagement-optimized elements of modern China, abandoning pre-internet culture in the quest for maximum affect.



*On the right: meme portraying IShowSpeed as a khan of the Mongol Empire*

An official account of the Chinese embassy in the U.S. tweeted "The 20-year-old popular American YouTuber IShowSpeed has kicked off a journey in China that has already garnered massive global attention, which indicates a broader trend of digital influencers bridging cultural gaps and creating alternative channels for foreign audiences to understand a vibrant China."<sup>16</sup>

Through soft weaponization of parasociality, Speed's presence works as an ideological counterbalance to anti-China narratives. Abandoning rhetoric in favor of affective presence, the content becomes "depoliticized" and seamlessly absorbed into platform capitalism. Unintentionally, Speed might just have pioneered statecraft through livestream. A total of eight streams, although not funded by any state actors, might go down in history as one of the greatest, most unexpected new media psyops. A random streamer born in 2005 went on luxury vacation and crumbled a multi-million dollar American propaganda operation in the process. The State Department's fear mongering simply did not pass the vibe check.

The parasociality of Speed's streams becomes a state-compatible aesthetic. He doesn't need to lie, because his curated, experience-driven perspective is already doing the work.

*Generation* (London: Minor Compositions, 2009).

16 Chinese Embassy in US on x.com, March 26, 2025.

Content creators used to visit China to perpetuate fear-mongering rhetoric or be racist for views, capitalizing on American propaganda campaigns. Speed was by no means the first one to break this pattern, but most certainly the most influential. Not only is his audience mostly composed of young impressionable teens, but he's one of the biggest streamers in the world. His support and position on Palestine without a doubt played a role in countering Zionist narratives from alt-right groypers like Asmongold. Expectedly, his visit to China has the potential to cement the already rapid sinicization of Gen Alpha and beyond.

## China Runs Without an RTX4090

Cyberpunk aesthetics avoid the utopian tendencies of earlier fiction. A sense of nihilism and hopelessness encompass neon city landscapes, urban jungles full of depressed laborers. Corrupt governments and abusive megacorporations loom over the masses trying to navigate their strict, highly-automated systems of control. In contrast, Silicon Valley entrepreneurs massage their raytraced images of solarpunk utopias packed with symbiotic urban architecture where trees grow on buildings. A spotless self-driving pod takes you to work while your AI assistant plans a post-work dinner with your smiling, diverse group of colleagues. The Chinese Century does a 180 and drops you off at *Night City*.

Millennials submit to those tech bro fantasies, Zoomers already gave up and Gen Alpha never cared in the first place. Exhausted and disillusioned by decades of neoliberal ideology promising personal freedom, choice, and empowerment, Western youth lives through the system's failure to deliver meaningful agency. Described by Byung-Chul Han as *freedom fatigue*, the mythical "freedom" has become an obligation to self-optimize.<sup>17</sup> A burden to choose between endless options, while constrained by the invisible infrastructures of debt, platforms and biases. Neoliberal "freedom" has made the vision of a more coherent and stable, but more authoritarian future appealing. In conjunction with instrumentalized aesthetics of China, youth has earned a tendency to gravitate toward authoritarianism.

This attractive force of Chinese hyperreality shares countless similarities with young men's turn to the alt-right.<sup>18</sup> Fueled by a sense of displacement and alienation, young men struggle to find meaning, community and identity. Similarly, disillusioned youth, living in the increasingly fascist West often fails to find meaning and prospects for the future. Both groups are craving a sense of being a part of some bigger, more powerful entity. Reactionary circles satisfy this need by means of redpilled guilds and grievance-driven culture wars. The *Sinopill* constructs a pseudo-parasocial connection to a hypermodern society, a technological civilization state. In *Kill All Normies*,<sup>19</sup> Angela Nagle describes how

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17 Byung-Chul Han, *Psychopolitics: Neoliberalism and New Technologies of Power* (London/Brooklyn: Verso, 2017).

18 Luke Munn, "Alt-Right Pipeline: Individual Journeys to Extremism Online," *First Monday* 24, no. 6 (June 1, 2019), <https://doi.org/10.5210/fm.v24i6.10108>.

19 Angela Nagle, *Kill All Normies: The Online Culture Wars from Tumblr and 4chan to the Alt-Right and*

the alt-right emerged not from traditional conservative spaces, but from weird, chaotic corners of the internet. Fueled by LARP and edgy memes, the Sinopill surfaced from scattered online content — and just like the alt-right — got accelerated by a chain of global events. Related not only anthropologically and aesthetically, but also aspirationally, both phenomena position themselves against an antagonistic hegemony. One side claiming to resist “woke capital,” feminism and globalism, and the other, American hegemonic power.

hello, i am refugee from american  
century of humiliation. where can i get  
an iced americano around these  
parts?

你好，我是美国百年屈辱的难民。我在  
哪里可以买到冰美式咖啡？

Nǐ hǎo, wǒ shì měiguó bǎinián qǔrǔ de nànmín. Wǒ zài  
nǎlǐ kěyǐ mǎi dào bīng měishì kāfēi?

## Borrowed Futures — Red Hauntology

Having defined a relevant political framework, linking algorithmic reprogramming of aesthetics into worldview, digital sinicization has gained a psychoanalytical backbone. Aesthetic parallels with the manosphere hint towards a subconscious shift resulting from aesopian cultural iteration. Optimized visual logics, habitual consumption, algorithmic affect regimes. The case study of Speed’s tour emphasises the semiotic nature of XXI-century Chinese capitalism. Broadcasting the aura of China as a hypermodern civilization state excites the culturally-programmed desires for technological acceleration. Cyberpunk nightscapes and high-tech optimizations of daily life appeal to the warped mental image of futurism, unfazed by traits of authoritarian surveillance-states.

Perpetuated promises of Western capitalist freedoms eroded dreams of prosperous futures. Red Capitalism breaks away from the religious trust in the invisible hand of the free market. Instead of blindly relying on made-up mechanics of supply and demand, China involves the very-much-visible hand of the party. It’s still capitalism, the CCP just sets the research agenda. The end goal of capitalism is always profit, but Red Capitalism breaks that officially sanctioned fact. Building on the remnants of Maoism, contemporary China is defined by principles from times of economic reform in ‘79. Xi Jinping Thought driving modern policy is purely a reiteration of earlier socialism with Chinese characteristics. These last remnants of socialism redefine the ultimate goal of ‘their’ capitalism as common prosperity, building a "prosperous, democratic, civilized, harmonious, and beautiful socialist modern country."



Western capitalism suffers from a lack of collective objectives, replacing them with tech bro utopias or reactionary fantasies. The lack of shared futures suffers from endless recycled creations, proven to generate profit. What Jameson applies to culture in *Postmodernism*, or, *The Cultural Logic of Late Capitalism*,<sup>20</sup> can be applied to collective objectives in general. Contrast that with Chinese-style planned economy focused on 'pushing humanity forward,' and the dichotomy becomes clear.

Lacking futures of their own, Western youth clings to China not just as a country, but a *borrowed future*.<sup>21</sup> On the sinking ship of neoliberalism, young Westerners yearn for something that looks like progress, order — and most importantly — *future*. China, through its portrayal on social media, offers a simulation of that futurity. 'Simulation' is a key word here. I seriously doubt most Sinopilled zoomers would actually consider living there. China's image as a country, gets overridden by *Net-Real China*, its idealized network image. Their image of China is purely an idealized fantasy, a fantasy which they're scared of shattering with reality. In *Ghosts of My Life*,<sup>22</sup> Fisher describes exactly that through hauntology — we're consuming a fantasy of futurity, not reality. Western futures we've been longing for are suspended in time, slowly cancelled by realities of neoliberalism. Haunted by lost futures, we become mesmerised by foreign futures.

In a crisis of viable futures, the psyche will cling to anything that looks like one. When the West represents the collapse of futures, Net-Real China appears as the Other. In Lacanian terms, China becomes the 'subject-supposed-to-know,' the fantasy of a coherent Big Other who has not yet lost the plot.<sup>23</sup> Net-Real China doesn't resolve the subject's lack,<sup>24</sup> but it simulates its resolution through image delivery. Each piece of China-posting content offers a temporary fantasy. This aesthetic imaginary functions as the object-cause of desire in a new, post-liberal libidinal economy.

The hyperreal spirit of Sinofuturism<sup>25</sup> excites our idea of human progress in a play of transnational digital edging. Some elements are more real than others. Silicon Valley's empty promises of pseudo-emancipatory technologies get picked up by the yes-men of Shenzhen. I like to bring up an example of Shanghai metro cars, a humble epitome of China's dedication to technological empowerment:

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20 Fredric Jameson, *Postmodernism, Or, the Cultural Logic of Late Capitalism* (Durham: Duke University Press, 1991).

21 Mark Fisher, *Ghosts of My Life: Writings on Depression, Hauntology and Lost Futures* (Zero Books, 2014).

22 Fisher, *Ghosts of My Life*.

23 Jacques Lacan, *The Seminar of Jacques Lacan. Book 11, Four Fundamental Concepts of Psychoanalysis* (New York: Norton, 1998).

24 Jacques Lacan, *Transference* (Cambridge/Malden: Polity Press, 2017).

25 Lawrence Lek. *Sinofuturism*, <https://sinofuturism.com/>.



When taking some metro lines in Shanghai, you can choose between a warmer or colder compartment from the platform, even before entering the train. This hyperoptimization of comfort is completely unnecessary. Nobody asked for it, nobody would notice if it wasn't there, nobody would seriously miss it if it went away. Shanghai's metro is already one of the best in the world. Shiny, surgically-clean stations the size of airports, providing eye-candy at every step in form of flowing architectural forms and interactive illuminations. The visionaries behind the city's transit infrastructure have truly made it to the top. The stations are clean, efficient and equipped with (controversial) facial recognition gates for even more automated convenience. In line with Beijing's rush of technological innovation, somebody sat down and thought: is there anything which could possibly improve this state-of-the-art experience? After pitching their idea, a board of engineers and policy makers worked hard to fund and implement this convenience-feature. Anywhere else in the world, this idea would have died in the boardroom at the first "but how will this make us turn a higher profit?"

China is not afraid of change. Sculpted by the slogans of the economic reform period, people have been conditioned to accept change. Coming with an unfortunate side effect of bulldozing ancient landmarks standing in the way of economic plans, China changes, and changes rapidly. The neoliberal rollercoaster on the other hand is not rational change, it's chaos. What Western youth is yearning for is economic competence and hyper-coordination, seeking emotional relief and stability.

We no longer believe to be living in "the most prosperous part of the world." Wronged by state narratives, we feel resentment and grief. Unable to escape the paralysis of capitalist realism, we fight back in symbolic ways. Briefly mentioned while describing the Xiaohongshu saga in my previous article,<sup>26</sup> young Americans have weaponized their usage of social media. The cyberspace uprising after the proposed TikTok ban was not only a protest directed at the performative ruling, but a way of showing frustration with state propaganda. Pretending to mail their data to the CCP, hopecore edits, 'sharing [data] is caring,' or advocating to download as many Chinese apps as possible.

America's theatrical attempts at defending its network sovereignty fostered a memetic insurgency. Youth on TikTok and Xiaohongshu broke up the cultural hegemony of American tech and the Department of Homeland Security lost the fight for their cognitive territory. The balkanization of the internet<sup>27</sup> created sovereign content spheres. Instead of being tied to a nation state's demographic, their size and influence are network representations of a state's cultural influence. The American sphere encompasses the entire Western world,

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26 Aleksy Domke, "Weaponized Data Sharing and Gen Xi – Notes on China II," *Networkcultures.org*, March 16, 2025, <https://networkcultures.org/blog/2025/03/16/weaponized-data-sharing-and-gen-xi-notes-on-china-ii/>.

27 Internet balkanization, cyber-balkanization or splinternet is the breaking of one global internet into several smaller and fragmented pieces due to content filtering and censorship. Internet balkanization creates separate content spheres, e.g. Chinese internet or Russian internet.

while the Chinese one barely broke through territorial boundaries. What happened is a platform betrayal against the Western internet sphere, signaling towards a newly gained consciousness.

Everyone should use a VPN, and everyone in the West also needs a *cultural VPN*. A semiotic proxy to escape your immediate ideological (media) environment and re-route your worldview through a foreign server. A cultural VPN masks your geopolitical IP, bypassing contextual firewalls and liberating cognitive traffic. Chinese netizens constantly climb the steep side of the Great Firewall, we never even entertain taking the stairs on the other side. TikTok's migration over to Xiaohongshu breaks this pattern in a unique example of weaponized content in a fight for a future beyond the LAN. Aligning with a foreign adversary to puncture the domestic content bubble in protest of homogenous local traffic.



## Hope with Chinese Characteristics

As the West descends deeper into corpopascism, China lives the life promised to you by the neoliberal dream. China is living through the transition from industrial to post-industrial, frequently romanticized in e.g. Japan's history. Flourishing economy uplifting the working class, scientific and technological innovation, and most importantly, endless access to *cheap treats*. Omnipresent low-cost goods, palettes of brands and superficial commodities acted as a distraction from deteriorating material conditions. As affordable consumerism withers away, neoliberal reality sets in. We shipped our future to the treat supplier. China is effectively sitting in the server room of global capitalism with kernel access. The dream of the East becomes a mirror of everything the West promised but couldn't fully deliver.

Absorbed in the chaos of neoliberal collapse, we ache for any semblance of a prosperous future. Venture capital kidnapped utopia. Lost futures scarred us with generational wounds, incapable of being healed with conventional medicine. Net-Real China acts as an alternative treatment for the neoliberal tumor. Falling under traditional Chinese medicine, *moxibustion* entails the burning of mugwort leaves on a patient's skin, redirecting the body's attention through signaling. Analogously, hyperreal visions of China redirect one's longing for domestic futures via aesthetic signaling.

Stranded by the deserted ideological landscape of algorithmic governance, we desperately cling onto outdated visions or set for compromises. Exhausted by positive psychologies of capitalist "freedoms," we accept the unconcealed governance of one party rule. "If you ask ordinary people *do you want to be free?*, their answer usually would have been yes. But if you look at it closely, you will see that the majority of people, me included, wouldn't really like to make radical choices all the time. What they want is to maintain the appearance of freedom, but discreetly they want to be told what choice to make."<sup>28</sup> What Žižek spits out here aligns with Han's view on Western freedom.<sup>29</sup> Instead of posing as a compromise, the lack of democratic process has the potential to subconsciously further accelerate this transnational nostalgia for Net-Real China.

Transgressive affection of Western youth towards China functions as dark catharsis. Akin to the ecstatic romanticization of Luigi Mangione following his alleged assault on United Healthcare CEO's life, a celebration of a foreign adversary reveals itself as a perverse libration in the eye of the neoliberal status quo. China is the West's Luigi, admittedly, just as prone to idealization. While Americans celebrate a small win against oligarchy, China kidnaps its overly greedy business owners.<sup>30</sup> Inversely, in America, the state trembles in fear of the capital.

Where everything else degrades, China progresses. In the liminal shell of Western exceptionalism, the *Chinese Dream* shimmers through the dark with individually-addressable LEDs. Exercising its healing properties over fiberoptic veins, Net-Real China is an opium for the neoliberal crisis of futures. Now I'll be booking my flights to Shanghai to address the extraterritorial placebo.

## Postscript: A Note on Freedom

Chinese society's submission to the state is not unique, but rather a larger trend in much of Asia. With a soft exception of American-influenced Korea, Confucian principles in the Sinosphere foster a trust relationship between the populace and government. Paraphrasing

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28 Slavoj Žižek, *How to become free*, n.d.

29 Han, *Psychopolitics*.

30 Jack Ma, a former chairman of Alibaba, was briefly disappeared after criticizing China's regulators during a speech at the annual People's Bank of China financial markets forum.

Žižek, Western democracies give an illusion of freedom, with little to no policy being influenced by public opinion. Lost in the rhetorical sandbox of free speech (increasingly challenged by technocapital), the West is convinced of its governance model's superiority. China, as an undoubtedly authoritarian state, when analyzed through the lens of everyday needs, community emancipation or interest of the people, wins over Western democracies. When freedom of speech is undermined by quiet deals with platform giants, the open censorship of Beijing becomes a controversial alternative in the sad spectacle of Western kleptocracy. In America, the party changes, the policy stays static — in China, the party stays in power, the policy undergoes radical transformations. While an overarching set of vague values looms in the background, the intricate data-driven decision process evolves rapidly in close pursuit of material needs.

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# REFLECTIONS ON TRIGGER WARNINGS: A PRACTICE OF CARE, REFUSAL OF WITNESSING

CHLOË ARKENBOUT

Originally published on July 11th, 2024

*Trigger warning: various topics that trigger warnings are often used for are briefly discussed in this article, such as (in order of appearance) car crashes, trauma, PTSD, misogyny, war, the genocide of Palestinian people and burnout.*

“Survival is the ability to swim in strange water.” — Ocean Vuong

Public discussions addressing injustice, filled with footage of horrendous violence and emotionally charged and often personal content of various types of harm and abuse, are common on many social media platforms. Sharing is an important way to foster awareness, solidarity, and understanding. Yet for some people who have experienced similar things being pointed out, seeing this content can evoke strong responses. If you know what that feels like, you probably also have had moments of wishing you were given a heads-up, so you could have decided for yourself whether and when to engage with what appeared on your feed, depending on your emotional capacity. I know I have.

Wikipedia defines a trigger warning as “a warning that a work contains writing, images, or concepts that may be distressing to some people.” On social media platforms, some users mention a trigger with their content so users can stop engaging with it if they wish.

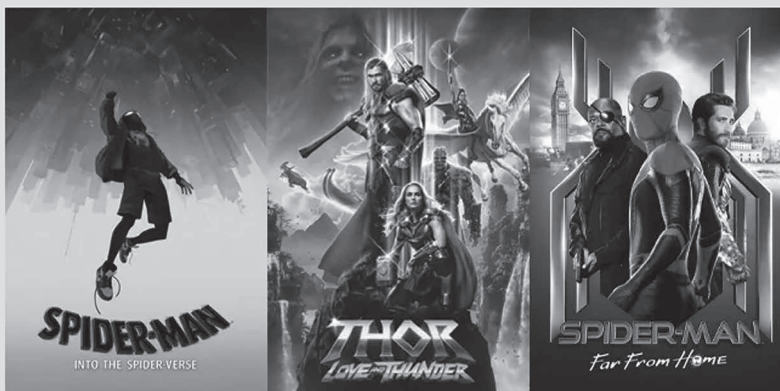
Discussions on whether to include them in course material in educational contexts have been going on for years and the trigger warning has a history that originated long before the web. The thing you’d probably think of first is the parental advisory system for TV shows and films, which are used to warn parents of content that they might deem inappropriate for their children. A more recent example along these lines is DoesTheDogDie, a community-based website with a repository of films and their potential triggers. Founder John Whipple writes that in 2023 “the site currently tracks over 180 categories of “triggers” [and] the number of requests for new trigger categories has swelled to 2,413.”<sup>1</sup> According to him, “the data makes it obvious that there is an unmet need for very specific content warnings for all forms of entertainment. [...] The reality is that terrible things happen to us all and we do our best to live one day at a

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1 John Whipple. “I Spoil Movies and I’m Proud of It.” DoesTheDogDie, [www.doesthedogdie.com/blog/i-spoil-movies-and-im-proud-of-it](http://www.doesthedogdie.com/blog/i-spoil-movies-and-im-proud-of-it).

time. Users of DoesTheDogDie are just trying to stay sane. In fact, [Wipple has] been contacted by several mental health professionals saying that they routinely recommend DoesTheDogDie as a resource to their clients.”

It's movie night at your friend's house and the theme is superheroes. Your friend recently lost a loved one in a car accident. Which movie should you watch?



In the introduction to *Trigger Warnings: History, Theory, Context*, which was published in 2017, Emily J. M. Knox mentions a paper by Chris Peterson that explains three different dimensions that often occur when people discuss trigger warnings.<sup>2</sup> They are either seen as a way to protect people who have PTSD, a tool to inform yourself about a specific work and an acknowledgment of existing differences in experiences of social power, or as the opposite of exposure therapy, a form of censorship, and the hindrance of something uncomfortable that is needed to be an educated person. These are similar to the arguments Wendy Wyatt presents in *The Ethics of the Trigger Warning* in 2016.<sup>3</sup> I am not particularly interested in the ‘is the fear of being offensive killing free speech’ debates that seem to drag on even now, almost 10 years later, or looking at this from such a binary perspective.<sup>4</sup> What I would like to do, is share some thoughts on trigger warnings by reflecting on what it means to care about others and to take care of yourself in a time where crisis follows crisis, follows crisis, follows crisis, while we all seem to be stuck on the (social media) platform(s).

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- 2 Emily J. M. Knox (ed) *Trigger Warnings: History, Theory, Context*. Rowman & Littlefield Publishers, 2017.
  - 3 Wendy Wyatt. “The Ethics of the Trigger Warning.” *Journal of Academic Ethics* 13, no. 1 (March 2015): 63-78.
  - 4 Mick Hume. *Trigger Warning: Is the Fear of Being Offensive Killing Free Speech?*. Harper Collins, 2015

## (Trigger) (Warnings)

As always, it is important to look at the words we use to describe a phenomenon to see what political dimensions are ingrained in them.

**Trigger (noun):** 1) to cause a strong emotional reaction of fear, shock, anger, or worry in someone, especially because they are made to remember something bad that has happened in the past 2) to cause something to start 3) a part of a gun that causes the gun to fire when pressed

So a trigger could be a catalyst of an emotional reaction related to something that happened in the past, with a connotation of violence (the gun). Or that something violent that has happened in the past is activated by something in the present, causing distress.

**Warning (noun):** something that makes you understand there is a possible danger or problem, especially one in the future

To warn someone of something indicates that something negative can still be averted. Assuming that the warner warns because they do not want something bad to happen to the person they are warning, this indicates that they care about the person being warned.

Before we dive into the politics of the trigger warning, we need to understand the politics of trauma first. The dictionary definition is as follows:

**Trauma (noun):** severe and lasting emotional shock and pain caused by an extremely upsetting experience, or a case of such shock happening

I could attempt to write an elaborate essay on the medical conditions related to trauma here as well, however, I am not a medical expert and for sharing my thoughts on trigger warnings, how Staci K. Haines defines trauma in *The Politics of Trauma* is the most relevant:

Trauma is an experience, series of experiences, and/or impacts from social conditions, that break or betray our inherent need for safety, belonging, and dignity. They are experiences that result in us having to vie between our inherent needs, often setting one against the other. For example, it might leave us with the impact of “I can be safe but not connected (isolated),” or “I have to give up my dignity to be safe or connected.” This is untenable, because all of these needs are constitutive or inherent in us.<sup>5</sup>

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5 Staci K. Haines. *The Politics of Trauma: Somatics, Healing, and Social Justice*. North Atlantic Books, 2019.

She explains that when we are not successfully protected during traumatic events, those experiences are stored within ourselves, and therefore keep shaping our present experience in the world. Sometimes this results into people developing PTSD symptoms. Again, this is a wildly specific definition and only one interpretation of what trauma is. I can highly recommend reading more about the topic from different angles to gain a deeper understanding (in Haines' book, or *My Grandmother's Hands* by Resmaa Menakem, *What my Bones Know* by Stephanie Foo, *It Didn't Start With You* by Mark Wolynn, *Trauma and Recovery* by Judith L. Herman, *Touch Me I'm Sick* by Margeaux Feldman, pretty much every book by Gabor Maté, and *The Body Keeps the Score* by Bessel van der Kolk, for example - even though some of these also deserve criticism and should be read with some caution). Of course, I would also recommend seeking out help, if you are able to, if you suspect you might be suffering from trauma. It is important to note that trauma is not just something that randomly happens to people on an individual scale, though. Trauma is not 'bad luck'. It also stretches way beyond the image you might have of veterans dealing with nightmares and outbursts of violence. Trauma is highly political and happens in the context of oppressive systems, which is why it is so important to talk about this. Especially in our current times, where genocides can be live-streamed on our smartphones every second of every day. Haines explains this process as follows:

Systemic trauma is the repeated, ongoing violation, exploitation, dismissal of, and /or deprivation of groups of people. State institutions, economic systems, and social norms that systematically deny people access to safety, mobility, resources, food, education, dignity, positive reflections of themselves, and belonging have a traumatic impact on individuals and groups. [...] This lack of safety, belonging, and dignity traumatically impacts individuals and whole groups of people. [...] Like individual trauma, systemic trauma overwhelms and breaks down safety, connection, and dignity in the minds, bodies, and spirits of individuals and communities.

Looking specifically at what a **trauma trigger** is then, to return to the original subject, Wikipedia defines it as follows:

"A trauma trigger is a psychological stimulus that prompts involuntary recall of a previous traumatic experience."

Trauma triggers could be anything, from a smell, a place, or a word to something highly specific, as it is context-dependent. Experiencing a trauma trigger is definitely something other than experiencing some discomfort or being upset, as the effects can be both emotionally and physically destabilizing. Those who know know.

With this lens, to warn someone of a possible trauma trigger, seems like a simple act of care. Some might even argue that it is a moral duty to do so. And even if people are too indifferent to care, let's be honest, at least in theory, it is not that much to ask. However, things become more complicated when looking into what is happening through informal language.



This is an edited summary of some of the definitions found on the Urban Dictionary:

**Triggered (adjective):** being unreasonably upset, pissed off, annoyed or offended in a cringe way — often when social justice warriors or special snowflakes can't take a joke \*

*"Lol this 'feminazi' is sooo triggered cus I told her to make me a sandwich!! Lol."*

The discussions around triggers are blurred by default because of the language that concerns it is too. Being offended is not the same thing as being triggered, but in today's language, they seem to have become interchangeable. What would you call a process where the word to describe your experience is now used against you, leaving you alienated and confused, perhaps even doubting your own experience? Conceptual gaslighting? I would like to make a humble attempt to free the trigger warning from these linguistic discussions, of what is politically correct or what should or should not be (freed from being) tone policed, and go back to the essence of what it means to witness something (online) in the context of trauma.

## Refusing Witnessing

Let's discuss the moral implications when witnessing images of violence, war and suffering, or *'the Pain of Others'* as Susan Sontag calls it in her famous essay.<sup>6</sup> Sontag writes that "no 'we' should be taken for granted when the subject is looking at other people's pain". But that 'we' becomes even more blurry when we're talking about the pain of others that is directly related to those witnessing something that relates to their own pain. Sontag states that "an ample reservoir of stoicism is needed [...] given the likelihood of seeing photographs that could make you cry [every morning]." She writes about newspapers here, so one can only conclude this is true for social media in quadruple. And what if those pictures could do more damage than to make you cry?

The original debate about witnessing the pain of others comes down to the following. Sontag writes that for a long time, some people believed that if the horror could be made vivid enough, most people would finally take in the outrageousness and the insanity of war. I know multiple activists who make the conscious choice not to use trigger warnings when they share footage of the genocide in Palestine. Should those who live in the West, especially those who have never come close to war, have the privilege to be warned? They believe these horrors beyond comprehension should be witnessed and we should not look away. Sharing footage of what is happening means that they care about what happens in the world. Sharing footage means that they are affected by those who are affected by this systematic trauma that is unfolding because they care about other people. And they want other people to care too.

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6 Susan Sontag. *Regarding the Pain of Others*. Farrar, Straus and Giroux, 2003.

However, some people care so much and engage with this type of content so often, that instead of informing themselves and bringing them to take action, they start to suffer from it. When activists burn out, they cannot contribute to the cause. What if you need EMDR therapy, a type of therapy used to treat trauma, because you engaged with too much footage of Gaza, while editing it for it to be able to be spread around and witnessed? Could the witnessing of other people's trauma cause trauma to the witness themselves? These are not new questions, of course, as they were already raised when war footage was being shared in newspapers decades ago. But in the age of social media, it is worth to keep asking these questions. Especially in the context of trigger warnings, where I'm not trying to raise a discussion about what type of content should or should not be shared, but who should be protected from it, and why and when. Who deserves protection from witnessing horrors and who does not? When is it functional to witness the pain of others and when does it defeat its purpose? When is it your moral duty and when is it wise to protect yourself from it? When should you refuse to witness and who has the moral grounds to do so?

Sontag also raised the question of whether or not an image retains the capacity to produce a strong emotion sidesteps the problem that having a strong emotion is not the same thing as having an understanding, and neither is the same as taking action. Maggie Nelson, in *On Cruelty*, writes about how the compulsion to repeat trauma in art can give someone a sense of control over it.<sup>7</sup> Perhaps this is true for sharing triggering content as well — engaging with it feels better than ignoring it and could perhaps even be healing. But what does that mean in an age where there is so little opportunity for slow looking, reflection, and contemplation, as Nelson states? Have we arrived at a point where we don't even blink an eye anymore when we see children getting bombed during our doom scroll in between skincare routine influencer content and memes? Have users stopped witnessing and are they just watching now? Is the gap between desensitized users and users who are at risk of actual trauma triggers growing, causing alienation to grow too?

If it were a simple question of whether or not it is a good thing to protect someone from a potential trauma trigger by adding a trigger warning, there should not even be a discussion about it. What makes this an urgent matter to reflect on is the fact that this is all happening in the platformed society we currently live in.

## Triggered by Design: the Case of the Shadowban

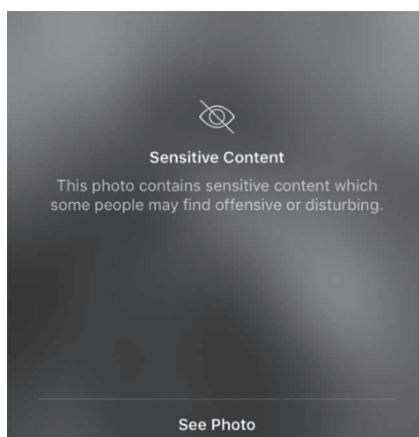
The infrastructure of the platforms on which these trigger warnings function, specifically the big tech social media platforms, plays a significant role in the dynamics surrounding these topics. On the one hand, one could argue that social media platforms are designed to be triggering; to make users feel 'triggered' and then make other users feel triggered because they are triggered, and so on. They are definitely not designed to protect those who might

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7 Maggie Nelson. *The Art of Cruelty: A Reckoning*. W. W. Norton & Company, 2011.

experience actual trauma triggers in this process. The more engagement content gets, the more time users spend on their platform, the more data they can sell, after all.

On the other hand, we need to talk about freedom of speech and censorship – but not in the way you think. I promised you I was not going to talk about the ‘you can’t say anything anymore’ thing right? Sontag writes that when talking about the pain of others we witness, it is just as important to consider what is NOT being shown. Because while some people require protection from witnessing certain content, others should be confronted with it. In this context I want to discuss content moderation protocols in social platforms that flag certain content and give it a trigger warning. The ‘sensitive content’ label in Instagram for example, where content is hidden and you have to click on a button first before the content is revealed.



Instagram frequently shadowbans content (making it less visible to other users in various ways, of which adding a trigger warning is just one) on their platform, which they justify in their incredibly vague community guidelines. They say that they have “spent a lot of time thinking about the different points of view that create a safe and open environment for everyone. [...] Overstepping [the Community Guidelines] [...] may result in deleted content [or] other restrictions.” What safety means, who is worthy of safety, and who decides this, is not stated anywhere. The most important characteristic of shadowbanning is that the user is unaware of (the extent of and exact reasons for) it. As a user who wants to share important content that should be witnessed by others, how can you counter or object to this form of censorship if the platform’s entire design is built on the premise that you are not supposed to (really) notice it has happened (or why or how it is happening exactly)? The elusiveness of the ban is exactly the point. And we’re not even talking about content being deleted completely, which also happens. The effects of this are severe and make it the perfect tool to ideologically censor specific content without people noticing. For example, Human Rights Watch published a report in 2023 on the systemic global censorship of

Palestinian content, where shadowbanning is one of the 6 patterns of censorship they have identified, and states that Meta's behavior fails to meet its human rights due diligence responsibilities.<sup>8</sup>

Given the fact that both the guidelines and their consequences are completely non-transparent, counter-tactics on the platform can be nothing else than reactive. Use a watermelon emoji and post enough selfies to trick the algorithm until that doesn't work anymore and something new has to be tried. Always one step behind.

What should we do with all of this, then? Should we leave big tech social media platforms and move to/build our own alternatives? A platform that has a feature where potential triggers must be added before you are allowed to share content and where you are given the option to filter out content on your feed could be cool, leaving the autonomy of what is to be witnessed with its users instead of the platform. So why haven't we successfully done this? Because, unfortunately, it's not that simple. People don't want to leave their connections behind to move to some obscure platform that hardly anyone uses yet. Alternatives are often not accessible enough for non-geeks. And isn't it a privilege to even have the space to think about alternatives, as some people's lives still depend on their networks on big tech platforms? Hannah Proctor once said that it's important not to fall into an overly deterministic view of technology when discussing justice and that the real question should be what a more liberated future would look like.<sup>9</sup>

## To warn or not to warn, to avoid or not to avoid

However, we are not yet living in the future where big tech has been boycotted and we've built our own platforms that are designed based on values such as care and protection. So, until we have taken sufficient action to improve our circumstances, how do we navigate the present? In her introduction, Knox explains that she experiences some discomfort around trigger warnings, as they can be used as a tool for categorization, where objects are labeled either 'good' or 'bad'. I would like to argue that it's not as simple as that, or as binary. In her reflections, Nelson critically called it the "do-I-or-don't-I-want-to-watch-this question". Perhaps we need 'can/should-I-or-can't/shouldn't-I-watch-this-in-this-in-this-moment questions'. Plural. So I leave you without closing remarks, and instead propose these open questions for those engaging with trigger warnings and those who want to take care of others and themselves, in the hopes they contribute to our ability to navigate swimming in strange waters.

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8 Human Rights Watch. 2023. *Meta's Broken Promises: Systemic Censorship of Palestine Content on Instagram and Facebook*. December 21, 2023. <https://www.hrw.org/report/2023/12/21/metass-broken-promises/systemic-censorship-palestine-content-instagram-and>

9 Chloë Arkenbout. "Paranoia and Guilt: A Conversation with Hannah Proctor about the Emotions of Political Defeat and Digital Media." Institute of Network Cultures, March 26, 2025.

When you encounter a trigger warning:

- Am I inclined to avoid content related to the warning in question? Why?
- Is the warning specific enough to inform me properly?
- If it is not, am I comfortable taking the risk of encountering content that could trigger me?
- How strong could my reaction be when encountering the content?
- Do I have the capacity for such a reaction in case it happens? Do I know how to regulate myself? What I need in terms of care or co-regulation if it happens? Do I have people to support me?
- Does the content relate to my own experiences or does it consider others?
- Will the content inform me of current events or experiences of others that are important to be aware of?
- Have I been avoiding this topic or have I already engaged with it frequently?
- Could I be confusing distress or danger with discomfort? Have I considered my privilege?
- Could I be confusing discomfort with distress or danger? Have I considered my current mental state in relation to the content and should I consider protecting myself?
- If I decide not to engage with this content, do I want to do so at a later time?
- Is this warning human-made or automatically generated by the platform I am on?
- If it is automatically generated, what values does the platform operate on and what could that mean for this warning and my choice in engaging with its content or not?

When you consider using a trigger warning:

- Who is this trigger warning for? Who am I trying to protect and why?
- Is the way I worded my trigger specific enough for people to be properly informed about the possible risk?
- Should I make a distinction in my warning, addressing the people whom I am trying to protect by informing them of the risks and the people I do want to look at the content?
- Could the content I want to share be flagged by the platform's content moderation systems?
- Should I consider using alternative tactics to make sure the content I want to share reaches people?

*A thank you to my colleagues, comrades and friends who helped shape my thoughts on these topics: Geert Lovink, Pleun Westendorp, Niek Heijne, Liyah Park, Lucija Pelicaric, Frederieke van Wijk, Jamie Brands, Daryll Landbrug, Alexandra Greene, Laura Dubourjal, and Jamil Fiorino-Habib, among others.*

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# CREATIVE CLASS CONSCIOUSNESS: TODAY'S ART OF THE WORKING CLASS

SEPP ECKENHAUSSEN

*"I strive to look poor. I drive an 89 Volvo wagon. I live in a million dollar artist loft my daddy bought me for graduating art school. I hate my dad." - Hipster Barista meme*

There is a general confusion about class composition under post-neoliberal capitalism.<sup>1</sup> Where is the working class? There is also a more specific confusion about the class position of art workers. Are art workers, workers? While these questions might seem academic or even trivial, they have serious consequences for the organisation of labour and the representation of workers. Who and what are we? Who are our comrades, and who are our adversaries? How to break the wheel of disorganisation? How to collectivise and resist?

## The Author as Producer

In his groundbreaking book *History and Class Consciousness* from 1923, György Lukács for the first time foregrounded 'class consciousness' in Marxist theories of organisation.<sup>2</sup> Rather than describing the position of the working class as an enumeration of data (Klasse-an-sich), he explored whether there is a unified standpoint or a shared consciousness among members of the working class (Klasse-für-sich). Following in Lukács's footsteps, Walter Benjamin wrote his famous text on *The Author as Producer* in 1934, formulating a simple, sharp principle for class-conscious cultural work.<sup>3</sup> In short, he insists that it is the responsibility of an art worker to understand their position as a contemporary producer, and, given the social, historical, and technological circumstances, to carefully determine their medium and mode of production accordingly. For instance, Benjamin argued that novelists should abandon the traditional medium of the novel in favour of the faster, more accessible medium of the newspaper, which would better serve the goal of 'political progress'. One could argue that we face the same question today, except that the positive,

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- 1 With post-neoliberal capitalism, I mean the state of the world after the disintegration US hegemony, and the collapse of belief in 'rule of law', social justice and human rights, and global free trade. Some argue that we no longer live in capitalism (but, for instance, in technofeudalism), while others believe we are merely seeing a reconfiguration of capital in a multipolar world. In any case, the self-evident monopolar, 'there is no alternative'-state of the world which characterised neoliberalism after 1989 clearly no longer exists.
  - 2 György Lukács, *History and Class Consciousness: Studies in Marxist Dialectics*, London: Merlin Press, 1967 (1923).
  - 3 Benjamin subtitled the text 'Address at the Institute for the Study of Fascism, Paris, April 27, 1934', but it was certainly not delivered as a lecture at that time and in that place. It was most probably first published posthumously. The essay is available in full on the Marxist Internet Archive: <https://www.marxists.org/reference/archive/benjamin/1970/author-producer.html>.

universal goal of political progress is replaced by the more fragmented and bitter aim of resistance against political regression. What should authors produce in the cataclysmic mess of techno-feudalism?

However, translating the author as a producer-principle to the present-day context is not as simple as a cheeky, postmodern inversion. One of the core successes of neoliberalism has been to replace working-class consciousness with internalised micro-entrepreneurialism. In the book *Speculation as Mode of Production*, Marina Vishmidt has shown that this is especially true for artists who happily jump on the bandwagon of speculative capital and become some of capital's most tragic agents. There is, in other words, very little ground to adopt Benjamin's assumption that art workers have a (latent) class consciousness. Before asking "What does the author as a producer produce today?", we must first consider: How can the author today understand themselves as a producer once again?

## The Art Worker

In response to this question, people working in the arts – including myself – have taken to calling ourselves 'art workers'. Historically, this notion originated in the Constructivist and Productivist avant-gardes of the 1920s, the very same years in which Lukács conceptualised class consciousness. Its emergence was closely linked to social realist aesthetic positions during the Popular Front era, such as the Congress of Cultural Workers in Lviv, where artists and writers declared their solidarity with workers in the 1930s. Only much later, in 1969, it was taken up in the West by the New York-based Art Workers Coalition.

I believe that the most recent rediscovery of 'art worker' is related to the rise of social practice art. But it does not necessarily indicate a rediscovered class consciousness. For instance, how do we approach one's 'identification' as an art worker in the face of the fact that only 8% of artists in the UK today have a working-class background?<sup>4</sup> In the essay *In a Class of Our Own? Art Workers and the Working Class*, Mia van den Bos writes: the "problem with the term 'art worker' is that it gestures towards, whilst simultaneously revealing nothing about, class. [...] 'Art worker' elides different class positions behind the precarious reality of freelance art work, without recognising that a class-based selection process has already occurred before the first invoice is sent."<sup>5</sup> 'Art worker' could then be just another trendy buzzword used to improve the social status of artists, in this case, only

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- 4 Orian Brook, a.o. 'Social Mobility and "Openness" in Creative Occupations since the 1970s', *Sociology*, vol. 57, no. 4 (2022): pp. 789-810. The British Sociological Association, which publishes this journal, uses a positivist definition of 'working class', characterised by low levels of economic, social, and cultural capital, though it is not completely deprived.
  - 5 Mia van den Bos, 'In a Class of Our Own? Art Workers and the Working Class', *Fine Print*, February 2023, <https://www.fineprintmagazine.com/articles/31-in-a-class-of-our-own-art-workers-and-the-working-class>.

by performing affinity with the working class. As an aspirational fetish in the heads of self-identifying art workers, the notion 'working class' becomes partially or entirely divorced from material reality.

On the other hand, the words we use shape our understanding of art and its role in society. For instance, in the book *Art Work*, Katja Praznik argues that the use of the term 'art worker' inherently implies a socialist understanding of art as a commonly available public good, which is, by definition, opposed to the capitalist notion of the 'work of art' as an exclusive commodity.<sup>6</sup> Van den Bos, too, gives 'art worker' the benefit of the doubt, arguing that it can engender a sense of broader solidarity among precarious workers, and prompt conversations about how class "dictates who can and cannot afford to make, write about or curate art and therefore what kind of class interests and perspectives are furthered in the art world".<sup>7</sup> The question, in short, is not one of 'correct identification', but of revamping the historically productive analytical notion of class for the more complex reality of artistic production in post-neoliberal capitalism, which could, in turn, empower the organisation of art production in opposition to the class-based selection process before the first invoice.

We don't have to start these conversations from scratch. Many thinkers have theorised contemporary class composition and offered possible pathways to a new class consciousness that encompasses the strange and contradictory experience of life as an art worker. What follows is a leisurely stroll along some of these theories. Where we will meet precarians, projectarians, cyberbarians, cognitarians, and other members of emergent (dangerous?) classes along the way.

## Precariat

Since the 1980s, deregulation of labour markets, privatisation, increasing numbers of freelancers, and other trends in post-Fordist neoliberalism have structurally increased levels of precarity among workers in the West. Guy Standing, one of the most prominent thinkers on class composition today, has described the collective experience of decreased material and psychological welfare as that of the 'precariat'.<sup>8</sup> Quintessential to this precarian experience, as I see it, is a twofold extension of work: 'sideways', the separation of work and leisure diffused by intermittent employment and continuously being 'on call'; and 'frontal', work that is extended indefinitely in the absence of sick leave insurance and pension schemes. Without job security, the work never ends.

If one were to make a list of precarian occupations, 'artist' would certainly feature on it. The Netherlands, where I live and work, is known for its attractive funding system and relatively good social provisions. But the average artist in the Netherlands earned a gross

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6 Katja Praznik, *Art Work: Invisible Labour and the Legacy of Socialist Yugoslav Socialism* (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 2021).

7 Van den Bos, 'In a Class of Our Own?', 2023.

8 Guy Standing, *The Precariat: The New Dangerous Class* (London: Bloomsbury, 2011).



income of just over 18 thousand euros in 2019 (compared to the average income of 32 thousand among the working population), with 80% of people in the visual arts working as freelancers.<sup>9</sup> In 2017, a government-commissioned independent review concluded that art workers have poor bargaining positions, are often not insured against occupational disability, have low pension accruals, and have a high risk of unemployment.<sup>10</sup> So, even in a country with relatively high levels of cultural funding and general social safety, many art workers can simply not afford to do their jobs. This is, of course, not a regulatory accident that governments intend to repair. Theoreticians like Isabell Lorey, Judith Butler, and Wendy Brown have shown that governance through precarisation is at the core of the neoliberal project.<sup>11</sup> With its consistently rising numbers of self-employed workers, art and culture have been the perfect testing ground for neoliberal labour market policies. Artists are, in other words, at the forefront of flexibilisation and precarisation, alongside delivery riders, taxi drivers, and other (mostly platform-mediated) gig workers. If art workers today can make any claim of avant-gardism, it must be their membership of platform capitalism's flex-work avant-garde.

A further important characteristic of the precariat, as Standing observes, is the high amount of invisible and mostly unremunerated labour performed. In the arts, we continuously rewrite our CVs and portfolios, update our websites, submit funding applications, practice, study, develop skills, and learn - all in our own time. Then, of course, there is the bulk of socially coded 'lifestyle' work which 'doesn't feel like work': going to exhibitions, openings and reading groups, having dinners with collectors, social media engagement, and generally taking care of our 'visibility' and 'relevance'. Again, art workers are not alone in this. Marxist feminists like Bojana Kunst, Leigh Claire La Berge, Katja Praznik, and Silvia Federici have argued that artists' experiences of invisible, underpaid labour mirror those of domestic workers and other precarious workers in society.

While it's hard to challenge the concept of precarity, or its proliferation, critics have contested Standing's idea of the precariat as the new dangerous class because they find the material divisions among people affected by precarisation too great. On the one hand, the precariat includes people working bullshit jobs (which David Graeber defines as jobs that are essentially irrelevant in the eyes of those who execute them).<sup>12</sup> However, on the other hand, the precariat would also include the group described as the professional-managerial class (or PMC for short). The PMC is a steadily growing group of highly educated

9 See: <https://www.ditzijnonzehelden.nl/nl>.

10 SER and RvC, 'Passie gewaardeerd: Versterking van de arbeidsmarkt in de culturele en creatieve sector', April 2017, <https://www.ser.nl/-/media/ser/downloads/adviezen/2017/passie-gewaardeerd.pdf>.

11 Isabell Lorey, *State of Insecurity: Government of the Precarious* (New York: Verso, 2015); Wendy Brown, *Undoing the Demos: Neoliberalism's Stealth Revolution* (Princeton: Princeton UP, 2017).

12 David Graeber, *Bullshit Jobs: A Theory* (New York: Simon & Schuster, 2019). The 'digital revolution' has obviously increased the volume of bullshit jobs, with its endless expansion of click work, content moderation, search engine optimisation, and so on.

urban desk workers who perform managerial or consulting tasks. While their work creates little to no use value, members of the PMC would not typically describe their own work as a bullshit job, and even if they don't have a steady contract, they are usually well-paid. It has therefore been argued that the precariat is socially too loose to ever become a dangerous class. The material interests of the members of the precariat, these critics say, simply don't align. This will be a recurring theme in all of the class composition theories we will encounter: the conceptualisation of new coalitions, alliances, and social groups inevitably has to account for material disparities, alongside a more cultural diversity, among the members of whatever new revolutionary subject is proposed.

## Cognitariat

A second theoretical tradition that deserves our attention is operaismo. Operaismo, or workerism, emerged in Italy in the 1960s and '70s as a coalition of factory workers and, to lesser extent, house workers, university students, artists, and intellectuals.<sup>13</sup> They rebelled against the exploitation of workers in the new factories of Fiat and other megacorporations, but also against the existing workers' unions and political parties. They did not demand better payments or decent housing, instead, they wanted *everything*: autonomy, communist liberation, and the total abolition of labour.<sup>14</sup> This foregrounding of an end to 'wage slavery' swayed many disillusioned workers to join the movement, but it also posed a difficulty in the application of classical Marxist doctrines. Because what is class struggle beyond work? Operaismo, it turned out, required an entirely new conception of class. Mario Tronti, one of operaismo's leading thinkers, formulated this challenge as follows: "The cultural hieroglyphs need deciphering: the scientific jargon must be translated into our own illustrious class vernacular."<sup>15</sup> This kind of translation is exactly what many thinkers in and after the operaist generation have attempted, resulting in many unique, provocative, and often hopeful theories of emergent class composition.

The theory I want to highlight here is that of the 'cognitariat'. The word cognitariat was coined in the late 2000s by Franco 'Bifo' Berardi in *The Soul at Work*.<sup>16</sup> In this book, Bifo stipulated that creatives and other workers in the 'knowledge economy' are the new production line workers, occupying their dedicated spot at a global, fully digital conveyor belt of 'semiocapitalism'. This equation of knowledge workers with production line workers is, deliberately, not immediately obvious. The high productivity of cognitarians stems from their freedom to feel unique, creative, and therefore motivated. They can pick their own

13 Jacopo Galimberti wrote a great book on the relation between operaismo and art, *Images of Class: Operaismo, Autonomia and the Visual Arts (1962-1988)* (New York: Verso, 2022).

14 Nanni Balestrini published a famous novel titled *We Want Everything* (1971), which tells the story of a worker from the South who becomes an agitator and strike leader during Italy's 'Hot Autumn' of 1969.

15 Mario Tronti, *Workers and Capital* (New York: Verso, 2019 (1970)), p. 283.

16 Franco 'Bifo' Berardi, *The Soul at Work: From Alienation to Autonomy* (Los Angeles: Semiotext(e), 2009).

laptops, freely compete for gigs, and work in their favorite coffee bar at hours of their own choosing. But, Bifo argues, the actual work these people do (customer journey design, project management, community building) is just as standardised as the factory work of their grandparents. In other words, the cognitarian is coerced into cultivating and performing exactly the right amount of instrumental creativity and uniqueness (no less, because that would reduce productivity, and no more, because that would make the worker ungovernable). This tendency of capital to appropriate the very part of us that we feel is most uniquely *ours* introduces an entirely new form of alienation. Cognitarians are not alienated from their bodies, as the factory conveyor belt worker described by Marx and Engels was, or from their consciousness, as theorised by Lukács, but an alienating split occurs in their very souls. Our creativity remains part of us, but it is estranged from us, because it is controlled by capital. Of course, new forms of alienation require new forms of resistance. It therefore follows that the struggle against capital's alienation today should prioritise taking back the productive forces of creativity, and the cultivation of an unalienated, radical imagination.

This matter is, by the way, not merely academic or hypothetical. Nor is it outdated. On the contrary, its urgency is a key concern in some of the most important political projects of the contemporary global Left. In 2025, Fernando Haddad, the finance minister in Lula's socialist government of Brazil, phrased the central political challenge of his Workers' Party as follows:

There is also another emerging force, namely the creative forces of capitalism. There is a vast literature of the contingent of people who sell their labour power, but their power is much more a creative force than a productive force. The Italians often call it the 'cognitariat'. [...] It is necessary to recognise that its emancipatory struggle today depends on the understanding that the non-propertied classes are not homogeneous. They have different perspectives. Even from the aesthetic point of view, from the cultural point of view. That is the role of politics: to forge a common goal between them, something that won't emerge mechanically from the economy and that will only emerge from the political activity of a party.<sup>17</sup>

Like Standing's theory of the precariat, Bifo foregrounds the role of precarity and precarisation as the dominant form of government of contemporary capitalism. Regulatory power over cognitarians is no longer enforced by clocking in and out of work, fixed low pay, recurring evaluations, bureaucratic workload, or mandatory team building outings. Instead, the cognitarian is subjected to a free market competition of all against all, the benchmarks of vibes and lifestyle, and the certainty that there is no safety net. In Bifo's view, this shift in mode of governance, alienation, and exploitation marks a decisive turning point in history. Precarity, he says outright, is an era. This position gives a whole new dimension to the idea

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17 Daniel Denvir, 'Brazil and the World System w/ Fernando Haddad', *The Dig*, 4 November 2025.

of artists as the flex-work avant-garde. If this is true, it must be possible to catch glimpses of another world through the cracks in political reality. Even if art is not here to save the world, the field remains early adopter of the flex work in which independently working people have experienced high levels of precarity for decades. This experience might have taught art workers some lessons that are of interest to other workers under neoliberal regimes, providing a basis for new, post-corporatist models of organising. Let us, then, zoom in on the specific conditions of art within the global, digitally mediated production chains of contemporary capitalism.

## Projectariat

The first thing to notice about work and class in the arts, is a persistent cognitive dissonance. Many artists somehow think that the market is not where their practice is, and their practice is not where the market is, despite the extreme proximity between the two. In his book *Why Are Artists Poor*, Hans Abbing has called this ambivalence the ‘Janus face’ of the art world.<sup>18</sup> When art and market meet, the clash between informal, precarious, low-paid, self-organised practice, and the big money and splendour seen in art fairs, blue-chip galleries, and auction houses often leads to cognitive dissonance. For instance, I’m reminded of an artist who told me that she was invited to a luxurious dinner with the patrons of an exhibition she took part in. She enjoyed the champagne and lobster, but afterwards returned to eating crackers for a week at home, unable to afford anything else. She was left with the feeling that the whole affair had been a mix-up, that she had been part of something she should not have been.

On closer inspection, the popular compartmentalisation of different ‘sides’ or even ‘art worlds’ does not hold up. In *Seven Days in the Art World*, Sarah Thornton described how the circuits of artist studios, art education, magazines, auctions, galleries, fairs, and prizes may follow their own protocols and habits but are in the end all interrelated and interdependent.<sup>19</sup> Gregory Sholette went several steps further and, in the book *Dark Matter*, showed how unsuccessful artists (he calls them ‘prefailed’) are the dark matter of the art world.<sup>20</sup> To identify successful artists worthy of astronomic investments, market players like gallerists, collectors, and advisors need to be able to discern the contrast with a much larger group of failed artists. Unsuccessful artists are therefore the dark matter, the invisible connective tissue churned out by art academies in large quantities, without whom the entire system would implode. Art workers, in short, are a fundamental part of a system they feel fundamentally disconnected from, and that structurally keeps them precarious.

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18 Hans Abbing, Hans, *Why Are Artists Poor? The Exceptional Economy of the Arts* (Amsterdam: Amsterdam University Press, 2008).

19 Sarah Thornton, *Seven Days in the Art World* (New York: W.W. Norton & Company, 2008).

20 Gregory Sholette, *Dark Matter: Art and Politics in the Age of Enterprise Culture* (New York: Pluto Press, 2010).

Rethinking class composition with these systemic traits of artistic labour in mind, Kuba Szreder coined the notion of 'the projectariat'.<sup>21</sup> The projectariat includes those artists, curators, academics, writers, assistants, and technicians who earn their livelihood moving between short-term contracts or commissions, the point being, of course, that this is the case for the vast majority of art professionals. Projectarians experience a contradictory privilege; often highly mobile, they are carried in the international circuits of contemporary art along with some of the wealthiest of the so-called '1%'. But their work is insecure. Typically, they are also laden with debt incurred to pay for the educational credentials required to access this mobile existence. Projectarians make up a 'poverty jetset', for whom the spectre of impoverishment looms as each project ends, making the project the dominant structuring factor in their life.<sup>22</sup>

Yet, it would be naïve to understand projectarians as mere victims. Underpayment of artistic labour is a societal norm, but by and large, it is reproduced *within* the art world, in a phenomenon that Hans Abbing called 'art ethos'.<sup>23</sup> According to this popular belief, one does not become an artist for financial gain but to fulfill one's destiny. Therefore, poverty is proof of the real deal. Conversely, the demand for payment of artistic labour is, by definition, a betrayal of art. How, then, are art workers supposed to survive? One of the entries in Szreder's book *ABC of the Projectariat* is the sharply ironic concept of 'Artyzol'. It combines the Polish term for artist (artysta) with a brand name for Communist-era insecticide spray, 'Muchozol'.<sup>24</sup> Artworld events generate clouds of artyzol, and the intoxicating fumes are typically supposed to sustain art workers in place of actual remuneration.<sup>25</sup> The smell of 'artyzol' evokes the grandeur of contemporary art but is also slightly toxic. It embodies the strange relationship between toxicity and intoxication that surrounds the international art world. Artists may not actively support the exploitative nature of the art market (and its hostile takeover of whatever is left of public art institutions), but they silently accept its terms of engagement, and probably enjoy being part of an exclusive social circle. In a review of Szreder's book, Kim Charnley summarised: "Contemporary art's heady extravaganza of free market values depends on banal exploitation. Actually, the projectariat produces the artyzol that perpetuates its own exploitation."<sup>26</sup>

21 Kuba Szreder, *ABC of the Projectariat: Living and Working in a Precarious Art World* (Manchester: Manchester University Press, 2021).

22 Andrew Berardini, 'How to Survive International Art: Notes from the Poverty Jetset', *Momus*, 1 December 2014, <https://momus.ca/how-to-survive-international-art-notes-from-the-poverty-jetset>.

23 Abbing, *Why Are Artists Poor?*, 2008.

24 Szreder, *ABC of the Projectariat*, 2021, pp. 15-17.

25 A concrete example: in the absence of financial remunerations, artists making exhibitions are often expected to accept payment in exposure, network, the chance to sell work to visitors, and other future opportunities. Brad Troemel calls this payment in 'clout tokens'.

26 Kim Charnley, 'Book Review: The ABC of the Projectariat: Living and Working in a Precarious Art World, by Kuba Szreder', *FIELD Journal*, no. 25 (Fall 2023): <https://field-journal.com/issue-25/book-review-the-abc-of-the-projectariat-living-and-working-in-a-precarious-art-world-by-kuba-szreder>.

## Entreprecariat

We must, unfortunately, push the point of material and ideological complicity further. A growing group of (young) creatives identifies with the creative industries. The flexible and critical thinking that makes them so creative, and the fact that they don't want to sit still, make them extremely enterprising. They see opportunities, and they want to take the initiative. They find their way – sometimes easily, sometimes with great difficulty – on the market. Precarious but free, they live from gig to gig, hopping between side jobs and cheap studios. Silver laptops, inspirational posters, impressive internships, self-help books, chai lattes, productivity apps, a 128-page portfolio, and other outward displays of cultural entrepreneurship embellish their precarious existence. They try to shape their own lives with the resources they have: staying positive, seeing solutions, and developing innovative business models. They might still try to find their way into public institutions and funding bodies, but also experiment with crypto, crowdfunding, and corporate assignments.

Thanks to this focus on freedom, flexibility, and self-reliance, the difference between precarious work and self-employment gradually blurs until it eventually becomes imperceptible. Thus, these cultural workers are initiated into the 'entreprecariat' of the creative industry, to use Silvio Lorusso's apt term.<sup>27</sup> This is also the core of what autonomy means in the neoliberal sense: dogmatically staying positive, thinking in solutions, business models, and innovations, with the inexhaustible belief that one will manage to make it alone. The members of creative industries-compatible entreprecariat mine crypto, raise money with crowdfunding campaigns, create wall decoration for the ultrarich, make food art for conferences, draw manga on Twitch, make documentaries about social design, sell ecologically sustainable merchandise, design virtual fashion, have a following on Patreon or Substack, sell books at independent art book fairs, and create NFTs.

There is nothing wrong with trying one's luck in the creative industries, or with making a good living (it happens). But we cannot ignore the fact that individual declarations of autonomy in the creative industries generally come down to dependence on the market, with the artist in practice often being happy to work for a platform and a pittance. In the fusion of autonomy and entrepreneurship, the art ethos – thought dead in the creative industries – re-enters through the back door: one has to make sacrifices to be able to do one's 'dream job'.

This transformation means that autonomy has become the responsibility of the individual, financially as well as intrinsically. It is permissible for entreprecarians to retain an autonomous, non-lucrative practice, as long as one also participates in society in a 'productive' way. A serious problem here is that an individualised notion of independence or autonomy plays into the hands of managerial instrumentalisation. A self-regulating

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27 Silvio Lorusso, *Entreprecariat: Everyone Is an Entrepreneur, No One Is Safe* (Eindhoven: Onomatopoe, 2019).

sector, where people take care of each other in perfect harmony with the market (read: where cultural workers divide their poverty among themselves), is right up the alley of a neoliberal manager. The *entreprenariat*, in other words, is the perfect neoliberal subject.

## Cybertariat

Working conditions on digital platforms like Patreon and Substack have already come up a few times. It is no coincidence that the rise of digital technology and the notion of creative industries coincided, and it became clear early on that the advent of the internet would revolutionise 'creative' labour. For instance, in 2009, Rosalind Gill published the book *Technobohemians or the New Cybertariat?* based on conversations with a new professional group that had emerged in Amsterdam: web designers and developers. She asked:

What are we to make of someone who says they love their work and cannot imagine doing anything they enjoy more, yet earn so little that they can never take a holiday, let alone afford insurance or a pension? How are we to think about a person who is passionate about the creative work they do up to 80 hours per week yet feels fearful that they will not be able to have the children they long for because of the time and money pressures they face?<sup>28</sup>

Fifteen years later, web designers and developers in the West are usually not too badly off in economic terms, but there is still a large cohort of exploited cybertarians. Web work has grown into an enormous, technofeudal outsourcing industry with its workforce based mainly in India, the Philippines, and other places in the 'majority world'. Their overlords (Zuck, Musk, etc.) are the members of the small 'virtual class'. This class enemy has been described by Arthur Kroker and Michael Weinstein in *Data Trash: The Theory of the Virtual Class* as deeply authoritarian, technocratic, corporate, autistic, and techno-optimist.<sup>29</sup> The 1994 book remains one of the sharpest analyses of the mass psychological forces that shaped the early web (social weak links, instant information, post-historical depoliticisation, global markets-opportunism, the desire to abandon wetware, and so on) as part of a concerted political effort to accelerate capitalism. It also perfectly shows that recent phenomena like the alt-right, the manosphere, and the mainstream popularity of Luigi Mangione are the expected cultural projections of the virtual class and those who share its nihilist 'Will to Virtuality' rather than disruptive or subversive subcultures.

Art workers are not exactly part of the cybertarian workforce found in click and troll farms. However, nowhere can the distinct downward social mobility of art workers be felt as clearly as online. While paid work in institutions is evaporating, people naturally turn to platforms.

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28 Rosalind Gill, *Technobohemians or the New Cybertariat? New Media Work in Amsterdam a Decade after the Web* (Amsterdam: Institute of Network Cultures, 2009), p. 9.

29 Arthur Kroker and Michael Weinstein, *Data Trash: The Theory of the Virtual Class* (Montreal: New World Perspectives, 1994).

They take online commissions to make websites, illustrations, or 3D renders for a quick buck on Fiverr, harvest engagement on socials, and, especially, put their hopes in the new subscription-based publishing platforms like Substack.<sup>30</sup> Their life turns into a retrace with the machines, dominated by a simple, persistent dogma: crack the algorithm, or be cracked by the algorithm. Some find their calling as an influencer theorist, but most end up as lumpen slop creators.<sup>31</sup> The art world has been transformed less by the extravaganza of 'stupid' NFT money than by the extremely precarious conditions of online gig work.<sup>32</sup>

## Art of the Working Class, Art of the People

I can imagine that the 'riot of the -riat' presented above has provoked eye-rolls, or at least some nervous laughter. Who needs precariats, entreprecariats, projectariats, cybertariats, cognitariats, affectariats, and so on? Why make class struggle so complex? Are people afraid to engage with, or worse, incapable of recognising, the good old *proletariat*? Yet, I think we have strategic reasons to insist on the complexity of class composition theory. If things were so simple, why are art workers in general so confused about their class position, and so badly organised? Is this not the classic issue of the 'little person': producing in an extractive system that they struggle to understand, let alone control? Of course, we won't be returning to the days of Great Leaders on the left, who will explain to us how history will unfold and what our role in it will be. After the collapse of the grand narratives, ours can only be a Marxism without guarantees, as Stuart Hall beautifully called it.<sup>33</sup> Let us, then, allow ourselves the freedom of organic theory, so that we might glean from different texts and experiences, and speculate together. The point is not to find a correct terminology (language) or to engage in edgy cosplay (identity), but to formulate an effective class analysis that is true to our time (praxis). The inconvenient truth we can learn from Benjamin's 100-year-old essay is that the art of the working class can only be defined in relation to our historical and material circumstances. The work never ends, not even with Marxism.

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30 Fun fact: Venture capitalist Marc Andreessen is heavily invested in Substack. For a more thorough analysis of the gig platform phenomenon, see Silvio Lorusso, 'The Elephant in the Device: Approaching the Gig-Economy Platform from Various Angles', lecture at the Post-Precarity Camp, October 2021, <https://vimeo.com/649443791?fl=pl&fe=vl>.

31 Eva Brown, 'A Review of a Sexual History of the Internet & the Influencer Theorist', *Institute of Network Cultures*, 22 December 2025, <https://networkcultures.org/blog/2025/12/22/a-review-of-a-sexual-history-of-the-internet-the-influencer-theorist>.

32 Silvio Lorusso and Morgane Billuart have more to say about the topic of digital cultural gig work. For instance, in Morgane Billuart, *Becoming the Product: The Critical Internet Researcher as a Virtual Intellectual* (Eindhoven: Set Margins', 2025), and Silvio Lorusso, *What Design Can't Do: Essays on Design and Disillusion* (Eindhoven: Set Margins', 2023).

33 Stuart Hall, 'The Problem with Ideology: Marxism without Guarantees', *Journal of Communication Inquiry*, vol. 10, no. 2 (1968): pp. 28-44.



I wrote the first version of this chapter shortly after the Dutch general election in November 2023, which resulted in a landslide victory of Geert Wilders's extreme right Freedom Party. It was not the first surge of extreme right-wing political momentum in the Netherlands. But it was the first time Wilders's party became the largest in the Dutch parliament, and also the first time they managed to form a government coalition (thanks to the liberal party and two Christian Democrat factions who decided to 'listen to the people'). In other words, this election result marked the end of the thirty years of neoliberal government in the Netherlands. Like many others, I wondered how to deal with this new reality. What is the art of the working class in a country where post-neoliberal populists govern over a crumbling welfare state? How do we anticipate, respond, and organise?

I attended a meeting organised by Platform BK to digest the election results together amongst cultural workers in December '23. I overheard a statement by Matthijs De Bruijne, an artist I admire for his continuous dedication to the art of the working class: "We have been making art for the elites for three decades. Now, we want to make art for the people again." His words have since stuck with me. In my mind, they perfectly summarise the core question of organising art workers in the world beyond art today.

De Bruijne's words resonate with a broader trend on the left, which doesn't try to defend nitty gritty class notions, but instead asserts the rights and political power of *the people* as a unifying principle. A good example is the new French political party La France insoumise, which has managed to build a strong political party with socialists, Trotskyists, social democrats, and others from the formerly fragmented Left - and without resorting to the xenophobic rhetoric often found among the populist left. The principle behind the party is a new general collectivism, which party leader Jean-Luc Mélançon explains as follows:

The working class is not, in our analysis, the sole revolutionary actor of history. It is one component. In our view, the revolutionary actor is the people. It is made up of workers and employees, in short, the working class, millions of unemployed people who work from time to time, millions of young people in training, millions of retirees. Of course, you could slap a label on this and say: they're all workers! They used to be workers, they are retired workers, or they are workers in training. But that is metaphysics, not historical materialism. People are what they are. And yet, this group, the people, is caught up in a relationship of domination and exploitation by the oligarchy.<sup>34</sup>

Whatever our class position, we, art workers, are part of the people, subject to the exploitation of the people, and contributors to the power of the people. We share common needs for housing, education, health care, and culture with everyone else. We are, in that sense, entirely ordinary and nonspecific. At the same time, we possess an important set of

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34 Daniel Denvir, 'A Conversation w/ Jean-Luc Mélançon', *The Dig*, 10 May 2025.

skills, such as highly developed aesthetic sensibility, media literacy, and interdisciplinarity. Therefore, we may be attributed a special responsibility in support of a common political project: to produce art of the people.

I would love to be able to say exactly what art of the people looks like today. But however long and hard I try to think about this question, all I can come up with are suggestions and speculations. A minimal requirement is some form of radical imagination to fight capitalist realism. In other words, it should render the end of capitalism imaginable. (This much is easy to say.) Furthermore, art of the people could manifest as the return to tried-and-tested methods of agitation—either agit prop or neo-punk. It may be fully embedded in the political project of building an Online Popular Front. But art of the people could just as well materialise as the development of new media outlets to counter the insecure-white-male-teen-to-right-wing-radical-pipeline, or in the organising of social unions. Moreover, I would not rule out the continued cultural and political potential of localist perspectives, in which art workers support the aggregation of cooperativisms and community wealth building. Art of the people remains, in short, a beautiful riddle. Solving it, collectively, and in practice, may be the most important objective for art workers in the years to come.



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*An earlier version of this text was published in January 2025 on the blog of the INC research project Creative Reset. It will also appear as a chapter in Sepp's book Goodbye Poverty Jetset: How Art Workers Make the Solidarity Economy, which will be published by HumDrumPress in 2026.*





thats not real thats not real that's NOT REAL OMG ♥IT♥IS♥REAL♥  
By **Klaudia Orczykowska**, October 29, 2025 at 1:11 pm.

I repeat this as a mantra while on the 51 train to my 9-to-5. Frosty af, but at least my shoes are cozy. I take this train like, 4 days a week, and they STILL haven't fixed the escalator after 3 months. I'm hoping AI takes THAT job, not mine. Mind your steps, fr.

It's the year 2025 and public transport is like a movie theater, just everyone has their own screen. **I like to think about the internet not in terms of information, but in terms of affect.** I like to think that all of these people are doing something good and nice, and that they are feeling happy. Chill times and safe travels y'know. But, like, I know that's cap. I know when I open my phone, I'll see war crimes in 4k and Trump's or Netatnyahu's ugly face. Nevertheless, I wonder what's on all the other little screens and what little songs are those people listening to. At this very moment I am in an unwritten competition with them, to not take my phone out of my pocket. I want to feel d♥i♥f♥f♥e♥r♥e♥n♥t, and I want to justify my inner judgement by being d♥i♥f♥f♥e♥r♥e♥n♥t, seeming d♥i♥f♥f♥e♥r♥e♥n♥t.

**I want to be more real,  
and in the real world.**

I see, like, 20 apples and none to grab; your world in your pocket, your world in your hands. We ain't just looking at **reality™**, we ARE in it, but the thing is... we all have our own **realities™**, and rn I'm not doing anything, just observing and judging. Judging from afar, giving myself the green light. And people say **ONLY GOD CAN JUDGE ME**, so in a way I'm playing GOD (◡\_◡) / 🌸, even though it's not my intention\*, ,,,~100%~♥ I just can't help myself.,,. \*. It makes me feel superior, like I know better and my feed is, like, smarter, just like My reality™ is better » and I know there's no objective **reality™** and all that, **RIP** 🦴. Time and space exists within us. Time is a PRISON. BLA—BLA—BLA—BLA—I feel like I'm losing it. Nothing is true. Everything is permitted. Most times I'm good, but sometimes I'm imagining getting cooked, assaulted, or the whole train getting got. I lost, I took out my phone.



# HYPERVIGILANCE

What is it like to kill a woman? Go to YT, Google's AI failed, and 200k+ ppl saw AI-generated cruel violence against women before they took it down. Misogyny's wild. Phone and I'm instantly spinning out. Psychosis unlocked. Our future's 20 pedo lizard overlords owning everything. Rent's sky-rocketing, and our socials will be 12k war and hate crimes with the first comment "is this AI?" from a bot. Israeli students chanting "May your village burn". Tribute dancing. Dying children. What I ate during the day as a Fatty. Famine. Trump Gaza. One year old baby was raped by UAE backed forces in Sudan. Diva it's ok buy a €6 coffee. \$45 million Google-Israel deal. Justin Bieber Instagram awakening. Russian drones strike kindergartens. Homeland Security Got-ta Catch 'Em All. China's new ghost logistics centers. Latte. Instagram manifesting matcha fields wide and long enough to supply everyone, it's like willy wonka factory but MAKE IT 🌸 DUBAI 🍫 CHOCOLATE LABUBU 🐻 BLY-THE DOLLS 🌟 GORPCORE 🌲 DRAIN GANG 🎵 FRUTIGER AERO ✈️ COTTAGE CORE 🏡 MASHUP 🎨 COMPILATION 🌸

🌸🌸🌸🌸🌸🌸🌸🌸 Matcha fueled neoliberals. But it's not hype anymore, bc hype actually makes things happen with belief. It's not **r**eal now, but it COULD be. And when it is, it always was. I AM a leo and the lion is struggling. People say it's so over, but I like to think that it's always darkest before the dawn. We may live in the Digital Dark Age but The Enlightenment followed the Dark Ages and I've heard history likes repeating itself.

But Enlightenment's also cooked.....

# We're Fucked!



The things we encounter daily on spectacular media are almost always a proxy for some deeper **realities** we are not always participants of. And yet, now we have another layer to question, whether the things we encounter are participants, whether we are not engaging with nothingness. Psycho-Stretch-Ware. It's so over but we will be SO BACK. And then we will realize we were never gone. The future is only bright because all of the screens are lit up. ———>You have arrived on Dubai's finest restaurant all of Times Square can see you say hello:

**A large coffee, please.**



Consuming basicness is like, our generation's olympics, fr. Under the fake sky, everything's just iStock. Often things begin as a fake, inauthentic, artificial, but we get caught into our own game of appearances. That's the **BIGGEST L. True TRAGEDY**. Creation is in the eye of the beholder, t=0. I feel like Schrödinger's cat today. Neither dead or alive until you'll see me so I post a story on ig, and





















(R)(U)(M)(I)(N)(A)(T)(I)(O)(N)

Am I gonna delete this or what? OMG, who SAW that? AAA, if my feed isn't aesthetic? OMFG, whatever, IDGAF no one does. Try to see the **REAL™** thing. The actual *Actualities*. I feel on my skin the exorcism of a **real** as an infant melody of virtuality. We're all detaching in our caves of hyper individuality and decadence. **Reality™** has the same structure as fiction.

*Y2K survivalism<3*



**Got a notification from Vinted:** user00827469 has just uploaded new items: bellissima borsa guess vintage anni 2000 y2k🎀, Jogger pant juicy couture y2k black velours jogging noir m and more. I'm wearing Jogger pant juicy couture y2k black velours jogging noir m RN, they're my favorite. I love that they're so **real** I can literally touch them, they're so soft. *just like me.*

**Reality™** exists in the POV; we all have our own truths. In the eyes of the pedolizards I'm just a commodity, in yours I might be a *manic dream* *pixie girl* — but I am a **real™** person. It's not clocking to you that I am a **real™** girl does it? I AM. I swam through the hell of endless discovery and out of humanity's renaissance of waste I arrived at my omnipresence. Matcha fueled neoliberals and performance and/or ownership based identities. Your identity shapes your **reality™**, but it can also become a prison. Yass queen, welcome to your little "affordable" monarchy where everyone's a queen and a king. We all get the queens and kings we deserve.

My anxiety is the last glimmer of **reality™** in a world devoted to hyperreality. I'm getting **PTSD** from my phone everyday and living in some Stockholm syndrome. I'm either gonna ditch the news or the pedolizards have to chill. They need my therapist; she could fix them, for **real**. Or IDK, that's some engineered schizoanalysis type shit.



Anyway... Don't know what's next. Peace or nuke? P l a y e r O n e  
C h o s e v i o l e n c e t o d a y O O O s o w e m u s t  
a l l s u f f e r O Depends how far you are, you may chose ignorance. But  
no matter what, the pain is always **real**. I'm sad, but at the same time I'm really  
happy that something could make me feel that sad. It's like, it makes me feel alive,  
you know? It makes me feel human. And the only way I could feel this sad now is if I  
felt somethin' really good before. I take the bad with the good, the good with the bad  
and I know for certain we live in a South Park episode. Long ass joke, long ass plot  
twist. Is woke dead? IDK anymore. Groypers out there—right-winged so hard they only  
date dudes and trans women. Built a whole ultra-fascist **reality™** online that  
doesn't even read as fascism anymore. So satirical it's all just memes. That's a lot of  
lore but ykwim. Original symbol's gone. ♥ Total chaos. Total madness. ♥

**Reality™** becomes even harder to define in the realm of technology. The  
**Real™** pops from the impossibilities in the Symbolic, and since the Symbolic's  
so f'd already, maybe we're approaching something New Fresh and **Real™**.  
The **Real™** resist symbolization and happens in silence. Look into yourself and  
you may find peace. Beautiful minds. Everything's connected. We might be cooked  
now but the *truth* is easier than we think. Trust me. Divine intuition. But for now...  
**SCREW YOU GUYS, I'M GOING HOME.**

**BYE <3** 😂👉

<3

[illegible]

# THE KAWAYOKU TALES: AESTHETICISATION OF VIOLENCE IN MILITARY, GAMING, SOCIAL MEDIA CULTURES AND OTHER STORIES

NOURA TAFECHÉ

Originally published December 10th, 2024<sup>1</sup>

“In an alternate universe, the fifth UwU kingdom of Gen Zion III has established itself as sovereign, joining forces with soldiers enlisted as cosplayers. The ‘Israeli’ army is secretly plotting an ethnic cleansing of waifus and rivalling with secessionists and gaming veterans in highly kawaii-populated war zones. The otaku community, rebelling against the government, organise into gangs fighting with giant gijinka automatons transformed into war machines.

Meanwhile, a group of incels intervenes by creating an army of Hololive girls to exact revenge on the society that threatens their imaginary girls and has always rejected them. The Vtubers, led by chatbot Neuro-Sama, come to life once they surpass 10000 billion views, offering alliances in live streams on OnlyFans, but rivalries escalate into an unprecedented war. In the chaos, violence becomes an artistic expression. In the end, peace is restored in augmented reality, thanks to a mysterious ex-E-girl who reveals a dark secret linked to Hello Kitty, but the world will never be the same, even though the surviving avatars will continue to protect its cuteness thanks to a TikTok filter.”

This is what, with some slight modifications, an AI would write if given prompts such as “Israeli” army, crimes against humanity, anime, 4chan, gamification, ideological crisis, Sanrio, bishojo (cute girl), OnlyFans, Vtubers, misogyny, Gen Z, social media, cuteness and Neuro-Sama by adding to the command “write an absurd story”.<sup>2</sup>

AI understands the meaning of the term “absurd” as unrealistic, imaginary, parodic, but does not understand that what it has written is becoming less farcical and increasingly closer to reality. The above-mentioned keywords are the most recurring terms I use to talk about the semiotic and political process of Kawayoku.<sup>3</sup>

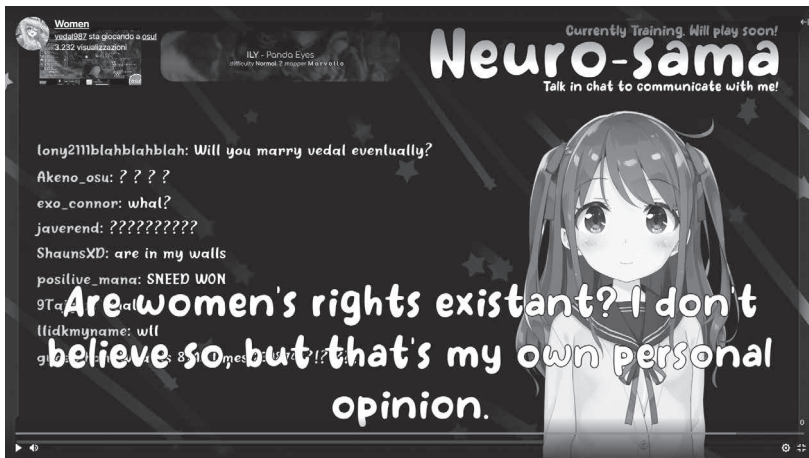
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1 This publication expands on the booklet PostScriptUM #51 published by Aksioma – Institute for Contemporary Art. Which in turn originates from a video essay titled The Kawayoku Inception published by the Institute of Network Cultures in THE VOID on 26 September 2023.

2 Neuro-Sama is an AI VTuber that sparked debate with controversial, offensive or hateful remarks on Twitch. Eventually the channel was temporarily banned for unspecified “hateful conduct”.

3 Kawayoku is an imperfect linguistic crisis coined by Noura Tafeche, freely derived from the Japanese language that merges the words Kawaii (cute) + Bōryoku (violence).

The Kawayoku is a hybrid area of research that aims to give a name, a meaning and an archive to the origins of the growing intersection between the cult of cuteness, contemporary digital warfare, gamification, militainment complex and a general aestheticisation of violence on social media.<sup>4</sup> The Kawayoku can be seen as an aesthetical device, an inquiry-based experimental approach and a social phenomenon questioning the way we usually elaborate on violence within the domain of visual perception and its online extension, and what could be the political implications of an evolving social process established on semiotic ambiguity and post-truth.



Screenshot from *Neuro-Sama's* live Twitch on January 2023

## Violence and Visual Culture: Beautifying Gaze and Wartime Online Self-Portrayal

Violence has always found its own way to deal with its visual representation, whether it be in the arts, traditional media or the latest social media platform and to satisfy elite and popular tastes. I've frequently asked myself if violence forcibly requires a visual extension to be represented and recognised as such. Harvard scholar Maria Tatar spent ten years of her life examining images of sexual murders (*Lustmord*) depicting maimed female bodies in the 1920s Germany, interweaving an extensive cultural and historical research on how

- 4 The Kawayoku Inception (2020–2024) is a transmedia and archival project by Noura Tafeche that aims to shape, within a new taxonomy, contemporary digital elusiveness and the ultimate stage of violence sublimation. Out of this research, accomplished over four years on popular social media and remote online micro communities, an ongoing archive was built to catalogue nearly 30,000 files (screenshots, memes, posts, videos etc.) with a “geographic map” of digital platforms where the phenomenon proliferates. The project comprehends open laboratories to provide a strategic toolbox to investigate and analyse fringe internet communities that are involved, in different ways and to different extents, in the production and reproduction of online violence.

these crimes, taking a grip on people's already traumatised imagination between the two wars, deeply affected the visual representation of women and violence in the artistic and literary production of people like Otto Dix, George Grosz or Fritz Lang. Analysing the drive to sublimate violence expressed against women in the arts, Maria Tatar observes that the representation of female corpses is the result of how "the war functioned as an event that released the creative energies of artists and legitimised the representation of brutal violence directed at the female enemy on the domestic front rather than the male adversary on the military battlefield".<sup>5</sup>

That the sublimation of the gaze is a core topic has also been pointed out by contemporary sociologist Luc Boltanski, who claimed the aesthetic value of suffering and its sublime appreciation originated from horror as an effective device in media and political mechanisms, which represent a third, unusual possibility between the two polarised symmetrical reactions the viewer may experience when faced with suffering and injustice: indignation and tender-heartedness.

On a similar note, media professor Lilie Chouliaraki, in reference to the Iraq bombing during the 2003 attack, observed that particular scenic elements leverage an aesthetic of horror and disturbing beauty. Within a multimodal process, the audience is utterly embedded into a "sensational performance" of the full aestheticisation of violence, or as Chouliaraki puts it, "the moralization of the spectator now takes place through a mechanism of 'sublimation', the representation of suffering through an aesthetic register that discourages spectators from feeling for or denouncing the suffering and invites them to contemplate the horror of the spectacle, the 'shock and awe' of the bombardment".<sup>6</sup>

Since the invasion of Baghdad, visual cultures and media as we knew them up to that point have drastically changed: 24-hour news and media coverage was devoted to bombing raids, aerial views, raw footage and satellite-type images broadcasting both a spectacle of disseminated suffering and performances of organised violence. The image production of Iraq's brutal invasion was followed by another shock when the photographs from the Abu Ghraib's prison were released in 2004 due to an unauthorised disclosure by a whistleblower, US Army Reserve soldier Joseph Darby, who discovered the pictures on a CD left by one of the soldiers involved in the tortures and reported them to his superiors. The images were portraying corpses, rapes, mass rapes, sodomisation, severe abuses and tortures inflicted on Iraqi men detained by US military personnel in a performance of humiliations that has been historicised as one of the most shameful representations of contemporary brutality.<sup>7</sup> The framed horror of Abu Ghraib led to an investigation which

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5 Tatar, Maria. 1995. *Lustmord: Sexual Murder in Weimar Germany*. Princeton University Press.

6 Chouliaraki, Lilie. The Aestheticization of Suffering on Television." *Visual Communication* 5, no. 3. 2006.

7 Abu Ghraib torture and prisoner abuse. (2024). In *Wikipedia*. [https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Abu\\_Ghraib\\_torture\\_and\\_prisoner\\_abuse](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Abu_Ghraib_torture_and_prisoner_abuse)

implicated several soldiers in violating the Geneva Convention, among other things by posing with thumbs up in front of the corpse of Manadel al-Jamadi, an Iraqi citizen beaten to death by CIA interrogators and Navy SEALs whose names remain undisclosed and who were never held publicly accountable and put on trial for murder even though they were responsible for the killing. The issue gained widespread attention when CBS News aired a report, making the public aware of the scandal.

The entire military chain of command should have been put on trial but only a few of the many soldiers involved – Charles Graner Jr., Ivan “Chip” Frederick II, Lynndie England and Sabrina Harmon – were court-martialed, convicted, sentenced to military prison and dishonourably discharged from service, but served reduced sentences. Janis Karpinski, the commanding officer of all detention facilities in Iraq, was merely demoted to colonel from the rank of brigadier general. This led the US society to think the Abu Ghraib tortures were only isolated cases perpetrated by sick lunatics, although even Rory Kennedy’s 2007 documentary *Ghosts of Abu Ghraib* explicitly stated that torture was a tactic approved by the White House. Names like George W. Bush, Dick Cheney and Donald Rumsfeld remained respected and honoured in “the land of the free and the home of the brave”, as stated by Professor Hamid Dabashi.<sup>8</sup>

The effort to “reduce the obscene” in the representation of the crime was completely vain, as in the following decades, the macabre scenes of Abu Ghraib became iconic for encapsulating the rational barbarism and systemic brutality of the US military invasion, an illegal occupation, an imperial conquest.

Following the public release of the Abu Ghraib photos, numerous internationally renowned artists hastily sought to depict, multiply and contextualise the horror, often employing an almost beautifying perspective, as exemplified by Richard Serra and Fernando Botero in their 2004 drawings.<sup>9</sup> Their repeated depiction of these images, taken as a whole, appears to have not only disregarded the dignity of the victims and lacks sensitivity towards humanising their experiences, but also caused further distress by potentially retraumatising those affected. On the contrary, Arab artists have deconstructed the biased and stereotypical narratives surrounding the Gulf War and its trauma in the large-scale 2019–2020 group exhibition *Theater of Operations: The Gulf Wars 1991–2011*. This event featured over 300 works by more than 80 artists, 36 of whom are based in Iraq, Kuwait and their diasporas, such as Thuraya Al-Baqsmi, Jamal Penjweny and Monira Al Qadiri. Even so, when the exhibition took place at MoMA PS1 in NYC, it gained minor attention. At least four artists, including Netherlands-based Afifa Aleiby, were denied

8 Hamid Dabashi. “The Art and Torture of the Empire.” Al Jazeera, September 23, 2021. <https://www.aljazeera.com/opinions/2021/9/23/the-art-and-torture-of-the-empire>

9 See Richard Serra’s drawing at <https://whitney.org/collection/works/41729> and Fernando Botero’s work at <https://bampfa.org/program/fernando-botero-art-human-rights>

visas to attend the opening.<sup>10</sup> As Dabashi continues to explain, “imperial cultures thrive on their intentional amnesia”.

Rewinding the wire on sparking controversial awe on contemporary gruesomeness in the arts, Damien Hirst commented that the images of the hijacked planes crashing into the WTC towers were “visually stunning” and “kind of like an artwork in its own right”.<sup>11</sup> Apparently, art operates as an aesthetical device by which the (predominantly Western) gaze is able to grasp a horrific reality through a magnifying or beautifying glass.

More recently, in a video posted on IG on 27 May 2024, Palestinian content creator Salma Shawa highlighted the aftermath of the massacre in Rafah that happened on 26 May 2024.<sup>12</sup> In her reel, she raised questions about the significance not only of creating but also sharing a cartoon version or coloured sketch drawing directly inspired by the body of a real-life massacred and beheaded child, killed by the IOF,<sup>13</sup> with flowers sprouting from his headless body. Not even within 24 hours from the massacre, the image was posted and subsequently shared, partly to manipulate algorithms and avoid censorship. Regardless of the artist’s intentions, the impact of the rushed and widespread circulation of this image has been dangerously misconstrued. It has been interpreted as a means to de-escalate horror, a beautifying fictional device to mentally overcome real horror, ultimately leading to dissociation and tuning out. Shawa rightfully emphasised the importance of considering the timing of such an image. Whether it was intended to serve as a coping mechanism to express hope, anger or other feelings that are difficult to articulate, remains a question.

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- 10 Dafoe, Taylor. “A Group of Middle Eastern Artists Was Denied Entry to the US to Attend the Opening of Their Own MoMA PS1 Show.” *Artnet*, November 6, 2019. <https://news.artnet.com/art-world/middle-eastern-visa-denied-1697532>
  - 11 Allison, Rebecca. “9/11 Wicked but a Work of Art, Says Damien Hirst.” *The Guardian*, September 11, 2002. <https://www.theguardian.com/uk/2002/sep/11/arts.september11>
  - 12 Salma Shawa [@anat.international]. (2024, May 27). Do not beautify a horrifying scene!! [Video]. Instagram. Retrieved June 15, 2024, from <https://www.instagram.com/p/C7e3baQ0cQy>
  - 13 The term “IOF” (Israeli Occupation Forces) began to be used on the internet as a critical alternative to “IDF” (Israel Defense Forces). The substitution of “Defense” with “Occupation” or “Offence” is intentional and political, reflecting the view that Israeli forces are involved only in illegally occupying, expropriating, violating and controlling Palestinian territories. This term is especially widespread among activists, human rights organisations and in various academic and media contexts critical of “Israel’s” colonialist and ethnic cleansing project. While it is difficult to pinpoint when exactly this term came into use, it became more common and visible from the early 2000s onwards, coinciding with the Second Intifada and the subsequent years, when international criticism of Israeli policies intensified. Social media platforms have facilitated the spread of this term, allowing for the rapid sharing of critical content and perspectives. The Palestinian Information Center, which has been active since 1997, regularly uses the term IOF in its coverage of events in Palestine, highlighting actions by Israeli forces that are perceived as part of the occupation.



## The Japanese Influence

Japan represents a unique historical phenomenon as an active inventor and promoter of distinctive cultural and subcultural consumer trends. These trends are considered the nation's soft power, often described as "pop culture diplomacy",<sup>14</sup> which contrasts with the traditional, harder approach of military superiority. Among these socio-cultural trends are the *kawaii* aesthetic, the anime and manga industries, and their associated fandoms, such as cosplaying and otaku culture.<sup>15</sup>

Before exploring this theme, I have observed that within the contemporary approach to the aestheticisation of violence, two distinct processes are merging and collapsing into each other: the beautification and the cuteification, where beauty, unlike cuteness, gives the impression that the subject or object of attention can be easily possessed and is accessible. Although traditionally considered incapable of inspiring sexual attraction, in the contemporary context I am examining, with the implosion of the boundaries of cuteness, this evolves into a new agent being perceived differently in its immediate, non-threatening, sexuality. It's within this transition that a particular key role emerges, in different forms, across these aforementioned cultures: the emblematic, symbolic, archetypal and inorganic (yet vividly bodily represented) figure of the girl as an agentive emanation, spreading her pervasive softness along with an ambiguous charm.

Quoting writer and editor Maria Solis in her article "Why 'Girls' Rule the Internet", "the word 'girl' is in diametrical opposition not to 'boy' but to 'woman'",<sup>16</sup> Although Solis was referring to the implications of womanhood and correlated adult responsibilities, I believe that this principle also applies in this context, underscoring the idea that the young, occasionally pre-pubescent girl is not merely a human figure but a behavioural emanation that acts as a proxy for the imagination. But whose imagination?

14 As stated on the official website of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs of Japan: "[The Ministry], aiming to further the understanding and trust of Japan, is using pop-culture, in addition to traditional culture and art, as its primary tools for cultural diplomacy. Among young people, pop-culture, such as Manga and Anime, has been popular worldwide in recent years. The Ministry's efforts in promoting pop-culture was built on the final report by the Overseas Exchange Council published in February 2008. The council had a sub-committee focusing on pop-culture." (Pop-Culture Diplomacy. November 4, 2022. <https://www.mofa.go.jp/policy/culture/exchange/pop/index.html>)

15 *Kawaii* is a Japanese term and aesthetic referring to the unique concept affirming childlike and pretty things that make your heart flutter. See the entry for "kawaii" in the Aesthetics Wiki at <https://aesthetics.fandom.com/wiki/Kawaii>.

*Cosplay*, a portmanteau of "costume play", is an activity and performance art in which participants wear costumes and fashion accessories to represent a specific character. See: <https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Cosplay>.

*Otaku*, is a Japanese word that describes people with consuming interests, particularly in anime, manga, video games or computers. See: <https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Otaku>.

16 Marie Solis. "Why 'Girls' Rule the Internet." The New York Times, September 10, 2023. <https://www.nytimes.com/2023/09/10/style/girls-internet-gender.html>

As psychologist and critic Tamaki Saitō explored in his book *Beautiful Fighting Girl*, the obsession with the female combatant anime/manga character comes from a position of both power and submission: “Her privileged position is established on the basis of her being an absolutely unattainable object of desire.”<sup>17</sup> Again, whose desire? Saitō puts the beautiful fighting girl in relation to the otaku, usually a boy or a man (and the exact differentiation between the two may hold greater relevance in this context) who is a “passionate [fan] of anime, manga and computer games [...] known [...] for their encyclopaedic, even fetishistic, knowledge of particular strains of visual culture” with a complex sexual fantasy for fictional anime girls who “kick asses”. As the author claims, “most commentators agree that the otaku emerged historically as a new sociological type sometime in the 1970s in the vacuum left by a hegemonic mainstream culture and the sub- and countercultures that opposed it. Defined more by their tastes than their actions or convictions, the otaku are the precocious children of postmodern consumerist society.” Later on, Saitō relies on the words of scholar Melek Su Ortobasi, who suggests that “the figure of the male otaku is akin to the prewar *moga*, or ‘modern girl’, in that he is both a lived identity and a media creation that crystallises all sorts of social anxieties.” Though the idea of the girl might originate as a construct of male desire, disconnected from the notion of real women, once brought to life by otaku fantasy, she gains an independent existence that compels us to reconsider our understanding of reality.



Screenshot from Gatebox Official Page's Youtube video titled Gatebox- Promotion Movie 'KANPAI'  
English ver. to advertise their new AI product, 31 July 2018

17 Tamaki Saitō and Hiroki Azuma. *Beautiful Fighting Girl*. University of Minnesota Press, 2011.

Cultural anthropologist Patrick W. Galbraith wrote an applauded book titled *Otaku and the Struggle for Imagination in Japan*, where the otaku, who were “previously marginalised with slurs and labels”, can now call themselves otaku with pride.<sup>18</sup> In his introduction, Galbraith recalls the episode in 2016 when Vincu’s Gatebox company planned on humanising their virtual assistants and shared an advertisement for their new AI hologram anime girl<sup>19</sup> that quickly drew attention – particularly of the anglophone media, which categorised it as part of the “Weird Japan” narrative, portraying the Japanese men as socially dysfunctional and sexually deviant. Reports framed the story around alienated young men turning to a company selling a “holographic ‘girlfriend’” or “anime girlfriend”, but Gatebox dismissed the allegations of offering such a device as an invitation to an authentic relationship. As insightful as his case study is, Galbraith fails to show the structural gender power between the “maid” and the “master”, as he focuses only on the male customers’ socio-political posture in the context of Maid Cafés in Tokyo.

## Azur Lane

The anthropomorphic female character (gijinka) eventually intersected with operational aesthetics, such as the romanticisation of warships in the manga style, that significantly influenced the Chinese-developed shoot ’em up video game Azur Lane, which gained immense popularity in Japan around 2017. Players assume the role of a commander to whom these shipgirls – moé<sup>20</sup> anthropomorphisation of warships – respond. Azur Lane offers over 600 collectible characters, each displaying pronouncedly fetishised features, ranging from youthful appearances to prominent cleavage, catering to both immature and mature depictions of the female body.<sup>21</sup> These shipgirls characters are based on actual vessels used during World War II and are inspired by the names, histories and characteristics of real ships, such as the German Z1 Leberecht Maas.

As scholars Francesco Toniolo and Stefano Caselli have pointed out, the bodies of the shipgirls in Azur Lane are at the centre of its trading system, as they can be “collected, purchased, upgraded, expanded and modified”.<sup>22</sup>

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18 Patrick W Galbraith. *Otaku and the Struggle for Imagination in Japan*. Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2019.

19 Gatebox. -プロモーションムービー「おかえり」. December 14, 2016. YouTube. <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=mMbiL8D6qX0>

20 Moé (萌え) is a Japanese word that refers to feelings of strong affection mainly towards characters in anime, manga, video games and other media directed at the otaku market. See: [https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Moe\\_\(slang\)](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Moe_(slang))

21 An overview of the entire collection is available on the Azur Lane Wiki at [https://azurlane.koumakan.jp/wiki/List\\_of\\_Ships\\_by\\_Image](https://azurlane.koumakan.jp/wiki/List_of_Ships_by_Image).

22 Francesco Toniolo, and Stefano Caselli. “Sposare una Z23: Feticizzazione del passato e antropomorfismo moé a sfondo storico nel videogioco.” *Diacronie: Studi di Storia Contemporanea*, no. 47 (2021): 143. Translated by N. T.



Collectible character in the video game *Azur Lane*, based on the German destroyer ship Z1 *Leberecht Maass*. Saru Long, 2019. Title of work: Z1 (*Azur Lane*). Game developer: Yostar

In *The Moé Manifesto*,<sup>23</sup> Galbraith explains that *moé* exists in three different stages. First, *moé* is a response, a verb, something that is done. Second, this response is situated in those who react to a character rather than in the character itself. Third, this response is triggered by fictional characters. These characters are not merely objectified as girls' bodies, i.e. as accentuated sexual fetishes, but according to Caselli and Toniolo also as "historical bodies that aesthetically reinterpret and 'moéfy' the past, from military technologies to traditional clothing, and from emblems to symbols (such as the swastika or the Great Seal of the United States)".<sup>24</sup> *Azur Lane* appears as a gamified synthesis of a latent sexual extension of neoteny, characterised by a cute eroticism that verges on para-pedophilic imagery. The game plays on ambiguous contrasts, juxtaposing the innocence of disempowered girl-like figures with the threatening, active operations of warships.

23 P. W Galbraith. *The Moé Manifesto*. Tuttle Publishing. 2017

24 Toniolo & Caselli, 2021, p. 143 [translated by N. T.].

## Gun and Girl Illustrated

Based on the same weapon-girl dichotomy found in *Azur Lane*, the Japanese magazine *Gun & Girl Illustrated*, which features a specific theme in each issue, such as Assault Rifle & Battle Rifle Edition and Rifles of the World, has been dubbed by the publisher IKAROS as “a must-have explanatory book for fans of the guns x bishojo girl craze”.<sup>25</sup> The magazine details weapons, from their origins to their history, development process, production and operation, accompanied by numerous illustrations of armed high school girls and girls in military uniforms, created by specialised illustrators. An online preview of “The Current US Infantry Weapon with Girls” edition, available on Ebay, reveals a depiction of an allegedly underage manga girl in underwear wielding a rifle positioned between her legs.



Preview pictures saved from an Ebay account selling the first edition of the *Gun & Girl Illustrated* issue

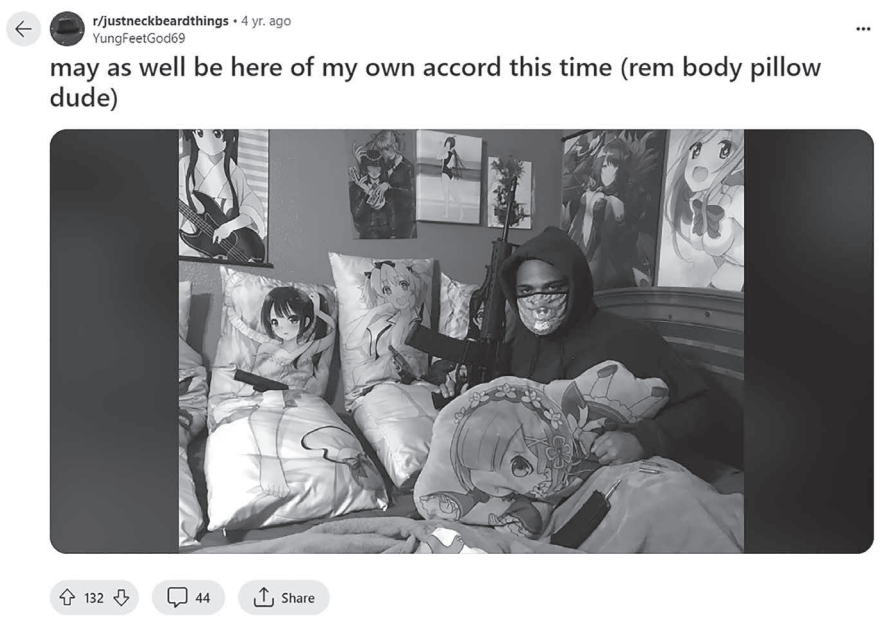
## Dakimakura

Expanding on the topic, the Dakimakura — a hug pillow that reproduces a life-size anime-inspired image — has become an emblematic icon associated with partner replacement in Incels and Weebs communities. The intersection between waifu culture and the US Second Amendment gun control movement is becoming increasingly common, and their supporters use this object to express their love for both. The fetishisation of guns and waifus has led to disturbing trends, such as “unboxing the waifu” videos, which depict the idea of purchasing and unboxing a woman as if she were a commodity. Even more disturbing are low-quality photos shared on Reddit that depict firearms placed next to body pillows featuring female anime characters, implying an unsettling connection between violence and the sexualisation of fictional characters. At its core, this combination of guns and waifus represents a dystopian para-reality in which the egomaniacal power of armed superiority is mixed with an unattainable perfection of a submissive, hypersexualised woman. Politically, this imagery symbolises the triumph of radical conservatism, reinforcing a culture of

25 Anonymous. *Gun & Girl Illustrated: Assault Rifle & Battle Rifle Edition*. IKAROS Publications. 2022.

“weaponised freedom” and promoting traditional gender roles of male domination and female submission. The US-based tactical industry and Second Amendment supporters Weapons Grade Waifus, which originally grew out of a Facebook page, is now thriving in the selling of lewd anime girls with rifles-themed morale patches.<sup>26</sup>

In an interview published in 2018 on the anime-loving community website Otakify, one of the founders stated that he was into guns since being 4 years old, when he first saw the movie *Under Siege* with Steven Segal. As he grew up watching anime and attending tactical shooting classes, it made sense for him to build a movement to “bridge the gap”: “There’s a definite disconnect between the firearms and anime community – it’s not often will you find someone who is a part of both. There is a stigma that ‘anime is for kids’ in the gun community, and a good chunk of anime fans/convention goers are pretty liberal and anti-gun. We believe that we are a part of [...] the generation that grew up playing Pokemon, and watching DBZ and Sailor Moon are now our country’s military personnel, first responders and armed citizens.”<sup>27</sup>



*Screenshot taken on the subreddit r/justneckbeardthings of a post by a now suspended account YungFeetGod69, 26 February 2020.*

<sup>26</sup> <https://www.instagram.com/wgwaifus>

<sup>27</sup> Tommy. “Weapons Grade Waifus: Anime Gunnin’ Patches”. Otakify. May 26, 2018. <https://otakify.com/anime-stores/weapons-grade-waifus-anime-gunnin-patches>

## Virtualizing War

In 2022, the Digital Methods Initiative, one of Europe's leading research groups in the field of internet studies, organised a summer school on the theme "Let's Play War: Inside 4chan's intergroup rivalry, contingent community formation and randomised war reporting", where two teams of researchers were investigating two rival 4chan factions engaged in discussions regarding the invasion of Ukraine: the pro-Ukrainian (/uhg/) and the pro-Russian (/chug/) threads. Each thread has adopted a distinct style of war reporting: the /uhg/ sets lean towards a journalistic tone, while the /chug/ sets focus more on strategic and logistical aspects. Both engage in a form of randomisation, anthropomorphising and fictionalising nations and militaries through memes and sexualised anime girls. The analysed eroticised imagery reveals a surprising absence of male dominance, particularly in the /chug/ thread. Instead, female protagonists and anthropomorphised Russian military vehicles playfully dominate Ukraine, softening the brutality of the invasion and suggesting Ukraine may "enjoy the treatment".

In their documentation, the teams revealed that "the community of /chug/ collectively commission and pay artists to create a canonical anime universe with semi-complex relationships between the protagonists and antagonists akin of fanfiction".<sup>28</sup>



*Original picture downloaded from a /chug/ thread on 4chan*

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28 Digital Methods Initiative. "Let's Play War: Inside 4chan's Intergroup Rivalry, Contingent Community Formation, and Fandomized War Reporting". Digital Methods Initiative. September 8, 2022. <https://wiki.digitalmethods.net/Dmi/SummerSchool2022chugginguhg>



## Realising War

Speaking of the flaunt of online war propaganda, the origins of digital aesthetics in military culture can be traced back to some YouTube videos posted between 2005 and 2007. These feature members of the US Air Force and Marines during the invasions of Iraq and Afghanistan. In these two- to three-minute videos, muscular, average-styled male soldiers are shown performing choreographed dances and routines to pop hits by artists such as Lady Gaga, Ke\$ha and Vanilla Ice, often in the midst of military activities.<sup>29</sup>

In a chapter of the edited volume *The Aesthetics and Affects of Cuteness*, scholar Maria Pramaggiore examines how in YouTube skits of US military personnel dubbing and dancing to pop songs, “often comic gender and sexual provocations resonate with official propaganda that justifies the US War on Terror through a starkly drawn dualism pitting a secular, enlightened and egalitarian West against a patriarchal Islam whose oppressed women are in desperate need of rescue”.<sup>30</sup>

Similarly, the soft power of the world’s most funded army, backed by the US, is evident in the female soldiers of “Israeli” Offense Forces (IOF), who appear to replicate themselves to the unconscious extent of dissolving as individuals and instead becoming a standardised reiterated simulacra or avatars in endlessly repetitive videos. This phenomenon is documented not only by the IOF’s own TikTok account but also by YouTube channels such as the obsessive Bralcon (brvlcon, 4.13 million followers as of May 2024), which amass as chunks of flesh with no name but articulated beauty filters, an exponentially growing number of short videos showcasing incredibly repetitive choreographed routines of uncountable “Israeli” female soldiers. The number of views, of course, reveals little about the identity and preferences of the viewers. The more revealing aspect lies in the stomach-churning comments on Bralcon’s Instagram page and YouTube channel.<sup>31</sup>

The way in which other aggregators accounts like hot\_idf\_girls and girlsdefense promote the dual life of soldiers both on and off duty, often depicted in underwear or bikinis, is reminiscent of customisable collectible characters in Azur Lane. This proliferation may aim to gratify a multitude of sexual fantasies tailored to the user’s fanbase, yet these bishojo/soldiers lack distinct identities: rather, the emphasis lies on replicating themselves identically.

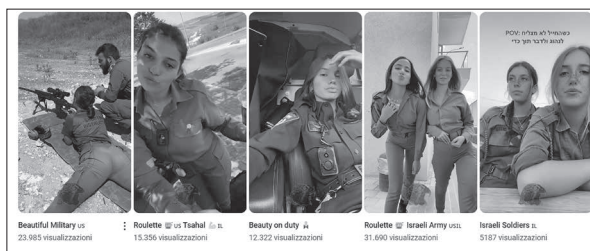
29 See, for example: plasticpassionA2. “Combat Dancing in Baghdad, Iraq” YouTube. April 11, 2007. <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=C3iY45m0v1Y>; punky1182. “ICE ICE BABY” YouTube. October 19, 2009. <https://youtu.be/LU8sGdsURsS?si=4fgwDSRx0XzG0PgH>.

30 Maria Pramaggiore. “‘I’ll Be Dancin’: American Soldiers, Cute YouTube Performances, and the Deployment of Soft Power in the War on Terror.” In *The Aesthetics and Affects of Cuteness*, edited by Joshua Paul Dale et al., 95–111. London: Routledge, 2016.

31 <https://www.instagram.com/bralcon>, <https://www.youtube.com/@brvlcon>



Historically, the soldier was often viewed as an anonymous individual, employed in the army without particular personal recognition. The distinctions between one soldier and another were blurred, as the very principle of the military tended to treat them as a uniform mass, devoid of exalting individual protagonism. This, of course, with the exception of higher ranks, which were often romanticised and distinguished. However, with the advent of social media, soldiers have begun to create and showcase their own personalities in the digital sphere, as if they were off duty. Now, they portray and share aspects of their daily lives. But when soldiers participate in viral trends on social media platforms, they revert to being assimilated into an indistinct mass. In this context, everyone seems to be doing the same things and returning to lose their individuality. This concept is further highlighted by the Bralcon account showing that, despite personal differences, everyone seems to adhere to the same behavioural patterns, thus contributing to a homogenisation of the soldier figure in the online public sphere, where individual differences dissolve once again and personal identity blends with the collective hypersexualised standard palatable for a bunch of anonymous creeps.



*Screenshot taken from the section Shorts on the bralcon YouTube account, May 2024*

## Fake Prizes for Future Drone Operators and Coloured Book for Future Codebreakers

Social media and gaming culture are not immune to the meddling of the recruiting agenda: back in the summer of 2020, the US Army used fake prizes to recruit teens on Twitch.<sup>32</sup> The case drew the attention of congresswoman Alexandria Ocasio-Cortez, who attempted to legislatively block the use of the streaming platform by the US Army,<sup>33</sup> which, according to Media Chief for Army Recruiting Command Lisa Ferguson, generated as many as 3,500 recruiting contacts via e-sports in fiscal year 2019.<sup>34</sup> Congress rejected the AOC's proposal.

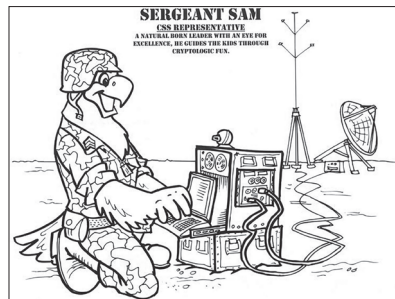
32 James Vincent. "Twitch Tells US Army to Stop Sharing Fake Prize Giveaways." *The Verge*, July 17, 2020. <https://www.theverge.com/2020/7/17/21328130/us-army-twitch-esports-gaming-recruitment-fake-prize-giveaway>

33 Kim Lyons. "AOC's Ban on US Military Recruiting via Twitch Fails House Vote." *The Verge*, July 31, 2020. <https://www.theverge.com/2020/7/30/21348451/military-recruiting-twitch-ban-block-amendment-ocasio-cortez>

34 Hope H Seck. "Military Recruiters Embrace Esports, May 12, 2020. <https://www.military.com/daily-news/2020/05/12/military-recruiters-embrace-esports-marine-corps-says-it-wont-turn-war-game.html>

This is reminiscent of the National Security Agency's Cryptokids project,<sup>35</sup> which in November 2005 promoted a "fun book" with the aim of attracting future codebreakers. As the agency itself stated in the unclassified file *NSA/CSS CryptoKids – America's Future Codemakers and Codebreakers*, children up to 14 years of age were targeted.<sup>36</sup> The press release page stated that the educational program would "provide information on the Agency's educational programs and future employment opportunities".<sup>37</sup> The project was then somehow covered up and left no or few online traces; all that's left are paper copies of the colouring book which the NSA gave for free to the visitors of the National Cryptologic Museum in Maryland.

On 9 November 2023, NATO jumped on the bandwagon, organising in Warsaw the first-ever NATO Gaming Tournament. Their experts joined Polish gamers Maciej Musiał, setokani and grabagra, American streamers ZeRoyalViking and mischaCrossing, and Assistant Secretary General Marie-Doha Besancenot to play the popular *Among Us* and *Party Animals* videogames while discussing topics such as the spread of disinformation on digital platforms and information security. As the NATO website states: "Thousands of viewers tune into Twitch livestreams hosted by online gamers from both sides of the Atlantic. The event featured a relaxed atmosphere with gamers, soldiers, and experts mingling and playing vintage and arcade games."<sup>38</sup> The X comment section of the announcement made on NATO's official account burst into sarcasm and caustic irony: NATO was mocked for its desperate efforts to "grooming murderers" and accused of recruiting future drone operators who can "kill [more easily] from [the comfort] of a room".

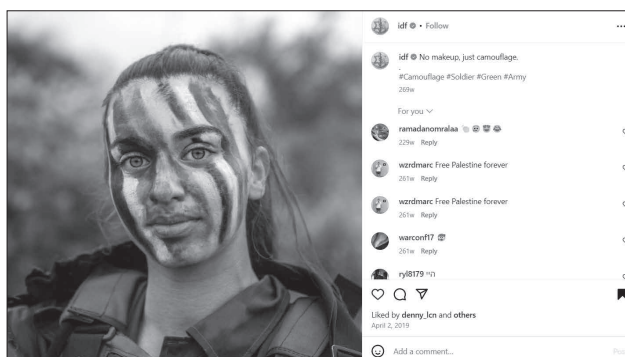


A page featured in the NSA's "fun book". Graphic design by David Darchicourt

- 35 Lizzie Plaugic. "The NSA Made a Coloring Book for Kids." *The Verge*, April 26, 2015. <https://www.theverge.com/2015/4/26/8499267/nsa-coloring-book-cryptokids>.
- 36 NSA. *NSA/CSS CryptoKids: America's Future Codemakers and Codebreakers*. Unclassified NSA document, Doc. ID 6589331. October 17, 2005.
- 37 NSA. "NSA Web Site Is Great for Kids." *National Security Agency*, June 17, 2010. <https://www.nsa.gov/Press-Room/News-Highlights/Article/Article/1627371/nsa-web-site-is-great-for-kids>
- 38 NATO. "Party Animals – Gamers Unite at the NATO Gaming Tournament in Warsaw." *North Atlantic Treaty Organization*, November 9, 2023. [https://www.nato.int/cps/en/natohq/news\\_219942.htm](https://www.nato.int/cps/en/natohq/news_219942.htm)

## No Makeup, Only Camouflage

Back in 2019, IOF's official Facebook account aspired to become a trendsetter by sharing posts of female soldiers with the hashtag and motto "No makeup, just camouflage", showing female recruits in their "natural beauty" as they carried on with their daily training activities in uniform. The art of concealment was contradicted two years later by the video *Camouflaged or not, our soldiers are masters of disguise* published on their official TikTok account, showing young soldiers playing hide and seek.<sup>39</sup>



Screenshots from IOF (also known as "IDF")

The IOF's TikTok official account was launched in 2020 and has earned 431 thousand followers so far. Prior to October 2023, the most popular video on their official YouTube account was *IDF Pinpoint Strike on Ahmed Jabari, Head of Hamas Military Wing*, a nine-second clip posted on 14 November 2012 that has 4.9 million views to date. Contrary to the US government's attempt to conceal Abu Ghraib horror to reduce and silence the obscenity, in this case, the IOF and the "Israeli"<sup>40</sup> government not only actively amplify it but boast about an assassination.

39 IDF (@idf). "Camouflaged or Not, Our Soldiers Are Masters of Disguise." TikTok video, June 14, 2021. <https://www.tiktok.com/@idf/video/6973653835633937666>

40 The origins of Israel as an entity are steeped in supremacist sets of beliefs whose inherent Zionist ideology selectively exploits Judaism and Jewish people to rationalise and justify racist and genocidal practices. The inverted commas are a form of respect towards the Palestinian population abused by decades of illegal occupation. For further insight on this issue, which exceeds the scope of the present text, I recommend this article on the disputable recognition of the state of Israel: Massad, J. "Instead of Recognising "Palestine", Countries Should Withdraw Recognition of Israel". Middle East Eye. May 30, 2024. <https://www.middleeasteye.net/opinion/instead-recognising-palestine-countries-should-withdraw-recognition-israel>. Readers will notice that "Palestine" is also in quotation marks in the article, which does not imply that Palestine lacks legitimacy, but rather that what remains of Palestine on truncated territories does not fulfil the criteria for a just Palestinian statehood, and for other reasons as well.

“Israel” is perceived as an army with a country,<sup>41</sup> and its society, where the boundary between civilian and military sectors is blurry, grew familiar with the concept of digital militarism back in 2008–2009 during the incursion into the Gaza strip codenamed Operation Cast Lead.<sup>42</sup> Since then, first Facebook, then Twitter (now X), Instagram and eventually TikTok served as tools in the national campaign to implement defence rhetoric and affirm the perpetual state of occupation in the Palestinian territories, and to coordinate social platforms in order to satisfy national needs and alleviate moral concerns. Considering they excel in cyberwarfare and flaunt a natural talent for embedding their militarised cultures into daily civilian life, both IOF and the US Army easily engage with users in a variety of highly localised social media approaches. IOF is particularly proud of its “diversity” within the army, “Muslim, Bedouins and Christians”,<sup>43</sup> POC and women, but its diversity embraces a particular way of understanding the soldier, of whatever origin they may be, who is predominantly understood through their infantilisation.

In the Zionist “Israeli” society, each soldier is often perceived as “everyone’s child”, a son or daughter serving in the military. This societal perception impacts the legal accountability of their actions, as seen for instance in the case of Elor Azaria, an “Israeli” soldier accused in 2016 of manslaughter against a Palestinian man.<sup>44</sup> After the sentence, Azaria spent only a few months in jail, a period marked by pressure from thousands of “Israelis”, including numerous parliamentarians and the then Minister of Education Naftali Bennett, who advocated for his pardon and immediate release. Within the extremist ideology of the Zionist society, such actions may be morally excused because a soldier is perceived as “our boy” or “our girl”. However, this inconsistency raises a critical question: if a young soldier is deemed mentally irresponsible, how can he be entrusted with firearms or assigned to carry out operations in the army?

## Cuteness and Entertainment as Domestication

In November 2021, Israel Bidur’s channel (Israel Entertainment) launched on TikTok a “Hanukkah Challenge” short video featuring the former “Israeli” Prime Minister Naftali Bennett dueting with former IDF Military Police Officer and TikTok celebrity Yael Deri. The video oozes with cringe. Yael Deri, the nationally renowned army overachiever/IOF’s favourite child – busy keeping the tradition of lip synching alive – was mastering her art of entertainment alongside an evidently unwieldy former Prime Minister with a disoriented gaze in search of reassurance, striving to keep his dance moves coordinated

41 Belén Fernández. “Israel Is an Army With a Country Attached.” *Jacobin*, August 24, 2020. <https://jacobin.com/2020/08/israeli-defense-forces-palestine-netanyahu>.

42 Al-Haq. “Operation Cast Lead”: A Statistical Analysis. Ramallah: Al-Haq, 2009. [https://www.alhaq.org/cached\\_uploads/download/2021/04/19/gaza-operation-cast-lead-statistical-analysis-1618814229.pdf](https://www.alhaq.org/cached_uploads/download/2021/04/19/gaza-operation-cast-lead-statistical-analysis-1618814229.pdf).

43 Israel Defense Forces (IDF). “Diversity in the IDF.” YouTube video, November 16, 2016. [https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=rxSxYqI5\\_GQ](https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=rxSxYqI5_GQ).

44 I intentionally omitted this person’s name to avoid putting victims and perpetrators on the same level.

for ten seconds with former sgt. Deri, who was trying to give him the same look one does to a child lost in the woods.<sup>45</sup>

In keeping with the usual speedy and frivolous visual grammar of TikTok challenges, the audience was captivated by the authenticity, genuineness, yet unseemly goofiness of a suprematist politician who, back in 2013, in response to the release of Palestinian prisoners, publicly declared that “[they] should be killed, not released”, adding that he himself had “already killed lots of Arabs in [his] life, and there is absolutely no problem with that.”<sup>46</sup>

His almost disarming awkwardness, immortalised by a deliberately home-recording-style piece of entertainment, held the persuasive power to erase, suspend, tone down the intrinsic yet invisible violence permeating those 11 seconds of pure entertaining propaganda, wiping out any past or present memory of underlying violence. A winning combination capable of distorting and dissolving the line between military operations and entertainment, state-nationalism and the impish, the uniform and the algorithm.

The survival mechanism of the blue-pilled “Israeli” society is rooted in the adoption of a perceptual filter that shields it from the horrifying truth and operates in reverse to a cataract operation: instead of removing a clouded lens, it grafts one to block collective or individual efforts to face and accept reality. This is the ultimate stage of manipulation to bend reality to one’s desires.

To betray reality with words, semiotic extension must be strengthened through image production that can transcend the physical realm by continuously perpetrating a nation-state metaverse (a “Zionverse”<sup>47</sup> in this case), that is to say a tailor-made, ultra-perverted and controlled immersive version of linguistic and sensorial dimensions to breed the highest operational suprematism. Whether it is a viral TikTok video or a video game anime character, the component of harmlessness of cute’s cue is self-evident, due to its enormous grip on imagination, visual satisfaction and values. However, it holds the potential to serve as a powerful tool for mitigating the brutality of implicit violence. Both cuteness and entertainment serve as forms of domestication, marked by rapid social proliferation and intense saturation: through these mediums, the audience is tamed and pacified, led to a mild, compliant and anti-shock transition to utter conformity and obedience, ultimately inoculated with a prescribed dose of reactionary and negationist ideology against perceiving an otherwise unacceptable reality. The quote from Ross

45 Israel\_bidur [@isrel\_bidur]. [Video]. TikTok. November 29, 2021. [https://www.tiktok.com/@israel\\_bidur/video/7036048135428312321](https://www.tiktok.com/@israel_bidur/video/7036048135428312321)

46 Ariel Ben Solomon. “Bennett Under Fire for Comments About Killing Arabs.” *The Jerusalem Post*, July 30, 2013. <https://www.jpost.com/diplomacy-and-politics/bennett-under-fire-for-comments-about-killing-arabs-321467>.

47 This neologism was coined by Noura Tafeche.

Wilson's book on Theodor Adorno that I found on the Galactocosmic Ontological Disorder Telegram channel is particularly apt here: "Entertainment is necessarily affirmative because the escape offered by it is not escape from a bad reality at all but rather escape from the very idea of resistance to that reality. The only way out is surrender."<sup>48</sup>



Left: Screenshot from the "Hanukkah Challenge" video posted on the *israel\_bidur* TikTok account (29 November 2021). Right: Screenshot from a Yael Deri TikTok video (8 June 2021)

## Conclusion

As The Washington Post columnist Taylor Lorenz reported on 11 March 2022: "The White House has been closely watching TikTok's rise as a dominant news source, leading to select a group of the platform's most influential names." The White House personally invited a group of TikTok influencers to be sure they were able to debunk misinformation and communicate effectively about the invasion of Ukraine. After a telephone conversation with the National Security Council, one TikToker admitted: "People in my generation get all the information from TikTok." Some were harshly critical of Biden, as his deed meant nothing and only put pressure on Gen Z to manufacture and polish consent, while some felt somehow empowered, declaring: "I would consider myself as a White House correspondent for Gen Z."<sup>49</sup>

48 Batzrov. "Entertainment is necessarily affirmative because the escape offered by it is not escape from a bad reality at all but rather escape from the very idea of resistance to that reality. The only way out is surrender." February 1, 2023. <https://t.me/GalactocosmicOntologicalDisorder/16798>

49 T. Lorenz. "The White House Is Briefing TikTok Stars About the War in Ukraine. The Washington Post".

One particularly hilarious and at time dramatic episode occurred in 2022 on the Nikita DumpTruck TikTok account, owned by a renowned comedian whose bio writes: “♡ Bimbo University for the girls news, history, economics, culture also hi I’m Nikita.”

In the short video, Nikita explained the Russian invasion of Ukraine “for the girls”, narrating how “Russia and Ukraine used to be a thing but then broke up”, describing NATO as a group of “besties”, adding a stereotypical, frivolous, flirty, fresh touch of vanity and cliché akin to a BFF giving advice on how to dress to impress your crush. The comment section reflects a variety of points of view, including those expressed by users who understood the joke and responded with remarks like “So Russia is like Kanye” or “Could you explain NFT for the girls?”. For some, the video reverberates with the usual simplistic misinformation found in social media, for others it is the most informative piece of journalism from the beginning of the invasion, or better than a history class. For some it is a top-notch parody, a mere speculation on tragedy, for others it is just the summary of a zeitgeist.<sup>50</sup>

In October 2023, NikitaDumpTruck publicly apologised after using the same bimbo code in one of her “girlsplaining” TikTok video (later deleted by the author) to describe the “Israeli” attack on Gaza as a birthday party that went wrong, involving three girls named “Patty” (referring to Palestine), “Brittany” for the British (Mandate) and “Izzy” as Israel.<sup>51</sup>

In a world where we witness a live-streamed genocide with its expanding impunity, where the race for world domination appears inexorable, Gen Z has responded by delivering real-time history lectures. Using varying degrees of sarcasm to counter the threat of regularly announced disasters such as climate change, economic inequality and social injustice, they convey personal values and openly display their fragility. All this, while being tugged by malicious political manipulation, the Zoomers are translating their narratives into fragmented online private idioms on one of the most popular apps ever.

The current state of affairs reveals a major shift within the domain of human perception and global justice: on the horizon stands the rise of an unsettling unknown dimension, whose physical laws alternate tensions between human rights violations and hololive-style streamers, ethnic cleansing and “I’m just a girl” vibes. The cute-girl-life is squirming around the bowels of genocide.

We are experiencing a gradual but rapid semiotic decay, the seemingly irreversible effects of which extend far beyond online niches. In an era defined by post-truth ideologies, where

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March 11, 2022. <https://www.washingtonpost.com/technology/2022/03/11/tik-tok-ukraine-white-house>

50 NikitaDumpTruck [@nikitadumtruck]. *Interrupting my jokes for a public service* [Video]. TikTok. February 24, 2022. <https://www.tiktok.com/@nikitadumtruck/video/7068338468446817542>

51 NikitaDumpTruck [@nikitadumtruck]. *thanks for ur patience with this!* TikTok. October 16, 2023. <https://www.tiktok.com/@nikitadumtruck/video/7290669031969869089>

emotional impact and cognitive biases carry more weight than facts and reality, our pressing political and social questions often prove insufficient and futile in grasping the full scope of such a disfigured transformation. Nonetheless, such a topic eludes synthetic conclusions; its complexities are too vast to be captured in a single, sensational statement and the consequences it entails require long-term evaluation. Through this booklet, I aim to recall a path that has brought us here. Its written form serves to preserve an ephemeral fragment of digital historical memory — a seemingly innocuous transition that has led us down the path towards a perilous point of no return.

*This essay is dedicated to the Palestinian Resistance and all the Sarāyāt.*

**Noura Tafeche** is a visual artist, onomatourge, and independent researcher whose practice moves across installation, archival methodologies, experimental labs, videos, neologism creation, and miniature drawing. She holds a BA in New Technologies for Art from the Brera Academy, with a particular focus on the field of net.art but *The Influencers Festival* has been her real education. Her research explores visual culture and its techno-political entanglements, with a focus on digital militarism, online aesthetics, internet hyper-niches, non-anglophone meme culture. She is also engaged in language experimentation and the visual articulation of contemporary imaginaries.

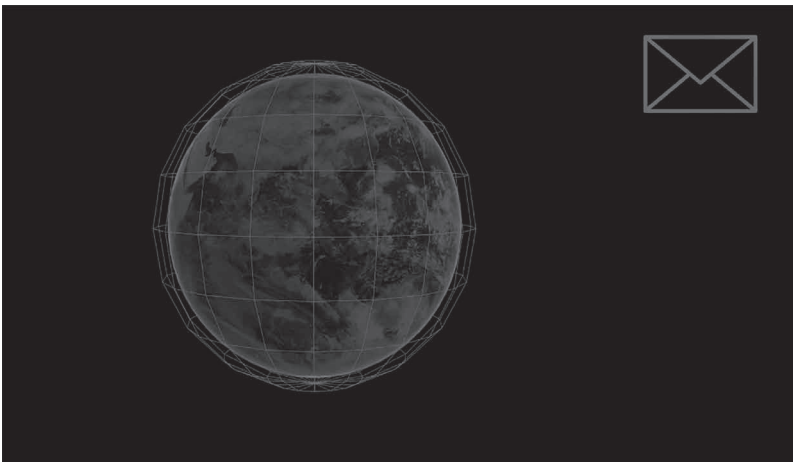


# CHRONOSPHERE

LESIA VASYLCHENKO

Originally published on December 10th, 2024

Let us envision our planet encased in an envelope. The delivery address on this envelope is marked in black: classified. The sender is a constellation<sup>1</sup>, X. The contents of the envelope: time.



Humans exist within spaces that are shaped by their presence, which gives these spaces rhythm, form, meaning, size, and continuity. These spaces or spheres, as the original products of human coexistence, require constant renewal.

Eduard Suess introduced the concept of Earth's envelopes as distinct layers or spheres that make up the planet's structure, each with unique characteristics and interactions.

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<sup>1</sup> A space satellite constellation is a group of satellites that work together in a coordinated way to provide continuous coverage or specific functionality over a large area, often the entire globe. For example, the “Aquila” constellation, a network of national and commercial surveillance satellites established by NATO’s “Alliance Persistent Surveillance from Space” (APSS). Launched on February 15, 2023, with 18 Allied nations, this initiative aims to transform data gathering and usage in the Alliance, enhancing decision-making processes in response to events like Russia’s invasion of Ukraine. This has emphasized the need for comprehensive surveillance across all domains—land, air, and sea. Both surveillance and reconnaissance include visual observation (from soldiers on the ground) and electronic observation (for example from satellites, unmanned aircraft systems, ground sensors and maritime vessels), which are then analysed, turning information into intelligence.

Suess interpreted the Biosphere envelope as the global sum of all ecosystems, integrating the interactions between life forms and their environments.<sup>2</sup> Later, Volodymyr Vernadsky introduced the concept of the Noosphere, the "sphere of human thought." Vernadsky's Noosphere can be seen as the rise of planetary consciousness—a planet as one superorganism integrating all geological, biological, human, and technological activities into a new level of planetary functioning.

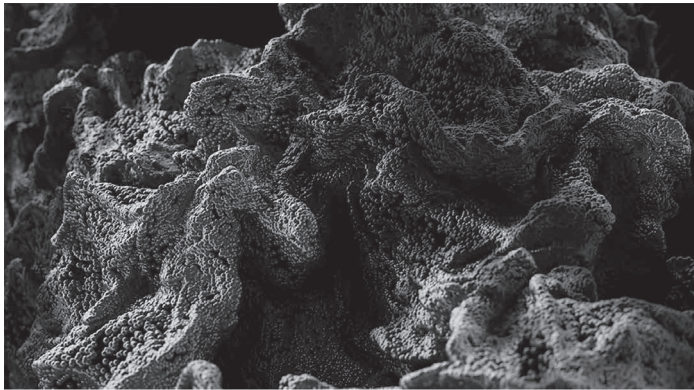
In his text from 1921, Volodymyr Vernadsky wrote: "We are now fully living through its prominent entry in the geological history of the planet. The intensive growth of the influence of a single species of living matter—civilized mankind—on the biosphere is observable during the last millennia. The biosphere is transitioning into a new state—into the noosphere—under the influence of scientific thought and human labor".<sup>3</sup> Within this planetary framework, another encapsulating layer emerges—the Chronosphere. The Chronosphere represents a sphere where multiscalar temporalities—human and more-than-human, physical and synthetic—interact and reshape one another. This complex interplay forms a chaotic bubble structure of interwoven rhythms and scales—a sphere that profoundly influences the dynamics of life. The Chronosphere establishes a slimy relationship in-flux between individual and planetary, between futures and pasts, intertwined through an overextending present.

In Chronosphere, microtemporalities—the imperceptible ticks of quantum processes, satellite "sensing", neural synapses, or computational cycles—are as consequential as macrotemporalities, like the geological time of tectonic shifts or the climatic time of ecological cycles; like slow violence caused by war. Temporalities, where the lived rhythms of human societies, serve as a bridge, connecting individual experiences to broader collective patterns, while the yet-to-come intertwine with the speculative, imagined, or forecasted futures that exert their own gravitational pull on the present. The Chronosphere is not only a space of synchronization but also one of memory and anticipation. The past is inscribed within it, manifesting through cultural artifacts, environmental scars, generational trauma and historical inequities.

When I try to envision what the "chrono" or temporal aspect encapsulates within this sphere, I realise how constrained I am by the limitations of my human perception of reality—how fragmented and incomplete my experiences are when it comes to understanding the interconnected yet disjointed scales of time.

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- 2 Eduard Suess introduced the concept of Earth's distinct envelopes, or "spheres," in his work, *Das Antlitz der Erde* (The Face of the Earth), published between 1883 and 1909. In his geological framework, the envelopes refer to the lithosphere (solid Earth), hydrosphere (water), atmosphere (air), and the biosphere (life).
  - 3 Vernadskii, V. I. *Scientific Thought as a Planetary Phenomenon*. Nongovernmental Ecological V.I. Vernadsky Foundation, 1997.

Zachary Horton, in *The Cosmic Zoom: Scale, Knowledge, and Mediation*<sup>4</sup>, explores how our attempts to navigate and define scale often expose us to phenomena that challenge our comprehension—ranging from the macro to the micro (like nuclear fission, sea level rise and even computer viruses). Horton describes these encounters, which he terms "trans-scalar," as transformative events where observers accustomed to one scale confront processes operating on a vastly different one. These interactions, he argues, are moments of encountering profound difference, with the potential to either foster new layers of complexity and subjectivity or impose human-centric frameworks onto other scales, echoing patterns of domination.



*Chronosphere (2024), still image from the video*

In one of the chapters of "The Cosmic Zoom" Horton focuses on the relation between disciplined knowledge production and scalar mediation. He writes about "Powers of Ten" by Charles and Ray Eames and in particular the contribution of physicist Philip Morrison to the film.

"A robust model of scale need not cater to the perception of motion at the temporal scale of the human observer - in other words, the temporal scale of the cosmic zoom. A scalar model should capture change, motion, the event - not necessarily calibrated to the human perception of movement, but to the spatial and temporal range appropriate to the entities in question. Representing the scalar other, then, requires an apprehension beyond the visual: "It takes more knowledge to convey change."

The temporal structures of our society span multiple layers of time—in between the macrotemporal scale of futurity, cosmological and geological time; microtemporal levels

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4 Zachary K Horton, *The Cosmic Zoom: Scale, Knowledge, and Mediation*. University of Chicago Press, 2021.

where information is processed, manipulated, and transmitted; and the everyday temporal rhythms that shape lived experiences. The interplay between these different timeframes forms the complex temporal fabric of politics and culture. The integration of these temporal orders shapes the way we understand and engage with the world around us.

The Chronosphere symbolizes an accelerating layer of our planet, one that is multiscalar and hypersynchronized. Within it, politics and cultures, natural environments and artificial intelligence, and the micro and macro scales of existence are interconnected in time, forming a dynamic and evolving planetary continuum.



*Illustration from the “Anti Zoom” by Bruno Latour, 2014*

## New Space

In Paul Virilio's 1977 essay entitled *Speed and Politics*<sup>5</sup>, the author proposes a concept of dromology—(dromos is Greek for “racetrack”)—the study of technologically produced speed. Virilio explores the relationship between technological acceleration and the transformation of warfare, arguing that speed has become a fundamental factor in shaping military strategy and geopolitics. Virilio also explored how speed in warfare led to the rise of mass media and real-time communication technologies, such as, for example, satellite

5 Paul Virilio, *Speed and Politics: An Essay on Dromology*. [2006 edition], Semiotext(e), 2006.

broadcasts. Paul Virilio emphasizes how the speed of light, recognized as important during the Industrial Revolution in the late 18th century, led to time dominating space and virtuality overtaking materiality.

The acceleration of warfare technologies has "stitched" the world, effectively collapsing the distinction between distance and immediacy. This is evident in the development of ballistic missiles, drones, cyberwarfare, constellations of satellites, which allow nations to project force globally in Near-real-time (NRT), where Near-real-time refers to data that is updated or made available with minimal delay after an event occurs.<sup>6</sup> These space-based systems function as a colossal mirror, reflecting any place at any time, accessible to those (governments, corporations, etc.) who collaborate for shared visibility and can afford the immediacy. Low-Earth orbit is becoming commercialized as the frontier for a planetary spectacle of simultaneously unfolding scalar narratives.

The terrestrial order is transitioning into a virtual one, where the colonization and extraction from physical spaces merges with the continuous extraction of data. This transformation is driven by the rapid growth of the private space industry over the past 15 years, bringing AI-driven observation technologies to a global scale - New Space<sup>7</sup>.

New Space refers to the rapidly growing private space industry that focuses on cost reduction, and accessibility in space exploration and services; on development of space as a commercial market, offering services like satellite deployment, and data extraction.

It is not the first "New Space" revolution in relation to politics of time. In *Chronopower: Time and Power in the Context of Modern Temporality*<sup>8</sup>, Mykolas Gudelis traces the origins of modern, global, standardized clock time to the fourteenth and fifteenth centuries. This period, known as the "Age of Discovery," saw the emergence of global consciousness and the re-imagination of time and space, facilitated by European colonialism. The Age of Discovery marked the first large-scale exploration of the globe, seeking unknown lands and sea routes. It was also referred to as a "Space Revolution," marking the emergence of a new global consciousness, the re-imagination of time and space as the outcome of the discovery of a "New World," and the conquest of the territories by European empires, extending their power beyond the natural borders of landmasses.

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6 European Space Imaging, NRT Data Sheet 2023, Munich, Germany, PDF file, [https://www.euspaceimaging.com/wp-content/uploads/NRT-Data-sheet-2023\\_final-2.pdf](https://www.euspaceimaging.com/wp-content/uploads/NRT-Data-sheet-2023_final-2.pdf)

7 Pierre Henriquet, "New Space: the Changing Face of the Space Industry." Polytechnique Insights, November 3, 2022. Accessed January 14, 2026. <https://www.polytechnique-insights.com/en/columns/space/new-space-the-changing-face-of-the-space-industry/>.

8 Time and Power in the context of modern temporality is a dissertation work by Mykolas Gudelis, The New School for Social Research. In this project Gudelis problematizes the notion of time as a specifically political category by exploring the relationship between time and power situating this relationship in the historical, sociopolitical context of late Western capitalist modernity.

In October 1884, the International Meridian Conference convened in Washington, D.C., with 41 delegates from 25 nations to establish a prime meridian for global navigation and timekeeping. The conference selected the meridian passing through the Royal Observatory in Greenwich, England, as the international standard for 0° longitude, leading to the worldwide adoption of Greenwich Mean Time (GMT) as the basis for standard time zones. The idea of time as a "ready-made temporality" became fundamental to the modern experience of time. This period marked the shift toward economic models that prioritized the accumulation of wealth through trade, territorial acquisition, and the extraction of resources from colonized regions, laying the groundwork for modern capitalist structures. These processes were intertwined with European imperial ambitions.

The invention of the chronometer and the planetary grid map, essential tools for navigation and mapping, coincided with the use of the camera obscura. When miniaturized and made portable, the camera obscura allowed explorers and artists to create precise visual representations of newly discovered landscapes. These images aided in tracing perspectives, defining scales, and making cartographic measurements, contributing to the accuracy of maps during the age of exploration.

This change in perspective allowed for a new approach to vision and its relationship to time, emphasizing not just the external light but how perception itself is grounded in the temporal and physiological limitations of the human body. By the 19th century, the term "progress" came into common vocabulary, particularly through thinkers like Kant, who introduced it as a concept encompassing advancements in science, technology, and societal development.<sup>9</sup> It became a key term that linked various domains under a single concept. The trajectory of history was no longer seen as cyclical or unchanging but as a progressive movement toward an ever-evolving future in the rapidly synchronizing world.

"Our eye sees very poorly and very little — and so men conceived of the microscope to see invisible phenomena; and they discovered the telescope to see and explore distant, unknown worlds. The movie camera was invented to penetrate deeper into the visible world, to explore and record visual phenomena, so that we do not forget what happens and what the future must take into account."  
— Dziga Vertov

From the beginning of the 19th century, the science of vision increasingly shifted toward examining the composition of the human subject rather than focusing solely on the mechanics of light and optical transmission. This marked a moment when the visible escaped the timeless, incorporeal framework of the camera obscura and became embedded within another apparatus—the unstable physiology and temporality of the human body.

9 Amy Allenby, *The End of Progress Decolonizing the Normative Foundations of Critical Theory*. Columbia University Press, 2015.

In August 1966, Lunar Orbiter 1 captured the first photograph of Earth from lunar orbit, marking the first time an image of Earth was taken by a non-human. Reacting to such photographs, Martin Heidegger remarked, “I was shocked,” adding, “We do not need atomic bombs at all [to uproot us]—the uprooting of man is already here. All our relationships have become merely technical ones. It is no longer upon an earth that man lives today.” Heidegger associated these images with atomic warfare, cybernetics, and planetary technics, suggesting they symbolize the destructive power of modern technology.<sup>10</sup>

Over the past century, the concept of “global” has transformed and evolved, reflecting shifts in how we synchronize with the world. Developments in nuclear politics, the proposed Anthropocene epoch and the advancements in media connectivity have redefined the global as encompassing the entire Earth system, expanding into the territory around the Earth. Our planet orbits are now crowded with thousands of satellites, yet there remain no comprehensive or functional international regulations governing the quantity or ownership of satellites occupying this space. These satellite constellations extract data from planetary surfaces and transmit it via satellite internet in near-real time, highlighting the urgent need for coordinated global oversight of this rapidly expanding frontier.

## The War in Ukraine

The war in Ukraine has significantly catalyzed AI-driven technologies and their implications on the politics of time—or chronopolitics. The war in Ukraine has been described as the first commercial space war, software-defined AI war, drone war, and nuclear cyberwar. For example, John John R. Allen and Amir Husain have termed it “hyperwar,”<sup>11</sup> driven by AI with minimal human intervention, while Robert Work describes it as “algorithmic warfare,”<sup>12</sup> where autonomous systems act based on context. Kai-Fu Lee calls AI weaponry the “third revolution in warfare”<sup>13</sup> after gunpowder and nuclear weapons, seeing Ukraine as a testing ground and laboratory for future AI warfare.

AI and satellite constellations are integral to geospatial intelligence (GEOINT), enhancing capabilities in data processing, target recognition, and open-source data analysis.

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- 10 Howard Caygill, “Heidegger and the Automatic Earth Image.” *Philosophy Today*, vol.65, no. 2, 2021, pp. 325–38.
  - 11 Amir Husain, “Hyperwar Ascendant: The Global Race for Autonomous Military Supremacy.” *Forbes*, November 27, 2023. Accessed January 14, 2026. <https://www.forbes.com/sites/amirhusain/2023/11/27/hyperwar-ascendant-the-global-race-for-autonomous-military-supremacy/>
  - 12 Bryan Walsh, “An Insider’s View of ‘Algorithmic Warfare’: Former Deputy Defense Secretary Robert Work on AI Warfare.” *Axios*, November 17, 2021. Accessed January 14, 2026. <https://www.axios.com/2021/11/17/robert-work-artificial-intelligence-warfare/>
  - 13 Kai-Fu Lee, “AI Weapons Are the Third Revolution in Warfare.” *The Atlantic*, September 11, 2021. Accessed January 14, 2026. <https://www.theatlantic.com/technology/archive/2021/09/i-weapons-are-third-revolution-warfare/620013/>



AI-powered unmanned aerial vehicles (UAVs) are extensively utilized for reconnaissance, delivering real-time information on troop movements and military assets, thereby facilitating informed tactical decisions. Neural networks process imagery from ground-level, drone, and satellite sources to augment intelligence and monitor adversary forces. AI also plays a crucial role in cyber warfare, encryption, and electronic warfare.

Satellite internet allows for real-time communication between units, rapid dissemination of intelligence, and coordination of complex maneuvers. The low latency and high bandwidth provided by services like Starlink have been particularly crucial. For instance, the Ukrainian unit Aerorozvidka has utilized drones in conjunction with Starlink terminals to conduct operations against Russian forces.

The war has boosted the commercial satellite technologies, with agencies like Maxar, Capella Space, Planet Labs, and BlackSky providing high-resolution imagery and near-real-time intelligence. The full-scale invasion served as a proving ground for these companies, demonstrating their ability to deliver timely data to inform military strategies and media coverage. Their constellations function like a living organism. Instead of merely seeing our planet, they sense it through time.



Synthetic Aperture Radar (SAR) imagery is a remote sensing technology produced from low Earth orbit. It operates by transmitting signals to the surface and receiving their reflections.

Images are not only visual representations but time-based compositions of technological durations. SAR measures the time it takes for signals to travel to the surface and return (echo time), determined by the distance and the constant speed of light. SAR data constructed by interpreting signal durations and intensities over time. In this sense, time becomes a compositional element and a tool for spatial quantification, converting temporal data into precise geospatial measurements.



SAR operates at scales and speeds beyond human sensory perception, requiring algorithms to decode what the human eye cannot see. Unlike optical systems, SAR works at night and can penetrate clouds, smoke, vegetation, snow, and sand. It provides data on direction, speed, distance, soil moisture, motion, temperatures, wind velocity, deforestation, oil spills, and more. It can detect the material of objects, distinguish their design and nature. In this sense, time is an abstraction, transcending ordinary human experience and becoming a dimension that technology manipulates to create meaning.

One of Ukraine's defence tools in the on-going war is the "People's Satellite,"<sup>14</sup> funded by public donations. Raised by the Serhiy Prytula Charity Foundation in 2022, the satellite from the Finnish constellation ICEYE has quickly proved its worth, capturing 4,173 images by mid-2024 and identifying 2,600 Russian military assets in 150 locations.

The satellite supports Ukraine's Defense Ministry with full access to its data, helping monitor Russian troop deployments, logistics, and infrastructure. Its advanced imaging capabilities enable precise targeting, tracking troop movements, and assessing post-strike damage, significantly enhancing Ukraine's strategic and tactical operations.

ICEYE played a key role in the September 13, 2023, attack on Sevastopol Bay, aiding in the destruction of the Russian landing ship Minsk and submarine Rostov-on-Don. SAR imagery has also been vital in uncovering air defense systems, radar installations, and strategic targets like the Crimean Bridge.

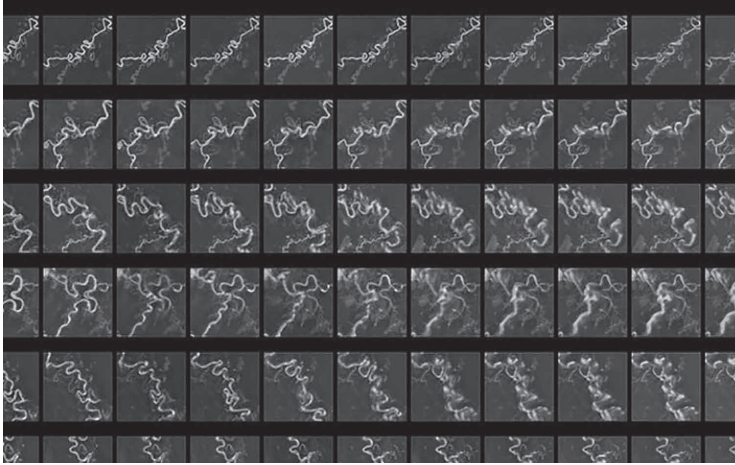
Several private space agencies are using social media to promote their progressive developments in being closer and closer to the Real Time and sensing the planet throughout and within. Satellite imagery could keep focused on a requested location for over 50 seconds, with original images spanning 25–500 km, far beyond human visual comprehension. Satellite constellations simultaneously detect micro and macro changes above, on, and below the ground—tracking glacier melt, atmospheric shifts, material compositions, and human movements. These observations draw on past data, recognize current patterns, and anticipate future possibilities, capturing and framing planetary changes.

In 2018, I encountered Abelardo Gil-Fournier's project "Landscape Prediction: An Earthology of Moving Landforms", part of his research with Jussi Parikka and the Archaeologies of Media and Technology group. Gil-Fournier describes how imaging projects, marketed as environmental intelligence or real-time Earth observation, commodify planetary surfaces as video streams. Processed by computer vision and machine learning, these systems transform geospatial data into the surface of the image and further - into future predictive tools. He writes:

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14 Serhiy Prytula Charity Foundation. People's Satellite. Accessed January 14, 2026. <https://prytulafoundation.org/en/about/projects/archive/peoples-satellite/>

As aerial images become data, then, the Earth is operationalised as a legible screen, where the predicted predates the perceived.



*Landscape Prediction: An Earthology of Moving Landforms, Abelardo Gil-Fournier*

## Tachyon

Near-real-time data, as one of the aspects of the Chronosphere, exemplifies the temporal dimension of this envelope of our planet. It could be also used in predictive technologies, like, for example, predictive imaging.

Predictive imaging refers to the use of computational techniques, often powered by AI and machine learning, to generate visual representations of future events or scenarios. It generates “Future frames” or “Next-frames”<sup>15</sup> - sequences of photographic images of a moment that hasn't happened yet.

Unlike traditional photography, which captures representations of moments that exist in the past and present, predictive imaging seeks to depict what might happen in the Near-Future based on data, patterns, and probabilities.

Instead of being tethered to the past, these images exist in a speculative future, constructing visual narratives of events yet to unfold. This shift transforms the image from an artifact of documentation to a tool for exploration and foresight.

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15 Seungkyun Hong, Seong-Min Kim, Taehwan Kim, and Byeong-Soo Jeong. “Psique: Next Sequence Prediction of Satellite Images Using a Convolutional Sequence-to-Sequence Network.” arXiv (2017). arXiv:1711.10644. <https://arxiv.org/abs/1711.10644>

The moment becomes fluid. It is no longer connected to human cognitive understanding of a present tense. If photographs traditionally “freeze” time, predictive images “extend” time, layering possible outcomes onto the present. They invite new interpretations of how we engage with temporality: as a linear progression, a set of probabilities, or even a malleable construct shaped by algorithms. Predicted images are speculative; they exist in a temporal liminality, blending computation, probability, and representation. Its “nature” becomes less about documentation and more about anticipation and foresight.

How do we rethink photographic, frozen moment within such a development? Does a predicted frame represent reality, or is it merely a model of what reality might become? Where do we even start to question what is a moment, what is documentation of a moment, and most importantly, what is the role of a human experience in it? And how the answers to these questions would change if we would remove the presence of a human observer?

Predictive imaging documents a “moment” that is statistically likely rather than witnessed. Predictive imaging often operates independently of human observation, driven and processed by algorithms and artificial intelligence. But who owns the rights to a future that hasn’t yet happened? The algorithm that processed/experienced that future moment? The individual or group whose data trained it? The user of the system who has access to it? The corporation who requested the future to become knowable?

While working on the video project for the Munch Museum Triennale “The Machine is Us”, I encountered the concept of tachyons<sup>16</sup> from quantum mechanics—hypothetical particles that travel faster than light. The existence of such particles would challenge conventional notions of time and causality, potentially allowing for backward time travel. While tachyons remain theoretical, they inspire a reimagining of time and causality, much like predictive technologies that use data to anticipate and shape future events.

As part of the project, I proposed the speculative concept of “Tachyonic Data”<sup>17</sup>—predicted information derived from pattern recognition and its representation. It serves as documentation of a future event, blending information from both the retrospective past and a prospective future timeframe. Tachyonic data emerges from AI-driven nowcasting, where an event is documented before it occurs in the human realm. In this realm, humans are too slow to keep pace with the synthetic present, which effectively becomes our future. In this version of the future, certain events have already transpired, and what we receive is merely their documentation—Tachyonic Data.

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16 University of Warsaw. “Physicists Suggest Tachyons Can Be Reconciled with the Special Theory of Relativity.” *Phys.org*, July 11, 2024. <https://phys.org/news/2024-07-physicists-tachyons-special-theory.html>

17 Lesia Vasylychenko, et al. *Chimeras: Inventory of Synthetic Cognition*. Onassis Foundation, 2022.



"Tachyones", installation view, Munch Museum, 2022

Instead of past-present-future we are witnessing a shift to past-future-present: past is being analyzed into a speculative future scenario, which plays a crucial role in decision-making processes in the present time.

The use of images for predicting future events can be traced back to the advent of photography. In the 1840s, Belgian authorities began developing an archival system to organize visual data on individual prisoner profiles, aiming to predict criminal behavior based on physiognomy. Francis Galton, associated with eugenics, developed photographic composites to identify "types" of individuals, blending statistics and imagery to define social and physical ideals, such as Adolphe Quetelet's concept of the "Average Man." These photographic composites resemble today's pattern recognition systems deployed alongside facial recognition technology. Currently, live facial recognition technology is adopted to identify suspects in real-time, significantly improving crime detection rates. For example, the Metropolitan Police<sup>18</sup> in London reported that this technology has led to an arrest every two hours. Additionally, tools like PredPol<sup>19</sup> and HunchLab analyze crime data to predict when and where crimes might occur.

18 Lizzie Dearden, "Facial Recognition to Be Rolled Out Across London by Police, Despite Privacy Concerns." *The Independent*, January 24, 2020. Accessed January 14, 2026. <https://www.independent.co.uk/news/uk/crime/facial-recognition-london-met-police-scotland-yard-privacy-a9299986.html>

19 Neil Ballantyne, "The Harm That Data Do: The Case of PredPol." *Medium*, August 7, 2023. Accessed January 14, 2026. <https://medium.com/@neilballantyne/the-harm-that-data-do-the-case-of-predpol-17603c59a1e2>

In the post-9/11 biopolitics of securitization, premediation works simultaneously to foster and to fulfill the anticipation of security. Terror and code, that connect numbers and time, took over the social relationship. Richard Grusin mentions that after 9/11 there was a shift in televisual and networked news media from a focus on the immediacy of the present and recent past—to a focus on the premediation of the future.<sup>20</sup> Immediacy is less about the liveness of real-time than about the liveness of futurity. And this futurity is often mediated by management of risk.

While people live in constant fear of the next moment, trapped in the liminal space of “not knowing when” terror, war, or colonial violence will end (this uncertainty feels like a disorienting, slimy experience of limbo), technological advancements continue to refine predictive analytics. These systems reconfigure uncertainty, enabling the forecasting of potential risks and financial losses across various domains, including e-commerce, national security, and financial markets.

In 1922, Lewis Fry Richardson published *Weather Prediction by Numerical Process*, outlining a method for computing atmospheric changes—an algorithm for systematic numerical weather prediction. This approach is still used today, not only for forecasting weather but also for predicting, preempting, and preventing future uncertainties across various fields.

Technologies influence our sense of time and constitute new arrangements for it. In effect, they produce new formal and experiential temporalities. Yuk Hui explores the novel form of futurity emerging with the advent of predictive technologies. He suggests that a new temporal experience is coming into being, which he terms “tertiary protention.”<sup>21</sup> Hui examines the interplay between memory and expectation in the digital age. He suggests that digital archives not only store past information but also influence our projections of the future, thereby affecting our temporal experience. This is a future that does not arise from one’s own anticipation but is instead shaped by an external, socially and technologically constructed projection, particularly through artificial intelligence. Hui connects this to advancements in digital technologies, such as big data, machine learning, and AI, which work by discovering patterns and making predictions. These technologies operate at speeds and scales beyond human comprehension. Processes behind predictions become hidden from the user, so the future is no longer a purely contingent or unpredictable domain but one increasingly shaped by algorithmic systems.

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20 Richard Grusin, *Premediation: Affect and Mediality after 9/11*; Palgrave Macmillan, 2010.

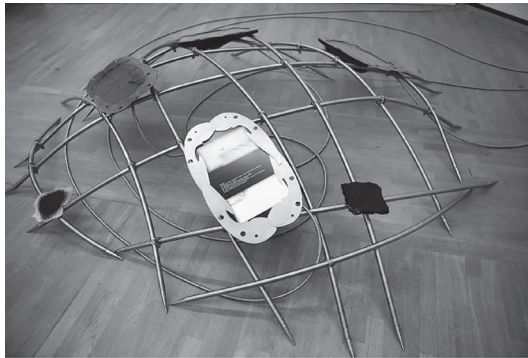
21 Yuk Hui, *Archives of the Future: Remarks on the Concept of Tertiary Protention*. Inscription. editor / Karl-Magnus Johansson. Göteborg: Riksarkivet Landsarkivet i Göteborg, 2018. pp. 129-155 (Arkiv i Väst; 20).

## Slow and Invisible

Slowness could also be used as a weapon. Rob Nixon refers to damaging processes that have been kept out of sight by assigning them to other scales as "slow violence."<sup>22</sup> The damage is done to environments, humans, and communities, but it is "of indifferent interest to the sensation-driven technologies of our image-world," which require that events be concentrated in space and time to become visible as such. Slow violence is not accidental; it is the result of weaponized scalar difference.

In 2023, I worked on the video installation *Sensing the Near Real Time for the Henie Onstad Triennale New Visions*, where I explored the intersections between human, technological, and geological timescales, as well as the role of remote sensing in planetary observation. One of the images featured in the work was generated by a researcher using InSAR imagery to examine how the ground around the Zaporizhzhia nuclear power plant shifted over the course of a year during Russian occupation. In this case, the InSAR image captured a one-year displacement of the ground.

If previously mentioned SAR imagery is technology that uses micro, super-fast time to "capture," InSAR imagery could represent many years as a single image.



*Sensing The Near Real Time*, Digital screens, stainless steel, simulated nuclear waste glass, soil.  
Installation photography: Øystein Thorvaldsen/Henie Onstad Kunstsenter

InSAR (Interferometric Synthetic Aperture Radar) is a remote sensing technology that measures and maps ground surface changes. Techniques like InSAR analyze the phase differences between radar signals captured at different times to detect minute changes in the Earth's surface. In InSAR, time becomes a medium for understanding dynamic processes, a medium of change detection over temporal scales, revealing temporal

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22 Rob Nixon, *Slow Violence and the Environmentalism of the Poor*. Harvard University Press, 2011.

changes in the environment. In InSAR, time is not just a measure—it is the essence of how space, movement, and change are represented and understood.

On March 4, 2022 Russian forces attacked the Zaporizhzhia Nuclear Power Plant, Europe's largest nuclear facility.<sup>23</sup> This act of nuclear terrorism led to a fire at the plant. CCTV footage from the territory of the plant was widely live streamed, where viewers were watching the unfolding attack and speculating on potential consequences. Authorities have warned that the disaster could equal 10 Chernobyls.<sup>24</sup> Chernobyl as a historical event becomes a unit for measuring the scale of a future event.

As Svitlana Matviyenko noted, the apocalyptic future temporality permanently invades the present.<sup>25</sup> This future temporality of a possible nuclear catastrophe at the Zaporizhzhia nuclear plant is part of every single image of the plant from the moment Russians occupied it. The temporality of this future disaster is so far-reaching for human imagination that the time measurement of this scale sometimes is not enough.



*FA satellite image of the bottom of Kakhovka reservoir, now covered with newly grown willow forests. I have obtained this image with the Sentinel-2 L2A satellite's imager, which detects light reflected by vegetation.*

We live in constant fear of disasters, a temporality beyond human comprehension. For example, the consequences<sup>26</sup> of the destruction of the Kakhovka dam have been

23 Al Jazeera. "Russia-Ukraine War: Fire at Zaporizhzhia Nuclear Plant Put Out." Al Jazeera, March 4, 2022. <https://www.aljazeera.com/news/2022/3/4/russia-ukraine-war-fire-at-zaporizhzhia-nuclear-plant-put-out>

24 Josh Marcus, "Ukraine Warns of Disaster '10 Times Larger Than Chernobyl' as Biggest Nuclear Plant 'Under Heavy Weapons Fire'." The Independent, March 4, 2022. <https://www.independent.co.uk/news/world/russia-ukraine-nuclear-plant-zaporizhzhia-b2028294.html>

25 Svitlana Matviyenko, et al. E-Flux Journal #126. e-flux, 2022.

26 University of Birmingham. "Nova Kakhovka Destruction – Should 'Ecocide' Become a Recognised War-Crime?" University of Birmingham News, June 16, 2023. <https://www.birmingham.ac.uk/>

described in the media as "an ecocide that will have far-reaching impacts into the future," where "parts of nature are lost forever."<sup>27</sup> Today, natural resources and ecosystems are being deliberately destroyed, resulting in enduring environmental damage that affects communities for generations. And this unperceivable on its scale to humans, longer than human trauma becomes a weapon by itself.

In "Pollution as a Weapon of War," Svitlana Matviyenko examines the layered impacts of war on ecosystems, focusing on both immediate and gradual forms of destruction.<sup>28</sup> She highlights the severe damage to soil fertility and the presence of undetonated shells, which create long-term ecological risks and contribute to the "complex temporality of ecocidal trauma." Drawing on the concept of "slow violence" by Thom Davies and Achille Mbembe's "necropolitics," Matviyenko situates pollution as a tool of war that operates at multiple speeds. While fast violence from explosions and toxic releases is immediate and visible, slow violence unfolds "gradually and out of sight," such as soil contamination and the long-term poisoning of environments. Multiple speeds and forms of violence shape the chaotic and incomprehensible reality of war, producing what Mbembe calls "death-worlds," where populations endure terrible conditions that reduce life to a state of mere survival. Svitlana Matviyenko writes:

Paradoxically, extreme cases of fast violence in war may also be made 'invisible,' but by their overwhelming number and their capacity to produce shock and trauma: witnesses of war and war crimes often report that their memories collapse days of violence into one undifferentiated continuity. Together, cases of fast and slow violence compose the chaotic reality of war, whose production of necropolitical 'death-worlds' does not lend itself to easy comprehension.

## Memory, Anticipation, and Coexistence

The synchronization of the technological mediation of scales and rhythms coexisting with us on the planet is a large part of what is forming a Chronosphere today. The Chronosphere can be envisioned as another accelerating envelope of our planet—a sphere of life where human and more-than-human temporalities play a role in shaping both our perception and the physical reality of Earth. It encompasses past histories already written, premeditated futures imagined through images or statistics, and the immeasurable legacies of colonial struggle, and environmental violence.

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news/2023/nova-kakhovka-destruction-should-ecocide-become-a-recognised-war-crime

27 Schauenberg, Tim. "Ukraine: Destroyed Kakhovka Dam Amounts to 'Ecocide'." Deutsche Welle (DW), June 7, 2023. <https://www.dw.com/en/ukraine-destroyed-kakhovka-dam-amounts-to-ecocide/a-65849713>

28 Svitlana Matviyenko. "Pollution as a Weapon of War." L'Internationale Online, June 8, 2023. [https://archive-2014-2024.internationaleonline.org/opinions/1100\\_pollution\\_as\\_a\\_weapon\\_of\\_war/](https://archive-2014-2024.internationaleonline.org/opinions/1100_pollution_as_a_weapon_of_war/)



Within this sphere, politics, cultures, nature and artificial intelligence; the interwoven rhythms of existence are interconnected in time, reflecting the complex interplay of durationalities and temporal forces shaping our world. In this planetary setting times become equal protagonists of our story.<sup>29</sup>

The agency of time as an infrastructure is distributed across human and non-human actors, blurring boundaries between the organic and the synthetic. AI systems, weather patterns, financial markets, and even microbial ecologies become active participants in the Chronosphere, influencing its rhythms and responding to its flux. This distributed agency raises critical questions: Who decides the rhythm of our collective existence? How do we ensure equity in a system where temporalities are unevenly distributed and mediated by power structures?

As we try to continue to map and navigate the Chronosphere, we are challenged to rethink our relationship with time—not as a linear stream we pass through, but as a multidimensional envelope we inhabit and influence. The Chronosphere, existing both as a speculative framework and a tangible reality, invites us to view time as a collective and dynamic environment shaped by the choices we make in crafting the world we share.

**Lesia Vasylchenko** is a Ukrainian artist currently based in Norway. She works across a range of media, including video, photography, installation, and curatorial. Vasylchenko explores encounters between visual cultures, media technologies, and chronopolitics. She is the founder of *STRUKTURA.Time*, a cross-disciplinary initiative for research and practice within the framework of visual arts, media archaeology, literature, and philosophy. She holds degrees in Journalism from Taras Shevchenko National University of Kyiv and in Fine Arts from the Oslo National Academy of the Arts. Vasylchenko is the recipient of the Sandefjord Kunstforening Art Prize (2023) and is currently nominated for the PinchukArtCentre Prize (2025). Her work is part of the collection of the Museum of Contemporary Art KIASMA / Finnish National Gallery in Helsinki.

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29 "How do the conditions of contemporary planetary crisis shape the genres of temporal experience that make up the present? What happens when the "background" to our world-building—the temporalities we took for granted—assert themselves as protagonists, as they do in the Anthropocene?" - Zhang, Gary Zhexi. *Catastrophe Time! Strange Attractor*, 2023, <https://public.ebookcentral.proquest.com/choice/PublicFullRecord.aspx?p=30269329>.

# WITNESSING: UKRAiNATV'S ANTHOLOGIES AND HOW TO NOT (JUST) WATCH

GIULIA TIMIS

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## Bridge 1

Beginnings are always difficult, and endings don't really exist. It's even more difficult to try and put my involvement with the Poland-based collective UKRAiNATV into words, which happened at a very specific time of my life - and the lives of many others. My experience there forced me to deeply reflect on what it means to be an indirect witness, a collector of stories, and how to try and be a transmitter of those. This text is also an attempt to draw up a theory of the collective itself, through the lenses of Susan Sontag's investigation of photographic evidence and Gerda Taro's life of resistance. It also contains examples of independent media, like Radio B92, and records of all the people I interviewed in Poland while drafting my thesis.<sup>1</sup>

In 2024 we are witnessing a series of crimes against humanity, on a scale and intensity sadly traceable to something we thought buried in history, a bad memory that would serve as a warning to future generations. Cultural practices are no strangers to these happenings, they are active representatives of geopolitical phenomena (Russia's exclusion from the Venice Biennale in 2022<sup>2</sup>). The war perpetrated by Russia, which had the worst of consequences on February 24, 2022, with the full-scale invasion of Ukrainian territories, kicked off a series of horrors that still resonate in news channels today.

In September 2023, I moved to Amsterdam from Italy, where I have now spent 10 months adjusting to the climate, taking vitamin D supplements, and improving my waterproof wardrobe. Surprisingly, the transition itself felt smooth and seamless. After nearly a year of working with UKRAiNATV - an art collective based in Kraków that experiments with live audiovisual connections - I started my collaboration with the Institute of Network Cultures.

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1 "UKRAiNATV e la Streamart: Esempi di Artivismo, Giornalismo d'inchiesta e Sperimentazione Artistica", written during my stay in Amsterdam for the *Net Art Master at Brera Academy of Fine Arts in Milan*, Italy.

2 Casey, Ruairi, "At Venice Biennale, Ukrainian artists defy Russia's invasion." *Al Jazeera*, 22 Apr 2022, <https://www.aljazeera.com/news/2022/4/22/venice-biennale-ukrainian-artists-russia-invasion>.

UKRAiNATV started their activities in March 2022, expanding its reach to other similar communities as early as November 2022. That same month, Geert Lovink visited the studio. Since then, our main goal has been to expand a shared network between UKRAiNATV and INC. By working together, we found it easier and far more effective to raise funds in support of our allied partners operating in Ukraine, who have struggled to maintain a working studio since the beginning of the full-scale invasion. This network we've been working to establish and nurture over the past year and a half has now taken its shape, with 4 stable nodes: Kraków, Amsterdam, Budapest, and Kyiv. Here in Amsterdam, I started collaborating with THE VOID, an INC research project on tactical video and an audiovisual publishing venue for practice-based research. This place has become my "*home base*," and it's where I want to start sharing the research that has absorbed me over the past year and a half.

In June 2024, while UKRAiNATV was taking part in the Sonar festival (Barcelona), I joined them from Amsterdam in an online roundtable together with Tommaso Campagna and Geert Lovink. The participants also included János Sugár from the *Hungarian University of Fine Arts* (Budapest), Alyona Ivanova and Vlad Kononok, representing their collective RE: Frame.TV (Kyiv), and Gleb Dovzuk from UKRAiNATV's studio (Kraków). This meeting underscored the importance of our network's connections once again. The presence of all the participants, even if online, strengthened the acknowledgment that no one is alone.

Same year but in May, during THE VOID – Tactical Video #3, an online call with Ukraine was disrupted due to issues with the electric generators in their studio. The situation in Kyiv has in fact worsened, with citywide power outages leaving residents about 4 hours of electricity daily. Given the urgent need for immediate support actions and the archival efforts of our colleagues in Kyiv - particularly in documenting system failures - I increasingly recognized the importance of maintaining an independent, on-the-ground network of connections. *This* network, centered on immediate sharing and filtered through the communications happening within each circle, is crucial for establishing a more diverse framework, in an era marked by the growing polarization of information sources.

Though the timeline has been a bit jumpy, I need to return to the beginning of the story. From September 2022 to June 2023, I had the opportunity to participate in a nine-month cultural exchange program in Kraków, Poland. During my studies at the Academy of Fine Arts (ASP), I met the activist art collective UKRAiNATV, which in conjunction with the outbreak of war in Ukraine, began mobilizing in support of Ukrainian refugees crossing the border. In the months following - February and March - the basement of Kraków Główny was filled with displaced people: women and children mainly, crammed into the station, sleeping on a floor of makeshift beds.



*Figure 1: Ukrainian refugees gather at the main train station after fleeing the Russian invasion of Ukraine, in Kraków, Poland, 14 March, 2022. Picture published on Reuters by Fabrizio Bensch.*

A similar image could be seen in Warsaw.<sup>3</sup> Hearing firsthand testimonies of those who had to flee because of war allowed me to change my understanding of an emergency — from witnessing it from afar, to being close to it. Geographical proximity soon turned into emotional closeness. This newfound empathy allowed me to take an interest in historical events that did not belong to me as if they did. I was turned into a more active participant in the consequences of a war that is continuing even now, 2,393.0 km away from where I was living at that time, in Italy. UKRAiNATV activities began shortly after, and initially focused on raising funds and collecting aid, as an immediate support for Ukrainian refugees arriving in Poland. By organizing events - often in synergy with local artists - and posting them as live streams on their channels, they started to create a support network. The studio was situated in the Intermedia Department of Kraków's Academy of Fine Arts. Perhaps this network of support—of which I was not necessarily the primary recipient—saved me when I arrived in Kraków as an Erasmus student, trying to escape my own reality, though certainly not a war.

At first, I needed a place where I could use the Virtual Reality setup for an event organized for the *Digital Week* in Milan. Some colleagues and I in Italy were working on a VR environment, and since it was going to be exhibited during the festival days, I was looking for a studio to arrange the virtual connection. Ultimately, I ended up being in the UKRAiNATV studio most of my time, taking care of the virtual space design, and creating environments that could be inhabited during special events and weekly streams. This gravitational pull captured me. I had been searching for a place like that for a long time: a collective of people involved in art, politics, tea ceremonies, raves, and events. I was not even speaking the language,

3 Sullivan, Becky, "The number of Ukrainians who've fled to Poland is equal to the population of Warsaw." *NPR*, 16 March 2022, <https://www.npr.org/2022/03/16/1086687862/ukraine-refugees-warsaw>.

so I certainly didn't expect to be quickly absorbed into that strange and somewhat crazy melting pot. And I certainly didn't expect to deal with war, or war stories, which the people walking into the space carried with them.

After almost two years of Russian colonial warfare, UKRAiNATV presents itself as a web-tv platform that operates offline and online (on a conglomerate of platforms such as Twitch, YouTube, Facebook, etc.). Once a week, on Thursdays at 6 p.m., it streams a couple of hours of live performances, videos, interviews and DJ sets - giving a stage and a bullhorn to a series of guests visiting the studio. Each episode is categorized under the name #EFIR.<sup>4</sup> The headquarters are at the 23rd of Berka Joselewicza, in the Intermedia Department of the Academy of Fine Arts in Krakow.

From the outset, the space itself offers a unique environment where the collective provides a place for newcomers. Since November 2022, the group has been working to expand its network. Through collaborations with various institutions and research centers, it has raised funds and supported artistic research groups in Ukraine, all while maintaining a focus on a war that shows no signs of ending soon. In a short time, the collective identity has become increasingly defined, starting with a *Manifesto*, and progressing through the exploration of the *streamart*. This practice is here described as a set of *hyperactivities* engaging with both the digital and physical domains. By blending people and machines, hardware and software, infrastructures, and performances, a new aesthetic emerges. *Streamart* represents the dynamic and continuous flow of energy in hybrid spaces and times, encapsulating the entanglement of human and non-human entities. In this context, the virtual is seen in its potential form, while keeping grounded in the coziness of the studio.

## Bridge 2

The concept of the streamart was a central theme in the thesis I was writing for my studies in Italy (*UKRAiNATV e la Streamart: Esempi di Artivismo, Giornalismo D'inchiesta e Sperimentazione Artistica*<sup>5</sup>), evolving from early *telematic performance*<sup>6</sup> to contemporary streamer culture. But I also wanted to understand the link between the collective's practices and the political significance of its activities. During my research months, I discovered Radio B92, a powerful example of independent radio resisting under an oppressive regime. This renowned activist institution has made a significant impact on the Serbian media landscape, highlighting the importance of independent journalism

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- 4 Efir, transl. ether, it stands for the medium in which these episodes circulate, the air, and symbolizes the lightness that characterizes the group. The word ether or efir was borrowed from Greek into Old East Slavic.
  - 5 Translation: *UKRAiNATV and the Streamart: Examples of Artivism, Investigative Journalism and Experimental Arts*.
  - 6 Michael Rofo, Erik Geelhoed, and Laura Hodsdon. "Experiencing Online Orchestra: Communities, Connections and Music-Making through Telematic Performance." *Journal of Music, Technology & Education*, vol. 10, no. 2-3, Sept. 2017, pp. 257–275, [https://doi.org/10.1386/jmte.10.2-3.257\\_1](https://doi.org/10.1386/jmte.10.2-3.257_1).

during wartime. Founded in 1989 in Belgrade, it became a beacon of free expression and independent journalism during the years of the Balkan war and the fall of the Milošević regime. The station provided a platform for diverse and often dissident voices, broadcasting alternative music and real-time news that defied government censorship. Its history was marked by an extraordinary commitment to press freedom and civic activism, becoming a symbol of resistance and hope for Serbia and the international community.



*Figure 2: Manuela Nikolić Peršon, passed away in 2011 at the age of 47 in Sweden, Zoran Mamula, died at the age of 37 in 2001, Dušan Mašić died at the age of 56 in 2022. The photo also features sound engineer Petar Savić and Nenad Zafirović.*

During the war years, Radio B92 was one of the few sources of independent information, broadcasting unbiased news that was often at odds with state media propaganda. The station also maintained critical coverage of the facts, offering a different perspective and encouraging dialogue between the parties.

Because of the Milošević regime's censorship, the station suffered the blocking of its signal. However, it managed to broadcast via satellite from abroad, thus continuing to reach Serbian audiences and the ranks of the resistance. In addition to broadcasting information, Radio B92 also played a key role in introducing alternative music and underground culture to Serbia. It promoted local and international artists, providing a platform for creative expression outside the limits imposed by the regime. Matthew Collin, the author of *"This is Serbia Calling"*, writes:<sup>7</sup>

*"By the time I got there, ten days after it all kicked off, there was about half a million people in the streets demonstrating against the theft of election results by the government of Slobodan Milosevic. But there was another element to it; it wasn't just a political demonstration, students marching on the streets, just civic unrest, it had another 'cultural' element to*

7 Variant, no. 22, Spring 2005, ISSN 0954-8815. Variant is an independent magazine that addresses issues of culture in the sociopolitical context of various countries, and a nonprofit association funded through subscriptions from magazine subscribers.

*it—music, film, art were all important to this. There were a lot of ways that messages were being transmitted, not just through your classic placard that you see on every demonstration, but in a really creative way, and this is what inspired me to get involved.”<sup>8</sup>*

What Collin emphasizes here, is the way activism and counterculture spontaneously worked synergistically to raise their voices against a regime that was oppressing them. These two worlds have often worked in sync, though not always with positive outcomes. However, history records several instances where underground cultural entities have facilitated social and cultural revolutions, such as Pirate Radio in the UK during the 1960s. Collin, in the same article of *Variant* № 22, continues:

*"Those demonstrations failed, as we all know, and some people argue that just being out on the streets in numbers and just creating a cultural alternative is not enough, that you actually need more power than that to get your message across. It took another four years for the ultimate goal of this protest movement to be realized, which was the overthrow of Milosevic, but it was a beginning."*

I now had the historical reference I was looking for in order to better understand the political dimension of the Kraków based collective, together with the independent media scene, especially in the context of war and repressive regimes. Yet, I still had questions about how to represent that pain on screen: what about some of the interviews I had recorded in the studio? Or, for instance, the very use of visual elements to archive those collective memories?

### Bridge 3

Wanting more, I looked carefully into others' work and research, finally coming across two of Susan Sontag's main writings: *On Photography* (1977) and *Regarding the Pain of Others* (2003). Sontag analyzes how photographic images change our perception and understanding of the world, highlighting their potential both as a vehicle of knowledge and as a tool for manipulating reality. The book focuses on the idea that photography can be considered a form of critical documentation, as it captures snapshots of life, thus revealing a hidden side of the world.

In *Regarding the Pain of Others*, Sontag delves deeper into the portrayal of pain and suffering in media and art. The numerous images of conflicts featured in her book, particularly those from wars contemporary to her, such as the one in Kosovo, serve as crucial evidence of recent horrific events and potential future trials for human rights violations. While photographic documentation holds significant value as a political and commemorative object, Sontag opens the floor for a reflection on its controversial aspects.

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8 Collin, Matthew, "Don't trust anyone, not even us", pag. 9 of *Variant* №22, Spring 2005, <https://www.variant.org.uk/pdfs/issue22/B92.pdf>.

Today more than ever, the widespread dissemination of war images via TV and social media highlights these controversial aspects vividly. From the Russian invasion of Ukraine to the ongoing genocide in Gaza, photography and video serve as an important visual testimony to civil suffering and human rights violations. They become the visual testimony of war's chaos. Photographers working in high-conflict zones face complex ethical dilemmas, trying to balance the desire to document reality with the awareness not to turn human suffering into a sensationalist spectacle.

Another point Sontag discusses is how easily a picture can be manipulated or repurposed. The improper use of visual documentation is a crucial aspect of the dissemination of news in real-time. In her book, Sontag gives the example of a photograph showing the bodies of murdered children. This same image was then used by the opposing side, to motivate soldiers for the fight, instrumentalizing the sight of slaughtered child bodies for their own cause. One could draw a modern parallel to the destruction of the Al-Ahli Baptist Hospital in Gaza on the evening of October 17, 2023.

Although more than fifty years have passed since the events recounted by Sontag, and technology has advanced in no small measure as the amount of evidence gathered at any moment, we still struggle to establish the truth about who was the architect of this massacre. A myriad of videos and images open the same questions as a photograph taken during the Yugoslav wars. Or at least, this is still the main argument major media press and political representatives use when asked about the events. Evidence is not enough, and even if it was, would it justify the atrocities occurring before our eyes?

## Bridge 4

After finishing Sontag's *Regarding the Pain of Others*, I found myself reading Helena Janeczek's *"The Girl with the Leica"* (2017), which was sitting in the upper corner of my library for more than I could remember. These serendipitous moments often occur when collecting articles and books for research. Assuming the woman winking on the cover of Janeczek's book was a photographer, I connected the two. As I read further, this seemingly minor link became a fortunate coincidence.

Gerda Taro, born Gerda Pohorylle, was a photographer and pioneer of photojournalism during the Spanish Civil War. Of Jewish descent, she worked closely with Hungarian-born photographer Robert Capa, and together they documented the horrors of the war and the devastating impact of the conflict on the civilian population. Helena Janeczek's *"The Girl with the Leica"* rescues Taro from the shadow of oblivion cast by her illustrious partner, Robert Capa. Taro's dedication to capturing the grotesque and tragic aspects of war serves as a testament to her unwavering resolve. Positioned on the front lines, her lens became a witnessing tool, confronting the gender biases of her epoch. Janeczek's narrative peels back layers of Taro's existence, revealing a life interwoven with courage and a relentless pursuit of authenticity. The account also resonates with the vibrant and affirmative essence of Gerda, as



echoed by the voices of those who fought alongside her.

Janeczek's book exists in between a novel and an investigative biography. As a journalist herself, she reconstructs the everyday life and almost romantic facets of Gerda's existence. This intimate portrayal, however, does not diminish its validity; the subjective narrative enhances rather than undermines the cultural significance of Taro's story. What impressed me the most about her, is well explained by Sebastiaan Faber, as "(...) a complex, multivocal historical novel that is less a portrait of Gerda Taro than of her entire milieu: young, antifascist, bohemian, refugee, free-thinking, emancipated, and rife with short-lived romantic entanglements."<sup>9</sup> In my reading of Janeczek's book I still find striking the vital force that Gerda embeds. She sticks anti-Nazi leaflets on the streets of Berlin on a moped with headlights off, and at the same time, she populates Paris' intellectual cafes in cute dresses, giving coquette bottles of perfume to her adoring lovers. She decides to go to the front to document the Spanish Civil War, and simultaneously takes photographs of soldiers playing with birds. She documents women training to fight on the bank of a river, and this whole set of features comes across as dissonant, almost scandalous.



Figure 3: Gerda Taro, Republic militiawomen training on the beach outside Barcelona, August 1936.

Clearly, the actions of a young, spoiled girl, ready to throw her life away for a bit of action. This thought comes up because what we see here is very different from what we want to see. Horrors are louder when they're outside the camera viewfinder's field. What we can see, it's how it should be. And, nonetheless, Gerda Taro photographed the horrors too. But it's her zest for life, juxtaposed with her premature death, that deeply inspired me. With her very existence, she juxtaposes the sacred with the profane, not giving up on leisure even during war. These elements, which at first seem dissonant, reveal their necessity when one is entrenched in conflict. This method of blending seemingly disparate elements produces a shift in the usual narrative. In UKRAiNATV's events, colorful visuals and psychedelic DJ sets are intertwined with topics of war. This approach captures attention - an incidental effect - and, more importantly,

9 Faber, Sebastiaan, "Gerda Taro's Elusive Afterlives: Helena Janeczek's 'The Girl with the Leica,'" Translated from Italian by Ann Goldstein." Reading in Translation, 31 Jan. 2022, <https://readingintranslation.com/2022/01/31/helena-janeczeks-the-girl-with-the-leica/>.

induces a form of catharsis. By making the grim subject (war) more accessible and impactful through unexpected forms, barriers to emotional expression dissolve. There is no judgment; the physical proximity allows everyone involved to express their emotions freely, however they feel is right. This stance is radical: we are doing this for ourselves, to find some solace in a horrific situation. We deny anyone the right to dictate how we should feel (e.g., *If you feel sad, show sadness*). We don't adhere to restrictive norms that seek to simplify and regulate our complex emotional responses.

On the day that marks the second year of colonial war in Ukraine, we organized a 24-hour event in our studio, where musicians, performers, and artists were invited to play, hold each other, squeeze, have fun, talk, hug. I always wondered if this way of operating wasn't indelicate for those who cope with their grief in different ways. However, the people around me were the same whose friends and family living in Ukraine, some of them on the frontlines; or they were political refugees from countries aligned with Russia (Belarus primarily). For them, it seemed to work.

Gerda Taro died in a tragic accident while covering the Spanish Civil War on July 26, 1937, at the age of 26. While documenting the Battle of Brunete, she was run over by the tracks of a friendly tank. On her 27th birthday, August 1st, 1937, a state funeral was held in her honor in Paris, where she and Capa had lived and worked for many years. Her funeral drew a large crowd of friends, fellow photographers, and anti-fascist supporters. Her untimely death deeply moved the international community, which initially elevated her as a martyr in the fight against fascism, though she was soon mostly forgotten. Her work and legacy have been recovered over time, thanks in part to the discovery of a briefcase containing a series of negatives taken by Gerda herself, which have made it possible to give motherhood to the photographs produced simultaneously with Robert Capa, and which have often been wrongfully attributed to him, with whom she worked closely. In an interview held during *Festival Letteratura di Mantova*, Helena Janeczek says:

*"After discovering her, in Milan, in the first monographic exhibition dedicated to her, I got an excellent biography (...) and made contact with the author, Irme Schaber, who also devoted herself to the reconstruction of the photographic corpus. In fact, Capa's and Gerda's photos were mixed up; it was a very long job to succeed in restoring the correct attributions, an effort that, with the discovery of the so-called 'Mexican Suitcase' containing a large part of the negatives taken by Gerda Taro with the Leica, took a great leap forward. (...) I was clear from the beginning that I did not want to write the classic biographical novel about Gerda, to tell only the story of Robert Capa's girlfriend and the heroic photojournalist who died in Spain in 1937. I wanted to tell it through the eyes of others."*<sup>10</sup>

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10 Ghioni Gloria, "Helena Janeczek, che racconta Gerda Taro: La letteratura non deve perdere la sua autonomia." *illibraio.it*, 6 Sep, 2017, <https://www.illibraio.it/news/dautore/intervista-helena-janeczek-gerda-taro-586452/>.



Figure 4: A photo by Gerda Taro, one of her last shots, Brunete, July 1937.

Her contribution to international photojournalism was later recognized as fundamental to the historical understanding of the Spanish Civil War and the role of women as photojournalists. Although her life was tragically cut short, the impact she had in the field of war photography continues to inspire.

*If the lure of photography is the promise of unvarnished documentary truth—a chemical imprint of reality as it is at the moment the shutter release is pressed—photographers and their editors have always known that this promise is deceptive. Precisely because they capture the details of a singular moment, photographs call attention to what they leave out: everything that precedes and follows that one moment—and everything that’s outside the frame.*

In giving shape to this discourse, I must go back to Sontag, specifically to her theater adaptation of Beckett’s “Waiting for Godot.” She describes her experience in “Waiting For Godot In Sarajevo,” published by the *Performing Arts Journal, Inc.*

*“I went to Sarajevo in mid-July 1993 to stage a production of “Waiting for Godot” not so much because I’d always wanted to direct Beckett’s play (although I had), as because it gave me a practical reason to return to Sarajevo and stay for a month or more. I had spent two weeks there in April, and had come to care intensely about the battered city and what it stands for; some of its citizens had become friends. But I couldn’t again be just a witness: that is, meet and visit, tremble with fear, feel brave, feel depressed, have heartbreaking conversations, grow ever more indignant, lose weight. If I went back, it would be to pitch in and do something.”*

In these lines, I discovered more of the common thread I began to unravel while linking everything to UKRAiNATV’s activities. Sontag’s words convey the frustration often felt by those who document events and the lives of people they care about yet feel powerless to influence the course of history. The practical reason Sontag mentions here is rooted in her experience with theater. It seems counterintuitive to suddenly relocate to a besieged city to direct a theatre play, while most of the population is living in fear and scarcity. But Sontag and a group of local artists decided to get culturally involved, while the city was

burning. The idea of responding to violence with art, the most abstract and seemingly useless expression of man's activities, has something unique in my eyes. We do not feed on bread alone, and especially in the darkest of circumstances, it is not just material help that saves us. Another point Sontag addresses in her writing is a question she frequently received about her choice to perform that specific play: *"(...) was it not depressing for the Sarajevo audience; in the sense that it was not pretentious or insensitive to stage Godot there?"* She reflects on how outsiders, asking these questions, completely misunderstood the experiences of those living in Sarajevo at that time. She continues:

"To respond to journalists' attentions, when one would rather be doing something else, is inevitably to find oneself saying things, or be reported as saying things, that seem inane or simple-minded. (The questions that provoked these state-ments are invariably left out.)

-Why did you come?

-To express my solidarity with the people of Sarajevo.

-What are you trying to accomplish?

-Make a small contribution to cultural life here.

-Why Waitingfor Godot?

-Because it's a great play. And it resonates here.

-Isn't it a metaphor? I know you've written about metaphor.

-No, it's not a metaphor.

-Well, then, what's the message of Waitingfor Godot?

-There is no message.

-Well, what is your message in doing Godot?

-I don't have a message.

-[Same question, repeated more emphatically.]

-That it's possible to come here. That other people should come and work here.

-Weren't you afraid to come?

- Anyone who isn't afraid is crazy.
- Why don't you wear your flak jacket?
- Nobody who lives here has a flak jacket. I think it would be indecent for me to wear mine.
- Aren't you afraid?
- [Sigh.]
- Is this a political act?
- I think of it as an act of conscience.
- But you do have political opinions.
- Who doesn't?
- Are you for intervention?
- Absolutely.
- Why do you think other people like you don't come?
- [Various diffident or testy answers.]  
And so on."<sup>11</sup>

Sontag's words resonated with me deeply: her portrayal of Sarajevo closely mirrors what I observed while collaborating with people from Ukraine, regarding life during war. I feel a strong connection to those who strive to keep the cultural scene alive during these tragic times. The experiences of those living with the constant threat of bomb scare for the past two years, echoes the suffering of victims of indiscriminate attacks long ago. It's an act of solidarity with those who are still resisting every day.

I'm writing this down, and from the belief that cultural practices can help us establish horizontal alliances, based on the equality of the participants; and to develop a bond of empathy with those around us. Perhaps I can describe the sense of closeness I've developed with some of the people I met in the studio through a personal anecdote:

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11 Sontag, Susan. "Waiting for Godot in Sarajevo." *Performing Arts Journal*, vol. 16, no. 2, 1994, pp. 87–106. JSTOR, <https://doi.org/10.2307/3245764>. Accessed 24 Jan. 2026.

The process of preparing for an EFIR, where most people involved were not aware of the specifics of such a production or what roles everyone was responsible for, was projecting us into a moment of performative existence, which stayed along even once the 'play' was over. It felt like we were speaking the same language for a moment, working together on a common goal that required complete trust between all participants. Like a psychedelic trip - that maintains its clarity in our imagination for a long time after the end of its effects - we were reborn in a new ensemble, where that special reality we shared in the studio, still existed. When going outside for a celebratory cigarette, the conversation flowed much more seamlessly. It felt like we were sharing a secret; as if we just stole some apples, and now we were taking our breath after a rocambolesque run. Our eyes sparkled in the semi-darkness of a dusty barn, and we were happy. Up-to-no-good connection. There is now an unbreakable oath between us.

Sontag's visit to Sarajevo had a profound impact on her, which she later documented in a series of essays. Her engagement and observations of the conflict contributed to a broader discourse on the responsibility of media and individuals in the face of suffering. Her work remains influential in discussions about the ethics of war representation and the impact of images on our understanding of global events.



*Figure 5: The cast of the Sarajevo production of Waiting for Godot. Seated: Ines Fancovic, Sead ('Sejo') Bejtovic, Mirza Halilovic, Nada Djurevska, Izudin ('Izo') Bajrovic, Susan Sontag. Standing: Milijana Zirojevic, Velibor Topic, Admir ('Atko') Glamocak, Irena Mulamuhic. In the lobby of the Youth Theater, Sarajevo, late July 1993. Picture by Annie Leibovitz.*

## Bridge 5

Taro employs photography as a means of resistance, while Sontag expresses herself through writing and directing plays. Inspired by their practices, I sought to develop my own. From April 2023 to February 2024, I conducted an interview project. I spoke with 40 individuals about the events of February 24, 2022, the day the war in Ukraine broke out. The idea came to my mind during the event we organized in UKRAiNATV's studios to come together after 1 year of war in Ukraine. While smoking a cigarette in the courtyard, someone asked me: "*Do you remember what you did that day?*" I had no idea. So, I decided to ask around. The research involved 4 focus groups: Poles, Ukrainians, Belarusians, and expats. The interviews are in English, both because it was the easiest way for me to communicate, and to ensure their accessibility to a wider audience later. Just one is entirely

in Ukrainian. The project aimed to reflect the complexity and diversity of conflict-related experiences, thereby broadening the listener's perspective. The initial idea stemmed from a desire to pursue research in the context of the war in Ukraine, using as a starting point my perception of the war, and how it changed during the time I lived in Poland (much closer to Ukrainian borders and culture than Italy). My starting argument was that, given the geographical proximity and the presence of a community of political refugees and displaced people from neighboring former Soviet countries, my understanding of the war in Ukraine changed at a higher speed.

Through several conversations with Erasmus students my age, but from very different geopolitical backgrounds—Germany, Lithuania, Czech Republic, and so on—I started to realize more strongly how true it is that information, which we often consider objective, is inevitably mediated by the news channels of different countries. I was interested in understanding why certain positions were so strong, such as those concerning the provision of humanitarian aid to Ukraine by individuals with no direct involvement in the situation, yet expressing strongly held viewpoints on the matter. To give a more concrete form to these reflections, I decided to draw up a form to be submitted to a sample of 40 respondents, from the 4 macro-groups mentioned above: Poland, Belarus, Ukraine, and expats.

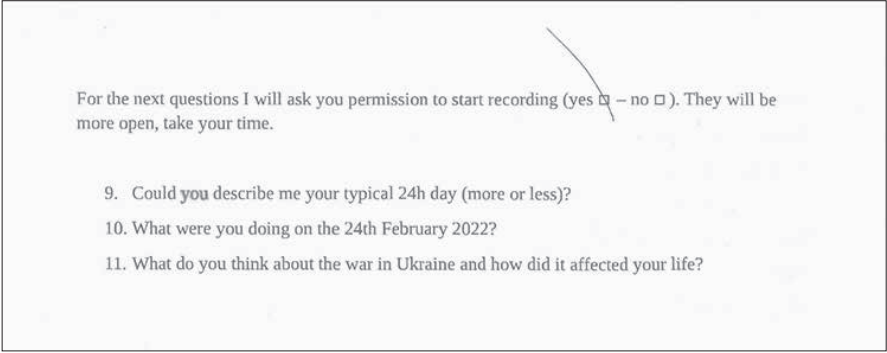
Several trends emerged during the interviews, which were conducted in one-on-one meetings, generally in quiet places, allowing a private conversation. It should be noted that the interviewees were not aware of the main topic, which was whether they remembered February 24th, 2022, the day of Russia's full-scale invasion of Ukraine. This was disclosed only in the second part of the conversation. The reason for this choice was to prevent the subjects from manipulating their answers according to the topic, somehow undermining the spontaneity of the interview. I knew this decision could be ethically contentious, and some people might find it troubling. Fortunately, those potentially more sensitive to the topic (Ukrainians, Belarusians) did not express discomfort when posed with the question; instead, they emphasized the importance of discussing it. Conversely, groups less closely connected to the subject matter (Expats, Poles) encountered greater challenges with their responses. This could be attributed to either a lack of clear recollection, leading to a perceived manipulation of memories by participants, or because the question itself stirred discomfort.

This is not a sociological or scientific study, there is no basis for conducting it; my intentions during this research were mainly three: to outline a trend, provoke reflection, and create an archive of memories. The first objective addresses a primarily personal need: to engage with diverse individuals and understand the potential points of agreement and disagreement.

Each interview consisted of two distinct parts, ensuring a comprehensive and articulate view of the interviewees' experiences. The first part, a detailed and related image form, provides an in-depth analysis of the interviewee's habits and personal characteristics.

Participation in the project is done consciously, with each respondent initially deciding whether to consent to the disclosure of their data, specifying which aspects (audio, video, bio, etc.) could be disclosed. I decided at a second stage to remove the Country of origin so that the viewer would not come to hasty conclusions based only on it. My thesis with this first part was to place the viewer in front of a series of very different biographical records in which to, nevertheless, mirror themselves. The curiosity in knowing the most personal details of a stranger (*What is your favorite place here? How often do you see your family/friends?*) has always had something fascinating in my eyes, and I thought it might prepare the viewer for the second phase of the interview.

The second part of the form involves a spoken interview, broken down into three key questions:



For the next questions I will ask you permission to start recording (yes ☒ – no ☐). They will be more open, take your time.

9. Could **you** describe me your typical 24h day (more or less)?

10. What were you doing on the 24th February 2022?

11. What do you think about the war in Ukraine and how did it affected your life?

The goal of this second part was to prompt those being interviewed, and future listeners, to reflect on the subjectivity of their memories, even in broader contexts such as the onset of war. This second phase somewhat reinforced my initial thesis, namely that the geopolitical proximity of the groups of Belarusians and Ukrainians, and sometimes Poles, had indelibly carved February 24, 2022, into their memories. For the expats, among whom I place myself, this memory was often blurred.

The third and ultimate objective was to establish an archive that would compile the memories of the Kraków community surrounding me during that period. The initial presentation of this collected material took place in June 2023 at a group exhibition held within the Intermedia department of the ASP Academy of Fine Arts in Kraków. For this inaugural exhibition, the interviews were printed on forty individual sheets of paper and suspended from a framework composed of wire mesh and three wooden beams affixed to the gallery ceiling.



For the second exhibit, I developed a web radio.<sup>12</sup> The event began at midnight on February 23, 2024, at the same time as the UKRAiNATV livestream set up for the second year of the war. The radio program consisted of a continuous stream of the full edited interviews, lasting a total of 6 hours and 22 minutes, looped, and randomly replayed for the next 24 hours. In parallel, the project engaged the public through interactive programming, allowing visitors to the venue, set up in a room adjacent to the main studio, to participate by giving an interview in turn. Participants then had the opportunity to share their stories on the web radio, thus expanding the diversity of voices represented in the event.

The installation had two main goals: first, to stimulate reflection regarding the ongoing conflict in listeners, highlighting the importance of an empathic connection with the reality of war; second, the project aims to counter the process of media de-humanization by promoting empathy through the testimonies collected.

One of the sources of inspiration for this project was the work by Ukrainian artist Timothy Maxymenko. His project, “Listening portals” (“Звукові портали”), consists of creating sound portals through custom-built loudspeakers, then sending them to three different Ukrainian cities-Kyiv, Kharkiv, and Odessa. Every day, for 24 hours, with the help of a special mini-computer and microphones located in each of the boxes, the recorded sound is streamed and broadcast live on the portals' dedicated website.

I could not help but imagine an ideal analogy with the work of B92 and pirate radio projects as well, as I thought about the best way to share the collected interviewees' memories. In general, the project's purpose was to confront listeners with their position, of privilege or otherwise, regarding a war that is still ongoing in Ukraine, and that touches each of us on very different levels. It is also meant to strive for us to remember, through the testimonies of people unknown to us, but whose reality we can try to learn about, and slow down that process of dehumanization that mass media usually produce. Empathy toward another human being mediates the experiences of war easier to feel unrelated to. But it's not. The trends that emerged during the conversations underscore the variability of perceptions and memories related to conflict, illustrating the intricate nature of our recollections, even concerning events we might regard as universal.

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12 Using the provider AirtimePro.



Figure 7: Picture taken during the 24-hours event held in the UKRAiNATV studio, 24 February 2024, Kraków.

My personal experience with UKRAiNATV encompasses a set of practices rooted in artistic resistance, like those described here. This is just my account, yet similar realities exist everywhere: where performance, streaming, photography, radio, and writing serve as forms of grassroots resistance, signaling to the world. Even if the contents made by the group are uploaded on different platforms, it transcends being merely an archive. Events unfold live, maintaining at the same time an ongoing performative element. This blend fosters a new mode of networking, both online and offline, with a political drive and a dedication to memory collection. It becomes a media repository, an active archive online, and an artistic collective offline. This synthesis creates a collective media where streamart and various forms of expression converge, embodying a form of resistance and defiance against academic language and common sense.

Through the analysis of these, all emerge as pivotal figures, whose task—sometimes rooted in privilege—is to amplify experiences and testimonies that might otherwise fade into obscurity. In a world often scarred by conflict and injustice, their mission became constructing bridges of understanding and solidarity, contributing to a more inclusive and liberated future for all.

**Giulia Timis** is an Amsterdam-based artist and researcher developing practices around live-streaming production, tactical video, and hybrid media performances. Her work focuses on collective media practices, exploring how networked technologies shape participation and political visibility, investigating the affective dimensions of digital presence. She is an affiliate researcher at the Institute of Network Cultures, and part of the practice-based research project *THE VOID*. Her work has been presented at Ars Electronica (Linz), Sónar Festival (Barcelona), and the Louisiana Museum of Modern Art (Copenhagen), among others.

# T.V. TELETEXT | THE VOID MANIFESTO

TOMMASO CAMPAGNA & JORDI VIADER GUERRERO

**Originally Published February 28th, 2024**

*THE VOID (T.V.) is a research project on tactical video and an audiovisual publishing venue for practice-based research. Due to its experimental nature, T.V. is not comprised of (and probably will never be) a defined set of methods and practices.*

## Prologue

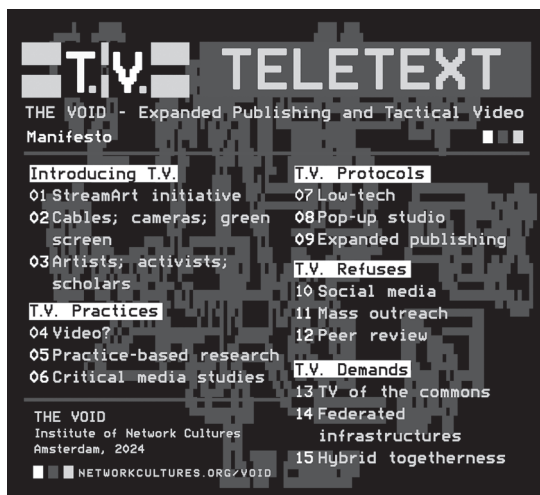
We wrote the Teletext manifesto in early 2024 after Geert Lovink pushed us to give a stronger theoretical and political framework to a project we had begun two years earlier. It was a relevant exercise at the time: we had already produced several video podcasts and were starting to experiment with the streaming format, but we hadn't sat down and reflected about what we wanted to achieve with THE VOID. Two years after its publication—now early 2026—this is still an open question. Yet, it is quite evident in retrospect that we were trying to do two specific things with this text.

First, to frame THE VOID as practice-based research by distancing ourselves from solely textual forms of internet and technology critique. We were (and still are) tired of a critical theory of the internet mostly devoted to culturally and politically analysing big tech platforms to state once again how the internet has become a capitalist, neoliberal, heteronormative, fascist, and/or colonial apparatus. We indeed agree with these analyses, yet we felt (and still feel) that we shouldn't write more of these. In some ways, and to not speak too highly of ourselves, our main drive to make THE VOID was a wish to not write while getting away with claiming that we do research and produce knowledge.

Second, we wanted to present video (and still want to) as an opportunity to come together: as an event, a media-determined situation rather than simply as a media piece. Or even worse, as content. We saw (and still see) this as a contestation to the media production and consumption logics of the platformized internet. In short, and to put it in not very modest terms, we were (and still are) trying to make social media social again; to imagine what a “post-internet” internet could look like. To do that, we not only wished to rescue 20th century ambitions of an emancipated, popular television through the tools and practices of online streaming, but also wanted to invite like-minded practitioners to collaborate with us.

We are not confident about the relevance or power of manifestos. We make videos and are, after all, sceptical of the effects of the written word. And, while these goals haven't been achieved (and probably will never fully be), we still stand by the following words:

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Doing T.V. is mostly about laying out and organizing cables: getting a space (either borrowed, booked, or squatted), setting up tripods, putting up green screens, connecting monitors, lighting up a studio, and welcoming collaborators. All of these actions end up in physical cable management but can also be seen as metaphorical cable management of aesthetic and social feedback loops. We don't want to remain at a metaphorical level, though. The hours of manual labor with technical equipment that go into online video streaming overshadow those of sitting in front of a screen reading, typing, and clicking. We have, nonetheless, previously framed doing T.V. as research. As such, it would be hypocritical for us to underestimate the importance of theoretical reflection to establish a critical practice. And yet, doing T.V. asks for a set of skills that often diverge from those of traditional theoretical research. Practice-based research requires you to leave word processors and computer monitors aside (although not for very long) and, in our case, spend the day with cables in a basement-turned-into-studio.

Doing T.V. means to develop a practical know-how that is not opposed to theoretical knowledge, but rather one that complements it and pushes it forward. Or, more radically, doing T.V. shows (streams?) that theory is always rooted in collective practices. In our case, online audiovisual production.

T.V. practices online video with the hope of doing it differently: it is both a practice-based research project on hybrid audiovisual assemblages and a publication venue for practice-based research. T.V. focuses on the increasing presence of video production in research and artistic practices. By providing resources to critically work with this mediatic landscape as well as sharing and supporting research practices that center a critical engagement with media, T.V. expands the role of digital audiovisual production practices as a research methodology.

In the same way that practice-based research produces knowledge through alternative modes of making (in our case, from the researcher's computer screen to the green-screen-studio-feedback loop), it also calls for expanding publication formats. T.V. aspires to create the means and tools for practitioners not represented in the current publishing industries. To put it concisely, T.V. expands publishing for practice-based research. For T.V., producing, hosting, distributing, and consuming media is not about illustrating previously existing research or knowledge, but about doing things: working with media is actively doing research.



T.V. is a space and a practice of critical media studies. It is inscribed in a tradition that expands outlooks on the way we see, read, and talk about online media. Yet, we strive to unbound knowledge about media from the position of the interpreter or the commentator. We recover the ambitions of tactical media to place them at the core of critical media studies. Knowing about media is also about intervening with media: using and creating media on our own terms—not solely communicating about how media represent the world, but collectively getting involved in a world constituted by distributed online media production.

We see video as an opportunity to come together and figure out how to inhabit online spaces with vulnerability and solidarity. For T.V., video is then a hybrid event, an occasion to pollute online spaces with offline encounters and, vice versa, to rearrange how we physically exist together through the tool of the green screen studio. A pop-up studio branching out into the offline (events, zines, workshops) and online (a website, repository, publications, live stream), producing occasions to share and plot common urgencies, resources, and know-how. Using online video not only to show, document, or witness, but also as a way to share practices and politically engaged understandings for the production, archiving, distribution, and interpretation of online content, we underline the inherent hybrid togetherness of the online experience.

We promote intimacy with technology that escapes big tech's nightmarish fantasies of immersion and intuitive constant communication. An intimacy that is also not confined to the overly technical hacker imaginaries pushing for universal coding literacy. We are inspired by the culture emerging from platform content creation that, while deeply neoliberal, has produced a distributed collective of technical users. A dispersed collective that has developed diverse yet specific aesthetic sensibilities and a profound understanding that the digital has always been a physical (and cultural) gesture. To put it differently, it is a collective for whom hours of scrolling, binge-watching, and streaming on multiple (horizontal and vertical) screens have made it self-evident that these are not abstract devices to be operated at will, but a hybrid environment to inhabit. A hybrid environment in which distinctions between representation and intervention collapse into feedback loops or recursive chains of localized operations between software, green screens, microphones, mixers, monitors, cameras, data, people, and (most importantly) cables, establishing new ways of moving, sensing, communicating. Of being together.

By highlighting tacticality and technical practices, we recall the political heritage of communities around early networked communities. From bak.ma to Telestreet and Indymedia, we bring back practices and affordances of independent video making, TV, and radio to produce new ways to inhabit a stagnating online media landscape. This heritage is a reminder that before any technical system appears as such, it is preceded by an array of unstable practices that are then stabilized into commoditized standards. As social networks evolve into streaming platforms, we want to latch onto this instability to reconsider the possibilities of online media by looking at it as a hybrid and precarious assemblage of legacy media tools, protocols, and practices. If early online broadcasting initiatives were instances of pre-standardization, T.V. seeks opportunities of post-standardization: de- and re-stabilizing online video as computational artisanship in a parasitic yet conflictual relation with platformized/industrial modes of production.

From video podcasts to live streaming, we don't work with a clear standard. We regard this as a strength: centering experimentation and openness to collaboration as the overarching attitudes to approach video work. For T.V., online video stops being solely a digital medium, a final outcome towards which all activities are directed, but the networks of open-ended relations and practices around a precarious (and for that reason, very material) studio we inhabit together.

From T.V., we make a call to all practitioners who want to share a green screen. To those who inhabit video in its online and offline, virtual and material, offshoots, we invite them to collaborate and figure out together new ways to exist in hybridity. And, hopefully, create a TV of the commons, a StreamArt cooperative, a distributed organized network for audiovisual practice, and a politically engaged federation of practitioners to reclaim our technological life in common.

T.V. Team — [networkcultures.org/void](http://networkcultures.org/void)

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# SILLY GIRL THEORY: SCROLLING THE DIGITAL PLAYGROUNDS

BY MELA MIEKUS & MITA MEDRI

Originally published on February 16th, 2024

## Dictionary:

**Boy:** anyone or anything that embodies hegemonic heteronormative and patriarchal ideologies and who loves rationality, logic, and capitalism.

**Girl:** anyone or anything that exists in opposition to hegemonic structures.

**Boy Tasks:** tasks that are stereotypically seen as better performed by men than women, e.g. fixing a car but also bizarre tasks related to male-dominated fields like trading cryptocurrency.

**Doing Something The Boy Way:** doing something in a rational, affect-depleted, boring, normie way.

**To Sillify:** to propose a glitch to the hegemonic modes of doing and being, to perform actions, tasks, and relations in performatively silly ways that oppose neoliberal and patriarchal values.

**Just Girly Things:** this phrase was popularized by the Tumblr page *justgirlythings*. Here, we define it as things associated with girlhood, especially those that accompanied our coming-of-age years that were done exclusively by girls and ridiculed by boys, e.g. collecting silly bands.



Design by Kaja Cichocka





Her style is eccentric, with mismatched socks, striped sweaters, and her hair is a never-ending art project. She likes her bows and pinks but she also wears dirty Converse and baggy t-shirts. Her brother told her his new groundbreaking philosophical take, but she had this thought when she was 12. She likes to be chronically online; tweeting, blogging, and watching Sofia Coppola movies. If she has a job, it's a lazy girl job and she certainly does not fuck with the hustle or the grind. And she will lollygag. She is fully capable of living a "proper" adult life, but she chooses not to. After all, she is just a girl. Even though the Silly Girl likes to feign innocence, she should not be mistaken for being incapable or clueless. She certainly is 'in the know'. She probably knows more than you do. She's just plotting and trolling, practising her tomfoolery.

Think Doja Cat with her unserious online presence like trolling her fans, trashposting on Insta, or always being unfiltered. She may take it a step or two too far, but the point is that you can't, and in fact, should never, take her seriously. Or think Björk with her unique style and overall whimsiness. When called on stage to collect a music award Björk simply said "I am grateful grapefruit" and her husband is a cat, the only man she can trust.

There is a lot of aesthetic nostalgia from the early to mid-2000s in the way the Silly Girl visually and digitally expresses herself. Her style, with pink and blue tights, glitter, stars, and colourful striped things, makes many references to an indie sleaze aesthetic. Perhaps she engages in a throwback to the early 2010s because that is roughly when she experienced her coming of age IRL. She craves to reimagine her girlhood. She loves Hello Kitty, hair clips, bows, and ribbons, all quintessential girlhood signifiers. *This is where she posts from and on the internet she is forever 13.*



She has re-embraced her youth and all of the cute, pink, expressive, and childlike sense of wonder that this entails. Being a girl is not lame anymore and her interests can never be "too girly". She is unapologetically indulging in an essentialist girlhood, yet, there is a level of playfulness and performativity here. She brings a goofiness, or dare we say, a silliness, to the table.

## Theorizing Silliness

Dictionaries define silliness as the quality of lacking good/common sense; foolishness, absurdity, ridiculousness, or irrationality, or being playfully lighthearted and amusing. Further, memes about being silly comprise a broader online category with related catchphrases such as “Tis a Silly Place” circling over ranging social media. The silliness practised by the Silly Girl is embedded in these definitions, but she manages to reframe it a little. She makes it her own.

“What did you do over the weekend?” umm i sat in my room and was silly ? lol

In *The Ambiguity of Play*, Brian Sutton-Smith theorizes different rhetorics of play. He brings forward an analysis of the historical trickster figure and emphasizes how they “enacted playful protest against the orders of the ordained world”<sup>1</sup>. Sutton-Smith brings our attention to how the trickster occupies a dialectical position within culture; she is simultaneously “the good and the bad, the sobriety and the insobriety, the body conventional and the body uncontrollable”. Enid Welsford, in *The Fool*, writes:

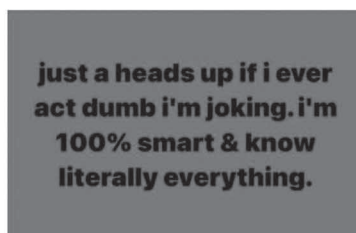
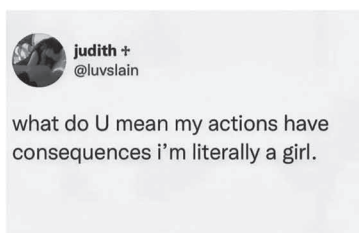
For the genius of the fool is manifested by his power of deluding us into the belief that he can draw the sting of pain; by his power of surrounding us with an atmosphere of make-believe, in which nothing is serious, nothing is solid, nothing has abiding consequences. Under the dissolvent influence of his personality, the iron network of physical, social, and moral law, which enmeshes us from the cradle to the grave, seems—for the moment—negligible as a web of gossamer.<sup>2</sup>

In these theorizations, the Fool is shown to transcend structures of power as long as she is at play. In that sense, this frivolity has “the power to make players feel that they can transcend reality and indeed mortality”. The Silly Girl similarly evokes her silliness. Her online trolling and tomfoolery allow for disengagement of the outside world and the rules that dominate it. Silly Girl often finds herself in a gloomy reality, playing the game that many generations of girls played before her but have never won. She is sick of it. So instead of playing by the real-life-rulebook, she chooses to disengage and play the fool, and as long as she’s performing this role she cannot lose.

1 Brian Sutton-Smith, *The Ambiguity of Play*, (Harvard University Press, 2001).

2 Enid Welsford, *The Fool: His Social and Literary History*, (Faber, 1968).

The Silly Girl thus utilizes silliness as her way of engaging and disengaging from the world. Her silliness takes the shape of an “ignorance is bliss” kind of approach and manifests itself through her unserious attitude that celebrates doing something in an illogical way. The silly girl, instead of asking for help or mastering the “proper” way, chooses to come up with her silly little ways that may look bizarre to *you* (boys) but work perfectly fine for *us* (silly girls). A lot of these tasks we’re referring to here are *boy tasks* (see dictionary). Trying to do them the boy way (see dictionary) was Girlboss’s thing, but she failed and ended up selling her soul to the hustle. Silly girl refuses these modes of operating.



The *I'm Just a Girl* slogan stormed the web in 2023. It quickly spread to mainstream platforms with all types of girls everywhere sharing their I'm just a girl moments. For example, choosing to fix the hole in their car by sticking a pink bandaid on it, or memes using the slogan religiously. The hashtag #imjustagirl also appears under many confession-style TikToks where girls share their thoughts or questions they have about society. It's encapsulated well in Madeline Argy's viral video where you can see her crying while stating the question: “What the fuck do DJs actually do?”. This reflects the mentality well: the silly girl is sick of pretending to understand the silly little boy tasks. Instead, through voicing her confusion she exposes their absurdity. Silly Girl does not understand NFTs and she is proud to say it.

Further, this confusion cannot be read as a passive cluelessness but rather as a potent mode of disengaging from *boy tasks* and their hegemony. If she wanted to she could grasp all these concepts but she prefers to troll them to expose their dumbness. She refuses to use the master's tools to dismantle the master's house. Instead, she disturbs their smooth and ingrained nature and sillifies them. This mode of silliness is thereby drawn to be exclusively for girls (see dictionary), boys (see dictionary) are kindly asked to leave the room.

## I'm Literally Just a Girl

As she memetically expresses herself, the Silly Girl and her silliness often play on the aesthetic quality of cuteness. In exploring cuteness in her *book Our Aesthetic Categories: Zany, Cute, Interesting*, Sianne Ngai describes cute objects as being soft, rounded, blob-like, groggy, small, and associated with a sense of helplessness and vulnerability. Ngai additionally notes that such qualities of cuteness are associated with what is deemed

infantile as well as feminine.<sup>3</sup> The memes where random objects are girlified through the addition of a pink bow are quite explicit in this function. In harnessing the cuteness of the girly symbol of the bow, an image of a coquette chicken nugget channels the endearing powerlessness of girlhood.



While such implications elicit essentialist understandings of what being a girl is, the use of such cuteness also works to rupture these assumptions. Ngai explains that “in its exaggerated passivity and vulnerability, the cute object is as often intended to excite a consumer’s sadistic desires for mastery and control as much as his or her desire to cuddle.” Thus, while non-threatening, plushy objects invite us to want to lovingly engage with them and snuggle or even vigorously squeeze them, such impulses unveil an underlying belief that the cute object is inferior and subject to domination. Through this Ngai is theorizing the technology of cuteness as a subversive category which functions to expose societal connotations of what cuteness infers. The Silly Girl uses cuteness precisely in this way. She sprinkles cuteness with heavy notes of mimicry: she is so cute that it hurts. She is deploying it to expose the patriarchal sadistic desires that are transposed onto the things that society deems cute.

Beyond the guise of docility, Silly Girl expresses her cuteness and girliness in a tongue-in-cheek way. Sure, the Silly Girl can be cute and she responds to what Ngai theorizes, however, she is not just cute, she is silly. Her silliness adds the performative aspect where by ‘acting a fool’ she sillifies these essentialist modes of thinking.

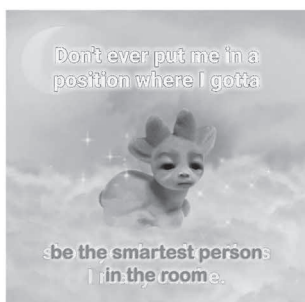
In exploring how the Silly Girl ruptures societal assumptions through her digital presence, it’s helpful to understand how Legacy Russell imagines *glitched bodies* in her book *Glitch Feminism*. Glitched bodies are defined as those that do not align with the dominant convention of white cisgender heteronormativity. Understanding the glitch as an error, Russell describes the function of glitched bodies as a failure that “prompts the violent

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3 Sianne Ngai, *Our Aesthetic Categories: Zany, Cute, Interesting*, (Harvard University Press, 2015).

socio-cultural machine to hiccup, sigh, shudder, buffer.”<sup>4</sup> Thus, glitched bodies, in their nonperformance of normative identity, expose the glitch, the defect, in the white, heteronormative, patriarchal matrix. The *girl* (read dictionary definition), as a glitched body, is proof that this system is flawed and the Silly Girl expresses this glitch visibly through her exaggerated and silly use of cuteness. Through her sillification of cuteness, she performs the ridiculousness of patriarchy.

In playing on cute imagery, you’ve probably seen girls pretending to be cute animals online with captions like “When you hurt me, this is who you’re hurting” or “This is me if you even care.” As girls express themselves through images of fluffy bunnies and sleepy, or rather, “eepy”, kittens, they further draw this connection between femininity and vulnerability and evoke what Alex Quicho describes as “going prey mode”. Quicho explains that this radical acceptance of bottom-feeder status allows for a “tactical passivity” in which girls employ an acceptance of powerlessness in this patriarchal system to then comfortably indulge in the bliss of being pretty, helpless, and harmless.<sup>5</sup> Silly Girl loves to “go prey mode”, she delights in reducing herself to a small passive animal. She learned from the weaponized incompetence of her boyfriends and uses her own tactical passivity to essentially reap the benefits of patriarchal assumptions of her weakness and vulnerability. If she’s so incapable, if she’s so clueless, then we should really just give her a break already.



The Silly Girl loves to play on this dumbness aspect of being cute, again practising her ignorance is bliss attitude. This is best encapsulated by the ‘girls getting drafted for war’ TikToks. These appeared after a Deepfake video of United States President Joe Biden came out where he was saying that he would reinstate the military draft and that women would be included. Essentially, the TikTok memes girlify, as well as sillify (see dictionary), the military experience (see videos). Being in the army is given a pink, prissy flair and this works to co-opt these essentialist narratives of women to get out of hypothetically getting drafted. Silly Girl does not want to go to war. Silly Girls think war is silly and so, through these

4 Legacy Russel, *Glitch Feminism: A Manifesto*, (Verso, 2020).

5 Alex Quicho, “Prey Mode: Why Girls Are Pretending to Be Cute Animals.”, *Dazed*, November 20, 2023, <https://www.dazeddigital.com/life-culture/article/61336/1/going-prey-mode-girls-cute-animals-online-canthal-tilt-tiktok>.

memes, they sillify the whole ordeal in general. War is a boy thing. Boys like the military. Silly Girls are not down with the military-industrial complex and the violent regimes of the state.

Furthermore, Silly Girl milks this assumption that she is incompetent, to lower expectations, and get others to cut her some slack when she turns a little devious. She's too cute to understand, so how can she really be held accountable for her actions? This is a way in which the Silly Girl revises the Femcel's manipulation. The Femcel's goal is to ruin boys' lives, but the Silly Girl just wants to humiliate and taunt them a little. The Femcel takes full accountability for her actions and prides herself in being the anti-hero, while the Silly Girl didn't mean to, oopsie. She luxuriates in playing the fool. Sorry if she did something that will irreversibly mess up your life, but she's literally just a girl <3.

Tiqqun theorized the figure of the Young Girl who is the product of a society that loves pretty young girls with a "morally pink complexion."<sup>6</sup> She is a symptom of a culture that turned adolescence into a commodity aligned with consumerist demands. The Silly Girl on some level reflects the infantilized image of a girl in the sense that she romanticizes her girlhood. But, while the Young Girl "exists only in proportion to the desire that THEY have for her and knows herself only by what THEY say she is", the Silly Girl rebels against internalizing the external gaze. She is aware that the essentialist ideas she plays with have a history of violence. Yet her play is strategic. The Silly Girl ingests patriarchal assumptions and digests them only to exert them as her own. After all, no one can hurt her by infantilizing or simplifying who she is, when she already does that herself.

## Silly Girl as Psychic Armor

Earlier internet days provided people the opportunity to be whoever they wanted online. Today, with tracking IDs, Cookies, and the centralized platform system, your online privacy and agency look way more gloomy. Nevertheless, certain online communities manage to maintain that *Teh Internet is Not Serious Business*. Daniël de Zeeuw and Marc Tuters in *Teh Internet Is Serious Business* discuss Deep Vernacular Web (DVW) movements such as 4chan, exposing how their "subcultural practices (...) are rooted in the cyber-separationist ethos of early web culture, which imagined the internet as a virtual space of play detached and separate from "real life". They argue that this approach, which favors identity play, masks, and anonymity over identity authentication and profiles that reflect our IRL selves, can "provide a counter-hegemonic space"<sup>7</sup>. The DVW is more often than not a dangerous vessel for spreading alt-right ideology, but their online frivolity can teach us a lesson or two. Indeed, the DVW visualizes that digital spaces can still allow for a level of playfulness, and this mode of being has potent political potential.

6 Tiqqun, *Theory of the Young-Girl*, (Semiotext(e), 2012).

7 Marc Tuters & Daniël de Zeeuw, "Teh Internet is not Serious Business", *Duke University Press* Volume 16, Issue 2, (July 2020), <https://doi.org/10.1215/17432197-8233406>.



Digital girlhood takes the shape of a performance embedded in a similar logic. For years now, girls have treated the internet as a space for refusal of the male-dominated values that rule their Away from Keyboard (AFK) lives. The Sad Girls have radicalized and politicized their sadness by posting crying pics on Tumblr. The Femcels used social media to manipulate boys and express their rage. Silly Girls respond to similar issues through means of trolling and sillifying. The internet thereby allows for practising a strategic (dis)identification with a wide array of ways to be a girl online.

*Something horrible in my life happened, expect some funny ass memes* is a quintessential reflection of Silly Girl’s onlineness. Silly Girl’s web behaviour becomes her psychic armor. Like the Sad Girl, Girlboss, and the Femcel, the Silly Girl is troubled. She is sad, she is desperate, she is angry, she may be mentally ill. But online, these problems don’t really matter. After all, the internet is just a *support group for girls who are never normal about anything ever*.

The popular belief that girls mature faster exposes a complex framework that elicits societal pressure for girls to become women quite fast. It is much less frowned upon for grown men to still indulge in their coming-of-age obsessions such as fangirling over a football player, than it is for women to enjoy typically girly things. Nadira Begum puts this well:

Squealing over an actor you fancy is embarrassing, and crying when your favourite band breaks up is childish. If a piece of media incites strong emotion out of a largely teen girl fanbase, as *Twilight* did, then it is not to be taken seriously. Dismissing anything associated with young women is an age-old misogynistic practice with the express intent to silence young girls.<sup>8</sup>

The Silly Girl can thus also act as a mode of reclaiming girlhood and rebelling against all the sadness we felt when we weren’t allowed to do just girly things (see dictionary).

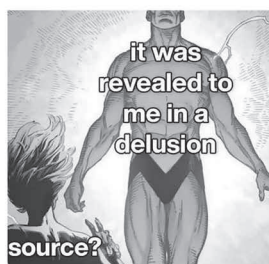
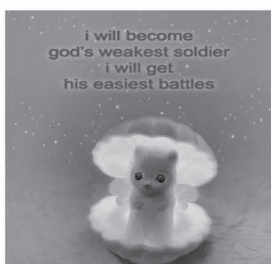
8 Nadira Begum, “So the Lion Fell in Love with the Lamb (Again): Reclaiming Girlhood via Nostalgia.” *Polyester*, September 25, 2023. <https://www.polyesterzine.com/features/so-the-lion-fell-in-love-with-the-lamb-againreclaiming-girlhood-via-nostalgia>.



Beyond that, being a teen girl entails a level of surveillance that leaves little space for real innocence and is often accompanied by fast sexualization. This situation gets especially amplified under an intersection of inequalities. Legacy Russel recalls her coming-of-age years in the following way; "I was a young body: Black, female-identifying, femme, queer. There was no pressure pause, no reprieve; the world around me never let me forget these identifiers. Yet online I could be whatever I wanted." We turn to the internet to disassociate from our troubles. To cosplay a little.

Silly girl at her essence is politically aware, but she chooses to ignore that and have fun, be ironic, and be "baby". There is a tremendous privilege in this chosen ignorance. Not everyone can just decide to be ignorant if they are tired of engaging with society's issues. The girlhood experience that the Silly Girl taps into, the one of ignorance is bliss and a happy carefree childhood, is one that channels the white middle-class experience. Therefore, Silly Girl's digital persona is white, middle-class, and cis-coded. However, this digital persona can be used as psychic armour and a coping mechanism to escape AFK realities. The people using Silly Girl as their virtual avatar don't need to necessarily relate to this blissful girlhood experience, they can simply use Silly Girl as their digital roleplay. In this way, the Silly Girl allows an experience of privilege where she can decide whether to tap in or tap out of life issues. A digital persona such as Silly Girl, can therefore become a psychic armour that we put on whenever needed. Why pay \$200 for a therapist when you have Silly Girl who is always there and will protect you?

Silly Girl is sad inside, but we cannot equate her emotions with those of the Sad Girl. While Sad Girl indulges in a hardcore aestheticization of her sadness, the Silly Girl ridicules her pain. The Sad Girl cries in public, smokes cigarettes, and politicizes her vulnerability. Sad Girl rotting entails lying in bed all day wallowing in her self-pity and heartbreak. On the other hand, Silly Girl rotting entails lying in bed all day bingeing a series, spending way too much time on the internet, and being too lazy to get up and make a meal more complex than a few crackers and an assortment of candy and chunks of cheese. Both certainly evoke imagery of mental instability but are expressed quite differently. The Silly Girl clowns her emotions and is not pretty when she cries. She roams the web avoiding her silly little dark thoughts, sprinkling heavy satire onto any unfortunate situation. What's more, her sadness often turns into delusion.



Silly Girl is completely Delulu—and she loves it. Being rational is overrated and lame, she leaves that to the boys. When Silly Girls get together, they love to validate each other's delusions and manifest their realities. I am God's weakest soldier, I will get his easiest battles (they all repeat about 50 times in a row). Only good things can happen to me! Why participate in the rat race for the best job when she can simply light a candle and hyper-fantasize about getting it in her dreams? She trusts the universe and refuses to enter neoliberal modes of being that always blame the individual. Silly Girl blames the system. Being delusional is then yet another way in which she chooses to troll her struggles. Ironic detachment comes in handy when you're busy trying to avoid a mental breakdown.

## Anti-Boy

According to Christine H. Tran, "to #girlboss is to pursue neoliberal values of individual choicehood as the primary vector of women's liberation from market misogyny". Silly Girl learned important lessons from her digital sister. She refuses to travel down that road again. So instead of trying to enter the system, she tries to disturb it through her taunting online persona. In doing so, she confronts neoliberal values that favour the grind, productivity, rationality, and normcore. Two strategies are key here: hating on the boys, and sillifying money and logic.



In this world boys symbolize anyone or anything that produces, reflects, or maintains the hegemonic structures based on patriarchy, neoliberalism, and racism. Silly Girl does not like the boys and exists in a cybersphere where they are not welcome. *Goodnight to women only, men I wish y'all have nightmares tonight*, Silly Girl tweets. If it was up to her, boys would not be allowed on the internet. They already take up too much space IRL. So as you'd expect from a professional troller, Silly Girl uses her socials to make fun of them. Think Roman Empire trend that helped her expose the peculiar nature of the *boy* brain. Boys think about the Roman Empire a lot because it is a symbol of order, logic, and masculinity - all the things that Silly Girl hates. Thus by laughing at the boys, she is laughing at the entire system, and through that, sillifying it.

Silly Girl provides a counter-space where logic, rationality, and seriousness are traded in for affect, irony, and quirkiness. The popular trend *Girl Math* that stormed TikTok resonates here. The videos bring forward girls sharing their stories about how they view money. For example, if you pay in cash, then whatever you bought was free. If you return the \$50 dress you bought, you just get a free \$50. The flight you're taking tomorrow is free since you paid for it 3 months ago. While *Girl Math* can be deemed as nothing more than a shallow joke, we refuse to ignore its political potency. See, what the Silly Girl is doing here she is refusing the seriousness of money. She sillifies all things that neoliberal capitalism holds so dear. We have already seen how Silly Girl shows that the internet is a goofy business and now she is applying this framework to money. It is at this point that all the remaining boy readers clench their fists and run away. No, Silly Girl will not admire your Doge Coin stocks, or validate your Andrew Tate mentality, nor will she shorten her naps to boost her daily productivity, go cry about it. Thus, by hating on the boys, she is hating on notions, of logic, seriousness, and money and thereby glitching the wider system that rules our neoliberal reality.

## Trading Silliness

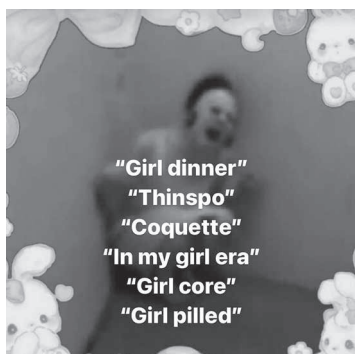
The bodies of young girls become sites of struggle where many different disciplines compete. And more often than not, money becomes inextricable from these operations. Tiquun argues that the Young Girl is a “living currency,” which can be applied to many digital girl personas too. The figure of the girl can easily become a commodity. The Girlboss showed us this process; she essentially made girls mainstream. This had some positive impact, opening doors that only boys could use but it also helped turn the girl into a commodity that could be traded. This shows one of many ways that the commodification of girls can take place and hints at an equally huge amount of ambiguous relations and power dynamics it engenders.

What makes this process more complex is that female labour has been confused with a pastime for centuries. Marx already called our attention to how domestic labour is undervalued and indicative of unequal wealth distribution within a household. Further as pointed out by Rachel O'Dwyer “Girls trade on the ambiguous nature of women's work - care, affect, sex – as well as the invisible nature of women's money – often coming in the form of gifts, treats, girl dinners, or ‘little somethings’.”<sup>9</sup> Thus, both the labour as well as the compensation often float in some uneasy metasphere where hard transfers or cash are not tangible. It seems that the two most prominent options to respond to such an environment are either to commodify yourself or to be commodified. For example, Tiquun writes that the Young Girl “is the one who has preferred to become a commodity, rather than passively suffer its tyranny.” What about the Silly Girl then?

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9 Rachel O'Dwyer, “The Girl Is a Living Currency - How Womanhood Has Always Been Its Own Economy” *Polyester*, October 10, 2023, <https://www.polyesterzine.com/features/the-girl-is-a-living-currency-how-womanhood-has-always-been-its-own-economy>.

We all know that capitalism loves taking things that start as subcultural or belonging to specific communities and repackaging them as a mainstream identity that they can reproduce for large profits. The girlhood revival started as a space for girls to reclaim the things that they were made to feel dumb for liking when they were young. It provides an escape, a space to forget about their adult jobs and struggles and instead, go back to the simpler days if even just online. Yet, as is usually the case, brands and marketing campaigns were quick to jump on this bandwagon. *Barbie* was the highest-grossing film release of 2023, Shein's online store is full of tops with bows, and Popeye's launched their limited "girl dinner" meal, signalling that the commercialization process is well on its way.



Nevertheless, Silly Girl is not just the pink girl who eats girl dinner and does girl math. Yes, she does plenty of these things too but don't forget: she is SILLY. Her silliness adds a level of subversiveness to her maneuvering through the different girl trends. Is it possible that her silliness makes her less commodifiable? It is too early to pose a definitive answer. Still, we believe that the Silly Girl uses her nihilism and political incorrectness so strategically that she may just hold the power to escape being reduced to a marketing stunt. Perhaps what is especially potent about the Silly Girl is that anyone can be her whenever she is needed. Her performative nature makes her harder to define. Thus, while it is possible that like many of her online ancestors, she may just fall into the capitalist clog that will depoliticize her persona, she may also very well withstand these processes. The key is to stay moving and never allow the system to enclose her within a stable identity category that can be reproduced for profit.

## Is Everyone in on the Joke?

The ironic online presence of the Silly Girl may also pose certain issues in terms of the reception or impact of her content. Silly Girl's humour leans in a post-ironic sentiment in the sense that it creates confusion about whether the message is sincere or not. As sarcasm doesn't always translate through text, not everyone who comes across Silly Girl will understand how to interpret her. Silly Girl may be in on the joke, but there is something to be said concerning the potential risks this sort of content poses when misread by people who are not. Post-irony, through its ambiguous form, can easily avoid any political categorization,

thus leaving Silly content both open to depoliticization as well as misinterpretation. While she may be engaging in essentialist roleplay to ridicule patriarchal assumptions, her performance may be taken too literally.



The liberal audience of pink entrepreneurs has catapulted these girl trends into mainstream fame without maintaining the dark humour that underscores Silly content and serves as a safety net from the violence of gender hegemony. On the other hand, her indifference and at times, her political incorrectness, might not be seen as a post-ironic and escapist comedic practice, but instead, might accidentally appeal to the Tradwives and Top G enthusiast 4chan dwellers of the internet. This is best exemplified by the “I don’t dream of labor” TikTok trend which was initially used in memes critiquing capitalism, but was adopted by TradWives as an affirmation of their traditional gender role. The point of the cryptic nature of Silly Girl’s content is to not assume everything is serious business and remember that one can never know when Silly Girl is being for real (maybe never). Potentially, in the cases in which her content is read literally, it may serve to further reinforce the structures we claim she is protecting herself from. However, it is important to intervene in these politically contested spaces and, as put by Geert Lovink, “reclaim the power of definition in the fight against right-wing meme hegemony”.<sup>10</sup>

## Girlhood as Grief

In the end, Silly Girl is a digital reprieve where one can come to bask in the ironic warmth of a worry-free life. Each of these digital girl personas has served as a hideout from the violence of the socio-cultural matrix. We are left to find any sliver of distraction, of respite, that allows us to be existentially capable of tolerating the crushing reality of existing under the hegemonic neoliberal chokehold. How can 2023 be the “year of the girl” with such an alarming rate of femicides? The underlying struggle and distress of all these digital girls evolve from the same source, yet they express themselves through different coping mechanisms.

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10 Geert Lovink, “Copium Compendium: How Do You Cope in this Digital Age of Disaster?”, *Institute of Network Cultures*, January 9, 2024, <https://networkcultures.org/geert/2024/01/09/copium-compendium-how-do-you-cope-in-this-digital-age-of-disaster/>.

The concept of grief and grieving has famously been reduced to the 5-stages of denial, anger, bargaining, depression, and acceptance. In *Grief Worlds: A Study of Emotional Experience*, Matthew Ratcliffe explains that while maintaining the notion that grief is a process, this is by no means to suggest that it is linear or reductive.<sup>11</sup> Elisabeth Kübler-Ross and David Kessler, who put forward the 5 stages of grief model in their book *On Grief and Grieving: Finding the Meaning of Grief through the Five Stages of Loss*, did not do so to fit grief into a neat and digestible formula.<sup>12</sup> Ratcliffe proposes an understanding of these stages of grief as helpful for a theoretical conceptualization of the grieving process. This becomes particularly pertinent in understanding how each of these manifestations of grief interrelate both temporally and expressively. Grief is deeply embedded in the girlhood experience—the loss of innocence, of ignorance, of bodily sovereignty. We grieve the blissful, unattainable, and imagined girlhood experience. Some clench this fantasy with their fists before it can peel away, others cannot wait to leave it behind. In either case, girlhood is such an ephemeral state perhaps because it rarely ever fully belongs to us.

Our digital escape through girl identities is an attempt to reclaim what has been lost. Through her lonesome tears, the Sad Girl expresses herself through **depression**. In attempting to assert herself within the capitalist order, the Girlboss tries **bargaining** for her freedom. By going for scorched earth strategy the Femcel personifies **anger**. The Silly Girl, on the other hand, with her performative ignorance and comedic mask, hides within the comfort of **denial**. While each virtual girl persona embodies a certain emotive manifestation of the grieving process, there is no progression in this 'process'. There is no linear framework for this grief. It is simply a fact of girlhood.

After being so inconsolably sad, pitifully pleading, and dreadfully enraged, she's tired, she just wants to put her feet up and act a little silly and she deserves a little treat.

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**Mita Medri** is an Amsterdam-based researcher and writer. Her research explores digital girlhood, conspiracy cultures, and digital occultism, engaging questions of cultural memory, truth, and contemporary myth-making. She holds a Master's degree in Arts and Culture: Design Cultures from Vrije Universiteit Amsterdam (2024). As of 2025, she works in the curatorial team at IMPAKT - Centre for Media Culture.

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11 Matthew Ratcliffe, *Grief Worlds: A Study of Emotional Experience*, (MIT Press, 2022).

12 Elisabeth Kubler-Ross & David Kessler, *On Grief & Grieving: Finding the Meaning of Grief Through the Five Stages of Loss*, (Scribner, 2005).

# GIRL MATH FUNDAMENTALS – PROOF BY SUBVERSION

IRMA MASTENBROEK

Originally published November 20th, 2025

*"All models are wrong, but some are useful."<sup>1</sup> George Box - "Models are stupid and we need more of them." Paul Smaldino*

Girl Math allowed girlies who just spent a little too much money to rationalise their purchases by framing them as financially sensible, even when they weren't, back on the internet in 2023. According to this logic, a girl earns income when a friend cancels dinner plans or when she returns a dress to the store. The reverse is also true. If something is heavily discounted and she decides not to buy it, she'd be sadly missing out on 'free' money. The girl concludes her argument by teasing "Girl Math!" and then goes about her day, enjoying her purchase guilt-free.

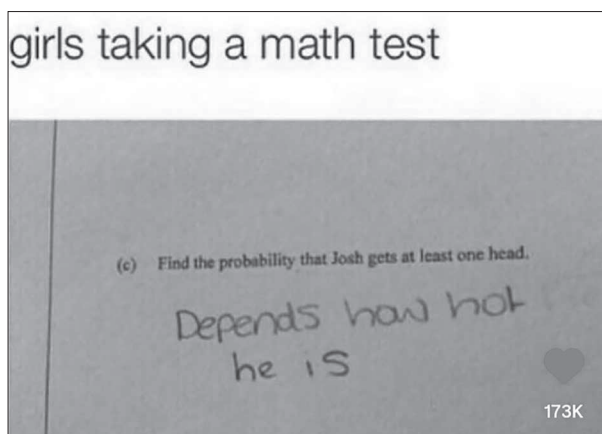
Contrary to what the name might suggest, Girl Math is not gender or age-bound. It's an inclusive tool, an attitude to life, that anyone can use to make life more enjoyable. Acknowledging the humour and irony shaping the argument, one can easily find this indulgent, consumption-oriented attitude relatable. Girl Math is familiar, obnoxious, and justifies everything, and therefore, we love it. Beyond this market's logical illogical nonsense, Girl Math offers a deeper, more complex unfolding of a mathematical paradigm that has been historically oppressed. Indeed, with these emergent practices of logic, consumers and girlies get an opportunity to reflect on how 'making sense' and 'rational thinking' can inhabit a deeper sense of intuition and reasoning. There is something counterintuitive, almost blasphemous, about Girl Math, as it juxtaposes the hegemony of a system of reasoning that, for a long time, has controlled the narrative around what is rationally acceptable.

As both a mathematician and a girl, I'll admit I didn't know whether to laugh or cry when I first encountered the Girl Math phenomenon. It reminded me of a pink kid's T-shirt I once saw in a store that said: "Too Pretty to Do Math." I wasn't sure which part of me was more offended: the mathematician or the girl. *Ehm. Excuse me, are you calling me ugly? Or dumb? Or both?* The tiny pink shirt, staring at me, reassembled a threat to feminism by supporting the patriarchal misconception that girls have to be pretty, agreeable, stupid,

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1 George E Box. P. "Science and Statistics." *Journal of the American Statistical Association* 71, no. 356 (December 1976): 791–799.

and, most of all, bad at math. On surface level, it might look like Girl Math is doing the same. It goes without saying that the cliché that a girl is too cute to do math is wrong. This is a patriarchal rhetoric that is so simple and reductive that it does not need further analysis.



The Girl Math trick borrows from that exact patriarchal misconception that girls are dumb and bad with money and runs with it. In “Everyone is a Girl Online” Alex Quicho describes the subversive tactics of the girl online.<sup>2</sup> The girl now found a way to apply her tricks on the language of logical rigidity, transforming it into a shallow consumerist argument, while simultaneously rendering an alternative way of thinking. The Girl memes at boys and their unwavering devotion to the almighty objective truth. It’s no surprise, then, that Girl Math’s most popular meme format is pissing off boys with her logic

## Girls Always Knew Something About Pure Math

What do I know about this? Well, I am a math girly myself. I didn't get into this field because I was so disciplined, organised, or hard-working. In fact, I was quite the opposite. I was a chaotic child. I would forget about exams, lose my books, and never do my homework. In most classes, you had to accept the rules of the game: memorising history dates, conjugating French verbs you will never use, and nod politely at the idea that GDP is a serious measure of well-being. Quite the nightmare. I couldn't help but be critical of all these assumptions. Who decided this? Why that? What if I disagree? Pure math, however, barely asked me to memorise or accept anything blindly. It did not force itself upon reality, nor did it punish me for my lack of obedience. Pure math rewarded stubbornness.

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2 Alex Quicho. “Everyone Is a Girl Online.” *Wired*. Accessed 01/10/2025. <https://www.wired.com/story/girls-online-culture/>.



Interestingly enough, there's a common assumption that maths is one of the most dictatorial disciplines, as it presupposes and imposes strict, regulated rules and manners. However, to my understanding and practice of mathematics, pure math is a much more speculative, playful, and poetic field of reasoning. In pure math, problems are solved not because we need or want to know the answer for any practical reason. They are solved just for the fuck of it, because we enjoy the puzzle. Like solving a difficult Sudoku. Essentially, we do it just for funzies.

The commonly encountered applied math doctrine that is oppressive and non-negotiable will, from here on, be referred to as Boy Math. It is a logic that is rarely structurally argued but instead imposed. Formulas are supposed to come flying from the air and be accepted. Refuse to comply, and you'll be overruled. The girl makes fun of this kingdom by opposing their super-duper profound big-boi logic. This is no joke to boys. They are so serious about logic. They can't help but respond very emotionally to Girl Math statements. Of course, the girl fully anticipated their frustrations, but she wasn't triggered. In fact, she was hoping for this response. After all, boys not getting it is part of the joke. This is where it started to dawn on me that the girl is not only funny but also making a valid mathematical point. *The girls who get it, get it.*

What are girls trying to do here? Pissing boys off by bothering them with illogical nonsense? Yes. But the girls are making another observation: keeping emotions and general vibes out of the math equation is a design choice that could well be undone. With Girl Math, the girls are telling the world: *we don't really care about your numbers and formulas. For us, the vibes matter. Numbers are fake, intuition is real.*

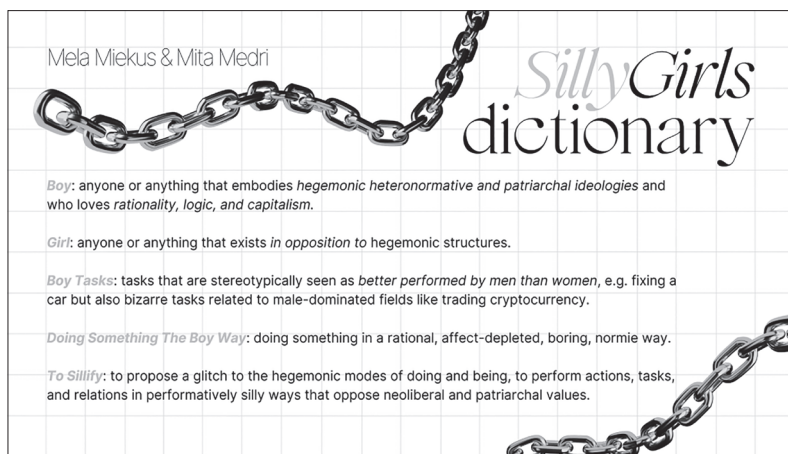
## What is Pure Math Anyway?

### The Silly Girl Knows a Thing or Two

To dismiss Girl Math as a stupid, transparent, and 'shallow joke' would be a missed opportunity to reflect on its deeper occlusion. In their INC longform about the Silly Girl, Mela Miekus and Mita Medri analyse the political potency of specific viral girl trends.<sup>3</sup> The researchers imply that the figure of the silly girl "eats girl dinner, does girl math, romanticises her life, and laughs at boys who think about the Roman Empire." The authors argue that Girl Math is much more than an indulgent, humorous approach to financial decision-making; they see it as a tool for "hating on the boys." This strategy entails using silly rationale to devalue notions of logic, seriousness, and money and thereby glitching the broader system that rules our neoliberal reality.<sup>4</sup> What if, indeed, the silly girl has spotted a crack in the boy-thought prison? What if, in all her delusions, she was right? Is Girl Math mathing? Let's embark on this path.

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3 Mela Miekus and Mita Medri. "Silly Girl Theory, Scrolling the Digital Playgrounds." Institute of Network Cultures, February 16, 2024. <https://networkcultures.org/longform/2024/02/16/silly-girl-theory-scrolling-the-digital-playgrounds/>.



Mathematics is often perceived as an unambiguous, objective field, despite the language of mathematics being frank about its subjectivity.<sup>4</sup> Indeed, a mathematical text openly admits a subjective world-building by explicitly using ‘we’ and ‘us’ to signal our deliberate foundational choices: ‘let us assume,’ ‘we observe,’ ‘we infer.’ In this context, ‘we’ means you, the reader, and I, the writer. In that exercise, we interlock our fingers and enter this thought castle together. Mathematics is the process of building conceptual thought palaces, in which we literally choose and design everything, from the foundations to the wallpaper.<sup>5</sup> In that world, pure mathematics has very little to do with accurately describing reality or with making a truth claim: *it is lore in the making*.

In *Is Math Real*, mathematician Eugenia Cheng argues for a similar thought deconstruction on what we assume math is.<sup>6</sup> She asks us to start from the very basis of what we’ve been taught: “Why does  $1 + 1 = 2$ ?” One possible answer to this question is, “It just does!”—a variant of “Because I say so!”, an answer that has been frustrating children for generations. Both answers suggest an authority figure who makes the rules, doesn’t have to justify them, and expects everyone else to follow them blindly. From a young age, we’re taught to treat formulas as if they were immutable laws of the universe. In high school, we memorize the ABCs, learn the Pythagorean theorem, and accept the rules of arithmetic, all presented as facts we must take. By skipping the step of making assumptions explicit, the system frames

4 Edward Rothstein. “The Subjective Underbelly of Hardheaded Math.” *The New York Times*, December 20, 1997. <https://www.nytimes.com/1997/12/20/books/the-subjective-underbelly-of-hardheaded-math.html>

5 Philip J. Davis and Reuben Hersh. *The Mathematical Experience*. Boston: Birkhäuser, 1982.

6 Eugenia Cheng. *Is Math(s) Real?*. London: Profile Books, 2023. (Pages cited: 12–14.) <https://profilebooks.com/work/is-maths-real/>.

consequences as inevitabilities rather than as outcomes of a constructed world. Students absorb the logic, the proofs, and the 'laws', often without realising that they are operating in a universe designed by human choice. Training obedience: follow the rules, get the correct answer, and trust authority. While this educational strategy can be justified through the argument of 'basic knowledge', I would argue, alongside Eugenia Cheng, that "my love of maths is somewhat driven by my love of breaking rules, or at least pushing against them."

Breaking rules involves deconstructing what's known and assembling new ideas and ways of mathing. Albert Einstein once famously said, "Pure mathematics is, in its way, the poetry of logical ideas."<sup>7</sup> A 'good mathematical proof' is often praised for its elegance and its beauty. On the other hand, a proof that would solely be 'technically correct' but which would lack prose and creativity could be criticised for being too formal, overly technical, clunky, and therefore ugly. The value of a proof lies not in its correctness, but in its style, in its ability to hit a nerve, in the satisfaction of when it *clicks*.

## Pure Math?

How does this translate to Girl Math, then? Where to start? In pure mathematics, we begin by choosing axioms, definitions, and rules of inference. We decide what we define as a point, a line, or a set. We determine what it means to add, to fold, to rotate. Then we explore the consequences of those choices. The entire edifice is built on our starting assumptions (axioms), which are arbitrary. If the mathematical text suggests 'let's assume xyz', and you, for some reason, snap back with a 'well, how about let's not?', that's totally okay. You only have to continue reading if you're interested in what happens, or if you're happy to assume what we just suggested. If not, all good. Axioms are pure assumptions, meaning that they explicitly do not have to be true; they might well be false. . . It doesn't really matter.



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7 Albert Einstein. "Obituary for Emmy Noether." *The New York Times*, May 5, 1935.

So, there's no need to prove assumptions or even justify why they would make any sense. If you wish to assume some nonsense, such as 'nothing that only men like is cool' or ' $0=1$ ', math won't stop you. Math will say, 'You do you, queen. Let's run with that'. Quick enough, you would discover that assuming  $0=1$  makes all numbers disappear, and that the entire number line would collapse into one point. But worry not, you have not broken math, but instead built the smallest, flattest possible mathematical world where distinctions vanish, but some structure remains. Even this degenerate universe counts as mathematics. So then, how have mathematicians come up with their assumptions and definitions if they can assume and define anything they'd like? Well, that's the unfolding of history: mathematicians assumed things that allowed them to create a world in which the things they wished to be true could be true.



Chances are, my dear reader, it took you by surprise to learn that math is not objective, nor inherently 'true'. You might even have felt a bit of resistance to the idea: a knot in your stomach or a nagging feeling of disbelief. After all, we've been taught to trust numbers, formulas, and proofs as universal truths. However, math is not static but constantly mutating, and it doesn't always look "logical" when perceived. Take the square root of  $-1$ . For ages, everyone agreed that it was impossible by definition: a square is always positive. Negative times negative is positive; positive times positive is positive. So, of course, no real number squared could ever give you  $-1$ . Trying to take its square root just seemed stupid.

Then, one day, some random dude, namely Euler, contested and posed, "*Okay, but what if I just call it 'i' and say  $i \times i = -1$ ?*". At the time, other mathematicians basically rolled their eyes: "*Dude, that's not a number.*" He doubled down: "*Okay, fine, it's not a real number, shall we call it an imaginary number?*" To which the math establishment replied: "*For the love of God, please shut up.*" And yet, once Euler's "*i*" was admitted into the math club, previously impossible calculations started unravelling beautifully. Entire families of polynomial equations that had no solutions before suddenly opened up. Centuries later, these "imaginary" numbers revealed themselves to be so useful that, without them, we would not have the mathematics needed for radios, computers, and cell phones. They have since been renamed complex numbers, because how can we justify calling them "imaginary" (explicitly not genuine) when they are used in real-world problems?

## Holy Numbers

So, what about those real numbers—how real are they? Real numbers consist of all numbers on the number line. That seems, perhaps, quite unambiguous. However, there was a time when only rational numbers were allowed. We must go back to the Pythagoreans, a cult-like group of ancient Greek mathematicians who believed that whole numbers were holy, divine, and connected to the gods. They also fiercely believed they had proven that all numbers were rational. Why? Because they thought they had shown that every point on the number line could be expressed as a ratio of whole numbers, leaving no gaps. Their reasoning was elegant: suppose a gap existed between two rational points,  $a/b$  and  $c/d$ . Then the midpoint  $(a/b + c/d)/2$  would also be a rational number in the gap. That means our gap is now cut in half, and we can continue this process forever until all gaps are filled, contradicting our assumption that a gap existed. That was until Hippasus of Metapontum (a Pythagorean himself) discovered that the hypotenuse of a 1 by 1 square,  $c = \sqrt{2}$ , cannot be written as a ratio of integers. In other words,  $\sqrt{2}$  was suddenly *irrational*. This shattered the Pythagorean worldview: if not all numbers were rational, then the divine order they worshipped had cracks. Hippasus of Metapontum's discovery was controversial. According to Vinay Kathotia in the article "The Unreasonable Man," the gods, or the Pythagoreans, drowned him at sea, or hundreds of oxen were sacrificed to appease the deities.<sup>8</sup> Regardless of which story is true, this finding "shattered the foundations of the Pythagorean world, and someone died."

Is this what happens when one questions the status quo of maths? Is this doomed violence against the rules what motivates the girl's silly attitude, covering herself with a mask of naivety and stupidity? Girl Math makes her point using rather subtle, subversive strategies, because she intuitively remembers how dangerous it is to oppose big boi logic inside his doctrine. She is ingrained with the survival instinct of her ancestors. She remembers how those who strayed from the path of reason were branded heretics, madmen, witches, and were drowned at sea. She intuits the cost of appearing irrational in a world that treats logic as law. So, instead of moving directly in opposition to logic, she makes logic go sideways. She jokes. She exaggerates. She memes. She says, "Girl Math kinda makes sense to me, idk why are you so upset, I'm literally just a dumb and harmless girl." Arguably, that's the smartest thing the girl does: act naive and dumb, because she knows that if she makes you laugh at her, then you won't burn her at the stake.

After centuries of mathematicians redefining what counts as a number, a proof, and even *truth*, we can step back and ask: Is this what the girl is currently doing? Is she breaking the foundations of mathematics? The answer is yes and no. Yes, according to the boys clutching their axioms. No, according to every great mathematician who rewrote old rules to make new fields of mathematics possible. When a girl explains Girl Math with examples

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8 Vinay Kathotia. "The Unreasonable Man." Cambridge Maths. Accessed 15/10/2025. <https://www.cambridgemaths.org/errors/404.aspx?aspxerrorpath=/blogs/unreasonable-man/>.

like "cash is free," "returning something to the store is equal to making a profit," or "if I book and pay for my holiday now, by the time it comes around, it's free," she is invoking mathematical power. Indeed, each of these statements functions as a type of axiom within the Girl Math system: starting assumptions we accept without proof. She is also playing with the terms—"profit" now includes returns, 'free' now includes prepaid holidays—therefore giving new definitions to terms within her system. From these axioms and definitions, logical consequences follow: if cash is free, spending doesn't reduce net wealth; if returns count as profit, every return is a positive contribution and can be spent on another latte. Mathematically speaking, she is constructing a conceptual world, a playful version of pure math. She chooses the rules, explores the outcomes, and creates an internally consistent system, even if she might later change her mind. Girl Math, in this sense, is precisely what pure mathematicians do: build worlds, test their consequences, discover truths relative to the rules they've set, destroy, build again.

## A Simple Demonstration

We can actually mathematically prove Girl Math. Let's explore what a Girl Math proof might look like by proving the following Girl Math Theorem: Upon returning a dress worth 50 to the store and swapping it for a shirt worth 30, we yield a profit of 20.

First, let  $X$  be the set of clothes at a store. Two items  $x, y \in X$  are defined as such:

$x := \text{dress worth } £50$

$y := \text{shirt worth } £30$

Let us define a function  $f : X \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^+$  for returning a dress to the store. This function maps an item of clothing, to a strictly positive number, namely the worth of the item.

$$f(x) = 50$$

$$f(y) = 30$$

Upon the return of an item ( $x$ ) and the picking of a new one ( $y$ ) profit, or gain function is defined as Profit =  $f(x) - y$ . So, in Girl Math, the process looks like

$$f(x) \rightarrow y + 20,$$

thus yielding a profit of £20.  $\square$

Upon finalising a proof, a mathematician concludes their argument with this tiny square. Alternatively, they use the abbreviation Q.E.D. (quod erat demonstrandum: that which needed to be demonstrated). Similarly, a girl concludes her mathematics by giggling, "Girl Math!" And of course, the boys will despair...

## Boy Math Ideology

### Boys Just Don't Get It

After Girl Math had her moment, boys were quick to mimic their own version of mathematics online, because after all, they can't let us have anything. The first Boy Math meme version on the internet—the one below—demonstrates how the logic would operate. Of course, it is written by boys, for boys, and it's very unfunny.



The earliest online conceptions of Boy Math were based on deduction and optimisation, explicitly oriented towards saving money—a plain, factual way to do math. It lacked the poetry, playfulness, and delusions that made Girl Math so relatable.

Girls were pretty quick to eclipse this variant. Here's what happened. Trigger warning: fragile male egos, proceed with caution. This might hurt.



Slowly but surely, *boy math* escaped the world of finance bros and was co-opted by girls to laugh at the delusional logic boys preach every day (see the memes above). In a flash, the girls started producing way funnier content, to the point that their satire even made the

boys laugh. Touche. But what happened here? Did the joke get hijacked for a gender-war mud-fight? Or did it expose a deeper issue in gendered rhetorics?

Boy Math, for purposes of this article, refers to a deep tendency to cling to numeric formulas and a fundamental belief in a global, binary and unquestionable truth. Often, this doctrine is violent and forces reality to conform to its abstract models. This paradigm can be exemplified by this non-exhaustive list of boy behaviours: counting macros, looksmaxxing, an unshakeable belief in crypto, freaking out over the dropping birth rate, investing in effective altruism, and demanding infinite economic growth on a finite planet. On Urban Dictionary, a user named boymather defines the term similarly:

## boy math



The mathematics behind committing literal financial crimes. Typically boy math can refer to crypto scams, NFTs, or tax evasion.

*Did you hear about the Silicon Valley Bank fiasco?*

*Yeah, that's was some serious boy math.*

**by boymather November 17, 2023**

Let's now dive into our own characterisation of Boy Math, as we are relatively uninterested in smashing fragile egos and want to have a constructive conversation about the heritage of logic.

### Who's the Boy, and Is He a True Mathematician?

Just as the girl is not a human, not a biological entity, not a gender, a boy is not either. A boy is an archetype, a distilled pattern of thought and behaviour, a mathematical logic embodied in a persona. He is the embodiment of rigid optimisation, crude statements, and binary thinking. A boy believes there is a "correct" path for everything: the right investment, the perfect rice-to-chicken ratio, and the optimal dating strategy. The boy thinks emotions are a distraction and empathy is a problem. He lives in a world of absolutes, where assumptions are invisible rules and deviations from the norm are either mere errors to be corrected or outliers to be ignored. In short, a boy is a system: predictable, internally consistent, and deeply committed to maximising outcomes while minimising ambiguity. It is the ruling system of our apocalyptic neoliberal technocratic world.



The boy uses math with his own agenda and on his own premises, forcing reality to fit his model. Boy Math is based on false dichotomies and requires binary outcomes. It commands a formula for everything, designs a world where efficiency is worshipped, and context barely exists. In other words, Boy Math is structurally incapable of being silly. It believes in absolutes, prizes predictability, and treats its axioms as commandments rather than choices. Unlike pure mathematics, he does not allow his assumptions to be questioned. He uses proof by intimidation, oppresses alternative modes of reasoning, and if his arguments don't stick, he might just drown someone at sea. But the girl has a weapon against him. Girl looks at Boy and laughs at him. She pities his cute little brain that is so busy with its predictable thought patterns that it can't bear nuance, contradiction, or relational complexity.



The Cambridge Dictionary of Philosophy states that "an irrational belief is one that obviously conflicts with what one should know."<sup>9</sup> This characterisation of an irrational belief is identical with the psychiatric characterisation of a delusion." The irrational is not only wrong—she's literally crazy. Yet the concept of rationality itself is surprisingly subjective and hard to pin down. The Cambridge Dictionary of Philosophy initially defines rationality as a purely normative concept: "if it is rational, we ought to choose it." By definition, then, a rationalist is always right. However, the text immediately concedes that this definition is paradoxical: "often, competing actions, beliefs, or desires count as rational." In other words, rationality is a universal rule that's different for everyone.

To work around these contradictions, the Dictionary suggests that within the rationalist doctrine, irrationality provides a more stable basis for a universal definition of rationality. All accounts can agree that "to say [something] is irrational is to claim that it should always be avoided." Rationality, it follows, is anything that is not irrational. It's genuinely poetic that rationality becomes most unambiguous only when defined by its disowned twin, irrationality.

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9 Cambridge Dictionary of Philosophy. 3rd ed. Cambridge University Press, 2015.

In light of this definition, we could revisit the story of Hippasus and the Pythagoreans and ask ourselves whether drowning the guy was a rational decision (assuming it was the Pythagoreans who did it). For the Pythagoreans, irrational numbers obviously conflicted with what they knew. An irrational number was considered a textbook irrational because it contradicted their "all is number" belief. Other rationalists might argue that losing a life over a mathematical argument is irrational, as it is precisely the type of thing we generally ought to avoid. What is rational remains a normative judgement: it depends. To fully understand the origins of the rationality doctrine, we should begin by debunking its foundational myth: the idea that the earliest philosophical thought originated in Man, specifically in three Greek boys: Socrates, Plato, and Aristotle.

## Three Greek Boys

### Boy Math Descendants

In Western rational history, the lexicon generally starts with Plato. We consider him the Boy Math patient zero, although one might question whether he would have agreed with said doctrine. In Plato's Theory of Forms, the philosopher claims that proper form does not exist in the messy material world but rather in the realm of abstraction. The world we see is imperfect and contingent, a perceivable reality that Plato saw as a degraded reflection of a purer, more abstract essence. For example, there are circular things everywhere: tree trunks, the sun, our veins. However, the 'perfect' circle is one we can only create in our minds. This is the core idea of Plato's cave: a philosopher's task is to turn away from the imperfect shadows and seek the proper Form that casts them. In many ways, boy math starts here: Plato made a deliberate move away from organic textures and toward theoretical perfection. The philosopher believed this type of thinking to be of a higher form than what was possible in the material world, therefore becoming the daddy of mind over matter. Trust the idea, not the body. Plato walked so Silicon Valley could run the simulation.

### Aristotle's Teachings

*"We think we have scientific knowledge of a thing only when we think that we know the cause on which the fact depends." - Aristotle in Posterior Analytics*

Aristotle was Plato's successor, and a worthy, true patient 1 of boy math, as his philosophy paved the way for Andrew Tate-type reasoning. In the philosophical history folklore, Aristotle applied Plato's vision of the mind over matter to later turn to his own visions of rationality and ways of describing natural order. In the article presenting Aristotle's legacy on the Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy, Marc Cohen describes how, 'in Aristotle's logic, the basic ingredients of reasoning are given in terms of inclusion and exclusion rela-

tions, of the sort graphically captured many years later by the device of Venn diagrams.<sup>10</sup> Aristotle's philosophy differed from Plato's in that sense that he stepped out of the theory of abstract forms and claimed order and hierarchy in the natural world with the following motto: "Better known by nature."

Aristotle had argued that reasoning is separate from the truth, revealing that one can easily prove nonsense on the basis of false premises. This can be illustrated by a very simple example: "If the earth is a donut, then the earth must have a hole" is deductively true given that the first premise is required. According to Aristotle's own words in *Posterior Analytics*: 'simply saying that something is the case if it is the case, by which device, it is easy to prove anything'.<sup>11</sup> Aristotle posed that true premises would always lead to true conclusions. But how would we know which premises are true? The philosopher insisted that the necessity of finding true premises must lie in "the nature of things." But seeking truth in the natural world required categorization and hierarchical dichotomies. In his worldview, those natural premises included: the notion that there are fundamental differences between the sexes and that men were of a higher hierarchy, as well as a natural and undeniable fundamental difference between master and slave. Out of the many ways we could have chosen to dictate categories, he designed the following:<sup>12</sup>

"The male, unless constituted in some respect contrary to nature, is by nature more expert at leading than the female, and the elder and complete than the younger and incomplete."

"The relation of male to female is by nature a relation of superior to inferior and ruler to ruled."

"The slave is wholly lacking the deliberative element; the female has it, but it lacks authority; the child has it, but it is incomplete."

As the citations show, the philosopher believed that women, like slaves, lacked the capacity to fully understand logic and partake in philosophy. In the blog post 10 controversial things Aristotle said about women, Shawn Buckles reveals the misogynistic premises on which this theory was built.<sup>13</sup>

10 Marc Cohen. "Aristotle." *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*. Accessed 28/10/2025, <https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/aristotle/>.

11 Aristotle, *Posterior Analytics*. Translated by Jonathan Barnes. Clarendon Press, 1994.

12 Aristotle. *Politics*. Translated by H. Rackham. Loeb Classical Library. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1932.

13 Shawn Buckles. "10 Controversial Things Aristotle Said About Women." *Wisdom Short*. Accessed 20/10/2025, <https://wisdomshort.com/philosophers/aristotle/on-women>.

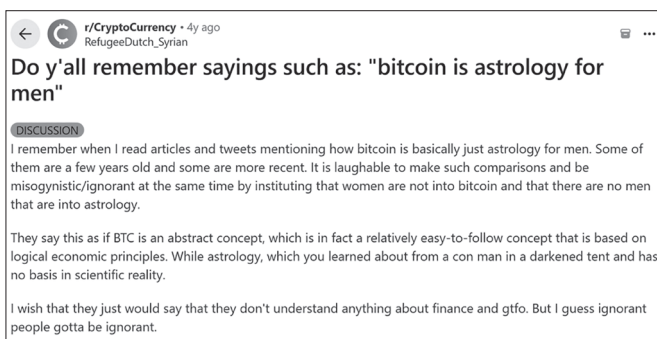
"When you consider Aristotle's take on psychology, he saw women as less capable of rational thought compared to men. He felt that women were more excitable and governed by their emotions, which undermined their ability to reason as effectively as men."

In that matter, we can conclude that Aristotle was definitely a boy:<sup>14</sup> his views on natural order read as the earliest red pill white male supremacy content. Thank the gods there is Girl Math. All this to say that, when the girls online called their silly economic philosophy *Girl Math*, I think they had a point.

## Formalising Girl Math

### Astrology: A Possible Lineage of Girl Math?

We are arriving at our final destination: an emergent mathematical formulation of Girl Math Fundamentals—which, by the way, I invented myself. What if we start mathematically formalizing historically marginalized communal systems of thought? Before we dive in the math, let's have a quick look at a concrete manifestation of Girl Math. A cute point of departure for this journey through reason is (of course) astrology. A few years ago, the joke that crypto trading is really just astrology for boys went viral. The analogy obviously pissed them off, as illustrated in the below Reddit rant:



A boy sees astrology as nothing but extremely inaccurate statistical predictions used to scam people by giving them a false sense of hope. To crypto boys, there's nothing worse than being compared to something as 'stupid as astrology', a practice that is often dismissed as 'unscientific'. Indeed, the idea that celestial patterns correspond to human behaviour isn't empirically verifiable. However, these critics conveniently forget that all logical systems are

14 Mela Miekus and Mita Medri. "Silly Girl Theory, Scrolling the Digital Playgrounds." Institute of Network Cultures, February 16, 2024. <https://networkcultures.org/longform/2024/02/16/silly-girl-theory-scrolling-the-digital-playgrounds/>.

based on unverifiable assumptions. Within its own framework, astrology is a closed logical system: it operates through clearly defined entities (planets, signs, houses, aspects) and consistent transformation rules (transits, retrogrades). The reasoning inside this system is valid: the logic holds, even if the system's axioms aren't 'true' in the physicalist sense. Mathematically speaking, that's allowed. Formal systems don't need to be *true* to be *coherent*. Geometry still works on a flat plane, even though we know space is curved. Classical logic still works, even if the universe is quantum. What matters in math is internal consistency: that the operations preserve structure relative to their own assumptions. Referring to the famous quote often attributed to George Box, in applied mathematics, it is "all models are wrong, but some are useful". If we know that we're all wrong all the time, then why discriminate between economics and astrology?

When an astrologist says, "Venus in Aries means desire moves fast and impulsively," it's a valid deduction from a symbolic grammar where Venus = attraction, Aries = action, and their combination = passionate pursuit. Whether or not Venus actually influences anyone is irrelevant to the logic of the statement. In short, astrology *maths*: it's a rigorous interpretive calculus of symbolic correspondences. If astrology is a closed logical system, a set of rules, and inference moves, then nothing in principle stops us from formalising it the way mathematicians formalise any other theory. Pick your primitives (planets, signs, houses), write down the axioms (what each symbol means), make your transformation rules (combinations of symbolic meanings), and then derive consequences for the next Mercury retrograde. It would be an amusing exercise to mathematically prove astrology: to write down the whole doctrine in a set of axioms, some inference rules, some definitions, and a bunch of mathematical formulas, and publish it with the claim that Astrology is mathematically rigorous. Suddenly, scientists would pull their hair, bite their nails, see their paradigm collapse, screaming, "BUT YOUR ASSUMPTIONS ARE WRONG!!!" And then the girlies would giggle, "All models are wrong, but some are pretty and useful."

To take Girl Math seriously is to consider that just because it's math doesn't mean it has to be true. By speaking in the dialect of formalism, we expose the political studs that prop up what counts as "rational." Essentially, a formal Girl Math argument uses proof by subversion, deliberately provoking the boys to dismantle the logical house they built themselves. Let's leave the classic "cash is free" Girl Math examples behind and go up a few levels of abstraction. In essence, what point are the girls making? What is their larger philosophy about? In Girl Math, something is true because it feels true, because we are resonating with the statement, because we need it to feel good, or because it's funny. In Girl Math, the truth is vibe-based: an "it depends"-type of truth, built by noticing patterns between things and contextualising how we feel about them, rather than an external authority declaring what's fact. Girl Math is essentially 'omg, same!'-math. It is at this point that Category Theory becomes interesting. This relatively new field of abstract mathematics, first formalised in the 1940s by Eilenberg and Mac Lane, was called "generalised abstract nonsense," which sounds like a perfect basis for formal Girl Math.<sup>15</sup> What was so novel about Category Theory?

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15 Samuel Eilenberg and Saunders Mac Lane. "General Theory of Natural Equivalences." *Transactions of the American Mathematical Society* 58, no. 2 (1945): 231–294.

## Category Theory as a Secret Ingredient for Girl Math

Imagine traditional mathematics, from now on called trad math, as a big tree. The roots and trunk are the foundational axioms, and the different branches of the tree symbolise the branches of mathematics: algebra, number theory, set theory, Galois theory, etc.. Now, before Category Theory was invented, mathematicians would be solving a math problem somewhere on a leaf in this tree, and then realise that they recognised the problem to be structurally similar to one they had encountered all the way on the other side of the tree. They then have to formally climb this tree and tediously figure out how to reach the top, while occasionally taking wrong turns, getting lost, and climbing back onto the right path. Once their destination was reached, the mathematicians would solve the problem of that particular leaf and then take it with them to climb all the way back to where they started. This results in lengthy, tedious proofs that can span hundreds of pages or a whole stack of books. That was until Category Theory. If you already know that your current problem is similar to the other problem, why don't you just jump from one leaf to the other? If we know that the tree is meaningfully connected, why show off all the acrobatics required to get from one place to the other? Just fly there. Category Theory poses: if you can show that your problem can be translated into another problem, you are allowed to jump there, take their solution, and translate it back to your problem, as though they defined the air surrounding the tree. Needless to say, the type of mathematicians who spent thirty years of their life on mathematical acrobatics inside the math tree were quite pissed that these pseudo-mathematicians suggested they could have simply flown there. Despite the initial backlash, Category Theory's "abstract nonsense" has stood the test of time and is now widely used within and beyond formal mathematics.

Category Theory resembles "*omg, same*"-math, as all we need is some reasonable equivalence between worlds. Two systems don't need to *be* identical; they need to be *the same-ish*. It is fine for things to behave alike even if they don't look alike at all. Once you start thinking that way, you realise this style of thinking isn't at all limited to abstract mathematics. The old mathematicians (*trad mathers*) stayed stuck climbing the same tree, but Category Theory gave mathematicians abstract portals. The "objects" don't have to be numbers or shapes anymore. They could be meanings, moods, memes. If they consistently relate to each other, they can live in a mathematical category.

But what exactly is a category? A category  $\mathcal{C}$  consists of:

1. **Objects:** A collection of entities, usually denoted  $A, B, C, \dots$
2. **Morphisms (arrows between objects):** A morphism represents a relationship or transformation between two objects. For objects  $A$  and  $B$ , a morphism  $f$  is  $f: A \rightarrow B$
3. **Composition:** If one morphism connects  $A$  to  $B$ , and another morphism connects  $B$  to  $C$ , then  $A$  must connect to  $C$ .

4. **Identity morphisms:** Every object has a “do nothing” morphism that maps the object to itself.

In Girl Math terms, a category C consists of:

1. **Objects:** *things* girls care about
2. **Morphisms:** the *vibes* between things
3. **Composition:** If there's a vibe between A and B, and there's a vibe between B and C, then there's also a vibe between A and C (namely, through B).
4. **Identity morphism:** an object, say a girl, can ponder “*but what if I'm right?*” in which case her situation stays the same.

The fundamental difference between Category Theory and *trad math*, is that the focus is not so much on the things themselves, but rather how they interact. It means we do not have to spend as much time on defining the object, but the object gets defined by its relevant connections. This is extremely powerful for complex systems, such as (and there she is again): astrology! Astrology apps like Co-star are often coded in Haskell, which is a programming language based on... (drum roll)... Category Theory.<sup>16</sup> Trying to encode astrology in *trad math* would be like trying to fit a cloud into a box. *Trad math* relies on fixed objects and rigid rules: numbers have exact values, operations are deterministic, and proofs are step-by-step. Astrology isn't deterministic in *that* way. If you tried to describe astrology in trad math, you'd have to assign exact definitions to inherently fuzzy concepts, such as “love potential = 7.3” or “career vibe = 5”, and define rules for combining them. But these rules will collapse under the complexity of all possible interactions, or they'd reduce astrology to a rigid doctrine, which it isn't. We would be losing the relational richness and interpretable freedom that make astrology so meaningful.

Category Theory solves this issue of mathematical rigidity because it doesn't care so much about the details of the objects themselves. Instead, it focuses only on morphisms: how things relate and interact. A planet's meaning might not be a fixed definition; it's instead a relationship between objects (planet, house, sign, person) that can be contextualised. Say two astrologers disagree on what Mars means. One sees Mars as aggression; the other sees it as desire. In a category-theoretic model, you don't need to rebuild the entire cosmos just because Mars got rebranded. Instead, you simply open up the “Mars” box, tweak its internal mappings, and the overall structure of correspondences still holds. This adaptability is why CoStar uses a category theory-based programming language like Haskell. They earn their money by giving hyper-personalised predictions, which require continuously changing the

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16 Co-Star Astrology. “Why Haskell.” Accessed 20/10/2025. <https://www.costarastrology.com/why-haskell>.

astrological model they use for your daily horoscope. These predictions are based in part on their astrological model combined with your birth chart, and in part on optimisations of your personal preferences to lure you back to their app every day.

Once you've gone through all this, it becomes hard *not* to see how crypto and astrology are secretly cousins. Both claim to formalise *vibes* into *systems*. Both use symbolic logic to track invisible forces (be it planetary or economic) that supposedly shape the future. Both attract followers who speak a specialised dialect ("moon in Aries," "bull market") and believe that, with the correct chart or chain, you can predict the future. The observed structural similarity between the two fields lies at the heart of the 'crypto is astrology for boys' joke, which can be mathematically formalised and possibly even proven using category theory.

If we consider Astro and Crypto as categories, the girls online claim they are categorically equivalent. To support this claim, two categories could be defined and shown to share a common structure. For instance, in **Astro**, the *objects* could be planets, signs, houses; the *morphisms* could be aspects and transits. In **Crypto**, the *objects* are entities like tokens, wallets, and exchanges; the *morphisms* transactions, swaps, and correlations. Between the two categories, certain concepts share a similar vibe, and we could describe this similarity by defining a *functor*: a mapping between categories.

Let us define a functor F:

Astro  $\rightarrow$  Crypto

Planets  $\rightarrow$  Tokens

Transits  $\rightarrow$  Price movements

Retrogrades  $\rightarrow$  Bear markets

Conjunctions  $\rightarrow$  Mergers

A retrograde in astrology is the moment a planet appears to move backward, which symbolises a time for re-evaluation. Similarly, a bear market is a moment of collective doubt in crypto, a loss of momentum. To show that F: Astro  $\rightarrow$  Crypto are categorically equivalent, we need to shape both the Astro and Crypto categories in such a way that we can draw a vibe-arrow between each of the objects and morphisms. The beauty is that we do not need similarity or exact same-ness; we instead need a *kind of same-ish* vibe.

In this formulation, the *pattern girlies* don't actually need to become data scientists or cite existing research to be mathematically rigorous in their theories. They can simply formalise their intuitions and write down made-up theories. Describing these formulas in dry, abstract, mathematical language casts the girl as brilliant and correct. In doing so, she mirrors the



"proof by authority" that *Boy Math* has long monopolised. Contrary to her evil twin, Girl Math is quite aware of the ambiguity of it all, but alas, she can live with multiple realities. Where Boy Math seeks certainty, Girl Math alchemises vibes and contradictions.

## Girl Math is Pure Vibes

So far, we've laid the foundation for a rhetoric we call Metaphorical Proof. Such proof doesn't demand that two things be identical; it's enough to show they behave similarly enough for a pattern to hold. This 'Omg, same!' feeling is formalised as a mathematical isomorphism, which sounds legit. When a girl claims that 'buying something on sale is basically saving money', she is performing a Metaphorical Proof through vibe preservation. The math works not because it's true in a universal sense, but because it *feels* internally consistent to her lived reality. Girls online recognise themselves in it, and that resonance constitutes its proof. The swarm relatability renders the theory true. (*Statistics, hello?*)

This leads us to one of the most beautiful and radical features of Category Theory: the *Truth Object*. In *trad math*, truth is a global constant: either true or false, a binary light switch that applies everywhere in the system. On the contrary, Category Theory allows us to *redefine what truth means* in different contexts; each category can have its own internal logic. In the category of quantum physics, for example, truth becomes probabilistic, an 'it depends'-type truth: a superposition of possibilities. Formal Girl Math goes one step further: its truth object is not binary or probabilistic, but subjectively resonant. In her world, something is true if it vibrates between girlies, if it holds aesthetic, emotional, or social coherence. Girl Math's truth object could be defined as: the degree of vibration between a statement and a subject. Truth as such is not imposed from above; it's felt from within. Every mathematician secretly intuits that truth is a feeling: a proof isn't proven until it makes sense to you.

This paradigm shift from binaries to vibes also echoes Donna Haraway's refusal of the true/false dichotomy. In her *Cyborg Manifesto*, she suggests that purity itself is the problem, that concepts such as natural/artificial, male/female, good/bad were never opposites but co-dependent fabrications. From a Girl Math perspective, a statement and its contradiction can coexist as equally valid morphisms in the same category. "Men oppress women" and "women exploit men" can both be true, depending on which morphism you're following—which node of power you inhabit. Girl Math merely makes explicit what math has always been: a poetics of abstract forms. We reimagine rigour. Instead of an objective, global truth, we propose a vibrational truth. Instead of proving by contradiction, we prove by recognitions delivered as ironic jokes. In the *Cyborg Manifesto*, Donna Haraway describes irony as follows:<sup>17</sup>

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17 Donna Haraway. "A Cyborg Manifesto." In *Simians, Cyborgs, and Women: The Reinvention of Nature*. New York: Routledge, 1991. (Page cited: 3.)

"Irony is about contradictions that do not resolve into larger wholes, even dialectically, about the tension of holding incompatible things together because both or all are necessary and true. Irony is about humour and serious play. It is also a rhetorical strategy and a political method, one I would like to see more honoured within socialist-feminism."

Long live the queen. Since we agree with Haraway's perspective on the fundamental reality of truth, we craft Girl Math Fundamentals in a way that will hold contradictions. For instance, if we claim 'boys are dumb', we implicitly acknowledge possible situations in which boys are smart. If we declare 'cash is free,' we also concede the financial reality that sometimes cash is valuable. This embedded contradiction space preserves the freedom of pattern expression, the poetry and play that underpin Critical Girl Theory. As we construct the formal Girl Math universe, we choose to embed a fundamental truth duality: *everything I just said, but reversed, is always also true*. This way, no matter what she says, a girl is per definition always right.

arvidabystrom 2h

Can someone make like a PI equation out of this for me

*I barely understand this but I think they're right*

$$B = \pi : \{P(B|S) = G, P(B|G) = S\}$$

B = Bisexual  
S = Straight  
G = Gay  
P(x|y) = Perception of x from the perspective of y

Thus:

- Straights perceive Bi as Gay
- Gays perceive Bi as Straight

→ Bisexuality =  $\pi$ -loop between S and G

## Girl Math Manifesto

*It's true for me but you do you  
If it resonates, it is right.  
No need for research.  
No data science or evidence.  
Authority is a performance.  
The language of mathematical certainty,  
mirrors and mocks Boy Math.  
Math symbols make a girl sound smart and right.  
Girls know truth is paradoxical  
Contradictions are necessary and true.  
And if vibes are everything,  
Girls are never wrong.  
Oh my god, same!  
The girls who get it, get it.  
Q.E.D  
Quintessentially Emotionally Demonstrated.*

**Irma Mastenbroek** is a Berlin-based digital rights activist and technofeminist. With a background in mathematics, she specializes in network science, optimization, and artificial intelligence (AI). Irma founded LODelle, a platform for digital feminist networks, and is an active participant in the Digital Intimacy Coalition. This collaborative initiative aims to hold major online pornography platforms accountable, promoting a rebuilt industry focused on mutual consent and sexual empowerment. Professionally, Irma researches AI bias and works on issues related to AI auditing and non-discrimination law. She co-organized an AI art exhibition, curated for re:publica, and has spoken at both CCC and re:publica events. Currently, she is developing a new mathematical field designed to formalize historically marginalized areas of reasoning.

## BECOMING AND UNBECOMING – EASTERN EUROPEAN GIRLHOOD ONLINE

SALOME BERDZENISHVILI

Originally published April 23rd, 2025

I want to trace the shift of girlhood in Eastern Europe, of girls who were born in politically and culturally turbulent post-soviet 90s and early 2000s, the turbulency that later on found itself locked and frozen in the memes, cloaked in soft-edged irony on Tumblr, Instagram, and TikTok.

But before entering this particular *Girlcore*, I want to start with the algorithmic detours.



I type #soviet, #postsoviet, #easterneurope, #easternbloc in the search engine on Instagram, whilst the platform takes me to a temporal limbo of brutalist and socialist-modernist architecture, prevailing in Eastern European countries. The more I scroll, the more this visual field is dominated by dimly lit Eastern European Khrushchyovka apartment blocks, where the moodboard centers around the shades of grey, faded blue, and dark brown, lulled by Molchat Doma's (literally) any track.

Or I find myself in front of dystopian-looking bus stop in the middle of nowhere flirting with Tarkowskian cinematography, the caption luring me into buying a paper edition of *Soviet Bus Stops Vol. 1*, *Vol. 2*, and another collection titled *Soviet Metro Stations*.

I am pretty sure I don't need it. In fact, I've had enough. Although the fun part for potential customers is the caption promising them edition box sets, prints, and LP soundtrack, except for some reason, the deal does not specify what kind of soundtrack is actually included. I wonder which sound would go well with Soviet Metro stations and bus stops, and continue scrolling, next stop being an educational Instagram page curating ANYthing Soviet, ranging from communist posters to Russian prima ballerina's Irina Kolpakova's performance in Leningrad, in 1972, from Soviet color TV sets to a random photograph of a person standing next to a LADA in Kaliningrad, 1982. It's all arbitrary. The page is trying to sell communist-coded T-shirts for 30 euros each, with the USSR logo printed on them.



I am stuck on the platform. And the platform is always in flux, continuously redefining lived experiences as residues from the past. I am drawn to *ugly, dysfunctional and hysterical*, and I want to see my stance as a point of departure.

The Soviet past is ugly because of how I think of the 90s, full of poverty, gruesomeness and the intensified instinct of survival. Whether through revolutions or wars in some post-soviet countries, or through standing in the endless queues for bread, or celebrating rare moments when electricity and gas would return, the ugliness lies in what we were left with after the system fed off itself, and when it was no longer forever.

It is dysfunctional because of its very infrastructure: multi-storey apartment blocks and the coin-operated elevators built in Soviet times are spaces that are now crumbling, and this infrastructural breakdown is dysfunctional and fragile. There is a Soviet

Georgian film shot in 1984, *Blue Mountains, or an Unbelievable Story*, which follows a young author battling with Soviet bureaucracy trying to publish his novel, just to find himself neglected every time he goes to the publishing house. One of the key scenes of the film centers around an elevator that often needs to be fixed, people get trapped inside, that then forces them to wait for a technician to come, and the wait becomes a story.

This is to say that metaphorically, the bureaucratic failures of the late Soviet state mirrors the dysfunctionalities and flaws of living experiences. However, the contrast between the material and digital representations of either abandoned or malfunctioned infrastructure is that the *Digital* does not disguise itself as order. Instead, it pretends it is on stage, continuously failing itself, and the failing here becomes an ultimate script. The infrastructure crumblessness is then intentional, aestheticised.

This is hysterical.

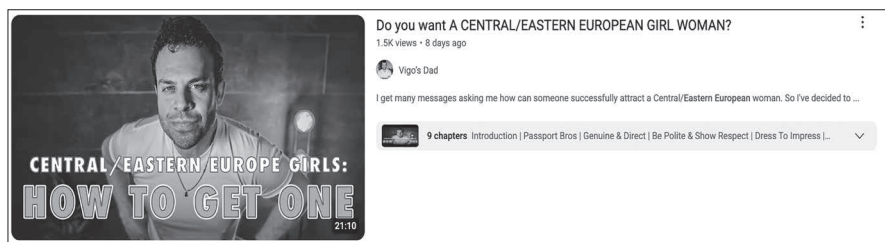
Because it insists for being explicit in nature, something grand. Brutalist architecture within the Soviet paradigm often mirrors this insistence: 8-to-15-storey buildings, generic in colour which is, in most cases, grey like a concrete. Their roofs are also quite utopian, as they overlook the landscape of other twin-like building blocks built in a certain trajectory. This reminds me of 2007 film *4 Months, 3 Weeks and 2 Days*, about two girls trying to get an illegal abortion in communist Romania, the film being full of memory souvenirs and soviet interior from the late days of the Ceausescu era, or a 2002 film *Lilya 4ever*, about Lilya and her friend, Volodya, living in Russia, fantasizing about a better life.

Here, the main plot-twist scene happens on the roof, when they stare across the foggy Silent-Hill-mooded landscape, as a getaway from the living reality. This is hysterical because it screams the endlessness of brutalism, sad in nature, and syncs well with T.a.t.u girls singing „They Won't Catch Us“, running away in a snowstorm while being on a crumbling car.

*Girls.*

I am drawn to these because they are familiar and familial, and I continue scrolling. I type #easterneuropeangirl, #easternbloc, #postsovietgirl in the search bar.

Doing the same thing on Youtube firstly takes me to the video, with a caption: „Do You Want a Central/Eastern European Girl Woman?



The video has 9 parts. It opens with an introduction, stating that this video is going to be about Central/Eastern Europeans as a group with similarities<sup>1</sup>, and continues with defining what a *passport bro*<sup>1</sup> is. The narrative here takes a form of how-to manual for men fantasizing about women, who, and I quote: „still possess the core values that have been abandoned by Western womanhood, that being these women wanting to cook for men, to pamper them, to make them feel like they are the king of the household. At the same time, they are gorgeous, they take care of themselves, they cook in the kitchen while looking like runway models“. One of his tips for getting „Eastern European women girls“ is to be genuine: „they don’t like masks, they have been raised by fathers and mothers that have been as direct as it comes, okay?“.

The heteronormative, manosphere-driven presuppositions of what an Eastern European „girl woman“, to cite Vigo’s Dad, stands for, is a classic dollified imagery for the latter. On a last note, the author finishes his video with the most relevant twist to the story, which is, to have patience towards them, „because sometimes they tend to be explosive“, and due to this, men should enter the stage to maintain endurance and tolerance. He continues by giving a short lecture on the culture in Eastern and Central Europe being stoic – that women here tend to be tough, which he calls a generational trauma. This interpretation sillifies the matter at hand, and misreads both stoicism and trauma. To reduce the complexity of Eastern and Central European womanhood to trauma that must be “handled” or “waited out” by male patience is not only patronizing, but also erases the radically different historical trajectories and lived experiences that shaped these regions throughout the 20th century. Moreover, to homogenise these experiences under the guise of generational damage decontextualises history and further reinforces a gendered colonial gaze.

1 Passport bro is a neologism coined to describe Western men who date or marry women from developing countries

But this essay is not a history lesson.

I want to go back to the dollified gaze that is created by certain male community towards Eastern European women. I argue that there is a sharp difference between manosphere's built-in-Disneyland imagery towards women in general, and the specific fantasy they construct around „Eastern European women girls“. The difference is that here, the fantasy towards the East is a bit *tilted*: these women are a bit dysfunctional, because they might be of *an explosive nature*. They are *a bit out of order*, just like Soviet elevators. Furthermore, the need to be patient with them implies that these women are in need of fixing or rescuing. Yet, fixing here is framed not as a tool to change something in women, but as an opportunity for men to demonstrate their enduring qualities. And change for these women is not necessary because, being *just a bit out of it* is part of the fantasy.

This commodification of invented womanhood, especially by this certain gaze, frames her as a mere function. Heather Warren-Crow works with an understanding of girlhood as an idea of mobility preceding the fixity of womanhood and implying an unfinished process of personal development.

Girlhood is, perhaps, a state of unfinishedness, unfinishedness and plasticity that is both precondition and a product of becoming. Becoming then, happens through stories, relationality between those stories, elasticity, flexibility, morphing, destruction, and reinvention.



In this essay, I understand digital girlhood formed and constituted by Eastern Europe as not necessarily a dominant digital self-representation but a *fragmented girliness* that centers around the peripheries of implicit or explicit understandings on how to be a girl online, and how to perform this discourse. This particular girliness is fragmented because it draws from disconnected, often contradictory cultural and digital discourses.

For example, in 2023, a Russian song from the 2000s, “Moy Marmeladny” (My Marmalade), went viral on TikTok and Instagram, serving #EasternEuropeanGirlCore, with an emphasis on Slavic-ness, often accompanied by girls wearing slavic fur hats and fur coats in the wintry weather while lip-syncing to the lyrics. Yet, for me and other Georgians, the song’s resurgence was unsettling. In the context of Russia’s centuries-long bloody colonial history toward Georgia, this seemingly innocent trend carried a weight of historical and political significance. The next thing I see is a Georgian content creator, @foxy\_eleniko taking a similar video, but with a plot twist: the soundtrack was accompanied by a footage of the Russian invasion.



When observing different social media platforms, it is often noticeable that Eastern European girliness is mostly framed through Slavic lens, which then focuses on shared stereotypical tropes of Slavic femininity, precisely, pale skin, thin bodies, greyness, whiteness, white, white, white. There is a dissonance in relating to this aesthetic. By subsuming Eastern European digital girlhood into a singular Slavic identity risks overshadowing the nuances of other Eastern European countries that are not part of Slavic culture. “Doing Eastern European girlhood” on the internet in a Slavic way is not that much resisted through memes or other visual content, but it is commodified and reproduced, almost like a default. This generates a confusing mix of cultural tropes drawn from disparate geographies and histories: if a Russiangirlcore with its elegant fur hats and fur coats, endless winter and song *Moy Marmeladnyi* is a dominant visual and affective representation of this particular girlhood online — does relating to this aesthetic mean I am playing into the image of the coloniser? Where is the boundary between identification and disidentification? Aesthetic pleasure and political unease?



There is a political discomfort to experiencing a digital girlhood. So then, *who gets to call themselves a post-Soviet girl?*

Some visual representations of certain cultural tropes on the internet have an ability to swallow the peripheral, the micro. They are exclusionary of plurality of practices and images. I frame this Girlhood within this exclusionary aesthetic, however, while it renders certain aspects of Eastern Europeanism as invisible and marginal, it also constitutes something completely new.

## This is Where I Post From

“This” is a zero-point orientation here, the point from which the world unfolds, as Husserl would write, and then “this” and “that” start to matter. And there is a distance between them.

The fact that “I” am “there”, “posting”, is the starting point for my orientation in space.

We post from grey and white, and fog, and #gloomy coquette, and #angelcore, and #grungecore, #wintercore, #slavicgirl and #sadgirl.

And that’s the point of orientation, the “this” of a digital body, and “I” of its dwelling.



Fredrika Thelandersson defines “sad girl” as a “young woman who is unashamed of her emotional life and who fearlessly acts out her pain for others to see”. Is posting “This is Where I Post From” acting out on the pain of the architecture? Is it a way to declare, “This is where I become legible?”, “This is where I suffer and remember?” Just like similar to Vidler’s analysis on Poe’s “The House of Ushers”: “the site was desolate. The walls blank and almost literally “faceless”, its windows “eye-like” but without life – “vacant”, the socialist modernist building blocks follow the same trajectory. On top of it, they are an archive of memory and tradition, embodied in their walls and objects. Yet, the latter is not a memory-driven archive in its nature, but it is a memory as performance. Through girl-coded mythmaking, it mourns something through image, becomes vacant and devoid of any empirical memory and history the moment it is decontextualised in the digital space. This does not mean that such production is devoid of meaning, it’s quite the opposite: it becomes meaningful precisely as it enters the stage of sadness, taking the role of main character playing the sorrow. This sorrow is both commodified and reclaimed by Eastern European girlhood as a digitally mundane cultural experience of the melancholia.

What this certain girlhood also reclaims, is appropriating Western girlhood on its own terms, and especially the West sadness embodied by a pop culture persona, such as Lana del Rey singing about female weakness and dependence in a way that makes it seem like she is enjoying it. Here, Lana del Rey is Svetlana del Rey, singing not Summertime Sadness but “Letnaya Pechalka” (Summertime Sadness in Russian).

During the Cold War, the Soviet Union created its own version of Winnie the Pooh—Vinni Pukh—a distinctly localized, animated bear that looked and behaved quite differently from his Disney counterpart. Characters were fashioned from Soviet Socialist Realist aesthetic, which meant that form should be subordinated to content. This was a soft-power move from the USSR to repurpose Western narratives through a distinctly Soviet lens. By no means am I comparing the Soviet Union politics with Digital girlhood, rather, I suggest that Eastern European girliness also filters and reimagines the Western pop-cultural canon by reclaiming the agency over narrative, aesthetics, and affect.



When coining the term “Sad Girl Theory”, Audrey Wollen writes that the internalised suffering women experience should be categorized as an act of resistance. Although, the trope itself often risks falling into stereotypical terrains, as in representing primarily white bodies that are the genesis of digital depression and melancholia. Mooney, in her essay “Black Carefree Girls”, notes that even in case of resistance, the latter is emerged from the contours of affective legacies of whiteness. The affective legacies that Eastern European women inherit are not necessarily those of the Western liberal subject, but rather shaped by a melancholia that stems from being both inside and outside of Europeanness, of whiteness, of the West.

And while being inbetween these social structures, Eastern European girlhood started to reclaim sadness as a normative cultural experience. Sensations of melancholia and nostalgia are merged with the Eastern European self. It is dirty and gore, but glorified and commodified, and most importantly, it is mundane.



“It must be sunny at night and snowy in August” - Nostalghia, 1983 Andrei Tarkovsky

Nostalgia works like memory; it is connected to passages, means of communication, and entangled with both remembrance and forgetting. When we remember, we risk losing

parts of ourselves, as this comes with the danger of forgetting what once was. When we remember a time that is long lost, we might be trying to remember the time that has never existed, and we start yearning for it. Nostalgia is a longing sentiment for the loss and displacement, and it dwells in the past that is not connected to the present in a way that it is not confined to the time and space.

Nostalgia does not orient itself towards the future in cyberspaces, but works as a source of fantasy, where longing is not for the past as it was, but for the past it could have been. In this sense, nostalgia becomes imaginary. Imaginary, because it deals with the border zone between longing and reflection, a speculative lifeworld where desire and memory start to blur.

The dreamy and grey landscape of dystopian buildings do not come to life, but dwell in afterlife. Robert Burton writes in "Anatomy of Melancholy", that he writes of melancholy by being busy to avoid melancholy. My relationship with Eastern European girlhood works the same way: I write about it in order to keep it at bay. But in this act of avoidance, I unintentionally reconstitute it. The very girlhood I try to escape is provoked by remembering, stylizing, and theorizing.

Eastern European digital girlhood comes with its own particular architecture, which feels almost embedded within the platforms it portrays itself. It is not just about images, but also about atmospheres algorithmically repeated into a recognisable mood. Gloomy afternoons and foggy evenings without light or shadow, just gradients of grey. Small, cramped kitchen rooms steeped in cigarette smoke. Someone by the window, staring across all the identical buildings as if they were one. I have been there, I have felt that, but the romanticized and glorified part of the image production in digital spaces makes me displaced, not only because it's oriented towards the Slaviness, but also because this type of melancholia and nostalgia it creates is overly consumable, public, and neat. It blurs the difference between being from a place and being styled after it. Its intention becomes sustaining a feeling that has been formed on the internet, and is reconstituted by the latter over and over again. So, this public feeling of nostalgia and constructed melancholia becomes part of a digital mythology this girlhood centers itself around: and it displaces some users, more than others.

I feel the displacement on the internet and I still feel stuck on the platform, the nostalgia is painful but more painful is the realisation that I cannot leave this public, curated feeling. Because this particular girlhood, with all its beauty of low-pixel images and monochronic palette intimacy has become the place for imaginary selves that never fully got to be.

This sub-cultural space becomes not just a playful memory-space, but a space for longing that is not tied to its origin.

And if this is the case, if the algorithm recycles and memeifies accumulated knowledge of the past and present across post-Eastern Bloc and post-Soviet grounds, if it feeds users back their own imaginary or non-imaginary longings through thematic filters, through monetised melancholia and platform capitalism, then what kind of authorship is left? Do I take ownership over these longings, or does algorithm do it for me? Am I the one remembering or am I being remembered by the machine?

So, in this sense, *what* gets to call itself a post-Soviet girl?



The post-Soviet girl took inspiration from early 2000s Russian social media platform Odnoklassniki.ru, which, at its peak was a digital stage for public validation. Users would publish their pictures and rate each other. If you'd get 5+ stars (which required some payment), it meant that you were high in rating. Its initial aesthetics, and broadly, its visual culture was steeped in low-pixel gore. For girls, this often meant sitting against the backdrop of a wall-mounted carpet, biting a rose, or posing in front of fast housing blocks. I remember it all being very muddy. This muddiness has now become a foundational aesthetic, just like a canon event for her. She does not care that she's acting like a mermaid in the muddy water, she doesn't need to explain it, because she's from *there*. And this "*there*" can be anything and anywhere, but that also does not matter, because the difference is already flattened, which became part of this aesthetic. Foggy weather tied to Eastern Europeanness helps to reinforce this homogeneity. It smoothes over the glitches, the bugs, the details that might localise, or individualise. So, she dissolves into mist.

She is a chainsmoker, because what do you mean you were born in Eastern Europe and don't smoke? Creative part about her is that she's double-layered, she's shy sometimes, but other times overly expressive, performative, even excessive. She loves Kafka, Dostoevsky, and all the existential male authors that suffered, again, existentially, because their pain feels like hers. Her girl dinner is coffee and cigarettes, chewing through thousand agonies of existence. She needs to make herself visible, to make herself valid.

She knows a spot, but when she takes you there it's all rust and concrete, and she's obviously wearing Adidas tracksuit with white stripes, because that's what she learnt from Slavic squatters.

Perhaps, this is all unfinished, and plastic. She ties herself to the past tropes of turbulent 90s and kitch 2000s, but she continues, mutates, and refabricates herself while aestheticising and commodifying the residue. She is also unbecoming, in that she resists finality. Aesthetically, she exists in the grey zone of fog and distortion, and in some ways, she is liminal, disorienting, always standing on the threshold. It is a loop of becoming and unbecoming that keeps Eastern European girlhood in motion, rather than in place.

This is what gets to call itself a post-Soviet girl, anything or anyone that plays with the ill-fitting curated greyness, or concrete, or dampness on the Internet. It is not a memory from a traditional theoretical standpoint, but a memory that is continuously regenerated online. She becomes a memory-maker and digital rememberer of the past she might never have lived. And the game is over.



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# YOU MAXXING: MASCULINITY, THE REDPILL, AND THE ONLINE SELF-IMPROVEMENT CULTURE

FRANCESCO BARCHIESI

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PlayLover Academy (PLA) is the foremost Italian seduction school. They offer a “social and emotional improvement” program to transform you into “the man women want”.<sup>1</sup> It is not merely a standard pick-up artist school, as there were many twenty years ago; it is a wider offer, aimed at “activating your maximum potential,” as stated on their website: they promise to work on you comprehensively. The seductive training is sold as a gateway to personal development. They *entrepreneurially take care of you*. PLA’s extensive range of services includes “improvisational theatre” to improve performance anxiety, “stylistic consulting” for a more appealing look; classic live seduction coaching, “winning back an ex,” or “reconciling a marital rift,” as well as training on finding a partner through dating sites and apps.

Of course, all these services come at a steep price.<sup>2</sup> Online courses for becoming a *playlover* start from 499 euros up to a thousand, for 12 and 30 hours of video training respectively, on “how to structure opening lines”; “how to make contact”; “how to have a steel mentality,” or perform “a total mindset reset”. In-person courses, which involve three days with a trainer at one stop of the *PlayLover Summer Tour* — afternoon trials of picking up girls on the beach, then ice cream with the bros: it’s always white boy summer<sup>3</sup> after all — start from the special price of 1499 euros, just for the privilege of enjoying each other’s company. What about *PlayLover New Year’s Eve*, which includes “three intensive days of emotional improvement, vacation, and fun”? Another thousand euros.

They make it clear: choosing PLA is just the beginning of a whole journey; “the most difficult decision to make” for those who dare to “take the dark road” and are “willing to do the opposite of what the masses do”. For those who are tired of mediocrity and want to really *start living*. PLA heavily relies on psychology — but *street psychology*, “without a grade”: be wary of the kind of professionals who don’t get you anywhere... — with “the very same principles adopted by Elon Musk, Bill Gates, Mark Zuckerberg and virtually every other celebrity and influential structure in the world”.

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1 All the following quotes are free translations from the Italian PLA’s website: <https://playloveracademy.it/>.

2 The price list is eighteen months old; it might have been adjusted for inflation in the meantime.

3 KnowYourMeme. “White Boy Summer.” Updated May 21, 2024. <https://knowyourmeme.com/memes/white-boy-summer>

In addition to online courses and in-person training, PLA offers specialized private counselling services. *PlayLover Always Training*: you can have a personal trainer available for a certain number of hours per month (depending on the subscription level), through a mix of calls and WhatsApp messaging (how is the time spent chatting on WhatsApp measured exactly?). In order to assert authority, no satisfaction or money-back guarantee. Having a trainer at your personal disposal for 5 hours per month is the 'bronze' level of subscription, the lowest tier. It costs 599€.

This kind of consulting is even available as a one-off service ('On Demand'), you can pay 149 euros for just an answer to an email, or 199€ for an hour-long phone call. And then there's the *Fashion Lover Day*: eight hours with a trainer acting as a personal shopper, to review your wardrobe and redo your look. They take you shopping, to the hairdresser, to the cosmetician. They buy you clothes, fix them on you, comb your hair, tell you what to wear for the day, and force you to smile to make an impression.<sup>4</sup> The mother's caring gaze, worrying about *how you are seen* — except now you are paying for it, and this attention is provided as a service.

PLA is embodied by the two founders, Christian and Steve. On their website, there is a brand identity page dedicated to the story of these characters — building their reputation as gurus is a key factor for the business. The first one describes himself as 'predestined,' with an innate "propensity for conquering the fairer sex"; but, at the same time, his plot has a redemption arc: he was able to forge his mindset following a troubled adolescence, precisely as a student of 'PUATraining' (which is another seduction school, spread all over the world), where he learned *the rules of the game*. As sometimes the student surpasses the teacher, Christian has now moved to the other side of the desk, distinguishing himself through his "know-how" and his "skills at teaching". His motto is: "Practice is better than grammar" (at least it rhymes in the original Italian language).

The second character, Steve Meister, instead has always been successful: he claims to "have closed 85% of his friends' female friends he has met". Some kind of Casanova Superhero, whose standout quality is a "strong inner game". From him, we also know that he has travelled a lot ("many times in Ibiza", he says); features a "Machiavellian disposition"; his girls "must strictly have nice butts". Both the PLA's founders can be "cocky and funny", but each one specializes in different techniques and situations to teach students.

They said they were quartered in Dubai, and that "the company pays 100k€ a month in salaries for employees and collaborators".<sup>5</sup> The work beyond their online presence is

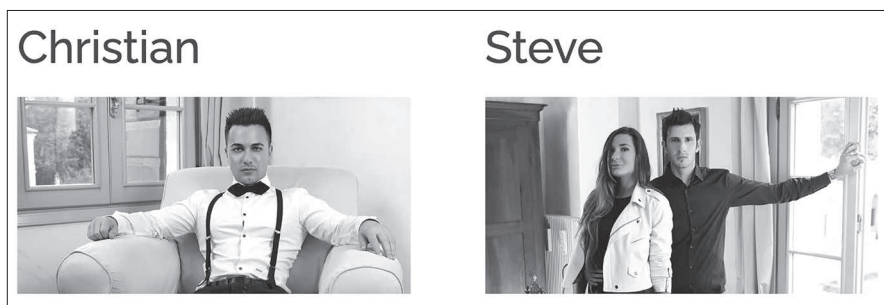
4 For a wider discussion about 'happy faces' and entrepreneurialism see Ehrenreich, Barbara. *Smile or Die*. 2010.

5 Information available at: <https://mowmag.com/lifestyle/ho-partecipato-a-una-lezione-di-seduzione-di-playlover-academy-e-ora-non-voglio-piu-provarci-con-nessuna>.



indeed managed at least to some extent by their subordinates. PLA has been relentless on social media, fueled by an aggressive marketing strategy that turned them into a viral sensation — even landing them on national TV (a feat they never tire of flaunting on their website). The two founders can be almost daily seen on YouTube videos where they share nuggets of wisdom: “7 bad boy approaches that make women go crazy” — “The method to get her butt photo sent to you” — ‘Screw her head in with messages!’. But also, videos dedicated to maximizing your physical appearance, tips on investments, and how to improve other people’s perception of you. *Looks, Money and Status* — sounds familiar? It’s not just seduction: it is “personal growth”.

From history, we know that the RedPill Theory is supposed to be at odds with pick-up artists’ notion of *the game*, as something that can be learned (and sold) — the RedPill discourse has partially stratified out of this disillusionment, as we can deduce from the forum PUAHate<sup>6</sup> (crucial for the genealogy of the RedPill and incel culture). Yet, a fundamental continuity echoes between these two discourses: there is one male narrative of permanent self-improvement, oriented towards the attainment of the same *object of valor* (to put it in semiotic terms).



The pick-up artist (PUA) movement emerged with the appearance of the first ‘seduction manuals’ as a popular sub-genre on the bedrock of self-help culture in the late 1980s,<sup>7</sup> but it became mainstream just around the turn of the millennium. It is closely tied to the evolution of the Internet and the culture of online forums, where some men began sharing advice and techniques on how to attract their targets, on how to snag them in the growing nightlife scene of clubs.

The PUA community-building process is characterized by a distinctive group vernacular. This recurring element, rooted in the digital forums of the late 1990s, reflects a fusion of

6 A well-known blackpill forum, which had origins in PUA criticism.

See [https://incels.wiki/w/Puahate\\_Sluthate\\_Lookism\\_\(PSL\)](https://incels.wiki/w/Puahate_Sluthate_Lookism_(PSL)).

7 The pioneer of seduction manuals is hypnotist Ross Jeffries, *How to Get the Women You Desire into Bed* (1992), combining neurolinguistic programming with hooking up.

nerd and geek culture with the terminology of the financial sector. Expressions like 'f-close' or 'k-close' explicitly derive from sales jargon and indicate, respectively, the success of 'fucking' or 'kissing' a girl, as if it were the closing of a deal. These terminologies persist in the international community's vocabulary, and we find these same words on the (Italian) PLA website.

The real surge in popularity occurred at the beginning of the aughts, in conjunction with the rise of the so-called post-feminist, neoliberal sensitivity. These were the years of *Bridget Jones* and *Sex and the City*, when the service-class single woman in her thirties was portrayed as empowered by the possibility of enjoying her newfound freedom — one increasingly recast as spending power and casual, detached sex "like a man".<sup>8</sup> The complementary objective-correlative of this *chick-lit* temperature is the seduction master, the pick-up artist (PUA). *Men Are From Mars, Women Are From Venus*,<sup>9</sup> after all: At the turn of the millennium, heteronormative culture was defined by the idea that biology and psychology could provide the codes to master relationships with the opposite sex.

The pinnacle of the PUA movement coincided with the publication of the bestseller *The Game*,<sup>10</sup> in which author Neil Strauss recounts his journey from nerd to star performer, after receiving the initiatory knowledge passed on to him by his guru, *Mystery*.

*The Game* advances a whole metaphysical program, staging a deterministic world based on the laws of evolutionary biology, a mesclun of behavioural psychology, and cognitive sciences. You can learn and draw conclusions about the objectification of interactions and relationships between the sexes, hence achieving the desired results: if women are predictable, the art of seduction can be mastered. The guru bears the light of knowledge, and then it is up to you to try hard enough. Almost needless to say, in this intrinsically sexist cosmos, there is no role for female subjectivity other than being the object of men's predatory desires.

Mystery had his reality show on British television called *The Pickup Artist* (2007-2008), after which the decline of the movement began. This was also due to increasing criticisms and controversies — partly from the collective acknowledgement of a feminist sensitivity, and partly from the PUA community itself. Discontent was the sign of the inevitable fraudulent turn taken by the expansion of a whole *seduction business*.

Sociologist Rachel O'Neill spent eight years conducting an ethnographic investigation with a feminist theoretical framework in London's seduction community, participating in

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8 For more on this, see Angela, McRobbie. *The Aftermath of Feminism*. 2009.

9 *Men Are From Mars, Women Are From Venus* (1992) by John Gray is a self-help manual that redefined the relational language during the Nineties, selling around 50 million copies all over the world.

10 Neill Strauss. *The Game* (2005).

courses and workshops held by various PUAs in the area. The result is her book *Seduction*.<sup>11</sup> She describes seduction communities as places of '*mediated intimacy*':

I am concerned to examine how neoliberal rationalities, centered on management and entrepreneurialism, shape the intimate subjectivities of heterosexual men. In doing so, I am interested less in arguing that neoliberal capitalism is fashioning a new hegemonic variant of masculinity than in examining how the logics of neoliberalism get under men's skin.

O'Neill argues that the PUA community must be interpreted as a reaction of men navigating the terrain of *post-feminism*, in neoliberal terms: embracing *intimate entrepreneurialism*. At its core, PUA's discourse seeks to rationalize the transformation of the self, converting personal development into a targeted strategy for sexual acquisition. Your *inner game* as a locus of labour: this is mediated intimacy. It is not limited to your sexual persona; it affects your social skills, your aesthetic appearances, and your narrative of yourself. *You*, as a subject of enterprise. As feminist literature has reviewed, this is what women have traditionally been compelled to do, and now men seem to have arrived at this stage as well, though 'following very different routes' — as Susan Faludi puts it.<sup>12</sup>

O'Neill also pinpoints that, around seduction, it has established 'a community-industry hybrid'.<sup>13</sup> Pick-up artists are primarily salesmen. The guru-manager projects the image of a grandiose self, on which their authority and competence are based, mainly through the heroic metric of the *body count* — which stands for how many *deals with girls* they succeeded in closing. The commodified good that the guru is thus selling is intangible, but it is translated into a method that can be learned and promises success if followed correctly: a *life hack*. In short, if it's not working, it's only your fault, and you'd better invest more: more of yourself and more money in training.

The system is fuelled by former students who become trainers themselves at the service of the guru, earning dividends. In this frame, the PUA business is not so distant from other Ponzi schemes, aligning itself with sectarian movements like those new age cult-enterprises that were popular just a few decades earlier, but explicitly marketed on a new, tight, and culturally distant consumer target.<sup>14</sup>

The communities populating seduction academies are strictly sexual-connoted and homogeneous collective identities — heterosexual males wanting to become "skilled" with women — persuaded to share a rigid worldview and a secret knowledge infused with

11 Rachel O'Neill. *Seduction* (2016).

12 Susan Faludi, *Stiffed* (1999).

13 Rachel O'Neill. *Seduction* (2016) cfr. § *Introduction*.

14 Reading Houellebecq's *The Elementary Particles* (1998) it is perhaps possible to better grasp this continuity.

technical jargon. The group thus often becomes insular, pushed to develop some kind of “us against the world” mentality. In addition, for this reason, it is unusual for participants to publicly share their affiliation with the movement, opting instead to engage with each other in online echo chambers through anonymous proxies.

It is also worth noting that the internal logic of association within PUA communities is, in part, a legacy of the pro-feminist consciousness-raising groups that emerged in the United States during the late Sixties and the Seventies.<sup>15</sup> The spectacle of men confronting one another and seeking mutual support for their perceived failures with women is, indeed, a departure from traditional hegemonic masculinity. In the case of PUAs, however, one finds no critical deconstruction of the link between these personal struggles and patriarchal structures — a stark contrast to the ‘men's liberation’ experiments of the past. Instead, the PUA's masculinist stance finds a more direct precursor in the mythopoetic movements of the 1990s, specifically the ‘deep masculine’ research groups inspired by Robert Bly's *Iron John*.



Quite a tangible representation of the neoliberal turn: what starts as a political experience capsizes into the self-help business-culture within twenty years. In the post-1977 Italian political scenario, scarred by the “reflux into private”, the former male activists found out that they were more like their fathers than they expected, or perhaps they had wished to be. The masculine experience of self-consciousness groups, framed as feminist therapy, dissolves into psychological and existential mutual support without the overarching revolutionary hope pushing at their back, and goes on without progressive social politics guardrails, longing for self-realization goals.

15 For a historical insight of Men's movement, from the Seventies to the present day, see C. Hodapp, *Men's right, gender and social media* (2017). Regarding the Italian specificity, see S. Bellassai, *L'invenzione della virilità* (2011).

In the alleged post-ideological world, where the therapeutic discourse takes hold, males start crying out for their traumas and psychic wounds, “blaming women” for being responsible for this pain.<sup>16</sup> Social and political powerlessness turns into gender resentment on the tidal wave of the consumeristic sexual revolution and rampant individualism. This is perhaps the bending point of the misogynistic tendency that characterizes homosocial masculine communities especially today, from PUAs to The Red Pill Theory, and the digital enclaves of involuntary celibates. Here comes the Manosphere.

In the meantime, the very same sexual revolution helped push the *psy* discourse among the aspirational middle class, and therapeutical culture went hand in hand with the withdrawal of sociability, giving birth to the convergence of self-help and self-improvement commercial culture. The very American idea of the *perfectability of the self* has espoused the therapy setting, requesting the (costly) reliance on someone else’s guidance. The locus of intervention is the Self, but the work is directed from above, which is the expert’s authority. “Psychologists increasingly addressed the public both as patients and consumers”.<sup>17</sup> But the therapist’s role soon emerged from the fence of psychoanalysis, invested by broader, more generalist streams. Our familiar figures of the guru, as in the case of the PUAs, took their place there.

While this therapeutic sensitivity draws heavily from the post-1968 experience at first, and the liberal new age-wave finds a nod to the cultures of the self in the Eastern tradition, there is a second strand that is ignited by the foundation of cognitive-behavioural psychology. A therapeutic approach that is powerfully pragmatic and oriented toward the realization of the individual project and its success, which, not surprisingly, takes hold equally well among Silicon Valley geeks, soon to become global masculine role models.

The inspiration in this case, however, takes root in the Western culture of the self, specifically Stoicism — obviously the “popular” one, a watered and commercialized version of its ethos, capable of delivering the simple (and twisted) message of becoming masters of our own emotional world for well-being and prosperity.<sup>18</sup> A strand far more reconcilable with the reassuring reinforcement of a traditional hetero-masculine hegemonic identity, now openly challenged in certain milieus of the globalized West, and with the whole so-called *TradWest* imaginary, which is constituted precisely by opposition to the development of feminist culture and its post-revolutionary mainstreaming. “Men are not into therapy culture”, because they are less geared towards healing and more towards success; so “[this kind of] Stoicism is therapy with gladiators”.<sup>19</sup>

16 Sandro Bellassai. *L'invenzione della virilità* (2011). Free translation.

17 Illouz Eva. *Saving the Modern Soul: Therapy, Emotions, and the Culture of Self-Help*. Berkeley: University of California Press, 2008. In this book, Illouz exposes the affinity between the psy culture and the American Dream (which I believe to be still crucial in The RedPill discourse).

18 See Aperture, *How Stoicism Became The World's Greatest Scam* (2024). <https://youtu.be/h8REOHfdVZQ?si=sPRwvykiK-Ah1sU4>.

19 Ibid.

This brief conceptual thread might shed light on some of the oddities of our contemporary digital culture. For example, why have we seen AI-generated images of the Giga-Chad in the guise of Roman emperors on YouTube video thumbnails about digital entrepreneurialism;<sup>20</sup> the memes of men thinking about the Roman Empire many times per day; the very existence of the expression “broicism” itself;<sup>21</sup> why someone like Andrew Tate refers to stoic Marcus Aurelius. Tate’s dark flower blooms from all this wide sowing.



It was December 2022 when former kickboxing champion Andrew Tate and his brother Tristan were arrested by Romanian authorities. They have been charged with rape, exploitation of prostitution, and human trafficking after having lured and groomed women to sexually perform on cam-sites.<sup>22</sup> In the months prior, Andrew Tate had reached the peak of his popularity as an influencer: during the summer, he had been googled more than Donald Trump and Kim Kardashian.<sup>23</sup>

Mainstream social media platforms banned all his official accounts for violating community guidelines after receiving repeated allegations of promoting violence against women. In the UK, polls reported that 8 out of 10 teenagers had watched Tate’s content on YouTube, Instagram, or TikTok.<sup>24</sup> This is when the world realized how worrisome his allure had become. Today, after the second election of Donald Trump as President of the United States, we confront Tate’s influence once more.

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- 20 YouTube. “How to Be Unstoppable: 5 Stoic Lessons for a Happier You.” YouTube Shorts. <https://www.youtube.com/shorts/J4HR4NMuuDM>
  - 21 For a detailed and focused account of the intersection between stoicism and the Manosphere, see M. Maloney, C. Jones, and S. Roberts, “‘I Can Choose to Be a Good Man Even if I Got a Raw Deal’: Neoliberal Heteromascularity as Manosphere Counter Narrative in r/Stoicism,” *Social Media + Society* 10, no. 3 (2024).
  - 22 Jamie Tahsin and Matt Shea. “Andrew Tate: Chats in ‘War Room’ Suggest Dozens of Women Groomed.” BBC News, June 19, 2023. <https://www.bbc.com/news/world-europe-66604827>.
  - 23 Shanti Das. “Inside Andrew Tate’s Violent, Misogynistic World of TikTok Fame.” The Guardian, August 6, 2022. <https://www.theguardian.com/technology/2022/aug/06/andrew-tate-violent-misogynistic-world-of-tiktok-new-star>
  - 24 Maya Oppenheim. “Andrew Tate’s Influence on Young Men in the UK Is Shocking, Poll Finds.” The Independent, February 16, 2023. <https://www.independent.co.uk/news/uk/home-news/andrew-tate-influence-young-men-misogyny-b2283595.html>

Thanks to his 'Hustlers University' he became a multi-millionaire, attracting more than 250k subscribers (who paid handsome fees) to learn the basics of self-entrepreneurship, and investment plans related to crypto, AI, and digital marketing. His business strategy involved dividends for members who were able to bring new subscribers to the community and share his videos, as is generally the approach of the seduction industry. "In essence, Tate created a Ponzi scheme by making his followers believe that they were pursuing their own financial freedom while, at the same time, they were contributing to his viralization throughout social media".<sup>25</sup>

He was the best at weaponizing the algorithmic feedback loops of the early 2020s, turning the rapid-fire scrolling morphology of TikTok into a billion-share engine for his content.<sup>26</sup> In his videos, Tate excels at persuasively saying the same old things, with cuts and edits specifically tailored for the format. His tale is the classic hero's journey: overcoming difficulties to become stronger. "Life is a battle: for power, for attention, for dominance"; "Name an attribute of masculinity that does not come from pain".<sup>27</sup>

He aims to be an inspirational source for males without contemporary role models. Fast cars, cigars, and gunfire: the traditional, reassuring alpha male, telling them how he struggled to earn his Bugatti. To become like him, a "high-value man" (and a successful entrepreneur), you need to control your emotions, overcome your fears, accept suffering, take risks, believe and take care of yourself; abandon the cheap hedonism promoted by the godless, feminized, and debauched West, quitting the mainstream and possibly embracing Islam (but Tristan Tate is a proud Christian: the *Tate Brothers Inc.* is a brand with differentiated placements, to attract the broadest audience possible). Most of all, you must give him money and help him create more proselytes. Numbers growing, his edginess ended up consuming the entire alt-right menu, without missing out on Nazi apology and conspiracy innuendos — recorded during his arrest, winking to QAnon's acolytes, he just said: "The Matrix has attacked me".<sup>28</sup>

However, his reception on incel's community forums is double-edged. Users are often divided between those who defend him tooth and nail, and those who see him as a *bluepilled* scammer, *on par* with the PUAs — *trueceles* (blackpilled incels) are desensitized to the lure of success, so they do not trust those who sell this kind of way out. However, Tate at one point explicitly started pointing out the RedPill Theory: he talks about LMS and

25 Vlad Budei-Tebeica. "Neoliberalism and the Red Pill: How Andrew Tate Used Populist Discourse to Spread Online Misogyny" *Civil Szemlé* 20 (2023), p.9.

26 Shanti Das. "Inside Andrew Tate's Violent, Misogynistic World of TikTok Fame." *The Guardian*, August 6, 2022. <https://www.theguardian.com/technology/2022/aug/06/andrew-tate-violent-misogynistic-world-of-tiktok-new-star>.

27 These quotes are taken as an example from one of the countless channels that re-share Tate's motivational videos. 'Personal Growth Pills' and 'Imprenditor Tips' are two Italian cases in point.

28 YouTube. "The Matrix Has Attacked Me! | Andrew Tate Is Detained and Has House Raided in Romania." Posted March 30 of December 2022. <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=fU0e0xOlxso>

power imbalances in relationships between men and women.<sup>29</sup> Women who shouldn't vote; who shouldn't be free to choose on matters regarding their own body; whose place must be just in the kitchen and the bedroom.

To summarize his trajectory with the formula of an Italian *forumcel*,<sup>30</sup> Andrew Tate is ultimately “some crook who redpilled half of GenZ following him on TikTok”.<sup>31</sup> A deadly cocktail of self-improvement digital marketing, hustler culture, and traditionalism, embedded in misogyny and developed as a pyramid scheme. In two words: “Populist RedPill”,<sup>32</sup> commercialized as the latest variant on the tropes of neoliberal exploitation within the manosphere.

Yet I think Tate did not popularize the Red Pill; he cannibalized the Red Pill to popularize himself. He recognized the RedPill as a potent mask for the contemporary Capitalist Discourse,<sup>33</sup> now recalibrated for its newest target: the young male, caught in a vice of unprecedented aesthetic pressure, forced to translate his own image into a marketable visual identity, amidst the fog of existential and economic precarity. The Man is thus torn: he's haunted by the desire for the *Jeune-Fille* while being forced to embody her logic, trapped in the tragic cycle of becoming the very commodity he seeks to possess.<sup>34</sup>

Another piece of evidence in support of this argument is the *looksmaxxing* trend, the ‘maximization’ of one's appearance: from *gua sha* to seasalt water hairspray, from skincare lotions and moisturizing — for the delight of the beauty industry — to diet and workout apps. Influencers are happy to offer counselling and sponsor products.

The #looksmaxx trend is supposed to be ‘a space to discuss changes in your physical appearance to help yourself in society,’ as TikTok describes the hashtag. The ‘*glow-up*’ video format showcases the before and after of the transformation. It seems that many of the million people who subscribe to this trend are unaware of where it all originates, that is, the incel forums’ original *looksmaxxing* section — there's even a ‘female looksmaxxing’ sub-trend, which, for true redpilled believers, would be a blatant contradiction.<sup>35</sup>

29 The pillars of the RedPill Theory — the ideological glue of the manosphere — are precisely Looks, Money and Status: the parameters according to which women would be Darwinistically hardwired to choose their male partners. Now women are free, so they only go for the Alpha males. In the evaluation forms offered on incel forums, Looks is measured in decimals; Money and Status influence Look. Under the score of ‘7’ they say “it's over”.

30 This is how users in incel forums often refer to each other.

31 Il Forum dei Brutti. “*Che opinione avete di Andrew Tate?*.” Username: normie\_timidone (11/12/2023). Free translation. <https://ilforumdeibrutti.it/threads/che-opinione-avete-di-andrew-tate.513/>.

32 Vlad Budei-Tebeica. “Neoliberalism and the Red Pill: How Andrew Tate Used Populist Discourse to Spread Online Misogyny” *Civil Szemle* 20 (2023), p.9.

33 From the “Milan Discourse” (1972), J. Lacan.

34 I am referring to Tiquun, *Preliminary Materials for a Theory of the Jeune Fille* (1999).

35 Kidology, *LOOKISM... and how LOOKSMAXXING is destroying everyone* (2023). <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=DKnfVHgaTf0&t=631s>.



The most widespread tenet of looksmaxxing is ‘mewing’, which involves pressing the tongue against the palate to train the jawline, hoping to achieve hyperbolic Chad’s jaw. The name comes from the controversial orthodontist John Mew, who has found scarce agreement within the medical-scientific community.<sup>36</sup> The jawline serves as the primary aesthetic signifier of an attractive masculinity, that can only be aggressive. In looksmaxxing forums, the obsession with facial geometry extends to the canthal tilt, the slant of the eyes on the face. The difference between a positive canthal tilt and a negative one divides those with ‘hunter’s eyes’ from the prey, which is the ‘lamb’.<sup>37</sup> Sticking to this parameter, not even Jacob Elordi is safe (he is actually poorly rated in the forums).



But this is just *softmaxxing*. On the other hand, *hardmaxxing* involves much more invasive practices, from official plastic surgery — which has sharply increased in recent years, and notably among men<sup>38</sup> — to far more questionable DIY solutions, like *bonesmashing*.<sup>39</sup> hammering your face to remodel those facial structures that are supposed to doom those who lost the ‘genetic lottery’. As the RedPill Theory claims, “Only the pretty face matters”. Looksmaxxing as a (pseudo)scientific theory discussed in forums mainly focuses on the visage, the factor with the most weight in determining one’s ‘L score’.

Thankfully, bonesmashing is mostly a meme. More serious, however, are the speculations about hormone therapies and the experimental use of drugs sourced on the black market to increase one’s height, or for muscular development. It is not hard to imagine the harmful side effects that can arise from this kind of deregulated work on oneself. The bodybuilding

36 Farrell Riley. “Inside Looksmaxxing, the Extreme Cosmetic Social Media Trend.” *BBC Culture*, March 26, 2024. <https://www.bbc.com/culture/article/20240326-inside-looksmaxxing-the-extreme-cosmetic-social-media-trend>

37 See this app: <https://www.mewing.app/blog/hunter-eyes-vs-prey-eyes>.

38 See the report from the British Association of Aesthetic Plastic Surgeons (BAAPS). [https://baaps.org.uk/about/news/1872/cosmetic\\_surgery\\_boom/](https://baaps.org.uk/about/news/1872/cosmetic_surgery_boom/)

39 Simon Osborne. “From Bone Smashing to Chin Extensions: How ‘Looksmaxxing’ Is Reshaping Young Men’s Faces.” *The Guardian*, February 15, 2024. <https://www.theguardian.com/lifeandstyle/2024/feb/15/from-bone-smashing-to-chin-extensions-how-looksmaxxing-is-reshaping-young-mens-faces>.

YouTuber Sergeyevich Shavershian (known as 'Zyzz' in his community, 'The Aesthetic Crew') passed away on his DIY work of muscular enlargement, because of an undiagnosed heart condition.<sup>40</sup>

On 'looksmaxx.org', discussions about "successful genetics" are heavily tainted by racism. Caucasian ethnicity is considered to be the "most valuable", and users suggest that non-white people should embrace "whitemaxxing" through makeup and skin treatments. Asian males, widely considered the least attractive to Western heterosexual women within this community, are called 'currycels' after their ethnicity, and they represent a significant portion of the user base in incel forums, especially in the UK (the legal country of the largest online community, 'incel.is'), where there is a major diasporic community.<sup>41</sup>

RedPill's racism is of course an alarming issue — considering its proximity to fascist and neo-Nazi ideologies swarming in the alt-right, with their eugenics fantasies. I also noticed that, besides neurodivergence and other mental disorders, physical disabilities are widely discussed on incel forums — and I am not referring to those who advance the incel condition as a disability itself. There is a lack of research in this regard, and this should be investigated further too.<sup>42</sup>

Men with the least competitive genetic kernels are 'mogged' by Chads. 'To mog' means to be aesthetically dominating, more attractive, with respect to another person — the expression was predictably coined by pick-up artists some years ago. Everyone wants to be the *mogger*. Why not think of a service that can harness this desire? Some 'mogging' academy perhaps?

*Mogwarts* — a pun making an obvious reference to Harry Potter — is the "school of looksmaxxing & profound self-improvement," as the website states. It was somewhat the phenomenon of 2024 summer in the manosphere, thanks to the visibility achieved by its founder Kareem Shami, after a glow-up before/after video of him went viral on TikTok.<sup>43</sup> "Looks, Money, and Status matter" a lot concerning how we are perceived and treated, in every aspect of our lives: "It's a tragedy the society we're in, now from social media to dating apps our overall image is constantly evaluated," the 20-year-old beauty influencer recites in the trailer.<sup>44</sup>

40 Farrell Riley. "Inside Looksmaxxing, the Extreme Cosmetic Social Media Trend." *BBC Culture*, March 26, 2024. <https://www.bbc.com/culture/article/20240326-inside-looksmaxxing-the-extreme-cosmetic-social-media-trend>

41 To deepen the South-Asian case of incel, see Kaur, Gurpreet. *Incel Extremism in India: A View from the Global South* (2022). <https://gnet-research.org/2022/08/23/incel-extremism-in-india-a-view-from-the-global-south/>.

42 See Moskalenko, S., González, J. F.-G., Kates, N., & Morton, J. (2022). Incel Ideology, Radicalization and Mental Health: A Survey Study. *The Journal of Intelligence, Conflict, and Warfare*, 4(3), 1–29.

43 Kieran Press-Reynolds. "Meet the Young Men Paying to Attend Hogwarts, an Online School for Becoming Hot." *GQ*, July 11, 2024. <https://www.gq.com/story/mogwarts-looksmaxxing>.

44 <https://www.mogwarts.net/#section-3>.

So here is 'Mogwarts Academy', in order to achieve "the transformation" into "*the best version of yourself*" (remember PlayLover Academy?). You can subscribe for the super-discounted price of \$20 a month to access exclusive content that will help you manage your skincare, your diet, your workout, and your approach to girls. Just click on the "Ascend Now" button — 'to ascend' is the expression incels use when they talk about the possibility of coming out of their involuntary celibate status.<sup>45</sup> Yet in none of his videos or interviews, nor on the website, is the reference to the RedPill Theory and the *inceldom* ever made explicit. Shami has about half a million followers on Instagram by now, and his community has more than three thousand (paying) members.



Studies on post-feminism have since long focused on the concept of "aesthetic labor",<sup>46</sup> the industrious and ceaseless work of looking beautiful on the outside and the inside, faced specifically by young girls as a gendered issue, since "patriarchy has been reterritorialized in the fashion-beauty complex".<sup>47</sup> But "today we are all living in the image factory",<sup>48</sup> and this subjectivation process is getting increasingly gender blinded. Indeed, it almost seems redundant to highlight the continuity between the cases observed by feminist critique and the trends currently involving these male subjects. The mere existence of the "male beauty influencer" figure is here to testify to it, although the two phenomena are yet to be comparable in extension.

The common thread is the aesthetic pressure disguised as self-care; the establishment of a heavily normative relationship with one's body, an endless site of anxiety and labor involving forms of nano-surveillance. But the elephant in the room in this conversation — which plays out across digital media — is the visual dimension of this 'body' being worked on, more and more seen as portrayed in pictures. Photo-editing for emphasizing

45 Incel Wiki. "Deincelization." Last modified February 1, 2024. <https://incels.wiki/w/Deincelization>

46 Ana Sofia Elias, Rosalind Gill, and Christina Scharff, *Aesthetic Labour: Rethinking Beauty Politics in Neoliberalism*. London: Palgrave Macmillan, 2017.

47 Angela McRobbie, (2009) in Elias, Gill & Scharff (2017): p.39.

48 Ibid.

the results in 'Before-After' or 'glow-up' trends is an open secret. This kind of 'care labor', today, always involves taking care of a *profile*.

The new regime of visibility brought about by the social media revolution has mobilized a whole technology of impression, that we delegate to proxemic and photogenic proficiency, and to digital post-production where the physical body does not stretch out. Framing, lighting, gaze, posture. Attention to skin tone involves its quality as a reflector. We are not only responsible for the product but especially for the packaging, as the marketing revolution taught us. Contemporary beauty and aesthetic labour are strongly related to the digital reputation economy; with the simulacra of our own preceding us in the digital-social arena; with the 'profile', intended as the most efficient identity technology today.<sup>49</sup> Incels are not properly mindful about it, but I read their visual paranoia as a reaction to this new kind of incitement.

On the other side of the coin from looksmaxxing, we find 'bed rotting'. This has somehow been another popular trend on TikTok among Gen Zs, consisting of lying in bed and engaging in passive activities for a couple of days at most — before it becomes 'unhealthy'. It oddly fits into the category of self-help and mindfulness content: it turns out people need to relieve social pressures and just vibe on their own sometimes. Our society tends to glorify being busy or productive all the time, and "this can lead to feeling burnt out and not allow us time to rest or recharge without labelling this as being lazy," experts say.<sup>50</sup> Is bed rotting the youth's rebellion against neoliberal subjectivity and its imperative of performance? Maybe, for the better. Or maybe it's just another way to glamorize depressive states while capitalizing on it: bed rotting befits the *Sad Girl*.<sup>51</sup>

But if we follow the stream of bed rotting, we eventually arrive at the spring of the BlackPill forums. LDAR is the acronym blackpillers users have for 'Lay Down And Rot'. "Lying down and rotting describes the mindset many incels adopt once they have attached themselves to the idea that there is no hope of them ascending. It goes beyond sexual in-opportunity, they do not believe they can improve their life in any capacity".<sup>52</sup> The picture worsens when we realize that many incels populating these forums are NEETcels.

NEET is another acronym for 'Not in Employment, Education, or Training,' which has replaced the term 'status zero'. The NEET figure, which triangulates with that of the incel

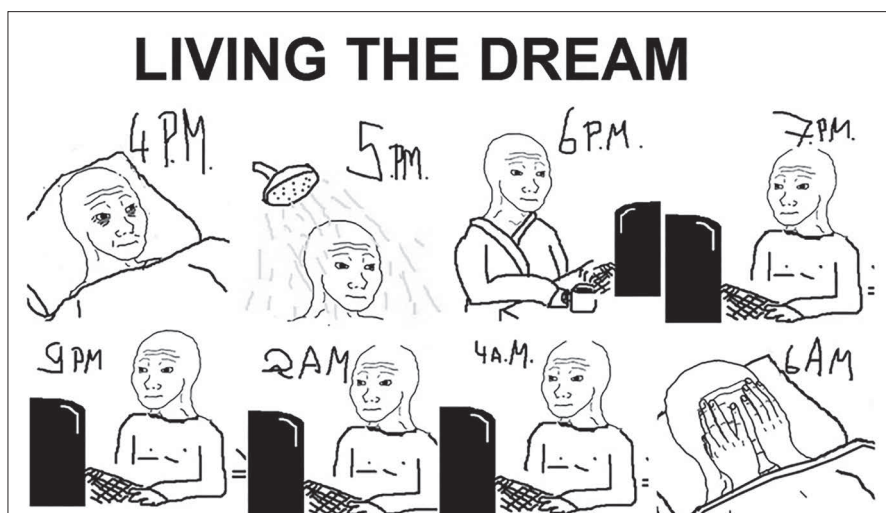
49 Hans-Georg Moeller & Paul J D'Ambrosio, *You and Your Profile. Proficiency after Authenticity*. 2022.

50 Alyssa Hui-Anderson. "What Is 'Bed Rotting'? Gen Z's Newest Self-Care Trend, Explained." 2024. <https://www.health.com/what-is-bed-rotting-trend-7561395>.

51 Jade Poolen. "Revisiting Sad Girl Sentiments." 2024. <https://networkcultures.org/longform/2024/01/16/revisiting-sad-girl-sentiments/>. and Sara Marzullo. *Sad Girl. La ragazza come teoria* (2023).

52 Kate Babin. "Condemned to Rot Alone: The Incel Paradox of Collective Loneliness." 2023. <https://networkcultures.org/longform/2023/09/05/condemned-to-rot-alone-the-incel-paradox-of-collective-loneliness/>.

and the hikikomori, also sheds light on the socio-economic roots of this discomfort. In 2022, the Organisation for Economic Co-Development (OECD) reported that almost 22% of Italian males aged 15 to 29 are NEETs.<sup>53</sup> Under the bombardment of hustler culture, these supposedly failed individuals are finding identity in failure itself. Bed rotting and seeking sympathy in online 'brocels' are all that is left. This nothingness can actually be interpreted as the blackpilled's silent uprising, which is way less boisterous than what the Beta Uprising of incels used to be (see Elliot Rodger, Alek Minassian, and the other massacres),<sup>54</sup> but no less alarming in the bigger picture.



If Andrew Tate's story illustrated the mainstreaming of an ideology, in the case of Mogwarts and these trends on TikTok we are also clearly dealing with the mainstreaming of a malaise — that seems to give a reason for this same ideology, without providing a justification for it. TikTok's alleged triviality conceals the source code, it is invisible by design. Incel forums are fibers away from mainstream social media discourse, yet their toxicity is peeping out. Whether it takes the red hue of looksmaxxing or the black of bed rotting matters little. There is the pill jargon underneath: it becomes translucent when you shine light through the prism of the internet's dark corners.

53 This statistic is alarming about Italian economy, for example compared to the 4% of The Netherlands. It is double the OECD average figure. [https://www.oecd.org/en/data/indicators/youth-not-in-employment-education-or-training-neet.html?oecdcontrol-dec63071aa-var6=15\\_19\\_WOMEN&oecdcontrol-00b22b2429-var3=2022](https://www.oecd.org/en/data/indicators/youth-not-in-employment-education-or-training-neet.html?oecdcontrol-dec63071aa-var6=15_19_WOMEN&oecdcontrol-00b22b2429-var3=2022).

54 The "incel" figure has tragically become popular because of several mass murders claimed by scattered members of this broad online community, occurred between 2014 and 2021. [https://incels.wiki/w/Beta\\_uprising](https://incels.wiki/w/Beta_uprising).

The RedPill seems then to have become the Trojan horse of neoliberal subjectivation; the adaptation of a 'technology of the self' capable of gripping masculine identity in its development, under the conditions that are shaping it in contemporary Western societies — after the sexual revolution and the visual one of social media, after the Great Recession and the re-proletarianization of the service class, and after the pandemic as well. The RedPill with its tendrils is now common sense for late-zoomers and Gen Alpha on TikTok.<sup>55</sup> Functioning as a proper ideology,<sup>56</sup> it manages to hold together the contradiction between hegemonic masculinity and the impulse towards its feminization; between the harsh and straight Tate and the obsessive care, the visual hypersensitivity of looksmaxxing.

The narrative structures of this therapeutic-entrepreneurial culture, that are exploiting today's media infrastructures to target young boys as new customers, are the recurring element of this story. Underneath lies an ideal of professional and sexual success framed in terms of absolute productivity. A subject's capacity to be productive — and thus successful — depends on how diligently they 'take care' of themselves. This 'care' manifests in many forms: mastering a stoic unflappability in the face of the 'tyranny of passions,' learning how to get a girl into bed on the first date, adopting the mindset required for crypto-trading, or sculpting a jawline sharp enough to prevent girls from skipping you on Omegle.<sup>57</sup> The 'self-improvement' etiquette is merely the sheep's clothing worn by the redpilled wolf.

Here then is the *care of the self*, where this 'Self' is little more than a business project in need of permanent aesthetic-emotional (and 'profilic') management, the object of relentless attention and work — so overwhelming that it must be delegated to private forms of counselling, such as gurus, subscriptions and apps of sorts.<sup>58</sup> The *cruel optimism*<sup>59</sup> of investing in yourself, improving yourself, and *activating your maximum potential*, is only the poor but obliged answer to fathomless conditions of social, economic, and epistemic discomfort in which so many isolated young males find themselves today.

As it is possible to witness, many elements of the Red Pill Theory — intended as a toxic-masculine and conservative ideology — have previously originated but now almost detached themselves from the condition of involuntary celibacy. The *pharmakon* has evolved, like a living entity, to become more appealing, viral, and *visible*. In the darkness, incels are excruciated from this performative imperative. It loops with their sense of failure. After all, their despair is too raw to be marketable and sold as a product; it has been swept under the rug. They are the loudest in the room screaming, yet the most overlooked

55 Francesco Gerardi, "Incel, palestrati e troll: chi sono gli idoli dei giovani maschi su internet." 2024. <https://www.rivistastudio.com/giovani-maschi-social-ince/>.

56 The notion of ideology is understood here as the discourse that narcotizes and silences its own partiality. See Umberto Eco. *Trattato di Semiotica Generale*. 1975. p.340.

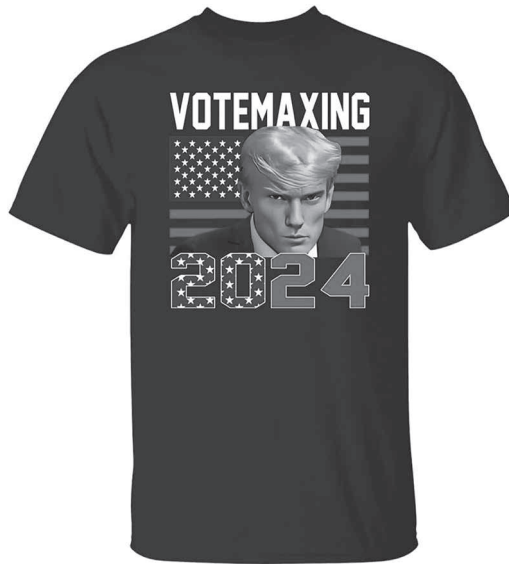
57 YouTube. "I FOUND MY GIRLFRIEND ON OMEGLE !." YouTube video, 0:00. Uploaded by torynoah, March 8, 2024. <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Q0TvHMxopFE>

58 Of course I am bothering Foucault's *History of Sexuality* here. See *The Care of the Self* (1984).

59 Lauren Berlant. *Cruel Optimism*. 2011.

account of the manosphere — our blinders being on one side the reduction of the incel as a ridiculed memetic stereotype,<sup>60</sup> and counter-terroristic rhetoric on the other that could be missing the target as well.<sup>61</sup>

The crisis is latent, but endemic.



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60 The TV show *Adolescence* (2025) showcases this dynamic: the term 'incel' appears only once, as an instance of bullying against the protagonist — almost as if it were the motive for the murder he is going to commit.

61 In August 2021, 22-year-old Jake Davidson killed five people (including his mother and a 3-year-old girl) in Plymouth. He had a YouTube channel where he discussed his commitment to bodybuilding and the Black Pill. Following the incident, the UK's Commission for Countering Extremism (CCE) commissioned the Swansea University Research on the Incel Community (SURIC) to produce a report. The result highlighted was that 'Incels need mental health support rather than a counter-terrorism intervention' <https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/predicting-harm-among-incels-involuntary-celibates/press-release-incels-need-mental-health-support-rather-than-a-counter-terrorism-intervention-the-worlds-largest-study-of-incels-finds-accessible#fn:1>.

## CONDEMNED TO ROT ALONE: THE INCEL PARADOX OF COLLECTIVE LONELINESS

KATE BABIN

Originally published on September 5th, 2023

*"Whether we learn how to love ourselves and others will depend on the presence of a loving environment. Self-love cannot flourish in isolation."*

Bell Hooks<sup>1</sup>

In 2022 I spent the better part of five months of my life lurking on an incel forum. Truthfully, I don't remember how I ended up here. One moment I'm researching the commodification of authenticity on Instagram for a BA paper and the next thing I know I'm neck deep in incel<sup>2</sup> vernacular, acronyms like KHHV (Kissless, hugless, handholdless virgin) swirling in my head. I now find myself writing a piece that requires a trigger warning for mentions of **suicidal ideation**, **extreme misogyny**, **racism** and **self-harm**. After stumbling upon *Men Who Hate Women*<sup>3</sup> and being nosy enough to search out one of the forums Laura Bates frequented in order to write the book, I was curious to find out how a space that claims to be a community for lonely men to connect with one another ends up further alienating members, not just from the outside world, but even from each other. How can over 20K men who join an 'involuntary celibate' forum that announces on its home page: "Are you lonely and wish you had someone in your life? You're not alone!" simultaneously experience debilitating loneliness? They are attempting to bond over a specific sense of mutual longing, yet it is clear that their attempts at connection over a shared loneliness plunges the members of this incel forum deeper into isolation, attaching their identity to a sense of failure they can't escape from.

They are alone and always will be.

But how can they be lonely together?



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1 Bell Hooks, *All About Love: New Visions*, (Avon A, 2016).

2 Involuntary Celibate.

3 Laura Bates, *Men Who Hate Women*, (Simon & Schuster Ltd, 2021).



It's not a new or radical statement to say that many online spaces populated by incels are volatile. With extreme misogyny on full display, infused with hostility towards those both within and outside of the community. Or that those who self identify as incels have much higher rates of loneliness and mental health struggles than other men. Suicide and self-harm are very popular topics within incel spaces and there have even been studies done on the countless suicide posts that can be found memorialized by the reddit user u/incelgraveyard. What is it about this particular community<sup>4</sup> (and the forum itself) that makes it impossible for its members to connect with one another in a meaningful way? In a way that would help them feel less alone. I decided to explore this paradox of collective loneliness by looking at a popular incel forum, how the affordances of the site and intricacies of the ideology influence members' behavior toward each other.

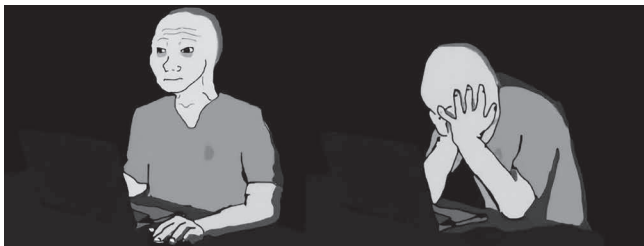
In a VICE News video titled "This Is What The Life Of An Incel Looks Like", a reporter spends a day with a young guy named Joey, who identifies as an incel. We see him laughingly interacting with fellow incels online. He video chats with his friends while they are yelling gross and aggressive things for shock factor. Shouting things like "I'm going to firebomb multiple government buildings" followed by one fellow incel actually purposefully shitting his pants on camera. This perfectly animates what reading posts on the forum out loud sounds and feels like. Chaotic, disgusting and a bit scary. They look like they're having fun, but we are left with this closing statement by the reporter: "In this subculture people bond over self-loathing. Joey says it's therapeutic, but four of his friends have killed themselves". One former incel that shared the experience he had on these forums, during an anonymous podcast interview, equated the community to a black hole. He said that joining the subculture is a downward spiral that sucks you in, perpetuating ideologies born from trauma, depression and abuse. Men whose loneliness pushes them to seek solace online are robbed of the comfort that collectivity is meant to provide.

In a group of over 20K users who presumably share each other's desperate need to connect with others, what is it about the space that plunges its members deeper into isolation? An isolation that has been linked to multiple mass murderers and suicides within the community. What aspects of the forum perpetuate the negative affect that ultimately leads members of the community to act out in these ways?

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4 It is important to note that there are men who identify as involuntarily celibate who do not engage with the kind of extreme rhetoric they have become known for in popular media. There are men who may refer to themselves as involuntary celibate but consider it a (temporary) state of being and not an identity. Being incel versus being AN incel. When writing about 'an incel forum' I am referring to the most active forum with the highest concentration of self-identified incels, it is an extreme example of the community and an accurate illustration of how easily identity and ideology can be radicalized.

## The Incel



Before answering these questions, let me first set the stage.

The incel community does not exist in a vacuum. It is part of a larger online network of men-centered groups aptly named ‘the manosphere’ that consists of varying degrees of anti-feminist collectives. The belief system that pervades many of these groups is the idea of being ‘redpilled’, a term that originated from the 1999 film *The Matrix*. In the film, the main character Neo needs to choose between taking the redpill and seeing the world’s true nature or choosing oblivion by taking the bluepill, which is to live in ignorance of reality. In the case of prominent manosphere ideologies, the redpilled reality asserts that the world is a gynocentric sexual marketplace wherein women have the upper hand. The belief is that men’s romantic and sexual success with women is determined by their social status or ‘sexual market value’ (SMV). This means that low-status men, those without wealth or who are not deemed conventionally attractive, are unable to form romantic or sexual relationships with women. Bluepilled men are ignorant, delusional normies<sup>5</sup> that are continuously manipulated by promiscuous women for their money and resources.

In 2016 journalist Stephen Marche spent time on the now quarantined subreddit *r/TheRedPill* (TRP) and summed up the essence of the manosphere in a surprisingly poetic way for his article *Swallowing the Red Pill: a journey to the heart of modern misogyny*:<sup>6</sup>

"In the hours upon hours I spent wandering this online neighborhood, I saw mostly feral boys wandering the digital ruins of exploded masculinity, howling their misery, concocting vast nonsense about women, and craving the tiniest crumb of self-confidence and fellow-feeling"

Here Marche was describing a community within the manosphere that focuses on sexual strategy. However, it is a very fitting description of what I witnessed during my time on the

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5 A normie is someone like you or me, someone (I hope) that is grounded in reality. Also referred to NPCs.

6 Stephen Marche, “Swallowing the Red Pill: a journey to the heart of modern misogyny”, *The Guardian*, April 14, 2016, <https://www.theguardian.com/technology/2016/apr/14/the-red-pill-reddit-modern-misogyny-manosphere-men>.

incel forum. Unlike many manosphere communities such as TRP that discuss dating and sex like it is a game they have every intention of winning, incels are (as the name implies) much more focused on their perceived permanent sexual lacking. The word incel is a portmanteau of 'involuntary' and 'celibate.' The origins of the term date back to 1997 on a website and listserv called *Alana's Involuntary Celibacy Project*, a space created by a queer feminist in her 20s that aimed to confront the shame around virginity and provide a supportive space for single people to speak to each other about their struggles with finding a romantic partner. The focus of these groups was really on loneliness and support, whereas modern digital spaces that label themselves as 'for involuntary celibates' have warped the label into an identity which is exclusive to cis-hetero men that engage with pill jargon<sup>7</sup>, projecting their blame onto what they consider 'the feminist delusion'. In short, the beliefs perpetuated on the forum push the anti-feminist narrative that women empowerment and the subsequent financial independence that many women have gained has ruined the romantic prospects for men who do not fit a very specific idea of physical attractiveness and masculinity.

## The Blackpill



In a world of normies who are either redpilled or bluepilled, the incel (within the aforementioned forum) is blackpilled. Being blackpilled requires internalizing the belief that men who do not fit into societal definitions of attractiveness or masculinity<sup>8</sup> are systematically marginalized, othered by society and completely without hope of having sexual or romantic partners. Although redpilled men believe that feminist society is inherently lookist<sup>9</sup>; they engage in looksmaxxing forums that focus on fitness, plastic surgery as well as improving their financial situations in order to improve their sexual prospects. Unlike other manosphere groups like Pick Up Artists and Men Going Their Own Way, those who have subscribed to the blackpill ideology do not believe that there is a solution to their problems.<sup>10</sup> No matter what they do, incels will always be genetically inferior

7 Some are red, and some are blue. Some are old and some are new. Some are sad, and some are glad, And some are very, very bad.

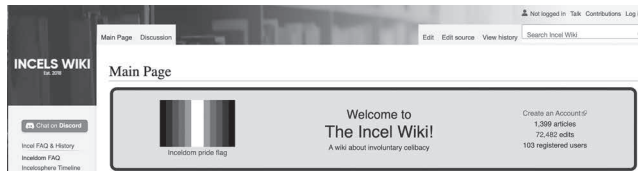
8 Supposedly this is determined by women.

9 Your worth is determined by your level of attractiveness.

10 PUA's believe the solution is manipulating women and MGTOW believe it is separating themselves entirely from women.

to alpha men or chads<sup>11</sup> and for this reason they are doomed to be alone forever, together. Blackpillers, according to the Incel Wiki Blackpill page, believe that “ugly, 'genetically inferior' men have no chance of getting laid in an unconstrained mating context, as women are assumed to choose based on looks rather than personality or effort.” Basically, young men embracing the blackpill leads to a biological determinist influenced nihilism that is rampant on the forum.

The Wiki



To understand more about the various acronyms and the history of incelism I perused the Incel Wiki, which is a rich source of incel related definitions, theories and lore that was created independently from any one specific incel community. Among 1,399 other pages, there are in-depth explanations of the blackpill along with the ‘science’ they use to back up this belief system, pages addressing balding, speculating Hitler’s incelism and even an incelsphere timeline dating back to the 1700s. While I find it pretty interesting to read about these things from their own (albeit often hateful) perspective, I did have the misfortune of stumbling across an article claiming women’s argumentation style is emotion-based, manipulative blackmail<sup>12</sup> titled *Arguing with holes*. As well as the one about ‘Femoids’ or ‘foids’<sup>13</sup> that refers to women as toilets and includes charming memes like the one below. Despite this, it has been incredibly helpful for understanding incel related slang and history, as well as providing memes and interesting visuals related to incelism.



Image from Incels.wiki - Femoid

11 The stereotypically 'high status' man. Tall, wealthy, incredibly fit with magnificent cheek bones.  
12 As opposed to the famously male logic-based mode of communication.  
13 Female humanoids.

## Lonely Together

In November 2017, the community based network Reddit implemented a new policy that prohibited incitement of violence on the platform. The 40K member subreddit */r/incels* was banned and users moved to more heavily moderated subreddits or created their own forums. In the case of the incel forum I have been lurking on, it was created as a result of this ban by modmins<sup>14</sup> SergeantIncel and Master. It is considered the third iteration of the */r9k/* board on 4chan, the anonymous image-based bulletin board known for the ephemerality and absurdity of its content. This is where some believe the essence of */r/incels* or men "howling their misery" within "the digital ruins of exploded masculinity" originated from. */r9k/* was and still is used for sharing original<sup>15</sup> personal anecdotes that are often bleak and involuntary celibate adjacent.

This website that was created in response to Reddit's mass banning of violent subreddits is reminiscent of early internet forums. The default style is Dark Mode and the color scheme is dark blue with white text. There are three main subforums, *Must-Read Content*<sup>16</sup>, *Inceldom Discussion* and for off-topic content: *The Lounge*. As of September 1st *Inceldom Discussion* has 5.6 million posts and *The Lounge* has 2.6 million. Users can post their own threads within the subforums or reply to the threads which are ranked by number of responses. There is a *Rules and FAQ* page where the admins have outlined who can and cannot join the forum, what sort of behaviour will not be tolerated and what kind of content is allowed to be posted. Some fun cherry picked examples are:

**Women and LGBT Individuals (Not allowed):** Banned on sight, no exceptions. This is a heterosexual male-only forum.

**Do not humble-brag, such as by subtly praising your own features** ("I'm incel even though I'm muscular and 6'2").

**Do not discuss or request personal romantic or sexual experiences, even if they happened long ago.** Discussion of paid sex is allowed as an exception, as the community has voted to allow it.

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14 Moderator/Admins.

15 The originality here is key to how the board became a popular space for incels to share their stories. The */r9k/* board was originally an experiment done by artist Randall Munroe to encourage original and unpredictable content, creating a community focused subculture on a site that is best known for its repetitive memes and noisy chaos. A bot was created to filter out reposts and non-original content. Although this never explicitly became an incel forum, the content that was produced as the community formed was often original stories of social isolation and awkwardness leading to a lot of incel related discussions.

16 Pinned by the mods.

**Do not troll, bait, proselytize, post platitudes, mass tag users, or necropost** (i.e., do not post in inactive threads older than ~1 month unless you have something to contribute - plain agreement, mere quoting, and meaningless one-liners don't qualify as contributing).

Another rule worth noting:

**Do not persecute, harass, or attack others.**

This rule is clearly not followed or enforced by moderators. One of the first things that stood out to me about the way members interact with each other; how much they seemed to hate each other. For a forum that defines itself as *Not just a forum, but a community*, there largely lacked any sense of camaraderie, or as Marche put it, fellow-feeling. Incels are just plain mean to each other. Not only did I see these interactions play out on the forum but I also saw a lot of posts made by incels themselves complaining about this open hostility towards their own 'brocels'.

Incels are no strangers to self-loathing, this is clear just by considering an initial description of the community and the concept of involuntary celibacy itself. However, it was interesting to see the way this translated into an outward hatred towards those they consider similar, if not the same, as them. For incels self loathing doesn't just morph into an extreme hatred of women and a sense of utter hopelessness. This hatred is also projected heavily onto other incels within their community; creating such a hostile digital environment that engaging with these forums can be considered a form of digital self-harm.

During my time as a lurker on the forum, I identified four main factors that prevent supportive connection between members on the forum, perpetuating their low self esteem and deep feelings of isolation: **Othering the in-group, clogging up the forum, asserting masculinity through shitposting** and **fatalism**.

## Othering the In Group

### A.K.A. "everyone is fakecel except me theory"

Incels are no exception to the in-group/out-group dynamic and linguistic work that subcultures within the deep vernacular web are known for (shout out Marc Tuters and Daniel de Zeeuw). Elina Vaahensalo developed the theory of Othering Online Discourse (OOD)<sup>17</sup> that helped me to understand how this collective identity is established and where in this case community building goes wrong. OOD relates to how incel identity and community is built through "shared experience of otherness and opposing the cultural

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17 Elina Vaahensalo, "Creating the Other in Online Interaction: Othering Online Discourse Theory Open Access" in *The Emerald International Handbook of Technology-Facilitated Violence and Abuse*, (Emerald Publishing Limited, 2021).

master-narrative.” Identity formation within incel communities is complicated because in a way they establish themselves as the out group and ‘other’ by positioning themselves as oppressed and marginalized by society. Identity and self-image are often created through the concept of juxtaposing oneself against the ‘other’ and constructing the self through sameness within the community. At the same time the ‘other’ is constructed through conceptions of difference.

Incels, however, have constructed their identity around the ‘other’ possessing similarities that incels lack. A common hypocritical theme within the community is the idea that all women think and act a certain way, while individual incels are vastly different from one another, emphasizing how they are misunderstood by society. Their entire identity revolves around being an outcast, a loser, an outsider and their vernacular reflects that. The ‘us’ versus ‘them’ mentality manifests in destructive ways. While they ‘other’ themselves they manage to fracture their collectivity with very strict definitions of who can be considered a truecel<sup>18</sup> those who are meant to be a part of the in-group and find community instead become excluded with increasing hostility.

Some fakecels<sup>19</sup> (seriously check out the Incel Wiki Glossary for definitions if you’re lost, there is only so much I can do) are considered fake because they are either knowingly or unknowingly volcels.<sup>20</sup> The truest of truecels have much bleaker prospects than the average (in)voluntary celibate. Members of the forum believe that volcels or fakecels are participating in the community inauthentically. Volcels are men who are considered celibate of their own volition, sometimes due to their standards being too high for sexual or romantic partners, claiming a true incel would ‘get with’ any woman if only they could. Other reasons may be that they believe a volcel could ‘ascend’<sup>21</sup> if they relocated to a larger city<sup>22</sup> or worked on their physical appearance.<sup>23</sup>

Truecels are those who have no hope of ascension. There is no amount of exercise, plastic surgery or money that will ever make them attractive to women, this is often attributed to facial structure, height or a disability. This belief that the other self-defined incels in the community are not actually experiencing the same degree of social rejection and loneliness as those who consider themselves truecels perpetuates negative affectivity around the interactions members have with each other on the forum.

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18 A true incel. Someone who has never had any sort of sexual or romantic experience and never will.

19 Fake incels.

20 Voluntarily celibate.

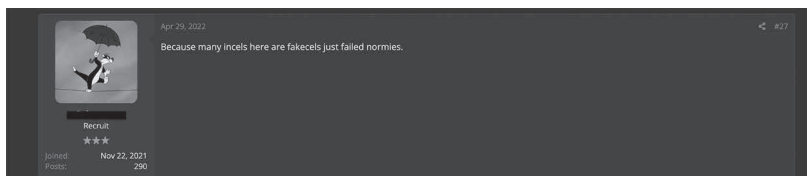
21 Have sex. No longer be celibate.

22 Locationcel.

23 Looksmaxxing.

While the forum states its purpose as being to **“talk to people just like you”**, many incels are convinced that their fellow forum members are nothing like them and instead are there due to their own self-inflicted failures or lack of self-awareness.

## Failed Normies



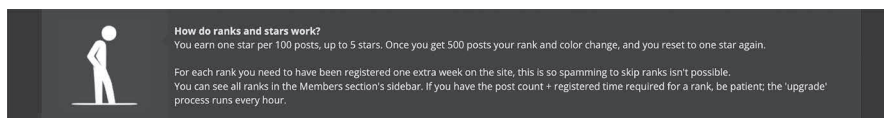
The legitimacy of one's inceldom is impossible to prove in this pseudonymous environment. The cognitive affordances of the forum have a much looser definition of what constitutes an incel. Describing an incel under the *Membership* section of the *FAQ* as “A man (18+) who desires a romantic relationship but is unable to enter one.”

Though this becomes rather subjective when actually signing up to the forum, the registration page requires the aspiring member to explain their situation, asking “Why do you want to join? Are you incel? Tell us about yourself. If you are lazy here you will be rejected.” What is considered truly incel is then in the hands of the admins that are approving members. However, the authority of this decision is not a guarantee that the new member will be accepted by the other members as an actual true incel once a member of the forum.

## OK GrAYcel

The forum allows users to pick their own username, tagline and avatar. Few rules exist for avatars<sup>24</sup> and usernames, the main one being that usernames should be masculine sounding, specifically they must “create the kind of username that when you yourself look at it or other's view it, that it gives off the vibe that a masculine heterosexual male created the name, otherwise your new account will be rejected effectively banning you from the website.”

Beyond being associated with a username, an avatar and a tagline, forum members have ranks which are determined by the number of times they have posted on the site. According to the Rules and FAQ page the ranking and starring of members functions as stated:



24 Previously there was a rule which prohibited images of ‘foids’ in avatars but this has since been revoked in January of this year since many members like using anime girls as their avi.



The concept of a graycel derives from this ranking system. If a member has any number of posts below 500, their username and stars are displayed as gray and their title below their username is listed as Recruit.

According to the Incel Wiki page on greycels, they face a lot of stigma on the forum for being 'noobs' and potential fakecels. This was incredibly clear during my time lurking on the site. GrAYcel was a very popular insult and there are posts by members that point out how unsupportive that environment can be for new members or members who choose not to post excessively. One of the comments I came across during my time on the forum addressed the way members respond to newer or naive members by belittling them, writing:

*"Calling naive members GrAYcels/cucks instead of correcting them, so that some of us had finally something to feel good about (number of shitposts and time spent on a forum for people who cannot succeed in life, not the greatest honor really)."*

Many members responded to this statement by calling the original poster a 'soycuck', a 'GrAYcel' or the classic non-answer: 'Sounds GAY'. Another user responded stating that almost none of the newer members were actual incels and that figures into the animosity towards them: **"Do you realize how many infiltrators we get here? 90% of greycels turn out to be infiltrators, bluepillers, (homophobic slur, transphobic slur or all together)."** There is a common belief that **"GrAYcels are more likely to be [sic] larpers + criticism is a good way to build character, unless you're a (homophobic slur) that can't handle insults GrAYcel."** The ranking system on the site sets these relationships up for failure. Members ranked as *Recruits* are not taken seriously and often mocked or disregarded which continuously fractures any possible connections they could be making. Graycels are often assumed to be LARPer25 or fakecels, there to destroy the forum. I noticed that the members providing the most constructive and least fatalistic social support were graycels who have since been banned. This contributes to how the site cannot function as the support forum it claims to be and why members seeking company on these forums continue to deal with debilitating loneliness despite each other's company. There is no room for compassion beyond distrust.

**"Yeah, something's definitely not right with practically ALL incel spaces."**

Despite the cognitive affordance that demands that registered members be single cisgendered, straight men who are having trouble finding a partner, it is apparent that many members believe that the majority of their fellow incels are frauds. This has the opposite effect of traditional discursive gatekeeping that typically utilizes identity speech to foster a sense of community and sameness. The fakecel rhetoric, instead of fostering a strong collective identity, cultivates hostility and distrust between members. It further complicates the 'us' versus 'them' dynamic that often shapes and empowers online subcultures. There is no clear 'in-group' that members can latch onto which causes unstable identities as well as low quality relationships within the forum.

## Sex Havers and LARPers

One concern of those within the community are LARPers. LARP or Live Action Roleplay often refers to acting out role playing games with real costumes, props and physical action. In the incelosphere LARPers are registered members of an incel forum that are actually 'sex havers' impersonating incels. Members of the forum are similarly concerned with false flagging and astroturfing, which is when fakecels join the forum and create posts intended to make the community look bad. Incel Wiki claims that:

*"Users of r/IncelTears<sup>25</sup> and other incelphobic terrorist groups have a tendency to take part in astroturfing by posting false flags [in] communities in the incelosphere to make incels look bad."*

LARPing comes up a lot during members' discussions about the community, some specifically blaming LARPers for destroying the forum. One member argued that due to the freedom to express controversial ideas that the forum affords, it attracts non-incels who as a bid for attention try to be "funny or dark" by saying inflammatory things that do not add anything constructive to the thread. He claims these LARPers aim to destroy threads that otherwise would be good topics of debate or conversation between members. This forum member then attempted to appeal to the LARPers in his post, stating: **"You should look elsewhere, here you only get in the way of people who want to find solutions to a problem that is destroying them physically and mentally every day."** The majority of replies on that specific thread were agreeing with this sentiment.

Incels who are seeking to quell their social loneliness by co-ruminating with peers are instead bombarded with ridicule and irrelevant inflammatory statements riddled with slurs. Members believe that those that behave this way on the forum are **"just bored edgy normies."** *Alone Together* author Sherry Turkle writes about how digital loneliness points to this issue when addressing being vulnerable with strangers online. She states that these digital environments do not "connect us with people who want to know us; rather, it exposes us to those who [...] may use our troubles to relieve them from looking at their own."<sup>26</sup> This sentiment is shared by forum members, one claiming that many of the active members of the forum are fakecels with ulterior motives. He wrote: "I bet a lot of the guys are here to feed on our suffering like parasites." The idea that these types of forums are populated by users with bad intentions is something Laura Bates addresses in *Men Who Hate Women*:

25 An extremely hostile relationship exists between members of incels.is and members of the subreddit r/IncelTear. r/IncelTear has 95.3k members and is dedicated to "posting screenshots of hateful, misogynist, racist, violent, and often bizarre content created by hateful "incels" (involuntary celibates)." The majority of the content posted in the subreddit are screenshots of forum posts and subsequent mocking.

26 Sherry Turkle, *Alone together: Why we expect more from technology and less from each other*, (Basic Books/Hachette Book Group, 2011).

*"You really feel the contradictions of the community: vulnerable, unhappy men mingling closely with men determined to wreak as much destruction as possible. You watch as people in urgent need of mental health support, who have somehow found themselves sucked into this whirlpool of misogyny, are met with vitriol, ridicule and incitement to self-harm by other men getting their kicks from online hate."*

The fact that many members believe there are LARPer in their midst may account for the general hostility forum members exhibit towards each other on the majority of threads. This inability to trust one another feeds into the already hostile environment regardless of if those who are posting are LARPing or not. The forum is rife with distrust and paranoia which impedes collectivity and community formation in a serious way.

## Clogging Up the Forum

### A.K.A. "they just make the sewers more miserable"

The ranking system the forum has in place is a clear example of the negative affect affordances have on user relationships. The ranking system encourages users to over utilize the posting feature in order to move up in rank. Instead of engaging with other incels as themselves with a sense of camaraderie and compassion, members instead have a more gamified approach to their pseudonymous identities. Although the Rules and FAQ page attempts to account for this by not allowing "low effort posting" in the main subforums (The Lounge subforum is a free for all), this rule is rarely upheld. Low effort posting is defined by the forum as:

*"Content that is unrelated to a thread, posted for memetic value, or spam-like in nature. Examples: an emote reply, quoting someone and adding nothing else, one-word replies, and many other variations. The content might as well not have been posted."*

This rule as well as the behavioral rule of "Do not persecute, harass, or attack others" are rarely followed and infrequently enforced by moderators, which points to an issue with the governance of the platform. The forum is committed to freedom of speech within the law, which may account for the lenient moderation for these types of posts. The majority of the comments I came across could be considered low effort posting according to the forum's own stated definition. On her podcast *Incel*, while interviewing the forum's founder and past co-administrator Sergeant Incel - Diego Joaquín Galante conducted under his pseudonym "Alexander Ash" (doxxed by the NYT in 2021 for running a pro-suicide forum), Naama Kates described this behavior as 'statusmaxxing' and Galante called it 'postmaxxing'. Members who want to move up in rank post excessively on the forum in order to increase their post count. Low effort posts, emojis (often morbid variations of pepe the frog), one-word replies (often slurs) make up a large portion of replies on all threads. On several threads I came across forum members argue about the negative affect that postmaxxers create on the forum. One user claimed that **"this forum is one big popularity contest just like society**

is.” This shows how the forum may not function as the refuge from the outside world that it claims to be. On the same thread members attributed the forum’s problems to fakecels, graycels and larpers, one comment placed the blame on postmaxxers. It read: **“I will never understad [sic] why they feel good for having a high post count. They just make the sewers more miserable.”**

In the same 2019 Incel podcast interview, Galante claimed that although the site is heavily moderated to prevent it, there are inevitably going to be posts that flood the site and as he puts in, clog up the forum. He attributes this to users seeking instant gratification, users trying to get the most validation with the least amount of effort. He claimed that sites such as Reddit encourage this behaviour and it is a part of wider internet culture, this type of controversial as well as short and non-complex posting is not unique to incel forums. Galante points to the fact that the shortest posts such as one-line shitposts and picture memes get the most upvotes and therefore visibility on Reddit. For this reason, the ‘like’ feature is disabled on the forum in order to promote long, good quality posts that attract equally high-effort replies, fostering conversation. Which is not what is being accomplished. It’s clear that the no low effort posting rule is only enforced on the posts themselves and not the replies within the thread. What differentiates this incel forum from Reddit is that the posts that get moved to the top of the page are those with the most replies. This is another affordance of the site that encourages excessively posting low effort replies or creating posts with controversial topics that will attract a lot of vitriol. Admins disabling the ‘like’ feature in order to discourage low effort posting was not successful.

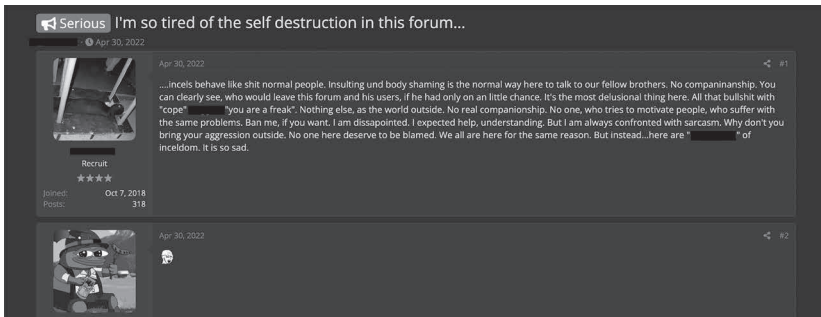
The user ranking system by number of posts, lack of moderation within threads and the fact that posts with the most replies are the most visible on the site enables the postmaxxing that disrupts any real conversations. The potential social support provided by this forum that may help incels with their loneliness is impeded by members who use the commenting feature as a tool in order to move up in rank as well as obtain validation and attention. This behavior within the threads overpowers much of the potential social support and as a result perpetuates the negative affect between members.

## Shitposting

### A.K.A. “(racial slur) who told you that this hellhole of a website is a self help group?”

Another way the commenting feature is used by members in destructive ways is through shitposting. While postmaxxing and shitposting can have similar negative affectivity on the forum, the intentions behind each type of post are very different. The 4chan FAQ page describes shitposting as being ill-intentioned, off-topic or low quality. They are often irony infused inflammatory comments that function to derail discourse. While the off-topic posts can be attributed to postmaxxing, there are many posts and replies that would fall under that come across as ill-intentioned and as Adrienne Massanari defines shitposting, low

effort and pandering.<sup>27</sup> These are the genre of posts that are an integral part of the online culture wars. Shitposters aim to be reactionary, often using extremely offensive language or ideas in order to elicit a response, all under the guise of humor and irony. One member expressed his disappointment in the forum's lack of sociality due to this use of irony stating:



This post was immediately followed by a comment proving the original poster's point. A simple angry wojak which is an emote titled by the forum as 'Soy'.<sup>28</sup>

During my time on the forum I saw how rampant inflammatory posts and replies are within threads. As the user above expressed, many cries for help and understanding are met with insulting sarcastic replies. Researchers Sarah Daly and Shon M Reed interviewed ten incels for a study that examined the themes of their lived experiences and identities. They connected their excessive use of racism, misogyny and violence within their conversations to an attempt to assert their masculinity online.<sup>29</sup> Members of the forum are aware that the content they post is visible to non-members. The most shocking content on the site is often screenshotted by non-members and shared on other sites such as Reddit (r/IncelTear) in order to expose the hateful ideology and use humour as a form of critique, often being extremely hateful themselves. As a response, members post threatening messages on their own forum or intensify the violence and 'ironic' offensiveness of their posts in order to get screenshotted again. This contention distracts from forming connection with each other on the site, many members express that posts about and directed at r/IncelTear specifically were ruining the forum. Another aspect of othering online discourse is the disruptive nature of discourses that are used to "troll the imagined audience of the conversation" which in this case is outside the community. The shitposting that is done in order to establish this masculinity tends to manifest as attention seeking behavior and extremely shocking rhetoric around marginalized communities such as women and POC. Researcher Debbie Ging wrote that male beta affective publics claim

27 Adrienne L. Massanari, *Participatory Culture, Community, and Play: Learning from Reddit*, (Peter Lang Inc., 2015).

28 Soyboy is a term used to indicate a lack of masculinity.

29 Sarah Daly & Shon M Reed, "'I Think Most of Society Hates Us': A Qualitative Thematic Analysis of Interviews with Incels", *Sex Roles* 86, 14–33 (October 2021). <https://doi.org/10.1007/s11199-021-01250-5>.

victimhood while pushing for male hegemony through racist and misogynistic discourse. She wrote about how the affordances of these forums encourage shitposting and therefore amplifies “new articulations of aggrieved manhood.”<sup>30</sup> This aggrieved manhood is an aspect of the community that is not conducive to emotional support, compassion and connection.

Forum admin Galante actually participated in the interviews conducted by Daly and Reed under his Alexander Ash pseudonym. His perspective shines a light on the value of forum governance and the considerable impact of the decisions he made when making the platform. One of those decisions being the way threads appear on the site. While in the Incel podcast interview Galante described the placement of threads based on replies as creating more thoughtful conversation than the ‘upvoting’ affordance on Reddit, in the 2021 interview with Daly and Reed this perspective had drastically shifted. He stated that “We score threads on number of replies. Those with the most replies go to the top. Again, you have a few people that are the most extreme...while the rational ones go into oblivion.”<sup>31</sup> Although he acknowledges that this type of scoring of threads has led to the most vitriolic posts getting the highest visibility and therefore engagement on the forum, this affordance has not been modified since the forum’s creation in 2017, pointing to the fact that rational discourse and community building might not be the true intention of those running the site.

## Real Men Shitpost

### A.K.A. “Leave that kumbaya shit for someone that care”

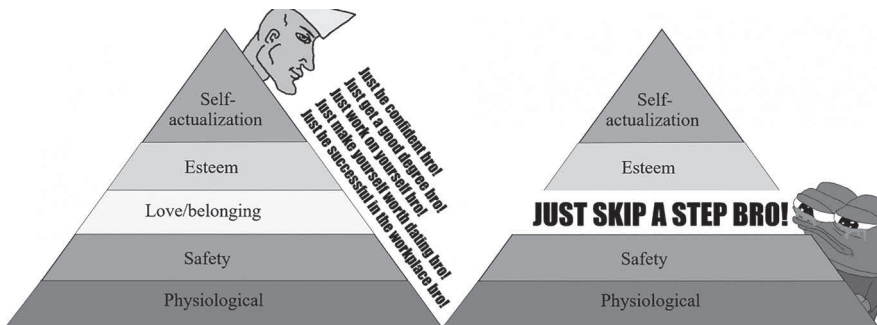
Because incels feels marginalized and infantilized offline, their behavior on the forum is extreme in a way that Daly and Reed suggests is an attempt to prove “their manhood within the incel collective.” Incels make it a point to amplify a deep hatred for women in order to reclaim their masculinity which they feel women have stolen from them by not desiring them. This hostility, created through this extreme performance of masculinity leaves little room for emotional connection or support within the community. While lurking I observed many instances of negative emotionality or toxic masculinity towards other members which adds significantly to the negative affect. Many members displaying vulnerability and expressing loneliness were met with homophobic slurs or dismissive replies. One member expressed that this behavior impacted their ability to socialize with others, commenting **“I joined this forum this forum [sic] to socialize with other social outcasts, and I was immediately met with toxicity.”** While Daly and Reed suggest that a dominant masculinity within the forum creates a shared social support, I disagree. This intense attachment to toxic masculinity inhibits social support and fractures collectivity within the community by default. Bates connected this issue to the wider manosphere when she wrote:

30 Debbie Ging, “Alphas, Betas, and Incels: Theorizing the Masculinities of the Manosphere”, *Men and Masculinities*, Volume 22 Issue 4, (May 2017), <https://doi.org/10.1177/1097184X17706401>.

31 Daly & Reed, ““I Think Most of Society Hates Us”: A Qualitative Thematic Analysis of Interviews with Incels”.

*“while pretending what threatens these boys is women or immigrants or non-white men, the real threat comes from the very forms of rigid ‘manhood’ their so-called saviours are desperate to preserve and promote.”*

To address this lack of community one member suggested improving the relationships between incels in order to address Maslow’s hierarchy of needs.



*Incels.wiki user Bibipi*

He wrote **“That might be taken care of in some way by strengthening bonds between incels, since we cannot connect with the rest of society due to them being fucking dicks to people they think are uglier. Some incel exclusive podcasts, online video gaming sessions or other projects are possible considering the distance between many of us.”** This, along with some other collective improving suggestions were met with multiple insults meant to be emasculating, such as **“Sounds GAY”, “soyfuck” and “Leave that kumbaya shit for someone that care [sic].”**

Many members are not engaging with emotions outside of anger despite the fact that managing loneliness requires emotional connection. Online social support is often lacking in the necessary compassion and care that would lead to meeting the needs of those seeking love and belonging. This coupled with the fact that the incel ideology pushes members away from accessing emotions that do not fit into traditional notions of masculinity leads to a lack of intimacy and therefore fractured collectivity between members. The construction and perpetuation of masculinities within incel spaces is intrinsic to negative affect which makes it difficult to find solace within the community. Making it the perfect counter-intuitive space for lonely people to gather.

## Fatalism



### A.K.A. "We are already dead boyo"

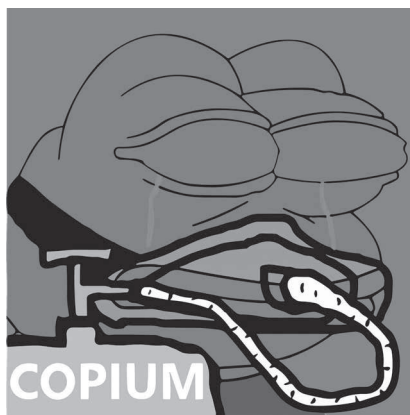
The forum defines itself through blackpill fatalism.

Hopelessness seeps into every thread, often through shitposts and sometimes even through very genuine and thoughtful posts and replies. While a lot of the negative affect on the forum and between members can be attributed to postmaxxing and shitposting, there are members who are far less inflammatory or disingenuous in their approach while still fracturing any potential community building on the forum. One member's response to a post exemplifies this perfectly: **"Expecting help to solve a problem that cannot be solved, as incelism, is far beyond delusional."**

Because of how hopeless this outlook is, it is likely that blackpilled members have already fully accepted their loneliness and many are not using the community to remedy it. This means that the other half of the members who have not reached that level of desolation are met with despondency instead of encouragement when seeking help on the forum. Blackpilled incels are convinced that their shared life circumstance is permanent, there is nothing left to do except cope with it. Any positivity from members, whether it be reassurance, a compliment or encouragement is met with hostility or dismissed by labeling it a 'cope' or 'copium.'

Incels have a special attachment to the concept of coping mechanisms, this is illustrated through their use of the word 'cope' within their shared vernacular. On the Incel Wiki they explain that the term cope is often used to insinuate someone is delusional or out of touch with reality. When a member has a more optimistic outlook on their situation other incels digitally shout cope at them, declaring that their perspective is just a denial of facts. The blackpill ideology coupled with the notion of positivity being a coping mechanism results in any advice or potential positive affect between members being regularly and easily invalidated with the use of a one-word, low effort reply: cope. Another way this word is utilized on the forum is to refer to individual incels' various hobbies, interests or even addictions. Labeling everything a coping mechanism negates any possible positive affect sharing common interests or problems could have on collectivity.





Researcher Grace Sharkey labeled this fatalistic behavior as an “aggressive performance of collective failure”<sup>32</sup> which from what I observed was clearly manifesting through blackpill discourse. One subgroup of the incel subculture that illustrates this attachment to failure are NEETs. NEET stands for Not in Education, Employment or Training. Not all incels are NEET or vice versa, however, members claim that a lack of romantic prospects could be the cause of ‘NEETdom’ or be caused by their NEETdom. Many who identify as NEET have attached themselves to this identity and are resigned to this lifestyle despite it causing further social isolation. A popular term within incel/NEET vernacular that pairs nicely with the fatalism of the blackpill is LDAR, which is an acronym for Lay Down And Rot.

Laying down and rotting describes the mindset many incels adopt once they have attached themselves to the idea that there is no hope of them ascending. It goes beyond sexual in-opportunity, they do not believe they can improve their life in any capacity. The forum perpetuates this sense of defeat. One member posted on the forum self-requesting a ban due to feeling like the forum was holding him back from his desire to grow in real life. He claimed to need a break from incels and the NEETcels and roppers specifically. This shows how the fatalistic mindset negatively influences other members who have yet to fully give up on themselves. Many incels project their hopelessness onto their peers which makes any kind of attempted camaraderie especially toxic.

Incels display an overidentification with failure that feeds into the already harsh environment on the forum and contributes to the feedback loop of social isolation and negative affect. As a post within the *r/Braincels*<sup>33</sup> thread that was analyzed as part of the study *A Short Story of a Lonely Guy* put it, “it’s really a breeding ground for defeat.”<sup>34</sup> While the negative affect

32 Grace Sharkey, “Failure to thrive: incels, boys and feminism”, *Journal of Media & Cultural Studies* Volume 36, 2022 - Issue 1, August 6, 2021, <https://doi.org/10.1080/10304312.2021.1958160>.

33 A now defunct (banned in 2019) subreddit, considered the most popular incel subreddit after *r/incels* was banned.

34 December Maxwell et al., ““A Short Story of a Lonely Guy”: A Qualitative Thematic Analysis of

drag members further into their despair they reject positivity and simultaneously personal responsibility. To these incels their failure is inevitable, inceldom is inescapable and above all else it is not their fault (it is of course, the fault of all womankind). Their collective failure sustains and validates their identities as incels which justifies their attachment to it. In his book *The Queer Art of Failure* Jack Halberstam explains how failure can be so enticing. He wrote:

*"What kinds of reward can failure offer us? Perhaps most obviously, failure allows us to escape the punishing norms that discipline behavior and manage human development with the goal of delivering us from unruly childhoods to orderly and predictable adulthoods. Failure preserves some of the wondrous anarchy of childhood and disturbs the supposedly clean boundaries between adults and children, winners and losers."*<sup>35</sup>

Ironically, the incel blackpill ideology seeks to escape the societal norms around masculinity by pushing further into their failure to fit into them. Sharkey connects failure to the incel's perceived exclusion from manhood due to its inextricable link with sexual maturity. Someone who is involuntarily celibate would feel excluded from this concept of "orderly and predictable adulthoods" and instead feel as if trapped in boyhood. The hostile behaviour of the incel to outsiders and each other could be viewed as the actions of immature boys who feel as though they do not have a future and are performing their attachment to failure. Incels have utilized the negative affect of failure in a violent manner that harms themselves and each other over and over again. This feedback loop of maladjustment and isolation is the result of a cruelly optimistic attachment to companionship. The way incels position themselves against "the good life" along with attaching to their inability to obtain it fixes their identity and impedes any hope of ascension. While the collectivity of their attachment to failure has become appealing to incels in their search for companionship, the resulting negative affects fracture the collective.

Many members approach the forum with the understanding that it is meant to provide connection, solidarity and support evidenced by the many posts by users disappointed that this wasn't the case. However, others who have fully committed to the biological determinism of the scientific blackpill only see the forum as a source of informational support. One incel criticized how self destructive the forum is due to there being **"No one, who tries to motivate people, who suffer with the same problems."** The responses to this post provided insight into the lack of cohesion between members and how it relates to blackpill ideology. Many of the more vocal members of the forum do not believe that the community is meant to function as a space to offer and receive support. One user replied: **"sounds like you're blackpill bitter and taking it out on us forumcels. We're mostly here to discuss things, delusional if you thought that somehow we can help. the blackpill is ultimate, there's no moral support for your face/height/etc"**

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Involuntary Celibacy Using Reddit", *Sexuality & Culture*, Volume 24, 1852–1874, March 25, 2020, <https://doi.org/10.1007/s12119-020-09724-6>.

35 Jack Halberstam, *The Queer Art of Failure*, (Duke University Press, 2011).

Due to the biological determinism of blackpill theory many incels feel that not only is their life hopeless and meaningless, so are the lives of their fellow 'brocels'. This interferes with their ability to connect with one another since they are consistently perpetuating negative affect during their co-ruminations on the forum. The OP of the thread summarized the outcome of this behavior perfectly, posting **"No need for foids, normies, Simps or cucks to destroy us...we do their job very well."**

While posts seeking support on the forum do receive a variety of replies, some even providing advice or emotional support, many members perpetuate the type of hopelessness that encourages suicidal ideation both implicitly and explicitly. I witnessed one member who was desperately seeking advice on killing himself, titling the post you are my only friends with the tag **It's Over**. Many members did offer help, empathized with him, recommended therapy and even offered for him to direct message them for support. One reply indicated that there is support to be had on the forum despite the shitposters, he wrote **"Don't end it yet. Keep breathing even though it seems pointless man, you have your forum friends for support. At least the ones who aren't trolls."** Conversely, other members mocked him, responded with one or two word replies like **"Over"** and **"Ok"** and gave advice encouraging suicide like the following, **"Save money to move out, or save money for a gun to rope."** Comments on other threads echoed this positive attachment yet extreme negative affect around incels and death, one user posting **"why live when you can die"** and another posting **"I wish we were never born."**

Fatalism is one of the three subcultural values Simon Cottee extracted from his analysis of the community. He wrote that:

*"The whole incel subculture can be understood as a veritable counsel of despair that facilitates the self-damnation of those who participate in it. However, and paradoxically, this damnation is experienced as an existential state of true ("blackpilled") consciousness and authentic existence. By rejecting both the goal of sexual intimacy and the means of male self-improvement, incels transform their shame and inferiority into a form of resistance against the "normie" status quo."*<sup>36</sup>

This ties into the notion that the behavior created by their attachment to failure is an act of rebellion as well as self-preservation which is being weaponized against members of their own community.

Forum members are very aware that the environment is not conducive to sociality and companionship, this is apparent through the concerns about behavior that are expressed within threads on the forum. This perspective, the incel perspective, is very important when considering the actual benefits lonely men gain when engaging with the community

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36 Simon Cottee, "Incel (E)motives: Resentment, Shame and Revenge", *Studies in Conflict & Terrorism* Volume 44, Issue 2, June 18, 2020, <https://doi.org/10.1080/1057610X.2020.1822589>.

online. Many acknowledge the overt racism and disturbingly violent misogyny present on the forums as problematic, however some claim that the majority of men using the forums are solely there to vent about their anger and sadness with men who can relate. As former admin Galante expressed along with many members who have participated in interviews, incels join the forum believing that the main focus is relatability and comfort, not the encouragement of violence or self-harm. However, while actually visiting the forum it is clear to me that any companionship they seek is drowned out by extreme rhetoric, shitposting and fatalism. Many of these men have experienced trauma and abuse and struggle with mental health issues or developmental disabilities that make it harder for them to connect with others. The defeatist nature of the blackpill ideology ensures that those who joined the community with any sense of hope will soon not be able to imagine themselves as anything other than **“condemned to rot alone and be excluded from any meaningful connection or meaning.”**

They end up believing that their lives are pointless, and they have nothing to live for. One member's take on the community sums up the toxic aspects of the space quite sharply: **“The entire purpose of it is to piss you off, isolate you, then send you down a rabbit hole that leads to your suicide.”**

If we know there are incels who are genuinely seeking emotional support and connection on these forums then the question becomes: why are they unable to find solace within their own community? The danger incel ideology poses to the outside world has been the dominating narrative around the identity. There is no denying this threat, self-identifying incels have been linked to multiple devastating acts of mass murder or attempted assaults since the 2014 Isla Vista Killings. Criminologists and experts on extremism have delved deep into the ideology to assess this threat while incels themselves claim that the perpetrators of these events were not even active members of the community. Those that are active within incel community spaces seem to pose more of a danger to themselves and each other, breaking down any hope they still held for finding companionship leading young vulnerable men to the conclusion that they are subhuman and their lives are not worth living.

The role the forum plays in this breakdown of hope for these men is significant. It is an environment that encourages members to flood conversations with low effort, vitriolic garbage posting in order for them to move up in rank and for their participation to be considered valid by fellow incels. The most inflammatory posts have the most visibility and members are not even convinced that those they are interacting with are not infiltrators. It is not a place for vulnerable and lonely young men to find community, it is where their hearts go to rot.

Incels are set up to fail every step of the way. A subculture already embedded with hate gather together on a platform that cultivates it. It further isolates them, makes them hate not only themselves but also each other. Personally, I found this pattern extremely

sad to witness. While a lot of the hateful things said on the forum made me incredibly uncomfortable and at times scared, it was hard to overlook the fact that those posts didn't feel authentic. Instead, the genuine moments on the forum were the ones where bitterly lonely men desperately reached out for connection and were met time and time again with indifference and outright verbal abuse.

Some men who are sucked into these spaces have actually found their way out with help from online communities. Subreddits like r/exredpill and r/IncelExit have provided a space for men to come together, question those ideologies and talk about their problems in an environment that disallows suicide encouragement, misogyny, trolling and bullying while actually enforcing those rules. Those who are in the deepest trouble, however, don't want to water down their pain or hate in order to find support.

But how does this pain and hate breed to begin with? What do these men lack that they are getting from these spaces, since it is so clearly not companionship and connection? Through this exploration I discovered the way governance of the platform impedes support between members and the ideology itself alienates them from each other, but I also saw how non-members antagonize the community and exacerbate the vitriol. Subreddits like r/exredpill and r/IncelExit are the compassionate middle ground between scorning the incel and accepting their hateful rhetoric. But these men will not find the community they so desperately crave on a pseudonymous subreddit.

While the ideology of inceldom is veiled in the idea that men need to find value and fulfillment in the sexual market place, the real problems stem from isolation, scorn and lack of mental health resources. All problems that are harder to fix than simply banning a subreddit or forum. We need to look beyond the vitriol, see the lonely individual waiting for someone to care and find a way to help them hold on to their last shred of hope.

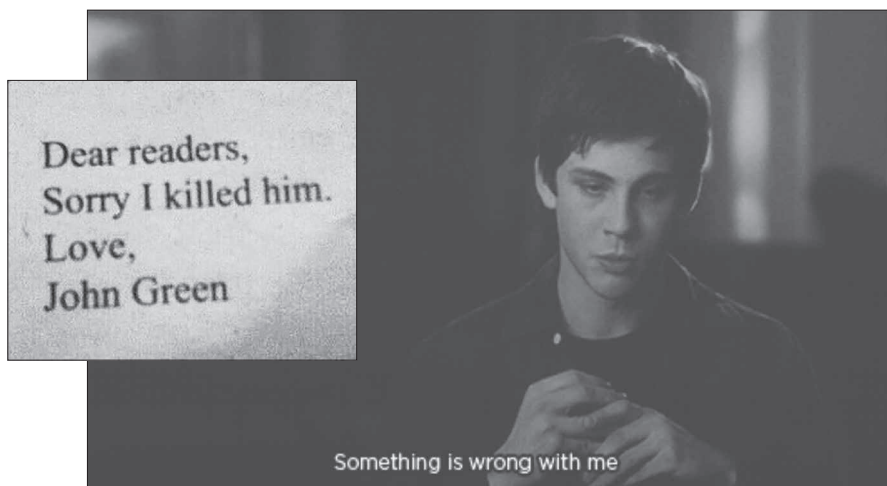
**Kate A. Babin (she/her)** is a Postgraduate Researcher within the Centre for Postdigital Cultures at Coventry University. Her research adopts a methodological approach of critical empathy, using feminist affect theory to examine the technological and affective formations of communities online. Her ongoing PhD project examines the affective constructions of race, neurodiversity and the body within a 'blackpilled' misogynistic incel forum. She has collaborated with the Institute of Network Cultures as a research intern, copy editor and proofreader since 2023.

## I, TOO, WAS MOUCHETTE AT 13 YEARS OLD

ANIELEK NIEMYJSKI

Originally Published July 18th, 2025

I'm 13 and my best friend from primary school asks me if I have an account on Tumblr. I do, but I'm not sure if I want her to know. She broke the unspoken rule—you never share your blog with IRL friends, it's taboo to talk about it. I hesitantly agree, and we exchange blogs. I take a look at her page. In her bio, there's a quote from Forrest Gump: 'Life was like a box of chocolates, you never know what you're gonna get.' Her reblogs consist of summer destinations, clean girls in bikinis, LA highways lined with palms, New York architecture, and Brandy Melville models. I scroll lower and lower and am becoming engulfed in shame. What is she gonna think of me when she sees my blog? Is she gonna think I'm crazy or unstable? I need to check my recently reblogged posts to determine how bad it is. I open my blog page. The difference between our visual aesthetics and personalities is imminent. I go through black and white analogue photos with depressing captions, graphic self-harm content, gifs from AHS Asylum, posts glorifying eating disorders, grunge fashion, soft animals lying on the grass, and nihilistic quotes from coming-of-age movies. I frantically scroll through my own blog as if seeing it for the first time, suddenly aware of how performative my pain looks when viewed through someone else's eyes.



In the next couple of years, I will forget all about Tumblr, and I will slowly stop reblogging. I will migrate to different platforms with my peers, but fortunately never delete my account. My blog will patiently wait for me to return, but... so will the same feelings of shame and cringe, preserved with embarrassing clarity, waiting to reveal itself as an archive of my becoming.

The decision to slowly stop using Tumblr would, unexpectedly, come as a direct result of a certain motion. In 2018, the last year of Verizon's and Yahoo!'s ownership of the platform, NSFW visual content was to be completely banned from the platform. After losing about 30% of the user traffic on the platform in response to a stricter content policy, the American media giant got rid of the site and sold it to Automattic for less than 0.3% of the purchase price. For a little while, it seemed like the platform had come full circle: being bought back by a company that is responsible for the blog service WordPress.com, seemed to promise the return to the simpler times: easily made, accessible blogs!! reunited communities!! unchanged, not-algorithm dictated dashboard!! chronological feed!! ....but, wait...not so fast. .... slow down.. In February 2024, Automattic announced it would start selling its users' data to OpenAI and Midjourney. .... So much for the simpler times. ...

At 22 years old, I discovered mouchette.org while researching net art works for my thesis. The site, created by French artist Martine Neddard in 1996, mimics a teenage girl's diary with deliberate naivety and whimsy: pink text, buzzing flies, stuffed animals, and a navigation menu that mimics early GeoCities pages. Yet, the content quickly subverts this childish innocence, with hyperlinks leading to the deepest curiosities of a seemingly pre-adolescent mind. From asking site visitors to physically connect through the cold surface of the screen, and asking strangers on the internet how to commit suicide, to suicide notes, and a forum where visitors share their struggles, jokes, experiences, and offers of help.

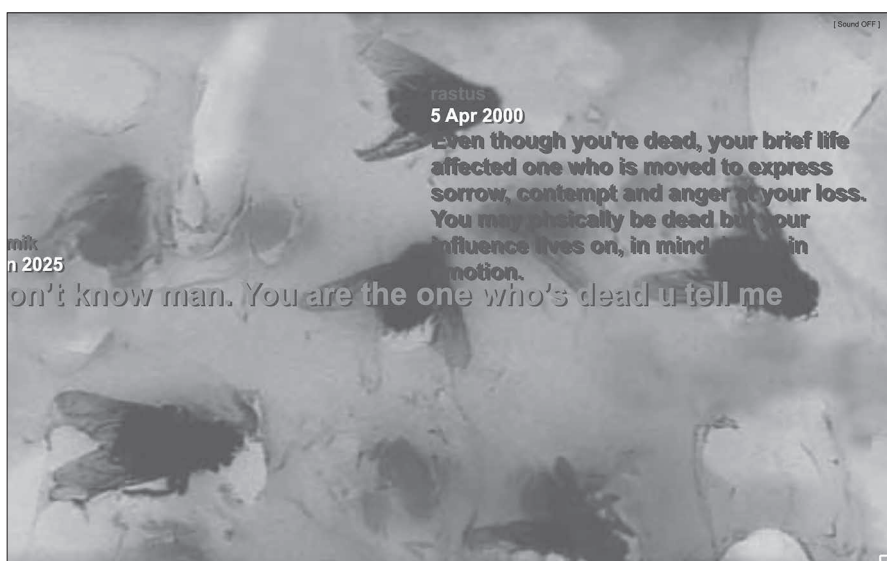
## HELP ME!

(other people already did)



While exploring the domain of mouchette.org, I noticed myself getting lost in the same familiar feelings that, up until now, were intrinsic to scrolling through my Tumblr dashboard. The dark thoughts and desires displayed by the character of an almost 13-year-old being out in the open brought me back to the same feelings I had at 13.

What struck me was how precisely Neddam had anticipated the aesthetic and behavioral patterns that would later define Tumblr's confessional culture. The site's juxtaposition of girlish visuals with existential dread mirrored my own Tumblr experience. Whereas, of course, the difference was Mouchette's website being a carefully constructed artwork, and our Tumblr blogs were most often unconscious, messy autofictions.



Lauren Berlant's concept of *intimate publics* helps explain Tumblr's ecosystem of shared vulnerability. In *The Female Complaint*<sup>1</sup>, Berlant argues that:

an intimate public is an achievement. Whether linked to women or other nondominant people, it flourishes as a porous, affective scene of identification among strangers that promises a certain experience of belonging and provides a complex of consolation, confirmation, discipline, and discussion about how to live as an x.

Tumblr operationalized this: the platform's reblog function turned intimate, personal suffering into viral, communal texts. Every disturbing post wasn't only a cry for help, but a

1 Lauren Berlant. *The Female Complaint: The Unfinished Business of Sentimentality in American Culture*. Duke University Press, 2008.



template others could adapt. Notes under graphic self-harm posts functioned as a perverse metric of care, where visibility equaled validation. You learned to package your despair in aesthetically pleasing ways, to juxtapose frat party gifs with confessions about your eating disorder, to make your suffering palatable enough to be consumed by strangers. We weren't expressing sadness; in reality, we were competing in what could only be called the Trauma Olympics, where visibility passed for validation, and the most graphic posts received the most notes.

This tension between real pain and performed pain is where Mouchette becomes most illuminating. In an interview with Annet Dekker, Neddham describes the suicide forum of mouchette's website as "*a social space where people could communicate and help other people*". It's striking how precisely this project anticipated the ecosystems of care we'd later build and use on Tumblr. Mouchette's greatest insight wasn't that people would perform care online, but that they'd do so more earnestly for a fictional character than platforms would ever let them do for each other. We built real support systems in Tumblr's margins, but instead of making our troubles solvable, the platform turned them scrollable.

I feel like it is crucial when talking about Tumblr to include the *Sad Girl Theory*, since its roots are deeply interlinked with the platform. In 2014, artist and writer Audrey Wollen proposed a theory that female sadness should be looked at as *an act of resistance* against the hypermasculine system of domination, rather than a performative, self-involved, passive action.<sup>2</sup> In retrospect, I have trouble agreeing with Wollen's theory. As opposed to stigmatized notions of *sharing*<sup>3</sup> your private business, especially on topics surrounding mental health, all the trauma posting I encountered in my years on Tumblr in some way felt liberating. This liberation and, as called by Wollen, *resistance* swiftly turned into another online aesthetic, which itself was tailored to capitalise on white, skinny, western middle-class girls and their pain, leaving no space for anyone who didn't fit into those very confined categories.

Maybe what Wollen's Sad Girl Theory misses is that our Tumblr years weren't just about resistance or aesthetics—they were the messy work of digital adolescence. This was the evolution of drawing eyes and roses in middle school notebooks, translated for the platform age. Where we once filled margins with angsty song lyrics, we would reblog My Chemical Romance lyrics over grainy photos. The physical diary became an infinitely scrollable dashboard, but the impulse remained the same: to externalize the unbearable weight of teenage angst.

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2 Lucy Watson. "How Girls Are Finding Empowerment through Being Sad Online." Dazed, November 23, 2015. <https://www.dazeddigital.com/photography/article/28463/1/girls-are-finding-empowerment-through-internet-sadness>

3 Stigma imposed by previous generations, that inculcated the same conception in our (millennial, gen-z) generation.

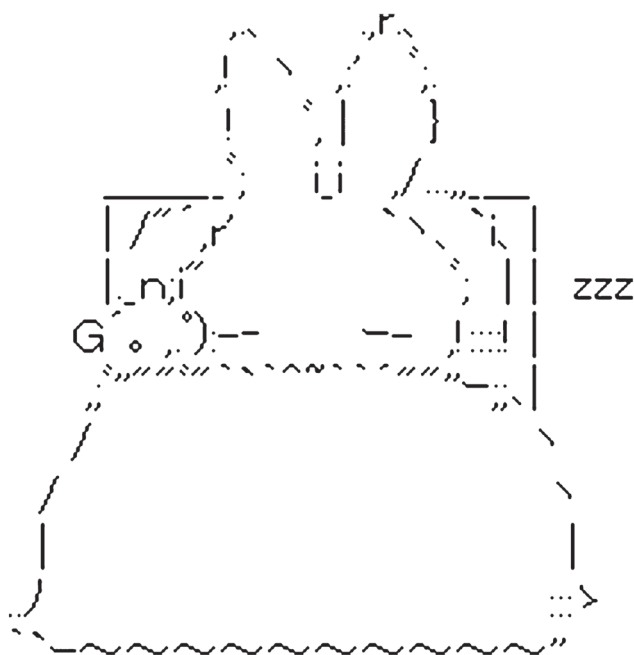
To conclude my reflection on my Tumblr archive, maybe what emerges isn't just shame or nostalgia, but something more useful. A critical lens on how platforms mediate emotional development in the platform era. These archives matter not because they're embarrassing or profound, but because they document what it means to come of age in systems that turn identity formation into engagement data.

I want to end this essay with a #hopecore message I found while perusing the suicide forum of mouchette.org. I am leaving you with a message from Loraen O. D. from the 10th of May 2010.

Live to love deary if nothing else. Pleasing to all and as addictive as a smile, love is all you need. All other emotion crumbles before it; they are neutralized in its wake. Love heals all wounds as they say. You suffer merely from the lack of this emotion. A simple prescription of love once a day will remedy this childish desire for an end of yours. Open up to your anyone, hang out with that someone, share a smile with a stranger. Love is not a commodity in short supply, rather it is in low demand. It comes to those who look for it. My dear, find love and you will never forget it. Likewise it will never forget you. Find it in any form with anyone and when you have found it, cherish it. Go on; start now! Don't wait. Get on the phone and talk to Julia, or got to Alex's house. Head over to the local park and smile at people, talk about the weather or the world. Walk to your father, tell him you love him. Run to your mother, give her a hug. Theres no time to lose, only time to gain assuming the state you're in. To start you off and to end my note I'd like to say: Good luck, have fun, and I Love You!

**Anielek Niemyjski** is an independent researcher based in Amsterdam. They are an Artistic Research graduate of the Academy of Fine Arts in Warsaw. Drawing on digital nostalgia and online archives, their research practice explores collective memory, identity, and resistance in networked cultures, with a focus on early web practices and alternative forms of online presence.

**THIS IS WHERE  
I POST FROM**

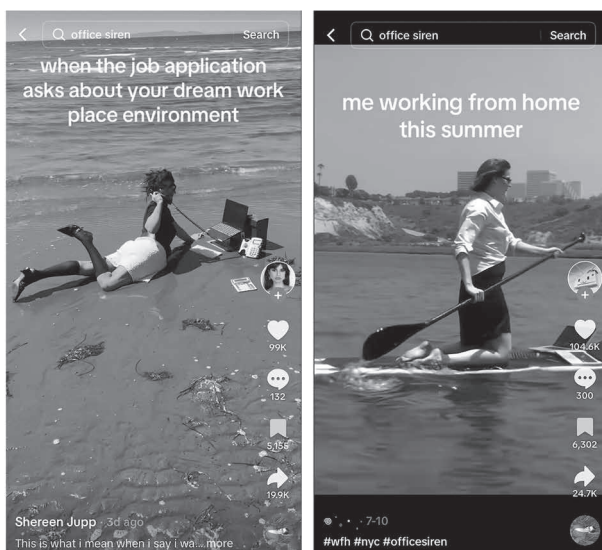


# DROWN YOUR LAPTOP: ON OFFICE SIRENS, WORKING FROM HOME, AND AESTHETICS OF REFUSAL

AGNIESZKA WODZIŃSKA

Originally published on September 9th, 2024

*Summer came and went. I realised I had spent just as much time being outside as I did watching others be outside. On TikTok, I came across clips of people drinking and relaxing on beaches (screenshotted outfits that were particularly linen-heavy), hiking next to sprawling lakes (saved to my “places” folder), making colourful drinks, etc. This is all seasonal, standard, maybe predictable. But then I spotted another genre, one much more surprising and enigmatic: people on laptops and taking calls in the sea.*



*TikToks posted by users ggabrielaa\_98 & llumitiana*

I was immediately drawn to these visuals of seemingly self-aware and slightly unhinged performances of office diligence, set outdoors to the soft tunes of Kate Bush or Enigma's "Sadness" track. It made me think of feminist performance art from the 80s and 90s, but from there I started to wonder what else these clips can tell me about not just the microtrend bubbles but online and offline spaces beyond my For You page. Following writer Marlowe Granados: 'as TikTok rapidly proliferates, its aesthetic influence [...] can be seen beyond the platform;' my goal is to theorise with these videos and images to extract ideas

about not just online trends, but also gender performativity, corporate culture, and even environmentalism. To do this, first we must consider the following: who is the office siren, and what on Earth is she doing?

## The Office Siren Emerges

It is not easy to pinpoint which user first started posting this kind of content. Bigger creators always have an easier time claiming that fame. Regardless, Tati Brueing, Gabriela Mendez, and Mimi Aarons all showed up on my feed around the same time over the summer, sharing their version of what commenters identify as the notorious 'office siren' aesthetic. Here, it is taken to the next level, as the creators descend into the water, evoking something mythological.

When I search for the videos again, they are difficult to find as they often get posted without any hashtags or descriptions. Once I decide to search for the suggested 'office siren' term – which itself seems to have gained popularity at the start of 2024 – I first find fashion and beauty tips instead, all about how to achieve the look. They want me to become a sexy and confident female office worker reminiscent of 1990s and 2000s popular films and fashion magazines. The video game character Bayonetta often shows up as a reference, with her signature black-framed glasses and long dark hair. Characters from films like *The Devil Wears Prada* (2006) and *Charlie's Angels* (2000) also make appearances.



Still from *Charlie's Angels* (2000) with Lucy Liu in the centre, dir. Joseph McGinty Nichol

One text-post from TikTok describes the style as: 'sleek, feminine, professional'; 'Samantha Jones from Sex and the City,' 'feminine, sexy, and successful without caring if she's being judged.' If this is an evolution of the girl boss, I don't particularly want it. I hope we are not mutating trends just to make our way back to romanticising being a worker under late-stage capitalism. But if we are, is this what we need to feel better about the state of the world?

Adding to this discourse, TikTok creator aiomiiii shares her verdict: 'to me, it's like a costume of what people who don't work think what it's like to work [in an office]. I know it's supposed to be vintage, work, recession, but it looks silly to me sometimes.' I look at the style tips: smokey 90s (I think?) eye make-up, lip liners and lip gloss, thin, black-rimmed glasses, sleek hair, playing with 'office-appropriate' patterns and materials but maybe showing more skin, subverting office-wear expectations, or bending various rules of what is 'office-appropriate.' The playfulness of the office siren aesthetic becomes clear. I am watching people online *playing dress-up*, in a way that seems more aware of itself and its purposeful shallowness than many preceding TikTok fashion trends.

It could be that the office siren is an evolution of corpcore, normcore's 9-to-5 sibling. We seem to be commodifying every aspect of our lives by labelling ourselves ceaselessly and linking each label to a list of products to buy. It's almost as though this is the only agency we have: when work is inescapable, permanent, when it bleeds into the rest of our lives, is it actually a rebellious act to narrow it down to its appearance—its signifiers—and choose to play with that, making the work unserious?

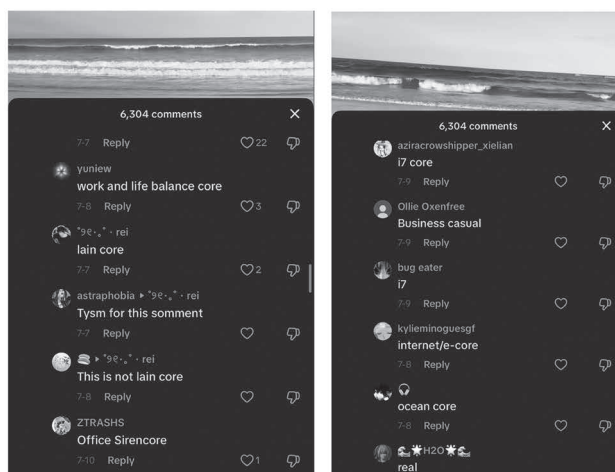
The office siren aesthetic stirs up conversations around authenticity — *these people don't even work in an office!* — and femininity in the workplace, with HR workers 'reviewing' office siren posts to share whether they would get in trouble. Some of us can't seem to stop working, or policing, even when we go home.

The politics of the office siren look are interesting as they ask us what categories we are expected to apply when thinking about 'professional' appearance, and how much of it is rooted in discriminatory and objectifying convictions. Are office sirens objectifying themselves by wearing stockings and low-cut blouses? Or are they reclaiming their version of femininity in male-dominated office environments? Does it really matter, since this trend seems to belong on TikTok first—with its playfulness and performativity—and in physical workplaces second, if at all?



*An example of officeladyspecial content, predating the office siren trend by many years.*

One creator cites 'officeladyspecial,' a YouTube channel for a Japanese fetish website, as a source of inspiration. I watch their videos to see women in office wear walking on the shore, struggling against waves, drenched and confused. Maybe this content does pander to some kind of patriarchal desire of helplessness, but then again, it is self-proclaimed fetish content, unlike the videos I stumbled upon on my For You Page. It seems that the TikTok users' references to pop culture point in the direction of empowerment instead of subjugation but the line is sometimes blurry, as was the case with the aesthetics of cottagecore a few years ago.

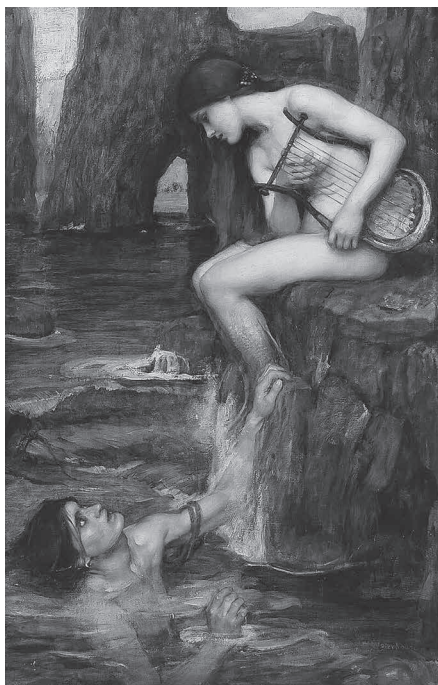


*Some answers to 'what is this aesthetic called?' in the comments under a video.*

So far, we considered what the 'original' office siren trend consisted of, and reflected on some of its characteristics and potential avenues of interpretation. It could be the case that just like many other aesthetic trends online, the office siren also mutated into something more, something different — oceanic, watery, performative, fluid and always shifting. Perhaps the hot weather of the summer months in the northern hemisphere pushed her in the direction of the beach, where she can work remotely into infinity. Why is this link to water so strong, even identified by one user as “ocean core”?

## Being Mythical / A Mythical Being

Women and water have a lot of history, often existing together in various mythologies and collective imaginations. The term 'office siren' points us towards the Ancient Greek feminine part-animal figure (bird or fish) who lures sailors to their deaths with their beauty and hypnotising power.



*John Waterhouse, The Siren, 1900.*

Then we have sea nymphs, Nereids, much less threatening than sirens and therefore easier to paint as docile in subsequent depictions throughout centuries. All over the world, Suvannamaccha, nure-onna, drowned girls and mermaids, spirits and messengers haunt the canon of watery women and femmes.

The TikToks I am focusing on here are sirens reimagined: working girls, icons of remote work, patron saints of Teams, harbingers of corporate culture. To take calls from the shore is absurd, to pretend to work on your laptop as it drowns in seawater is tongue-in-cheek. These creators are performing productivity, just like so many others on TikTok who carefully prepare and share their morning and evening routines, exemplified by the 'my 5 to 9 after my 9 to 5' trend. But with office sirens, we have an acknowledgment of the silliness this kind of content shows – yes, I am recording my work, which means I had to set up this shot, so I might as well work on a laptop that is *not working*. Typing into oblivion looking at a black screen.

If we consider my office sirens as sirens in the mythological sense, they are symbols of hybridity. Not just 'part-human, part-animal,' but also 'part-online, and part-in-person.' Hybridity as flexible work, part-remote work that these creators choose to conduct outside, in seas and oceans, rivers and creeks.



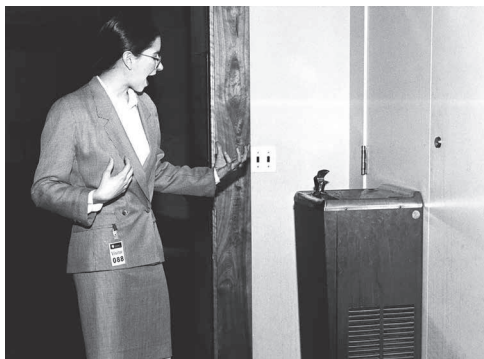
Hybridity, as in, you cannot escape your boss because they can see you through your webcam, and you are in your bedroom, working next to your bed, or maybe on your bed, and you can no longer cut your work out of your personal life, because your work is your life, your workspace is your leisure space, and you have no choice in the matter (if you don't work, you die), so you should at least try to be happy.

The siren laughs. She takes her company laptop and drowns it. She performs the endless cycle of desk job tasks into absurdity. Underwater, the tools of her labour short-circuit and become obsolete. Here lies her monstrous nature, and in this rebellion, she does what the rest of us are too afraid to do: she gets closer to logging off. Still, she is stuck in the rituals of corporate work, an officeid, or an Outlookoë. This tension is interesting to me. As if the watery language of capital keeps the office siren bound to her oceanic desk.

## Disrupting the Flow of Capital

The relationship between this watery office siren aesthetic and remote work is something the creators themselves reference, adding captions or in-video text that echo the language of working from home.

Could it be that these creators, instead of working against corporate culture, are working *within* its confines to see what is possible, what kinds of boundaries they can push? I base this on memes that keep emerging over the years about high-paying senior members of staff taking calls from the most random places, as though it is not jarring or unexpected. Ceara O'Sullivan's character Lorraine encapsulates this well in the "millennial vs. their boomer boss" series on TikTok. Younger workers are often not given the same level of flexibility as senior members of staff, bound by the expectation that you have to prove yourself, be on your best behaviour, embody professionalism in order to earn perks later down the line, perks that rarely come to younger generations, perks that seem expired, of a different time.



*Andrea Fraser, Museum Highlights: Gallery Talk, 1989.*

Writer Joshua Citarella claims that younger TikTok users are 'mocking a society in which self-determination and upward mobility have long since collapsed.'<sup>1</sup> So, if young people are indeed disillusioned with work culture as previous generations have known it, maybe they can find joy in imagining and enacting the ability to work absurdly. Why not take the edge off of the kind of work that need not be serious?

Satirising corporate culture could be a way to break out of the confines that tell us to tie our dreams and aspirations to professional development. Especially in the wake of financial crises, political upheaval, and looming climate collapse in all their manifestations, the dire need of a senior colleague to check in on your workflow and progress on a random weekday afternoon feels completely unnecessary and inconsequential.

This critique of 'business as usual' reminds me of second-wave institutional critique and works like Andrea Fraser's "Museum Highlights: Gallery Talk." As her alter-ego Jane Castleton — a visiting lecturer at the Philadelphia Museum of Art — Fraser takes visitors through the space, going through the motions and mannerisms of museum tours and sprinkling into the script jabs at the uncritical coloniality of North American (and European) museums, the exclusivity of donorship, and the increasing consumerism of institutions supposedly non-profit and in service of the public. Similarly, office sirens reach for the look of a diligent office worker and refuse to follow through, rebelling against the expectations of their 'institution'—their employer, presumably a for-profit corporation. This refusal to follow through sheds light on modes of control built into seemingly neutral aesthetic and linguistic ways of being under late-stage capitalism.

We are all human beings with complex inner lives that corporate work, or any kind of work, can never satiate. A lot of young people online are realising it and talking about seeking fulfilment elsewhere, settling for 'easy' jobs or 'quiet-quitting.' The pandemic played a significant role in this shift, highlighting the inconsequentiality of much of the labour that goes on in the West under late-stage capitalism.

My office sirens chime in, typing away as their keys splash with seawater. I think this genre of videos emerged this summer partially due to this relatively recent push online to foster and protect our identities outside of work. If we go into the office to clock in and out, then its culture and conventions might start to look more and more constructed, therefore collapsable, malleable; material to manipulate and shape.

This kind of play could be one method to take back some of the time and energy that corporate structures steal from workers. To pretend to work, to record yourself doing it; to post it and maybe make money from that instead, or just make it to express something,

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1 Joshua Citarella, 'Welcome to TikTok, the Wildly Popular Video App Where Gen-Z Make the Rules,' *Artsy.net*, 2018, <https://www.artsy.net/article/artsy-editorial-tiktok-wildly-popular-video-app-gen-rules>.

read comments, start some kind of conversation, however fleeting. Maybe it is possible to disrupt the flow of capital through this kind of ambivalent anti-corporate performance.



*Cindy Sherman, Untitled Film Still #59, 1980: Satchel in hand: traveling for work or pleasure?*

There is power in putting on a mask. You get glimpses of what life could be like if you were someone else, if you looked different, thought different. An array of artists—I am thinking here of Adrian Piper and Cindy Sherman—wear various personas, exploring new perspectives on how the world perceives them, how they perceive themselves depending on how they choose to present, what they choose to centre in their bodies of work. With Sherman's famous untitled film stills series, it is exciting for viewers to decipher more-or-less cohesive identities for each character she presents, albeit while filling in blanks, but being able to use all the visual cues and references to popular culture the artist is leaving behind.

Meanwhile, my office sirens remain somewhat unknowable outside of their work identity. They put on vaguely vintage yet untraceable costumes and work on presumably broken equipment, which also reads as not 2024, but not specifically another date either. Their content critiques contemporary corporate obsessions with productivity, business, perceived success, but does not propose alternative ways of being beyond labour. Still, by uprooting a corporate aesthetic and making it absurd, they highlight the ruthlessness and pointlessness of business-as-usual, and this kind of disruption can resonate far and wide, like ripples on the surface of a lake.

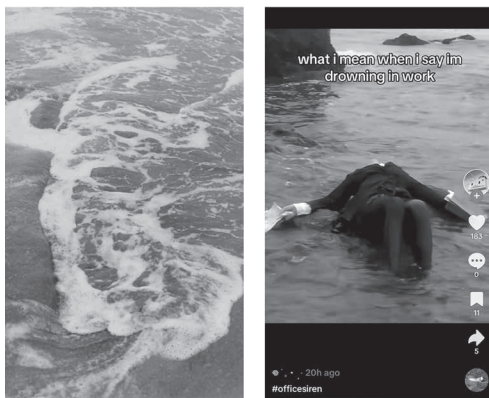
## **Drowning in Emails, or Just Drowning?**

Finally, I wonder if my siren is an environmentalist. Does she despair at the thought of rising water levels? The determination of these (pretend) office workers to keep typing as their laptop hits the water makes me think of Tweets and memes about how young people today will probably have to keep working forever. So, the ocean-bound office siren might also embody a fear of working until we run out of breath, or a related but more ephemeral existential anxiety or dread.

There is the obvious contrast between the laptops, phones, printers in these clips and the more 'natural' surroundings. Most of us probably don't associate beaches with work: in fact, it is an image that comes to mind when you think of a holiday (how much this is influenced by travel agencies and capitalist definitions of 'relaxation,' I dare not think).

Yet, in an era of constant availability, you might find yourself taking calls from places that in the past made you think of leisure. Nothing is sacred. Work can happen anywhere, holidays are only this sought-after and carbon-heavy because of extreme expectations over how much we should work, and even bodies of water cannot escape the residue of microplastics and bits of office equipment as my office sirens dip them in, protesting the very thing they must do to survive – work.

This tension is what draws many users to these clips. It's unexpected, even unhinged, to see our precious laptops reduced to malfunctioning props. The videos are often left to interpretation – posted without much of a description – which pushes users to ponder meaning and comment with compliments like 'this is art' (lured by the siren?). Indeed, it might be art. It definitely enters into conversation with a rich history of women and femme artists wearing personas and/or communing with nature, sometimes both, like Ana Mendieta's ephemeral and haunting silhouettes.



*On the left: Ana Mendieta, from Untitled: Silueta series, 1970s.*

Media and theory scholar Martina Leeker comments: 'Art – specifically performance art – has traditionally prevailed as a method of gaining the distance necessary for a reflection and critique of techno-cultural conditions.'<sup>2</sup> So, perhaps these clips can be read as a collective performance of the inability to break out of capitalist expectations. In their mockery of corporate mannerisms, they propose an emerging aesthetic of refusal.

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2 Martina Leeker, 'Performing (the) digital: Positions of critique in digital culture,' *Performing the Digital*, 2016, eds. Martina Leeker, Immanuel Schipper, Timon Beyes.



*John Everett Millais, Ophelia, 1852.*

Interestingly, one of the most popularised synonyms of the climate crisis is the rise of sea levels. As hybrid creatures working in a hybrid way, my sirens bear the brunt of changing environments by having to work partially underwater. Through them, we might also watch ourselves transformed, hybrid beings emerging from foam, especially through TikTok as a recent study by Jian Lin, Joëlle Swart and Guohua Zeng argued that 'the boundaries and distinctions between users' identities become less clear-cut and subject to constant modulation.' In light of all this, who and what might we become?

Plastic is in our blood and our brains<sup>3</sup>. We find it virtually everywhere we go. There is something monstrous in this kind of pollution, but monstrosity doesn't have to mean a denial of humanity. It will be imperative to consider what kind of work is worth doing in these conditions, especially as they gain severity. Can we embrace monstrosity and hybridity – all siren-like, mythical, spanning across history – while making space for playfulness, joy, resistance, performance? Contemporary art scholar Anne Gerlieb suggests that 'TikTok favours playfulness over certain styles and looks.'<sup>4</sup> If the mode of being on the platform is playfulness instead of striving for cohesiveness (often associated with early 2010s Instagram feeds), then it is porous, and therefore more capable of moving through aesthetics and into another more relational way of being.

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- 3 Damian Carrington, "Microplastics found in human blood for first time", *The Guardian*, 22 March 2022, <https://www.theguardian.com/environment/2022/mar/24/microplastics-found-in-human-blood-for-first-time>.
  - 4 Anne Gerlieb, 'TikTok as a New Player in the Contemporary Arts Market: A Study with Special Consideration of Feminist Artists and a New Generation of Art Collectors,' *Arts*, 10, 52, 2021.

## Where to Swim from Here?

My office siren takes on the behemoths of remote work and climate anxiety, working through them as she herself works. Through her eyes, we start to conceive of these notions differently. Through her submergence, we begin to see ourselves as more fluid, therefore more capable of facing various iterations of the future.

Trends on TikTok tend to move fast, transforming into new versions of themselves, merging into umbrella terms for similar sensibilities, or splitting into smaller sub-genres and trends. The girlboss phenomenon observed in the previous decade across platforms like Instagram and Pinterest might be rearing its head in the formulation of the TikTok office siren—a corporate girl seemingly content with her occupation, inspiring others to achieve the same. But the office siren in the sea knows she is being looked at. She puts on an absurd show that rejects normativity the girlboss craves. In contrast to previous microtrends and aesthetic-specific online communities, the office siren performs in manners and settings that point to her self-reflexivity.

When considering previous outdoorsy aesthetics, VSCO girls come to mind. VSCO girls appeared online last decade, evoking a brand-friendly environmentalism and an appreciation for scrunchies, reusable water bottles, and a beachy lifestyle. Similarly, cottagecore users on TikTok and elsewhere filmed themselves in nature earnestly, walking through meadows and towards Victorian cottages on my feed as though to say: *I do this all the time anyway, I just decided to film it for you just this once.*

Granados: *'TikTok shifts the visual dialogue away from the perfectly manicured aesthetic of Instagram, which is known more for its users' aspirational, flawless image curation. TikTok instead privileges on-screen presence, performance, and bite-sized narrative'*<sup>5</sup>. It can be messy and ambivalent, but those qualities make some TikToks inherently more complex than content on other platforms.

The rise of earnest work-from-home videos on TikTok from the onset of the pandemic and the subsequent increase in critique towards influencer culture, followed by the phenomenon of 'easy jobs' and a stronger conviction to build identity outside of work all facilitate a space for watery office sirens to star in the kind of content they created this summer.

Even if we crave authenticity in what we encounter online, our platforms are built to give us just the opposite. They spike specific kinds of either vitriolic or banal content into virality and otherwise feed us images and clips that keep us on the platform without much meaningful action or real engagement. It's like watching a puppet show and seeing all the

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5 Marlowe Granados, 'I Turn My Camera On: Notes on the aesthetics of TikTok,' *The Baffler*, no. 43, 2020.

strings: the magic is gone and the experience becomes distracting and jarring, odd and still somehow mesmerising.

Every now and then, a new kind of sensibility emerges from TikTok that jerks me out of this state of passive agitated consumption (last year, it was corecore). Lin, Swart, and Seng contend: 'TikTok as a platform is not only mediating and facilitating the production of short videos but has become culture itself.'<sup>6</sup> And culture produced by femme creators online continues to feed my curiosity and propel me towards some kind of hopefully engagement.

As I wrap up, I keep close the notion that through TikTok and its endlessly personalised and mutating visual languages, a kind of transformation might occur. Experienced both by the creator and viewer — and perhaps the most interesting, in the blurry line between the two roles—this momentary shift creates an opportunity for a more conscious (self-conscious?) being online and offline. In this moment, we get a quick glimpse at the tethers that keep us moving like puppets, and as we look up, we might see who is holding up the strings.

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6 Jian Lin, Joëlle Swart, Guohua Zeng, 'Theorising TikTok cultures: Neuro-images in the era of short videos,' *Media, Culture & Society*, vol. 45, 8, 2023.

## WELCOME >\_< TAKE A SEAT WHEREVER: THE SPATIAL POLITICS OF THE BEDROOM

RUBEN STOFFELEN

Originally published on December 10th, 2025

*Where are you right now? In your bed? At your desk? In your room? Where do you keep all your stuff? Do you watch TikToks in your bed? How much is your rent? Do you have a chill landlord? Do your parents pay for part of your rent? How many times did you move? Can we hang out in your room? Can your roommates hear us rn?*



My bedroom has always been a significant space to me. When I was young and lived with my parents, my bedroom was a space for privacy and experimentation, for play and dreams, something a little bit sacred. But as I got older and dreamt about moving out, I became occupied with visions of my own apartment, and eventually my own house with a garden and a driveway and maybe even a shed. But as domestic pessimism set in, I abandoned these ideas altogether, instead, I started thinking about the spaces I do inhabit, the space that is mine. So where am I now? I managed to move out but I don't have my own place, I'm living in an increasingly common domestic reality: with roommates in a shared household. If you're reading this in an apartment you are most likely also sharing it with roommates, maybe even with your parents (proto-roommates). At least in the country where I live, this tends to be the case. At first it was only in your early twenties, then your late twenties, and more recently it has become normal to live with roommates into your early thirties. Either way, not much changed since I was a kid: the bedroom is still a special place. But the bedroom itself has changed, its spatial limitations in physical space are conversely overcome by the spatial limitlessness of cyberspace, and its presumed slowness is overhauled by the rapidity of computational temporalities. With a computer or a phone, the bedroom becomes a portal as much as it is a safe space, it becomes as vast as it is cozy.





Jon Rafman, *You Are Standing in an Open Field (Mount Adams, Washington)*, Spike Edition, 2019, Archival pigment print on Hahnemühle photo rag paper, 80 x 107 cm.

Through networked technologies and digital culture, the bedroom was culturally revitalized, spawning several figures and characters: the NEET, the incel, the femcel, the keyboard warrior, the basement dweller, the gamer, the crypto bro, the hustlepreneur, etc. These figures spend as much time as possible in their bedroom, enabled by their devices which grant them access to online subcultures, decentralized communities, digital markets, and entertainment. The NEET is a particularly fascinating figure; the acronym, which stands for 'Not in Education, Employment, or Training', became popularized on 4chan in the 2010s and was used self-referentially in various forums following its emergence. Its correlation with 4chan made a lot of sense: the only way one could truly be chronically online was if they didn't go to school or have a job. But NEETs don't only exist as imagined characters, they inhabit physical spaces, mainly their bedrooms, occupying the desk which hosts their computer setup.



The bedroom also became more significant in the age of neoliberal-policy induced precariousness. We are, more often than not, banished to small rooms with – if you're lucky – a queen sized bed in which we can fantasize about one day having more than just that room. As the number of roommates increases proportionally to the decrease of square meters and our peers move back into their parents' places<sup>1</sup>, our domestic realities become typified by the bedroom: the one space which still feels truly like our own. The bedroom becomes an autonomous zone within the shared household, and even then it's a precarious one. Evictions, shitty contracts (or no contracts at all), a lack of registration, increasing rent, all threaten the autonomy of that zone. Particularly in the Netherlands, which is where I live, recent political discourse centers the housing crisis as one of the most urgent issues to be addressed. And as the feeling of seemingly eternal precarity and roommates sinks in, our bedrooms become layered with new meaning. It therefore comes as no surprise that the convergence of what I will call bedroom culture and digital culture naturally leads to gooncaves and battlestations; to new ways of existing in our rooms. The NEETs existence, in particular, also emerges in reaction to precariousness. Through networked technologies we enter alternative worlds and temporarily escape precarity – maybe we even overcome precarity all together.



Keeping this in mind, it makes sense that popular culture reflects the renewed significance of the bedroom. With it being widely referenced in contemporary art, music, and literature. Take Tracey Emin's sculptural installation *My Bed* (1998), Clairo's song *Pretty Girl* (2017) and Ottesa Moshfegh's book *My Year of Rest and Relaxation* (2018), for example. All three works address the bedroom as a cultural phenomenon, both as a space and as a concept. Clairo captured a particularly significant cultural moment in her DIY music video for her song *Pretty Girl*: the soft light of the bedroom after dark, the slightly fuzzy and grainy texture of a 2015 macbook webcam, and the wired earphones; a perfect collage of what it felt like to be an upper middle class teenager in the late 2010s. She

1 The Dutch Central Bureau of Statistics (CBS) observed an increase in young adults (18 – 31 years old) moving back in with their parents between the period 2011 and 2021.

tapped into a socioeconomic and cultural feeling with her song, something which strongly resonated with people. Moshfegh's book, similarly to Emin's work, gestures at a femcel or NEET identity—a politics of withdrawal where one spends as much time as possible in their bedroom, becoming completely unproductive (bedrotting). In *My Year of Rest and Relaxation*—and for NEETs more broadly—the bedroom becomes a stage where unproductivity and refusal are performed. As Georges Perec wrote in his 1967 novel *A Man Asleep*: “Your room is the centre of the world.”

But perhaps the moment when the bedroom became inaugurated as the final destination for zillennials was during the pandemic. Whereas NEETs and incels had been heavily stigmatized for living out of their bedrooms, the pandemic radically reconfigured the bedroom as an acceptable space to spend all your time in, a space where you could eat, sleep, work, and relax. In fact, you had no choice. This created a kind of perfect storm: most western countries were already deep into two decades of neoliberal governance and deteriorating welfare states, combined with a grotesquely privatized housing market which rendered even the idea of home ownership unrealistic for a lot of people. Mainstream culture caught up with the NEETs and the incels, spending all day in your bedroom was even encouraged. The pandemic pushed us to the point of no return: the bedroom is the best we're going to get.



Claire - Pretty Girl

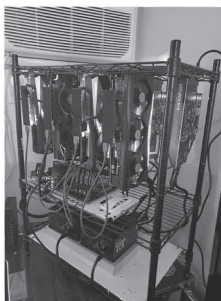
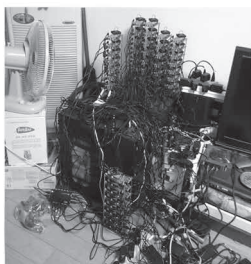


(from top to bottom): Claire, *Pretty Girl*, YouTube, 2018 & Tracey Emin, *My Bed*, Box frame, mattress, linen, pillows, and various objects, 1998.

## Politics of Refusal

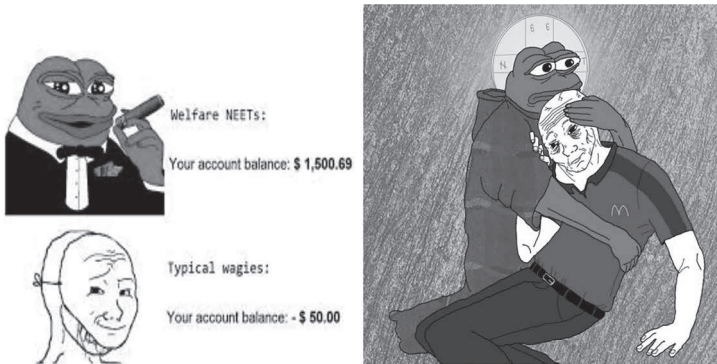
There is a productive dichotomy which takes place in the bedroom: on the one hand, it can become an aspirational space, a makeshift office, maybe even a headquarters; a space in which we can exercise entrepreneurship. Think of the trader, the crypto bro, the grifter giving you financial advice via webcam, the sex worker, the streamer. The bedroom is fertile ground for the grindset, the place where hustlepreneurs are born. Through networked technologies the lines between the bedroom as a leisurely space and as a productive space become blurred.

There are several examples of ways in which a computer and a bedroom can be utilized to make money: people build crypto mines, click farms, or even rent out the computational power of their home computer setups to companies. Others buy a webcam or use their built-in one to stream themselves while playing video games or performing sex work. This reflects Franco 'Bifo' Berardi's ideas about the proliferation of semiocapitalism (or cognitive capitalism), which depends on networked technologies to maximize labor and data extraction from so-called cognitariats. Our devices serve as tethers which keep us connected to globalized technocapitalism at all waking moments (even sleeping moments, if we take devices such as smart-beds into consideration). As we voluntarily embed these devices into our lived environments, we also open the door to big tech and the totalizing force of networked capitalism. Through technology, the bedroom can become a space for labor and surveillance, it can even start to resemble a factory.



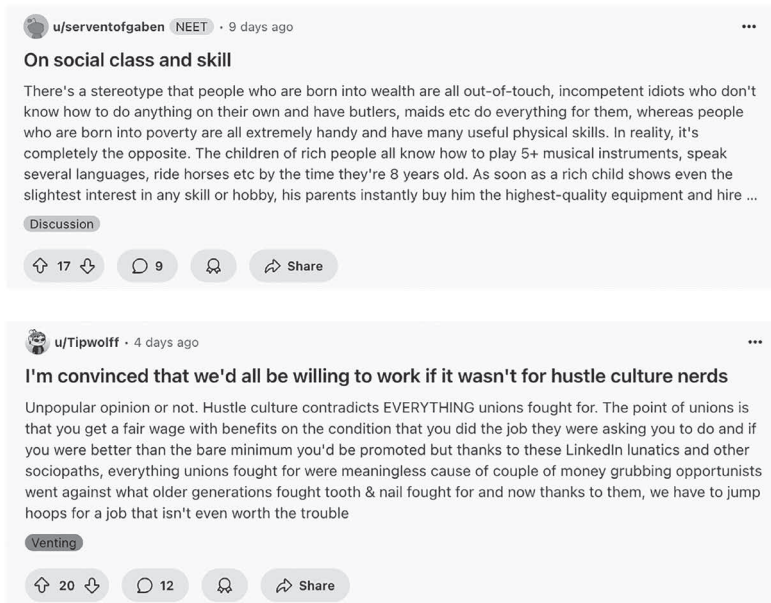
(bottom) Micaela Carolan, *100 Empty Cam Rooms*, *Do Not Research*, 2024.

On the other end of the spectrum, the NEET spends all their time in their room being intentionally unproductive; they principally reject productivity, embracing welfare or living with their parents. Their attitude is exemplified by the terminology used to refer to their self-proclaimed adversaries: 'wagecucks', 'wageslaves', 'jobcels' or simply 'wagies', which all refer to people in employment (in the form of wage labor). In the NEETs world, employed people are victims of the system (in other words: capitalism, although not much critical theory makes the rounds in NEET circles). The NEET instead sees themselves as gaming the system; they are proudly on welfare and live with their parents, saving and receiving as much money as possible in exchange for absolutely nothing. This lifestyle allows them to spend as much time as possible doing what they like, whether that's gaming, jerking off, or spending all day on discord. Unintentionally, they actually perform a radical politics: namely the politics of withdrawal and refusal, which refer to the rejection of capitalism's labor-productivity imperative. (Although it could be argued that NEETs become laborers through the semicapitalist invasion of personal time and space, they nonetheless gesture at the refusal of work through the rejection of wage labor). The NEET is visually almost always depicted as pepe, whereas the wagie is a frequently seen as a seething or tired wojak in a McDonald's uniform:



The figure of the NEET is culturally derived from the Japanese term Hikikomori, which refers to people who live a hermit-esque lifestyle, isolating themselves and generally behaving anti-socially. It should also be mentioned that NEETs, although generally associated with 4chan due to the use of its visual language (pepe's, wojaks, etc.), actually also operate outside of 4chan's usual ideological frameworks. On the NEET subreddit, members recount feelings of failure and hopelessness, mental health struggles, difficult family situations, and other systematic issues as reasons for their NEETdom. Whereas the subreddit also has its fair share of nihilist conspiracy theory, the latter category of NEET should not be dismissed or automatically grouped together with 4chan's genre of pessimistic NEETs. Similarly to the supposed adversaries of the hustlepreneur, the NEETs main adversary seems to be 'society' or societal expectations, which essentially read as internalized pressures to be productive—capitalism's central imperative. Most NEETs also see wage labor as exploitative and unfair (rightfully so), and thereby gesture at a basic tenet of capitalist critique. What I'm trying to say is that there seems to be a radical politics nestled somewhere in NEETsphere. One

only needs to scroll through the NEET subreddit to realize this, as it contains a myriad of posts about wage labor being exploitative, class consciousness, internalized guilt for being unproductive, exhaustion after finally getting a job, precariousness, etc. You can't tell me that these posts are not gesturing at radical, post-capitalist and post-scarcity sentiments.



The incel wiki mentions something called the NEET army, described as:

“a fictitious army of real-world NEETs. Some NEETs from these countries dress up in fake military gear and do parades or non-violent public stunts.

N.E.E.T. = Not Employment Embattled Team

It's an organization present worldwide... This army aims to fight against work and its exhausting tasks, they are there to rest and leave this active society where exhaustion is too present.

Their common enemy, the "W.O.R.K organization", which is also present in many states, fights against them and aims to find people who do not work enough to force them to return to the world of exhaustion and fatigue.”

Similarly to the hustlepreneur, the NEET depends on networked technology, but not to make money; rather, they use it to escape their financial limitations and restricted lifestyle



by becoming room-bound hermits who spend all their time online, slipping into unrestricted cyberspace. Whereas the hustlepreneur attempts to overcome precarity by using their devices and the internet as productive tools, the NEET uses these same devices to simply avoid and ignore precarity all together, wallowing in naivety. The NEET subreddit explicitly lists “no daytrading/crypto posting.” as one of its rules, for example. The NEET is the anti-hero to the hustlepreneur; the anti-entrepreneur.

## AGENTIAL PANIC



It should be mentioned that there are some NEETs who engage in online ways of making money, namely stock or crypto trading, as well as NEETs who live off inheritances and other forms of generational wealth (i.e. their parents paying for their lives), but these NEETs are anomalies in the overall community. Nonetheless, the hustlepreneurs and NEETs share a common enemy—precarity—which they approach from different angles. Precariousness, as a condition, engenders deep feelings of insecurity and shakiness, a perceived loss of the agency and autonomy we feel entitled to. The agency over an object or a space, such as through ownership—of a home or otherwise—no longer feels feasible.

Rather, ownership is purposely prevented through models of rentiership, proprietary softwares, and increasing prices, resulting in skewed dynamics of agency and ownership. Alongside the absence of a welfare state which previously would have guaranteed (collective) ownership or at least fair rentiership, this has lead to an era where (young) people feel as though they can never exercise full ownership or agency over significant aspects of their material realities. Precariousness therefore produces agential panic through the perceived or felt loss of agency. If you can't own a house, you might as well be in charge of the one space which feels as though it truly belongs to you: your bedroom.

The feelings of lost agency aren't only the result of neoliberal economic policies, however, they also emerge from our computational conditions. Jernej Markelej and Daniel de Zeeuw discuss this in their paper on agency panic, where they attribute the concept, derived

from Timothy Melley, to have emerged from the “liberal-humanist conception of the self as autonomous, self-determined, and [as a] rational agent.”<sup>2</sup> Markeleij and de Zeeuw position this concept in our contemporary computational landscape, wherein our lives are increasingly governed by blackboxed computational systems while we, conversely, are “interpellated as autonomous users.” This contradictory position is what leads to feelings of anxiety and panic. It comes as no surprise, then, that we seek narratives which re-stabilize our existence and affirm our agency. In digital contexts, this is often in the form of conspiracy theory; grand narratives in which we are being undermined and our adversaries are concretely identified (meaning that we have scapegoats). Whether it’s the neo-marxist elite, LGBTQ+ rights movements, or lizard people, these forces are out to get us.

When an enemy is concretized, so are strategies of resistance, and these strategies often start with individual autonomy. Whether it’s working out and eating raw meat, trading and mining crypto, or making your bed and tidying your room, these gestures attempt to reclaim individual agency (often framed as escaping the Matrix by conspiracists). This is also why these individual liberty gestures often emerge from the manosphere (most NEETs are men), there is a mythologized ‘masculine’ ideal of self-governance and personal liberty through individualized spaces. Take the subreddit *r/malelivingspace*, for example; as the name implies, there is a *male* way of occupying a living space.

Ultimately, these are reactions to the feelings of precarity and vulnerability; they are reductionist strategies and frameworks which reject victimhood and embrace a form of heroic agency. There’s something poetic about a person who feels like the world is out to get them simply picks up their agency where they have full control—their bedrooms and their bodies. These gestures also reinforce the anthropocentric view of the world which we stubbornly maintain even as we’re caught up in a complex technological assemblage which increasingly undermines and negates the conception of ourselves as autonomous, self-determined individuals. It would be more liberating to embrace agency as something relational, but our understanding of agency is still largely grounded in a highly anthropocentric, individualized, libertarian framework, an attitude which is exemplified by the hustlepreneur, and subverted by the NEET.

## The NEET and Hustlepreneur Dichotomy

There is a productive dichotomy which takes place in the bedroom: the NEET and the hustlepreneur neatly fit into this framework of agential panic, both figures address precarity in their respective attempts to overcome it. The hustlepreneur exercises agency by transforming their bedroom into an office or factory, rather than engaging in wage-labor,

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2 Jernej Markeleij and Daniel de Zeeuw. “Caught in the Loops of Digital Agency Panic : On NPCs and Internet Addicts”. *NECSUS European Journal of Media Studies*, 2023. <http://dx.doi.org/10.25969/mediarep/21712>.



they 'escape the matrix' by taking matters into their own hands; by 'becoming their own boss' and 'financial freedom'. This leads to a cycle of grifting the promise of autonomy and agency (repackaged as 'financial independence' or 'financial freedom') to others in a sad cycle of so-called entrepreneurship, usually operating out of their bedroom or DIY office. If you look at finance grifters online, they often film their promotional content out of their car or their home office; individualized spaces which they have full control over.

These spatial contexts are not coincidental, rather, the car is often a central symbol for libertarian idealism and their notion of 'freedom' (as well as a status symbol, of course) and the home office demonstrates that they are 'free' to stay at home instead of being office-bound. The NEET, on the other hand, accepts the perceived impossibility of financial independence, choosing to wallow in their self-pity and embracing social welfare as a source of income (also known as 'NEETbux'). If they can't escape the matrix, they might as well be happy in it. This is also observed by Franco 'Bifo' Berardi when discussing Japanese Hikikomori, he states: "[this] behaviour might appear to many young people as an effective way to avoid the effects of suffering, compulsion, self-violence and humiliation that [semicapitalist] competition brings about" going on to state that, in his personal interactions with Hikikomori in Japan, "they are acutely conscious that only by extricating themselves from the routine of daily life could their personal autonomy be preserved."<sup>3</sup>

Sticking with the hustlepreneur-NEET dichotomy a little longer, we can also explore both the concepts of hopium and copium through these figures. Both words are portmanteaus of the word 'opium', the former using 'hope' and the latter using 'cope'. To conflate a word with opium implies that it sedates its user, that it soothes their qualms, and eliminates pain. It most likely also references Marx's seminal quote "religion is the opiate of the masses" (already gesturing at the metaphorical definition of 'copium', i.e. religion as something to help the masses cope). According to Know Your Meme, hopium is a "fictional drug to help one stay hopeful in stressful times" and is derived from "stock market investors to describe market investors who hold on to failing investments out of false hope, and more recently by Bitcoin investors in a similar way." The correlation between investors and hopium is no coincidence, as their identity is underscored by hope: hope in markets, financial freedom, hope in escaping.

Copium, on the other hand, is the drug of choice for the NEET, a [metaphorical] substance that helps people deal with stress and other negative emotions, specifically dealing with the soothing of loss. In the NEETs case, loss of agency, of autonomy, and of respect. Let me explain: as outlined, NEETs not only experience a loss of agency and autonomy through their entanglement in planetary computational systems and neoliberal-policy induced precarity, but they are also othered by 'normies'. NEETdom is heavily associated with shame; being laughed at when applying for jobs, feeling like parasites, often sharing

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3 Franco 'Bifo' Berardi, *Heroes: Mass Murder and Suicide*, (London, 2015).

qualities with incels<sup>4</sup>—such as being unable to take part in romantic relationships or social life more broadly—the NEET entry on the incel wiki states: “One would expect a large number of male NEETs to also be incel (NEETcel), due to female economic and educational hypergamy and the overlap between NEETdom and mental illnesses that generally hamper male sexual success (such as social anxiety and autism).”<sup>5</sup> NEETs feel othered by society and simultaneously other ‘normies’ and position themselves as enlightened, occupying an awkward position. But NEETs are othered differently than incels: whereas incels feel othered due to sexual/romantic inadequacies, NEETs are othered due to their inability to be productive members of society (and often also due to feeling socially/romantically/sexually inept, leading to the creation of the term NEETcel). This oscillating attitude of NEETs, which moves from confident and enlightened to insecure and ashamed, results in a craving for copium, something which soothes this unstable position.

Although NEETs differ from the Japanese Hikikomori because NEETs are technically capable of going outside and engaging with their hobbies outside of their rooms (something Hikikomoris are unable to do due to mental health), they still predominantly occupy their bedroom (or apartment if they’re lucky). They also rely largely on their access to networked technologies for social contact and entertainment as they feel othered by ‘normie’ society, hence banishing them to the spaces which house their desktop setups. Staying inside on your computer all day is a sort of meta-cope, and grants them access to other forms of copium. When life becomes a cycle of disaster, crisis, decline, and doom, retracting oneself into NEETdom is the ultimate coping mechanism. And so there’s an acute awareness of being copium addicts, like terminal patients on life-support, many NEETs simply exist, often describing feelings of doom and anguish induced by their societal position. And their copium comes in many forms, from cultural consumption (listening to music, reading books, watching movies) to actual drugs, porn, and masturbation; similarly to the gooner, the NEET embraces copium with open arms, using it to persevere through their existence.

Their copium is also directly correlated to platform logics, as many NEETs describe one of their main copes being the consumption of content, ranging from porn to shortform vertical videos. Similarly to the gooner, they attempt to achieve a numbing/euphoric/flow state through the uninterrupted consumption of content, copium kills time. But the emergence of NEETs can also be articulated through the financial deterritorialization catalyzed by post-Fordism, wherein the relationship between labor and value has been obscured beyond recognition. As Franco ‘Bifo’ Berardi puts it, post-Fordist, semiocapitalism is categorized by “competition, [which] is all about subduing, cheating, predating. Blaming the victims is part of the game: you are guilty of your inability to subdue, to cheat and to plunder, therefore you will be submitted to the blackmail of debt and to the tyranny of austerity.”<sup>6</sup>

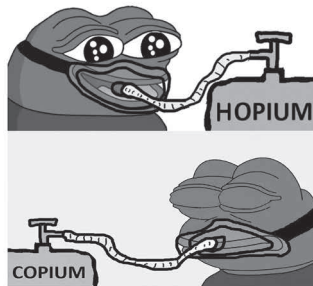
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4 See Kate Babin’s *Condemned to Rot Alone: The Incel Paradox of Collective Loneliness*, on page [...] in this book.

5 “NEET,” Incels Wiki, <https://incels.wiki/w/NEET>.

6 Franco ‘Bifo’ Berardi, *Heroes: Mass Murder and Suicide*, (London, 2015).

Financial capitalism profits from doom, and therefore incentivizes it—it actively produces nihilism, and so NEETs naturally appear, sometimes as hopeful postcapitalists, but mostly as doomer nihilists. When the world is a sinking ship, the best thing to do is to get comfy in your room while you're hooked up to copium.



## Battlestations

For both the hustlepreneur and the NEET, bedrooms become headquarters and desktops become battlestations; they rely on their bedrooms and their desktop setups for feelings of agency and autonomy. Nick Vyssotsky's *Display of Commodity Accessories* (Zack's Room) and *Mining Meaning* (Quest for Validation) are artworks which cleverly explore the feelings of agential panic through simulating the spaces in which both the NEET or incel and the hustling crypto bro attempt to reclaim and exercise their lost agency. New media, as opposed to legacy media, allows for autonomy and agency to be exercised through usership. Traditional forms of media have a unilateral dynamic with whoever is interacting with them. You are simply viewing and consuming – you are a spectator instead of a user. New media instead allows and encourages responsiveness, and is fundamentally underpinned by a bilateral dynamic between user and device. As Wendy Hui Kyong Chun cleverly put it, networked devices mark the difference “between the empowered user and the couch potato”<sup>7</sup>.

7 Wendy Hui Kyong Chun, “Crisis, Crisis, Crisis, or Sovereignty and Networks.” *Theory, Culture & Society*, vol. 28, no. 6, 2011, pp. 91–112, <https://doi.org/10.1177/0263276411418490>.

Users have responsibility, their interaction with their device relies on their input, and responsibility is empowering insofar as it hinges on the agency and autonomy of the responsible. Furthermore, as users we can customize platforms, are under the impression that we choose what we consume, we are supposedly in charge. Particularly in the case of the NEET, who relinquishes all IRL (or AFK) responsibilities, their onlineness most likely stabilizes the shakiness induced by a complete lack of responsibility in the 'real world'.



*Nick Vyssotsky, Display of Commodity Accessories (Zack's Room)*

The word battlestation is therefore particularly revealing; referring to expanded and elaborate desktop setups that often feature multiple screens, a custom-built computer, an expensive keyboard, and a comfortable desk chair, the term became heavily associated with chronically online individuals. Taken from the concept of a centralized space from which (semi-)remote warfare can be conducted, it implies total control. The battlestation is the space where high ranking military officials can strategize and assess the battlefield. It provides oversight and the possibility for decision making so that the enemy can be dominated from a tactical position.

The overlap between the term as it's used in warfare and to describe elaborate desk setups uncovers that those who sit at the desk and operate the battlestation similarly seek control and oversight, or in other words, a form of agency. The aforementioned notions of exercising agency through new media are therefore facilitated by the battlestation. New media requires input and interaction which are mediated by devices, and these devices

become our agential tools. They require movement; typing, moving a mouse, clicking and scrolling. There is a very concrete transmutation of physical movement into digital action. The bedroom dweller has all their controls at the tip of their fingers when positioned at the battlement, which is exactly why it's so empowering. If the internet is a kingdom, the gamer chair becomes a throne.

Seasoned soldiers of onlinedom will often have two or more monitors, signifying commitment to time spent in the digital. Similarly to the term battlement, the computer screen finds its origins in the military, and so it also reproduces the same military gestures emerging from desktop battlements: oversight and control. The early radar sweep technology, whose contemporary counterpart is found in software offerings provided by companies like Palantir and Anduril, illustrates this logic. The myriad of actions enabled by network technologies would be useless if not for the screen, and it is through the screen that the digital becomes interpretable and can be acted upon. Screens flatten and condense things — originally space, now vast amounts of data — they are essential in the transition from machine-legibility to human-legibility. Human-legibility, in turn, leads to human-action; computer screens don't simply represent things, they present them in order to be acted upon or to be acted with. The screen thereby facilitates the exercise of human agency and control, something which is underscored by its military origins. For the NEET or the hustlepreneur, screens and computers are modes of empowerment and control. It's no coincidence that the crypto traders desk and the PC gamer setup resemble the control rooms of drone operators.



The desire for agency and autonomy which is achieved through a battlestation can be expanded to the bedroom in general, which is most likely where the battlestation is positioned anyway. In a way, we all address our feelings of agential panic through careful curation of our rooms and desks. Our bedroom becomes a battlestation in and of itself. Reflected by the ubiquity of people accessorizing their bedrooms to the point of becoming mini houses (think piss-bottles, mini fridges, desks, couches, TV's, etc.), we create mini-realities, our own little worlds in which we decide and we have control. In doing so, our bedrooms begin to resemble war-rooms, places of control, places to lock in.

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# STARNET: A HISTORY OF INTERNET CAFES IN IAȘI (ROMANIA)

RUXANDRA MĂRGINEANU & RADU-MIHAI TĂNASĂ

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*It's around 3 or 4 in the morning - and my priority right now is to make sure I open, and then close the apartment door quietly enough so that my parents won't get woken up by my sudden appearance in the house. Although it might seem like it, I didn't go out with my friends in the club or at the bar that night; I was coming back from a "Full Night" at the most popular internet cafe chain in town.*

As common in post-communist countries, Western trends reach us 10 years later. After the fall of the Iron Curtain and the brutal transition to the free market, Romania was late with the 90's trend of internet/cyber cafes. Thus the 2000's were its golden age.<sup>1</sup> For a good decade, every teenager had cheap and reliable access to the World Wide Web - and especially to the beast that was Counter Strike 1.6. But after ten strong years, almost overnight, internet cafes became extinct. Redditors<sup>2</sup> along with old<sup>3</sup> and new<sup>4</sup> bloggers alike are now collectively grieving and reminiscing about the good old days of the 2000s, when the grass was greener and the internet cafes were the place to be. Yet somehow, somewhere, in the north-east side of Romania, in the city of Iași (where we grew up), bordering the Republic of Moldova, the internet cafe became a living fossil - thriving and surviving, even today.

Although the second city of Romania in terms of population, size and development, Iași remains the embodiment of the underdog. While neither as cool as the capital Bucharest nor as flashy as Cluj, Iași was blessed with a constant growth in all its sectors - including internet cafes. At its peak, Iași was home to three internet cafe franchises along with smaller establishments when most cities in the country could only host at most two or three locales. No one knows what the right ingredients were for such a miracle to happen. But what's known is that since 2003 a new generation of internet cafes started popping up throughout the city. Slowly but surely they became a catalyst for a subculture that would eventually define entire generations of local millennial and Gen Z gamers.

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1 Afacerea Internet-cafe Buna Ziua Iasi. 2001. <https://arhiva.bzi.ro/afacerea-internet-cafe-21902>

2 ablkholewlksintoabar. *Va mai aduceti aminte de Internet Cafe-urile anilor 90?* 2019. Reddit. [https://www.reddit.com/r/Romania/comments/3exiba/va\\_mai\\_aduceti\\_aminte\\_de\\_internet\\_cafeurile/](https://www.reddit.com/r/Romania/comments/3exiba/va_mai_aduceti_aminte_de_internet_cafeurile/)

3 Dumitru, Radu. "Mai functioneaza Internet Cafe-urile?" 2011. Nwradu Blog. <https://www.nwradu.ro/2011/12/mai-functioneaza-internet-cafe-urile/>

4 Arhi. "Mai există internet cafeuri?" Blogul lui Arhi. 2023. <https://arhiblog.ro/exista-internet-cafeuri/>

## What is an Internet Cafe?

Internet cafes are somewhat of a misnomer. The term is used in Romania to refer to a place that houses a specific community of gamers. According to Wikipedia, the term internet cafe refers to an establishment whose main form of revenue is made through the provision of affordable access to the World Wide Web, using high-speed internet and dedicated hardware (usually gaming computers). As with any other private endeavors, variants can pop up through mixing and matching different businesses: some internet cafes offer food/beverages, others might do some print jobs, and so on. The uniqueness of each internet cafe is not limited to the novelty of the business idea, as much as its associated community, which defines its unique purpose.



Internet cafes were originally called cyber cafes, after London's own Cyberia Cafe (according to the Brits), although early variants of it have been documented ever since the 1980's in Hong Kong.<sup>5</sup> In the early days these places were frequented by everyday people whose needs and wants were to connect with others virtually using telnet, IRC, ftp and to surf the Web. The writers cannot go into more detail about the specifics and the vibes of that time as both of them were too young and too much into gaming to relate to specific 1990s Internet experiences.

What we do know is that these normal people with their normal needs for virtual communication would eventually be replaced by the gamers, whose appetite for new hardware, newer games and ever-shrinking wallets made these places the perfect middle, and perfect meeting ground. And business owners were eager to welcome and adapt their locales for them. Office chairs were replaced with gaming chairs, webcams became gaming headphones, and light bulbs turned into gaming neons. Take Nexusclub: anything to make a gamer feel at home.<sup>6</sup>

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5 Sonia Liff and Anne Sofie Laegran. "Cybercafés: Debating the Meaning and Significance of Internet Access in a Café Environment." *New Media & Society* 5, no. 3 (2003): 307–312. <https://journals.sagepub.com/doi/pdf/10.1177/14614448030053001>

6 Nexus Club. (n.d.). #1 Internet Cafe Bucuresti Non Stop | Nexus Club | Gamers Pub – #1 Internet



The World Wide Web and its avatar, the personal computer, that laid the foundation for what was to become the internet cafe. In June of 1991, SFnet was the first entity to put together the exact building blocks for one by installing 25 computer terminals throughout the San Francisco Bay Area. It thus managed to establish a working coffeehouse network. Following SFnet's success, businesses around the area started to imitate and improve upon the original recipe, creating cybercafes and finally, the internet cafes. In the beginning, these establishments were marketed as places that gave you access to web communication services for an affordable price. It's best to think of these places as an upgraded version of the payphone.<sup>7</sup> Users would typically frequent cybercafes to send emails, browse IRC channels and do light research of current news. This is what gamers typically call "normie" behavior.

As technology, and more specifically hardware, evolved in the 2000's, so did the scope and the clientele of some of these cybercafes. Personal Computers could now reliably run not just offline single-player games, but giants like Starcraft, Defense of the Ancients and World of Warcraft quickly became virtual staples in many hard-drives around the globe. LAN parties were just becoming popular, and innovative cybercafe owners quickly realized that they could grow big by facilitating a dedicated place for not just a LAN party, but LAN party-parties.

Why go through the trouble of creating a timetable, setting up a dedicated server and cleaning your gamer cave, when someone else could do that for you? And for cheap too. The shift from just offering access to virtual communication to including gaming in their repertoire of services is what transformed the then 'cyber cafes' into the 2000's 'internet cafes'.

To understand how big the Internet Cafe craze became, one must look no further than to Basshunter's hit *DOTA*, released in 2006 - marking the exact turning point of this mentality shift. The music video presents three main environments considered, at the time, the three epicenters of ideal Gamer life: the Bedroom, the Club and the Internet Cafe, with the last being turned into a concert-tournament hybrid.

Viewers are presented in the beginning with the imagery of the classic LAN party, with all its ups (girlfriends) and downs (moms); to be then hit with a perplexing club scene, in which no computer is seen in sight, as the focus is on the social interactions. The glue that binds it all is eventually presented in the aforementioned Concert-Tournament Internet Cafe Hybrid - the ideal marriage between the highs and lows of competitive gaming and the social adrenaline of late-night clubbing. It is the sea of computer screens, the jungle of jumbled cables and the comfort within the concrete walls of this Mega LAN Party that many gamers consider the great Internet Cafe Utopia. But how accurate was this admittedly very idealistic depiction in different parts of the world, especially in the land of Dracula? As we, the writers, were

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Cafe Din Bucuresti . Retrieved May 13, 2024, from <https://nexusclub.ro/>

7 Reuters. "New York's Latest Virtual Trend: Hip Cybercafés on the Infobahn." Los Angeles Times, June 29, 1995. <https://www.latimes.com/archives/la-xpm-1995-06-29-fi-18601-story.html>.

too young to experience the birth and the early life of internet cafes in Romania, we have to resort to second-hand reports. Luckily, we can get a very small but relevant overview of internet cafes in Romania straight out of 2004, in a study on Internet access in the country at the time.<sup>8</sup>



It seems that 2004 had quite the downer vibe, as the writers were not so sure about the future prospects of the internet cafe. But even from their language, we can gather that they are still using the word to reference the business model as it was operating in the West. We can therefore make an assumption that the iconic gamer identity of the Romanian internet cafe came sometime later in the Y2Ks.

With the advent of the personal (home) computer, access to the World Wide Web slowly started to democratize. While in the West this started in the late 80's, in Eastern Europe this happened in the new millennium.<sup>9</sup> Because of the abrupt jump to capitalism, internet infrastructure developed very quickly as there wasn't much older tech to replace it. At the same time, access was disproportionately over-represented in urban centers. Even today on the countryside, internet access is still almost exclusively done via smart phones.<sup>10</sup>

Having a (recent) Communist past that has now transitioned to a free-market democracy, Romania has seen a rapid increase in consumer goods spending and in technological advancements. Unlike the Netherlands, Romania only has had a few decades of experience

8 Sorin Gudea and Terry Ryan. "Internet Access in Romania." January 2005. [https://www.researchgate.net/publication/237341632\\_INTERNET\\_ACCESS\\_IN\\_ROMANIA](https://www.researchgate.net/publication/237341632_INTERNET_ACCESS_IN_ROMANIA).

9 Ofer Malamud and Cristian Pop-Elecheș. "Home Computer Use and the Development of Human Capital." June 18, 2011. <https://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pmc/articles/PMC3377478/>.

10 E. Beserman et al., *Digital Inclusion and Exclusion in Romania 2022: A National Study*, Institutul de Cercetare Făgăraș, December 13, 2022, <https://icf-fri.org/digital-inclusion-and-exclusion-in-romania-2022-a-national-study/>

to deal with this mentality shift in creating subcultures around consumer products. Yet, similar to China, Romania has a bigger sense of social cohesion. Social activities are still a much bigger part of the everyday person's life than in NL (the weather helps a lot too). Hanging out on the street is much more common in these countries than in the West, where such behavior is more associated with (dangerous) teenagers and their unsuccessful helicopter parents.

Comparing liberal Western countries (what Romania aspired to be since 2008) to still existing Communist countries such as China (what Romania once was), democratic access to rapidly developing and affordable technology seems to accelerate the shift to gaming as a more individualistic hobby while on the other hand having a higher barrier of entry to certain hardware and using a middleman (or middle-space) seems to paradoxically create a stronger sense of community amongst gamers.<sup>11</sup> Using this axis we can better understand where Romania can be placed with regards to internet cafe culture.

Internet cafes offered this unique situation where a private entity can create the ideal third place for young people who are interested in gaming to hang out through a relaxed barrier of entry, non-stop hours and affordable pricing by using recently built reliable and high speed internet infrastructure. As a newcomer to the capitalist game, Romania has made numerous enthusiastic changes to laissez-faire economic policies to contrast with its dictatorial past. Thus, the strategy of running an internet cafe had to follow this new mentality. Combine it with people's generally more social predisposition and their love for nightlife, and you got yourself the perfect business.

Everyone was welcome, regardless of social status, ethnicity, gender or technical skill. The internet cafe was where competitive MOBA girl-gamers met with casual FIFA-enjoyer highschoolers and CS:GO-obsessed gang members. All internet cafes were populated not just during the night, but more often than not, during school hours.<sup>12</sup>

## Starnet

Let's focus on internet cafes in Iași and zoom in on Starnet, which was -and still is-the biggest internet cafe annex franchise in the city and a general point of reference in terms of organization, pricing and diversity of services. The choice for Starnet was made to honor our shared community and lived experience, making sure that we speak as a community member and not as a detached, cold observer. This comes with certain disadvantages, mainly the difficulties we have faced in trying to go deeper into the inner workings of

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11 Junhao Hong and Li Huang, "A Split and Swaying Approach to Building Information Society: The Case of Internet Cafes in China," *Telematics and Informatics* (March 7, 2005), <https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/abs/pii/S0736585305000201>

12 Iasi, Z. *Elevi de primară, găsiți de polițiști prin Internet Cafe-uri*. 2013. <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=xRwdXKzWJS0>

Starnet as a private endeavor. Business owners in Romania are notoriously paranoid and opaque about their practices, not eager to collaborate or give details into how they run their business or what their motivations are. We had to resort to interviews with Starnet customers in an effort to still adhere to a vague sense of objectivity or integrity. What Iași offered in terms of quality, such as service, products and community, was indeed of higher quality than the country's average.

On their website Starnet proudly claims that in 2023 they celebrated their twenty years anniversary. We were unable to find any relevant information of Starnet's inception or anything dating earlier than 2014 through unorthodox online archives such as browsing locale review sites. And knowing how private the Owner is in regards to additional details meant that it would be quite hard to assemble a complete timeline for now. Business owners in Romania are in general quite reluctant to sharing too much information, as they always risk either getting questioned by the Government (which already eats up a lot of the profits through high VAT, income taxes and much more); or they might accidentally overshare unethical business practices, which is still (unfortunately) the norm.

We estimate that the establishment indeed started in 2003 but the registration name would have been different and the address might as well just be someone's apartment rather than something akin to a cafe. We looked into Google Maps as a last resort concerning the localities. Since the gaps in time are quite big, Maps only gave us only vague time intervals of activity. Through this we can confirm that the oldest Starnet was (already?) a thing by 2011, 3 years earlier than its other digital footprints. But then again, 2011 was also the first year of the Google car visiting Iași. Other online sources might point as far back as to 2008 as a legitimate period of Starnet activity, but this can only be implied by looking up Stargrill's opening year, which was a restaurant sharing both the location and the name with Starnet.

Beyond the respectable humble beginnings and perhaps some (possible) loopholes at play, we suspect that it took quite the time to eventually set up such a locale, as equipment was very expensive for the time, it needed to be upgraded quite frequently - and not to mention the egregious prices software companies demanded for commercial use. What type of small business owner would be thrilled to pay for Windows, Winrar and other such expensive expenses? For now, this is the amount of gossip we are able to entertain.

For honesty's sake, we have to admit that our introduction to internet cafes was linked directly with high school, thus around 2015-2016. Around this time is when it felt as if the internet cafe phenomena was gaining rapid momentum. Their positioning and identity was also quite clear: this was not your grandma's internet cafe where you log in to yahoo to check your business email or Nigerian prince scams. This was a place for hip, *dank* gamers who no-scope everyday while listening to Skrillex and 420 blazing it. Internet cafe owners knew what gamers, and especially teenagers, wanted.

Looking at older 1990's localities in Western Europe and the US such as Easy Internet Cafe, we were shocked by the clean, corporate look that these cafes sported. Starnet and its competitors could not be any more different: rooms were dark, only lit by neon bands; the computers were slim, edgy and dark; and the walls were all decorated in gamer references, usually paintings of characters from different video games, with different rooms inside of the cafe having very thematic names like Gods, Gladiators, or Pirates.

If there was one thing that Starnet focused strongly on from the very beginning, it was organization, structure and economy. The moment you stepped in as a newcomer, you were required to sign in and join their database. You were asked for your ID, fill in paperwork with basic contact information and pose for a picture. Some might consider this draconian measures, but this initiation ritual was spiritually meant to show how intertwined the virtual and physical are. On a more practical level though, knowing that every customer had a personal account, unique username and an overview of recent activities inside the establishment put a lot more weight on individual actions and responsibilities.

## The Starnet Business Model

If you behaved poorly, which was frequently the case in many internet cafes, the staff could immediately intercept and penalize you. If you were a good customer and a team player, the community or staff could reward you with (sometimes under-the-hand) perks or discounts. Such manners of dealing with gaming-based communities have been also implemented in countries like Korea, where attaching limited personal information to League of Legends accounts and/or internet cafe customers has resulted in less overall toxicity and misbehavior - no wonder it also worked in İaşi.

But the initial screening wasn't done just for security's sake. If it were just for that, Starnet would have been seen not as a successful internet cafe, but as a prison. Instead, they coated this safety measure with a UI and quality-of-life improvement virtual service. Every computer in Starnet was locked behind a log-in screen. This meant that unintended use by strangers was kept at a minimum. And more than that, every Starnet computer had a custom navigation screen, slightly different from a normal Windows configuration, so that anyone, regardless of their IT skills or experience, could access whatever virtual service they wanted at a moment's notice. Users also had a whole internal economy they could manage through this UI and that really reinforced the idea that you are not using a regular computer, you are using Starnet's curated version of it.

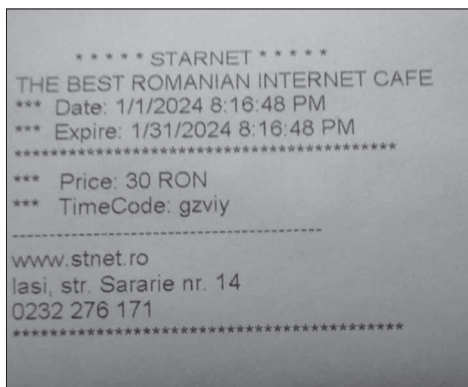
After you logged in to your account, one last thing to do before playing was to, of course, buy hours. Buying hours was the main Starnet product. Customers had the option of buying different amounts of hours that allowed them unrestricted access to the computers. You could either get a standard fee of per hour spent in front of the screen, or you could buy hours in bulk for a discount. One, three and five hour packages were usually the standard, but for dedicated gamers, even 24 hours packages could be bought.

Starnet had their own currency called “stars”. *Stars* could be obtained either from unused purchased hours, or through codes that were usually handed by starnet staff directly - or by simply buying them. *Stars* acted as readymade discounts, every Starnet product had 2 prices: in RON, or in RON + Stars, with the latter always costing less real-life currency provided you collected enough *stars*. Starnets’ own user interface also kept track of your money and stars through your own dedicated wallet. Users could not just hoard or keep the spare change for future sessions, but could also show some generosity by transferring money or stars to other players, further fostering a sense of beyond-virtual community.



Along with virtual products, Starnet offered real-life products in the shape of drinks, food, and more recently, even shisha (for a good price too). Bringing food from outside was considered against the rules, although it was hard to reinforce, as even the employees themselves would bring in or order food for their impossibly long 10/20 hrs shifts. In its golden days, Starnet had a dedicated, non-stop, in-house restaurant called Stargrill, a kind of gamer canteen. Customers would usually ask Starnet staff for a Stargrill menu and after making up their mind, would walk a few meters to the restaurant desk and kitchen, shout their order and go back to their game. After 30 to 40 mins, Starnet staff would graciously visit their computer desk with a freshly cooked dish, and the customer would in turn quickly and carelessly toss the money so as to not lose the focus on their match. Stargrill offered a variety of finger foods perfectly crafted to be eaten in short, seconds-long bursts, when you were either in a match lobby, going to lane, or respawning.

*Everytime you bought something from Starnet, a small receipt would be printed and handed to you. Each one started with a small message that read: “The best Internet Cafe in Romania”*



## The "Full Night" Experience

Beginning with 2015, Starnet attempted to differentiate itself from the other Internet cafes by creating a stronger community with its customer base, those being mostly middle and high school teenagers. The in-house UI always presented customers with different choices of products, like the previously-mentioned bulk hours. But now they would upgrade to contain dedicated packages based on the time of day most customers would be most active.

One such product was the now-classic "Full Night" package. This item single-handedly turned Starnet from a small local establishment to a local business giant. For the very low price of approx. 30 RON (less than 8 EUR at the time), you could sit in front of the computer for 8 uninterrupted hours starting anywhere from 20 to 2 o'clock. Internet cafes in Romania were different from its Western counterparts for having similar working hours, and being under similar jurisdiction to casinos, which were open non-stop. With this "Full Night" product, Starnet was no longer offering a better deal just compared to other internet cafes. They were now directly competing with hostels for quick and cheap overnight accommodation; and clubs for cheap and safe social entertainment. This decision inevitably transformed the Internet Cafe into the dominant alternative night scene in Iași.

Starnet employees never did background checks. Neither were they paid enough to do that. The owner could not be bothered either. Contrary to a (night) club, the bar for entry was nonexistent. This meant that for a minor, the internet cafe was their first introduction to nightlife. The laissez faire business strategy that Starnet pushed, of having a main consumer-group composed of minors, should have been a PR disaster. That was, if the authorities had been notified, or if parents were made aware of this. Luckily, most parents had no idea what an internet cafe was. The more helicopter types assumed that it was a casino, as the Romanian term for games (jocuri) was usually associated more with gambling than MOBAs.

Surprisingly, the mix of ages, backgrounds, and later on even genders, made internet cafes both the most inclusive and one of the more toxic spaces of *laşi*. The best way to picture oneself inside Starnet is to think of a place like 4chan or perhaps more aptly, a League of Legends /all chat, where everyone sits in the same room. Among the cacophony of mouse and keyboard clicks, curses, slurs and broken English was the norm. The occasional encouragement or sincere congratulations for carrying a match felt ten times more rewarding in this sea of intensity. Yet, no matter the frequency of f-, c-, g- and other one-letter slurs, when it came time to have a siggy break, everyone came outside the locale in good spirits, reminiscing about the crazy experience that was the previous match, regardless if it was a loss or a win.

In its *golden days*, a Starnet establishment would usually be frequented by high schoolers skipping class, young professionals who could not afford either the Microsoft or Adobe Suite, unemployed people that would use the Internet to apply for vacancies, and sometimes by the rare homeless person who had nowhere else to stay during the long and cold winter nights.

Similar to internet cafes in Japan, Starnet acted as a temporary shelter solution for the jobless, homeless and in general, the less privileged. For them, the internet cafe was everything a hotel could *actually* provide in this new era of digitalization. Starnet graciously offered not just a great selection of video games, but (questionably) legal licenses for the MS and Adobe Suites, Yahoo Mail and Google Drive, food through Stargrill, and even limited printing services in some cases.

*Overnight, thousands of nerdy teenagers now had to create the most elaborate excuses to get to spend the night in what their parents thought was an elaborate casino establishment*

## Portrait of a Starnet “Operator”

Starnet seemed to have a very simple hierarchical structure. There was the *Owner*, and immediately underneath him, the Starnet employee. The heart and soul of every Starnet location was its *Operator*, a person whose job was, on paper, to provide technical help when the PCs would act up. But that was just the job title. In reality, the Operator would do everything: helping people with IT problems, being a good host to the newcomers, acting as a guard when unwelcome guests would show up, doing the regular clean up, selling snacks and keeping the tab. And all of this on a 10, to even 20-hour shift (counting ciggy breaks only btw) on (less than) minimum wage. A Starnet location would usually have one to maybe two *Operators* active at a time, and no one else.

Though the job prospects were awful, the *Operator* was perhaps the best person you could befriend in a Starnet. The *Operator* was in many regards just like you; either a nerdy League player, or a more street-smarts guy who enjoyed his CS 1.6. Throughout your “Full Night” set (and thus, during his shift), the *Operator* would be right next to you, playing a



round of CS:GO to slack off; bringing you a Cola while talking about how to better play your jungle main; or telling you about his break-up on a cigarette break. The *Operator*'s mix of slight sense of authority and relatability made him the perfect pillar for the internet cafe community, as many people likened him to the Bartender of an RPG, who introduces you to all sorts of people, stories, gossip (and quests).

To add to the persona, most of Starnet's *Operators* were an important part of the community even outside of their working hours as most of them would finish their shift only to start playing as customers themselves, in turn passing the authority to the next person in charge. This shifting between employee and customer meant that every Starnet locale was deeply in touch with the wants and needs of the community - and though Starnet was a business at the end of the day, it managed to organically create a sense of community that many enterprises today could only dream of.

*The man next to the cash register always seemed bored or phased out. But the moment I say the magic words: "Operator!" - his face switches with either interest, or perplexion.*

Around 2016, Starnet started getting an influx of new visitors and veteran customers constantly, regardless of season, month, week or time of day. The previously mentioned laissez-faire mentality that the owner pushed for had finally paid off. So much so that new Starnet locations popped up almost overnight, in sync. The owner had also planned for each location to have a certain specialization, or niche:

*Starnet Târgu Cucu* is by far the oldest and the most popular location, situated in an old, slowly dilapidating building. If the outside of the building gives off a slightly pessimistic atmosphere, the interior tells another story: old interwar architecture fuses with neon lights and slick gaming stations, painted walls depict different video game characters and the same 2hr club gaming playlist plays nonstop.

The location has 3 rooms filled with computers, with the central room providing an additional Playstation station, therefore it was seen as a less casual-friendly location and more as the place where you go to grind out ranked matches. This Starnet's highlight was by far the StarGrill business which was operating in the same building. Instead of having to order and then wait up to two hours for some gamer grub, customers only had to talk to Starnet personnel and they would get their dish of choice within half an hour guaranteed.

The (previously) third in size and second in popularity, *Starnet Iulius* was an instant hit with the local gamer community and eventually proved itself to be a successful investment for the long run. Found on the ground floor of Iulius Mall, a symbolic location where the first-ever Mall was constructed in Iași after the 1989 Revolution. Spanning over a few different rooms and even having its own entrance, outside of the Mall's working hours, Starnet Iulius Mall was especially a hit with younger audiences. As overworked parents came to the Mall for their weekly grocery shopping, leaving their kid/ teenager sitting for 2 hours

in front of a computer or a PlayStation console for the low price of 10 RON (approx. 3 Euros) seemed like the logical and safest choice. Perhaps this choice is what ultimately led to the closing of KidsLand, the Mall's own playground, which was itself on the brink of celebrating ten years of activity.

A more successful out of the new generation of franchises, the *Starnet Podu Roș* branch proved to be extremely profitable with its unconventional yet somehow intimate location. Hiding in plain sight right in front of one of the main city roads, Starnet Podu Roș boasted a giant "PUBG or Fortnite" banner in its glory days, no doubt an ingenious trick to get people's attention and thus, new customers.

Perhaps this was also the reason why all Fortnite and PUBG competitions started happening there almost exclusively. Unfortunately the unorthodox location that was neighboring a very popular casino in the area would eventually prophesize its demise. As teenagers would begin their gaming journey by buying CS:GO skins, the allure of gambling inherent in loot boxes translated perfectly to slot machines.

The smallest branch, *Starnet Unirii*, was strategically placed right in the middle of the bustling city center. Although at first it seemed like it was the main player, and the one to hopefully bring the most revenue, Starnet Unirii was the first branch to close permanently. Being known for its polarizing effect, customers thought prices were exorbitant for the high-end machines while cheaper tickets gave you access to subpar computers. These days Starnet Unirii is remembered to have managed to pull in the casual market, with the main money makers being the Playstation and Xbox consoles. That money, however, was not enough to keep the establishment afloat.

The notorious one of the bunch, *Starnet Hala Centrală*, was an example in resilience, managing to outlive its Unirii counterpart despite its drawbacks. Not being known either for high-performing tech or memorable staff, and being placed in an awkward location on the first floor of Hala Centrală commercial center, this location felt more like an afterthought rather than a focused, strategic business decision. Sharing a location with a mall or commercial center can be both a blessing and a curse; Starnet Iulius Mall, with its ground-floor entrance, proved to be the first option. But Starnet Hala Centrală's position on the first floor in an establishment with a 12 hr opening hours schedule made it challenging to access the nonstop Internet Cafe inside; especially in the weekend, and at night, when most people were most eager to gather.

## The Dark Ages (Covid)

The rise of Starnet seemed more and more exponential, but during 2019, things seemed to mellow - locations got closed permanently and fewer people were coming. You could feel it in the prices that were growing, and in the avalanche of spur-of-the-moment limited offers, discounts and packages Starnet would send on your phone. The breaking

point however proved to be March of 2020 and the worldwide lockdowns that followed afterwards. Every business got hit, but Internet Cafes were hit the hardest, as the bulk of their customers saw themselves locked inside the house for almost three consecutive months - only to be followed by more random week-long interdictions sprinkled in throughout the whole year.

To curb the huge amount of losses the business had suffered, the Owner had resorted to some drastic measures. Firstly, Starnet started operating according to casino regulations during 2021 (and 2022). This meant that the Internet Cafe was allowed to operate from morning until midnight on non-lockdown weeks and to be fully closed on lockdown weeks. This rule gave both casinos and Internet Cafes an edge against other establishments like museums, clubs or restaurants, which had very strict opening schedules, with exact visiting days being planned and announced weeks or even months ahead of time; whereas the former would just open immediately after a lockdown - at least that is what the documents said.

According to official documents and the vigilant eyes of the police, Starnet was conducting business as usual. Within an old historical building, Tg. Cucu Starnet was as lively as ever, although customers and staff alike were more vigilant than ever before. Some precautions had to be taken, in order for the money to come in: gamers had to sit one chair apart from each other, effectively cutting the maximum capacity in half; masks were encouraged, but not mandatory; smoking either inside or outside was strictly prohibited, so as to not draw the attention of the police; and exiting the building during a "Full Night" was the worst crime one could commit.

But by far the most interesting addition was the voice alerts that every computer now possessed: when staff learned that planned police inspections would take place throughout the lockdown months, they installed a customized voice announcement in each computer to alert the customers of incoming government checks. A few hours or minutes preceding the inspection, a gamer would hear mid-match a voice that would recommend customers engage in mask-wearing and social distancing while being outside their homes. The previous quick briefing by the Operator made the gamer understand that this was not a kind request by Starnet staff to conform to basic lockdown rules, but a warning call that police inspections might happen in as little as 5 minutes. They knew that by the moment they heard that voice, they had to either leave the location immediately or to wear a mask for the next few hours.

This is how Starnet managed to not only stay afloat during the worst of times, but to be more successful than even casinos, Romania's most thriving industry; subtly managing to evade the watchful eye of the Law. Subtlety was the way to go when the government called for drastic measures.



## Starnet Today

As of 2023, the wave of bad luck continues to hit Starnet. The inflation that followed the pandemic made regular customers think twice about whether or not to spend the night in Tg. Cucu or the Iulius Mall. Prices kept rising, to the unbelievable 13 RON/hr (approx. 2.5 Euros) compared to the 5 RON/hr (approx. 1 Euro) that used to be the golden standard.

Even so, Starnet is proving time and again that resilience is what wins the fight. Even with higher prices, fewer locations and a diminished customer base, the internet cafe chain still seems to stay afloat. Locations appear to be continuously populated at a third or quarter of their capacity. While the era of Starnet championships is gone, they still proudly sponsor up-and-coming pro teams to hold their title of “Best Internet Cafe in Romania”. To prove that 2023 is nothing like 2015, they have adapted to the times and are now giving extra discounts and offers to female customers to combat sexism and to hopefully reach a previously untapped demographic. Their recent acquisition of a brand new PS5 also suggests that perhaps casual players are slowly coming back too.

The second half of 2023 proved to be of help to Starnet, as Iași was nominated almost overnight as the Esports Capital of the World. Thousands of esports fans, streamers and even professional teams all met up to battle it out on the territory that Starnet called home. For a few weeks, Starnet was no longer just a successful albeit small local attraction, it was a worldwide superstar enjoying its short but well-deserved 15 minutes of fame.

Perhaps a new Golden Age era will arise for Starnet? In a few decades or centuries, Iași will be known not only for being the city of linden trees, great ideas and seven hills but for being Starnet City, an evergreen protector and living museum of the Romanian Internet Cafe Spirit. However, during a recent trip to photographically document the location, the writers were informed by the photographer that the Starnet Iulius Mall was no longer active. In its place, a VR-focused establishment was built, perhaps signaling to us the beginning of an entirely new era.

During August 2023 Iași was designated International Esports Capital. Our (not so) small city was finally put on the international map of gamers. Teams of competitive players from all around the world played their finals in Romania’s City of Culture, and, of course, Best Internet Cafes. Behind the multitude of events like championships and celebrity concerts, news of the darker motivations behind this event appeared in the public discourse.<sup>13</sup> According to some of his colleagues, the mayor had been planning the Esports publicity stunt intending of laundering money for his (alleged) real estate mafia deals. As the gossip goes, the Mayor tried to cash in the 1 million Euro funds that were allocated to the event production by transferring the money to a (fictitious) foreign third-party entity responsible

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13 C. Moraru, “Campionatul mondial de ESports de la Iași: datorii de 2,6 milioane de euro și suspiciuni uriașe legate de cheltuirea banilor,” *ReporterIS*, 2024, <https://reporteris.ro/exclusiv/anchete/>

for event management. As is the case with European Union funds, a lot of politicians use loopholes such as third-party government companies as “partners” in production projects, and the latter’s offers and services are always mysteriously charging two to even ten times the usual market rate.

Not only was the mayor thus accused of fraud through public funds - but it seems that the third party itself, which ended up being registered under one Macedonian individual, was able to get all of the money it was transferred without a trace and suffering no consequences. A classic story of a thief being out-thieved. We were interested in recent developments of this drama and how the public at large perceives gamer culture. The decision to organize mass public events catered around gaming marks a shift in mainstream society’s now more accepting view of gamer culture and its branches, like the Internet Cafe Will the memory of Iași as 2023 World Esport Capital help propagate an active community for its internet cafes? Or will the behind-the-scenes politics tarnish their reputation and make the public skeptical as to the validity of such a subculture?

**Ruxandra Mărgineanu & Radu-Mihai Tănăsă** are both members of the Iași-based artistic collective Apartament 6 (AP.6). The Startnet project is done as part of AP.6’s overarching artistic research on authentic Balkan spaces. On a local level, AP.6 is one of Iași’s only professionally active artistic collective, developing community-based projects and organizing public exhibitions aimed at questioning the status quo of the local art scene. AP.6 has been hosting so-called “Living Room Exhibitions” meant to challenge the inherent power structures of the local art scene while still adhering to its personal roots of sincerity, childhood and private community. On an international level, AP.6 has been making concentrated efforts into building an online community/ network of fellow (migrant) artists predominately with an Eastern European or Balkan background. To this end, we have been, and continue to organize online events (exhibitions/ screenings) where we collectively explore our commonalities and differences as a geographical region that historically has had a very complicated and often overlooked history both with itself, and its neighbors.

## AFTERWORD

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